Forget the stale, confusing, politically correct history you were fed at school:

The Sumerians did *not* create the first culture: They destroyed it.

Athens did *not* create the Golden Age of the Greeks: They trashed it.

And it gets worse:

- **The workers of the world *have* been robbed, but not by the capitalists.**
- **You can blame the worst of the Middle Ages on Plato.**
- **The Rule of Law died two centuries ago.**

And the worst part is this:

Western Civilization is nearly doomed.

It was never too hard to understand – they just told you the wrong story.

Production

Versus

Plunder

The Ancient War That Is Destroying The West

By Paul Rosenberg



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With deep gratitude to

Hannah Arendt, Carol Quigley and Alvin Toffler

for the illumination they provided.

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Preface

As my last edit of this book was underway, I paid a final visit to the British Museum in London. On the second floor, where the most ancient artifacts are displayed, I found a sign entitled *The First Cities*. The text on this sign expressed the definitive mythology of ancient history, as it is now taught world-wide. It read:

> *This required organization and administration… With expansion came social differentiation and the development of an appropriate bureaucratic infrastructure, required to initiate and oversee the necessary public building programs.*

Through waves of suppressed fury, I wrote the sign's text on a card for use here. This is the traditional, accepted version of the founding of human society, and it is simply false. Organization *followed* the creation of civilization, and public building programs came long, long after. Signs like this on museum walls prevent an actual understanding of the ancient world, burying the truth beneath self-flattering lies. The most ancient history is the most troubling, but, troubling or not, covering it up is almost criminal.

I take no exception to the excellent work of archaeologists to document the past. Everything in this book is based upon the same scientific findings used by the British Museum and by almost every scholar in the West. I accept the archeological record as it is currently known. What I no longer accept is the standard interpretation of that record.

I did not want to do this. I would rather have accepted the interpretations that were presented to me; it would have been far easier. But the longer I studied the actual record (and this process took decades), the more I saw that the traditional interpretation was wrong.

The truth is that British Museum's sign and all like it are political. They promote a mythology that justifies the rulership of their place and time. Such signs and teachings were created in precisely the wrong way: Beginning with a mandate that the past must justify our current way of life, then fitting facts into that framework. That is a dogmatic and non-scientific way to describe history.

For many years I struggled to make sense of the distant past. I put ideas together, examined them, and pulled them back apart when they didn't fit… many times. I examined alternate theories, the sciences, and anything else I could find. And, of course, I kept reading history and visiting museums.

Over the course of this effort, certain parts of the whole began to make sense. From evolutionary science I came to understand that early man was the same as us – he was not a stupid, semi-rational oaf. This cleared a great deal of debris from my path. The second crucial piece came to me from a socialist theorist[1].

In 1908, Franz Oppenheimer, a German physician and sociologist with socialist leanings, published a book entitled *The State.* In it, he explains that there are only two primary modes of survival upon planet Earth: The Political means and the Economic means. Oppenheimer says this:

> *There are two fundamentally opposed means whereby man, requiring sustenance, is impelled to obtain the necessary means for satisfying his desires. These are work and robbery, one's own labor and the forcible appropriation of the labor of others.*

This is a stark, even rude, statement, but it holds up to scrutiny. Beyond this, Oppenheimer and I sometimes diverge in our opinions, but his simple idea is crucial for understanding how men live in this world – and how they have always lived in it.

My final understanding of the roles of production and plunder in the world came only after I had spent quite a long time with Oppenheimer's idea and with the ideas of the three people I dedicated this book to: Hannah Arendt, Carol Quigley and Alvin Toffler. Once all these ideas began to coalesce, however, this book took shape in ways I had not planned.

I should also add that this book does not attempt to cover the history of the entire world; I do not consider myself prepared for such a task. This book covers the West, from its earliest beginnings to the current day, and slightly into the future.

[1] Which is ironic, since I am opposed to socialism.

CONTROVERSY

I never intended this book to make dramatic claims; it just turned out that way. For example, as I began my work in earnest, I hadn't yet understood that the Sumerians were *not* the creators of the first civilization in Mesopotamia, as is always taught – and they were the ones who destroyed it. Similarly, I had yet to understand that Athens, rather than creating the Golden Age of the Greeks, ruined it.

The same can be said for the blame I place upon Plato for Europe's Dark Ages and, especially, for the great conclusion of the second half of this book: That Western Civilization is falling, and has been for a hundred years. I am an optimist by nature, and this was a deeply troubling concept to me, but the facts were clear; it was the only honest conclusion. I do think that recovery remains a possibility, but the West is moving steadily toward its end and mere changes of ruling parties will not stop it.

CREATIVITY & OBEDIENCE

A few years ago, Edge.org asked its scientifically-minded readers a question that later became a book: *What do you know, but cannot prove?* I wondered what I would have answered and I didn't have a strong submission to make. But, during the course of writing this book, I found one, and it is this:

Creativity and obedience are mutually-exclusive operations.

Humans do no operate creatively and obediently at the same time and in the same way: One excludes the other. If you observe carefully, you will notice this happening in yourself. Obedience demands that you override your own thoughts and act according an external command. Creativity requires unobstructed thinking. It is closed in the direction and to the extent that you are being obedient.

I know this to be true, but to properly prove it would require carefully structured experiments, a flock of volunteers, special equipment to monitor brain function, and a lot of time.

The truth of my statement became ever-more clear to me as I wrote this book on production and plunder. The connection is this:

On a large scale, creativity appears as production and obedience appears as plunder.

As I later learned, this was a core idea in Lech Walesa's mind as he and the Solidarity movement ruined the USSR's domination of Poland. As Walesa later said:

> *In the past, you could stand with a gun behind a man who had a pick and a spade and tell him to dig a hole two hundred meters long. But you can't put a man behind someone working creatively, behind a computer, and tell him, "Please devise something original." There is no way to do it, and I took advantage of that.*

AGAINST TIMIDITY

Looking at history the traditional way – that most humans are pulled through history by forces larger than ourselves – absolves us from all guilt. However, that is false; we are the ones who create history… or, more often, permit it to be created upon us. The specific actions of people in power may not be our fault, but setting the conditions for their rise to power is. This book describes average men and women as full-fledged players in history: giving them credit for their successes and refusing to absolve them for their failures.

I did not write this book in constant fear of making a mistake, as is frighteningly common among scholars. I certainly tried to avoid all mistakes, including sending drafts to some of the best-read people I knew, but I did not pull-back from statements that I couldn't base on a previous authority. I care about truth, not authority. Timidity is the curse of institutions.

If someone finds an error in this book, I will (sincerely) thank them to inform me of the fact, and I will be pleased to correct it, once convinced.

WITH THANKS…

To all my friends and family and to all who encouraged me, and especially to the following:

Luke Farrugia and David Schatz for their generous help editing.

Sean Hastings, Sandy Sandfort and Jim Davidson for reviewing the manuscript.

Matthias Menk for our many discussions regarding Chapter Twelve.

1

What Is Man?

What is man, that thou art mindful of him? and the son of man, that thou visitest him? For thou hast made him a little lower than the angels, and hast crowned him with glory and honor.
-- Psalms 8:4-5

It is an arrogance of modern man to think of himself as superior to his dim-witted and unimaginative ancestors. He is not. We are not. There has been no significant change to the human species in 30,000 years, and perhaps not in 100,000 years. Our images of grunting cavemen are self-flattering nonsense. We are them; they were us.

Yes, our current style of living is far more advanced than that of our distant ancestors, but only because they – slowly and with great struggle – were able to create our current mode of living on earth, and to pass it down successfully to us. Hundreds of generations of men and women labored and suffered to bring us to where we are now. It was not magic and it was not because we deserved it; it is only because of their benefaction. They lived in dark times, fighting toward whatever bits of light they could find – opposed by other men nearly the entire time – and they scratched through enough thorns, weeds and underbrush to bring humanity to where we find ourselves now. We have no right to insult them and to devalue them. It is cheap, and it is false.

AN ANCIENT SUPERIORITY

While we presently lead far more advanced lives than any of the ancients, there was one aspect of ancient existence that was superior to ours, and that was self-image. The core of this is captured in one of our older texts, the book of Genesis. A passage in the second chapter reads:

> *The man gave names to all cattle, and to the birds of the air, and to every beast of the field; but among them there was not found a helper suitable for him.*

This passage points out the most obvious conclusion of men who live in direct contact with nature: Human superiority.

A great number of contemporary men, insulated from the world of nature, walk around with a highly-cultivated sense of inferiority and self-doubt. Our early ancestors did not bear these burdens; certainly not at the levels of modern, institutionalized man. Early man was immersed in nature, and there was absolutely nothing in nature that came remotely close to being his equal. Our ancestors knew for certain that they were superior to the animals. Nothing in the animal world could reason, could talk, could create. Some of them were friendly enough, some were useful and some were serious threats, but none was remotely man's equal.

The acknowledgement of superiority is a long-lost human trait, at least for most of us, and when it does appear, it is generally in a corrupted form, featuring a sadistic thirst for domination. We will examine modern self-loathing in a latter chapter, but for now it is worth noting that this original form of acknowledged superiority seems to have been universal (living in daily contact with nature, it couldn't be avoided) and it seems not to have been destructive. In fact, it probably empowered a good deal of human progress.

AGAIN, WHAT IS MAN?

We have stated that modern man is essentially the same as our ancient progenitors, but we have not defined *what* we both are. This is obviously a large subject and one that we will cover only briefly, but the crucial fact is this:

Man is an animal, but he is not *only* an animal.

We most certainly *are* animals; mammals in particular. Our bodies operate almost identically to those of other mammals, although we live longer, have hands that are much more useful, and our children develop much more slowly than the young of any other species, which seems to be

necessary for reproducing our uniquely large brains. And this is where we become more than mere animals – our brains. The human brain operates with the same types of cells and chemicals as other mammals, but our brain is of a more complex design and is stunningly more effective and powerful.

No other creature on this planet has ever been able to deal with ideas as we do. In fact, we survive by thinking, which is a wholly different method than the one used by every other creature on this planet. They operate on in-born instinct, while we survive by thinking – by constantly modifying ideas and strategies. It is this ability that is unique to mankind and which makes him superior.

The unique thing about the human brain is that it allows for self-talk. We do this so continuously that we fail to recognize what a unique and powerful tool it is. Self-talk lies at the base of imagination, self-reference, self-analysis, and integrity. It forms the core of what it means to be human and seems to be possible only because of a brain structure called the pre-frontal cortex.

There are many different types of "software" that run in our brains, including problem-solving routines and routines for the integration of knowledge. Other software routines include the following:

- Pattern-Seeking
- Cause and effect
- Muscle-control
- Trauma responses

INSTINCTS

> *Man is born as a freak of nature, being within nature and yet transcending it. He has to find principles of action and decision-making which replace the principles of instincts.*
> -- Erich Fromm

Man *is* an animal, and we *do* have animal instincts. This is not a demeaning or low thing – instincts are highly useful. In fact, without instincts, neither we nor most animals would have survived to this point. Certainly we are foolish to value instinct above reason, but both are useful to us and we are mistaken if we try to disconnect either one of them.

Instincts are deeply related to hormones. These chemicals create automatic commands in us, either forcing us or pushing us to take certain actions. These hormones create our two primary instincts: To survive and to reproduce. The purpose of both instincts is the same, to keep human life going.

Our instincts can be very strong, and have no real connection to reasoning. Once your body hits puberty, you *will* be driven to have sex and to reproduce. If you are in serious danger, your body *will* begin to flee. These are things that happen to all healthy humans and they serve to keep us alive, both individually and as a continuing species. If you were to create living beings from scratch, these would be the root commands you would hard-wire into them.

There are other instincts or quasi-instincts, which are also important:

- Status
- Territory
- Pleasure-Seeking, Pain-Avoidance
- Expansion & Growth
- Caring For The Young

This is what man is. Certainly man is far more complex than this short description, but these are essentials and we will be referenceing them as we proceed.

THE INPENETRABLE PAST

For the last half-million years, our planet has experienced a string of at least four ice ages. In each of them, a huge portion of the earth has been covered with ice and snow and the rest of the planet was much colder than it is now. And, in each case, the surface of the earth has been radically changed, wiping out much or all evidence of human life before the ice came. Millennia of moving glaciers, runoff, winds, rock falls, and other geological changes would almost certainly erase most traces of what had been before. We simply don't know what happened before the end of the last ice age in any detail. We don't know what humans built and we know almost nothing of how they lived during the ice ages.

It has been suggested[2] that evolution and migrations through these four ice ages are what separated the races of men. This may well be true, but the theory has little support from evidence at the current time, and, given that glaciers, runoff and hundreds of millennia are not kind to artifacts, not much may be forthcoming.

The surprising thing about the ice ages is that they were very, very long. Warm periods, such as the one we now live in, are the exception. Most of the time, earth is half-frozen[3]. Look at the following graph of temperatures and ice volume and consider that the world is in its current state only at the peaks on the graph. These warm peaks, called "interglacials" have generally lasted in the range of 10,000-12,000 years, meaning that we may be approaching the end of a warm period and closing in on a new – and very long – glacial period.

The last ice age on earth ended at about 8000 B.C. In the years near that point, whatever humans that had survived the ice age began to spread out over the earth. We have little information on what these people did during the ice age. Since humans now and then are the same, we can carefully imagine ourselves in such a situation and come to some guesses of how we would have behaved, but evidence is greatly lacking.

The traditional view of early man has been that he lived, almost universally, as a hunter-gatherer, and while it is certain that many groups of humans lived that way (and some still do), that may not be a fair generalization. A portion of the idea's popularity may come from the fact that it is a simple explanation and because it fits with our self-flattering opinion that we are different and better than our distant ancestors. It may be that men lived as hunter-gatherers (*foragers*, in more scientific terminology) for a hundred thousand years before they learned agriculture, but we do not know that for sure – the ice age would have wiped out a lot of evidence.

Nonetheless, we do find evidence of foragers previous to the end of the ice age and we don't find evidence of farming. So, we will stay with that model, given the caveat mentioned above.

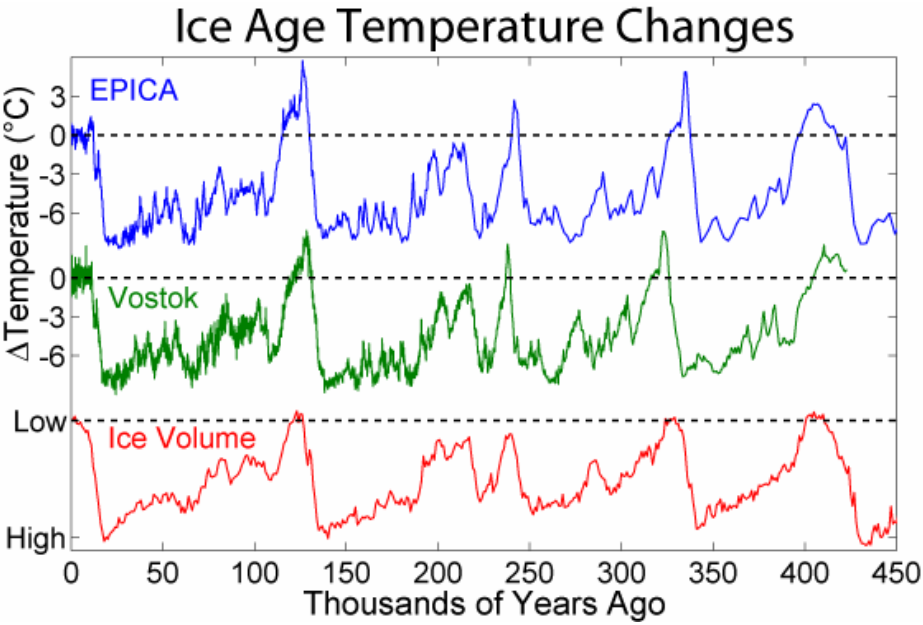
During the times of foraging, most humans organized themselves in small clan groups, probably in the range of 20-50 people per group. This

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[2] See *The Evolution of Civilizations*, by Carol Quigley, published by Liberty Tree.

[3] In the last ice age, what are now Indianapolis and St. Louis were covered with glaciers – the same as Greenland's current state. Even the areas where soil was exposed were much colder than they are now.

was probably a highly-functional type of grouping, and may have some sort of instinctive base as well, since human minds are very comfortable keeping fifty individuals clearly in mind, along with all of their abilities, needs and personal traits.



Courtesy Wikimedia Commons

Inside the clan, decisions were generally made by informal consent, and clans cooperated with other friendly clans to form loose tribal associations. They also interacted violently with unfriendly clans. These were not mass wars as we know them, but they were violent and deadly, generally being fought with stone axes, arrows and spears.

THE MINDS OF THE FORAGERS

The foragers thought the same thoughts we would think, if we were in the same situation they found themselves in, and if we found ourselves with the same small knowledge base they had. These people concerned themselves with the same things humans always have: How to escape fear, pain, and sorrow. How to increase security, pleasure, and joy. How to realize their dreams of something better. Beyond this, they needed to find some way to make peace with the hard areas of life:

- Sickness and death
- Existence itself

- Shame
- Fear
- Helplessness

These factors, and certainly others, led to the first philosophies and religions. Religion is, after all, just a type of philosophy that focuses on what philosophers call metaphysics[4]. So, because these folks did not have a great deal of knowledge, their philosophies would have included a lot of conjecture on things they couldn't explain. Having the faculty of imagination, they would have exercised it at some length, seeking clever answers to their questions. And, over time, the best and most entertaining of such imaginings turn into myths.

These early religious myths tended to focus on imaginary beings and powers that lay behind nature. This could have begun in ways as 'modern' as saying "The principle of the sun, which we do not yet understand," rather than saying "the Sun God," but, the simplest ideas are the ones that tend to stick, and the Sun God would have quickly displaced more scientific explanations.

HOW MANY?

There were very few humans on the planet at the end of the last ice age, and the available areas for living were as large as they are now. This meant that any group of humans would be almost entirely isolated from all other groups. This made the transfer of information exceedingly slow and uncommon.

The US Census Bureau produces a report called Historical Estimates of World Population. According to this document, there were only about five million human beings on earth at the end of the last ice age. That is less than one thousandth of the current world population, spread over the same area. (And the earth is mostly empty space even now.) Imagine every human being on the earth wiped out, save only those in the city of Baghdad, and then scattering these survivors all over the earth. That was precisely the condition at the end of the ice age. Humans were very few and widely scattered.

Aside from speech, which is not especially accurate over time, functional methods of transferring information barely existed – presuming that you

[4] Metaphysics asks, "What is the nature of existence?" and it tends to ask questions about what might exist beyond our sight and analysis.

found a group that you wanted to share information with. If you wanted information to last, you carved it into stone. So, not a lot of information was retained and shared.

YEAR	POPULATION (millions)
10,000 BC	5
8,000 BC	5
6,500 BC	7
5,000 BC	8
4,000 BC	10
3,000 BC	14
2,000 BC	27
1,000 BC	50
500 BC	100
1 AD	200
200 AD	230
400 AD	220
600 AD	200
800 AD	220
1000 AD	300
1200 AD	400
1400 AD	350
1600 AD	500
1800 AD	1,000
2000 AD	5,000+

The result of this incredibly low population density was not only that information traveled slowly, but that groups of humans were generally unopposed by other human beings. This lead to development without much stress from the outside. Once a group of humans found a way of life that worked for them, they could develop it among themselves with very little exterior pressure. Bear in mind that the greatest obstacle for productive men has always been other men. That was much less the case at a time when there was almost no one else around. This allowed ideas to develop without what we might call “natural enemies.”

THE INVENTION OF COOPERATION & HARMONY

It is not entirely natural for humans to get along. We tend, naturally, to favor those who are most closely related to us (with whom we share more DNA) and we have usually existed in conditions of scarcity, which has often-enough led to competition. Imagine two separate groups of foragers, attempting to gather food from the same forest: They would –

based solely upon animal-level instincts – dispute whose food it was, which would lead to aggressive and perhaps violent behavior. This is common in our times and would have be been no less in the past, at least where groups of humans pressed upon each other. In such conditions, human instincts are very similar to those of animals, and they push us to act as animals do – to defend, to attempt dominance, to show status, and so on.

However, as we have said before, we are not merely animals, and we can override instinctive impulse with reason. In specific, we can imagine better ways of handling problems, or remember how they were handled in the past – in ways that were superior to mere instinct, which leads to injury and death, possibly in great numbers[5].

Most importantly, we can override our instincts. We can control them.

We have learned to recognize when impulses strike us and to restrain them before thoughtless actions are taken. We interrupt the instinct and introduce into that moment a command to take a better, more rational course of action. Our ancestors knew, just as we do, that envy, greed, fear, and impulsive actions can cause great harm. They learned to monitor their own thoughts with vigilance and to maintain harmony, against some of their instincts.

Humans invented harmony – we were not born into it in some mythical past.

HARMONY VERSUS HOBBES

Thomas Hobbes was an English philosopher, famous for his book *Leviathan*, which established a foundation for modern political philosophy. In it, Hobbes claimed that overwhelming central authority and force were necessary to avoid discord, murder and civil war. Hobbes says that life without government would inevitably lead to conflict, to a "war of all against all," and that life would be "solitary, poor, nasty, brutish, and short." To escape this state of permanent war, says Hobbes, all individuals must yield their rights to a sovereign authority for the sake of their protection. And if this Sovereign were to act badly, men must accept it as the price of peace.

---

[5] Killing unprotected humans is not a particularly difficult thing. In ancient times it was generally accomplished with a stone ax or with a mace. Any healthy, post-adolescent male can kill with a mace-blow to the head, and even a small ax wielded by a child could kill in the days before antiseptics.

Prior to Hobbes, rulers in Europe defended their right to rule by citing the Divine Right of Kings. But with kingdoms failing, a new justification for rulership was required, and Hobbes provided it. This has been the default philosophy for rulers and their supporters for the past three hundred years.

Hobbes, however, was manifestly wrong. The reasons to say so are many: The flowering of crime underneath government rule, the lack of overwhelming crime where government force is lacking, human kindness, voluntary charity, and many others. The greatest proof, however, is the one that has existed since before recorded time: That men have learned to restrain their impulses, subjecting them to reason because it provides better results.

This really should be obvious to anyone who has seen a modern city: All of those buildings were created by people who chose to cooperate. That's a *lot* of cooperation, a fair amount of which has taken place outside the reach of the state[6]. The first men learned how to cooperate and to restrain their destructive impulses, just as we do now. *This* is the root of civilization, not a pistol pointed at everyone's head, as championed by Hobbes.

Humans created cooperation and harmony, and we create it still. This is the foundation of human progress and it began no later than the end of the last ice age, at about 8,000 B.C.

THREE GROUPS FORM

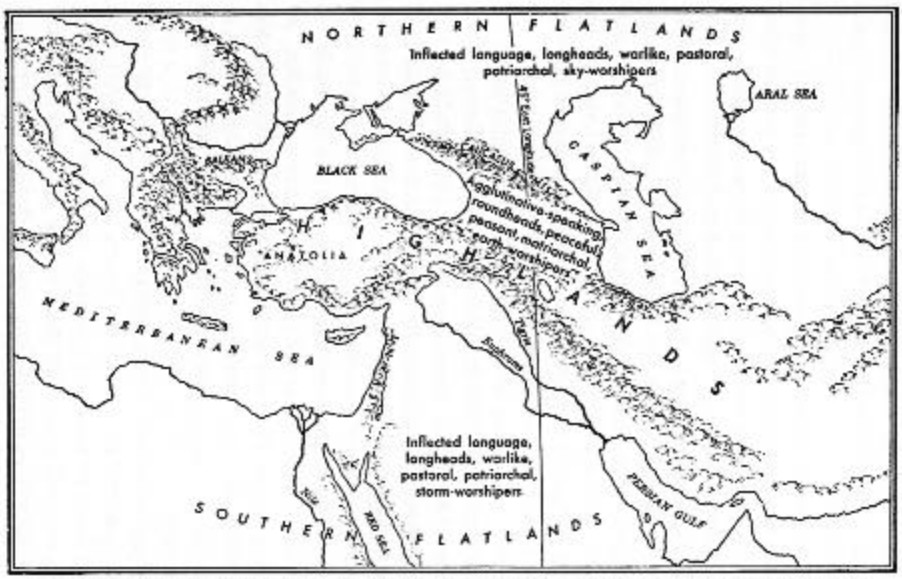
We have no good way of knowing how the few and scattered humans on earth migrated at the end of the ice age. We have only a limited and fuzzy idea of where they came from and how they moved. What can be deduced from the available information is that three general groups began to form in the greater Middle East – in the area from Arabia to the steppe of southwestern Asia. We know precious little about these groups, but we do know enough to understand their general characteristics. The figure below shows the general distribution of these groups. This particular distribution is from a later time, but it does show the general pattern we are discussing.

When discussing these groups, it is important to repeat what we have previously mentioned: That there were very few of them, that they were

[6] To give a small modern example: Unregistered immigrants work almost entirely without access to state justice systems, and do so very regularly and successfully.

widely scattered, and that there was very little interaction. These groups were in radically different geographic areas and almost certainly had migrated from different places. In all likelihood, they were completely ignorant of each other for some time.

Following the end of the ice age[7], there were several thousand years of quiet time: Not many humans and precious little interaction between humans. During such times, groups of humans tend to build specific characteristics. We tend to call these groups-with-characteristics "societies" or "cultures."



Sandwich distribution of peoples, languages, and cultures along 45th meridian East about 3000 B.C.

Courtesy Liberty Fund

Over time, three early groups developed their own cultures – cultures that informed their ways not only of daily life, but of looking at the world. More importantly, over time – and this was thousands of years – manner of living guides the development of human character. Indeed, the historic nature/nurture arguments[8] are moot in such a case – both

[7] I am discussing the ice age as if it ended quickly at 8000 B.C., which is not true; the ice receded for several thousand years, then stopped receding at about 10,000 years before the present time. So, there is a certain amount of simplification built into this discourse.

[8] The argument as to whether human character is the result of heredity (nature) or experience (nurture). In actuality, it is both, with a third factor added: Previous choices. The major

nature and nurture are operating. Specific types of nurture become normal within the group and are passed-down from generation to generation. And, since the group is more or less isolated and closed, the gene pool is refined and passed-down as a fairly consistent set of genes. These groups formed slowly and there were multiple generations worth of time.[9] With both isolation and time, groups of humans, such as these first three, produce distinct societal structures, including structures of cooperation and/or rulership, and of gods and worship.

These three groups are of two primary types: Farmers and nomads. Again, over time, different styles of living teach different lessons to men. In particular, farming leads to a cooperative model of thinking and living, while nomadic hunting and herding lead to a warfare and domination model of living and thinking.

Farmers learn to rely upon their neighbors. They help build each other's barns, share tools, lend their expertise for repairing their neighbor's equipment, and so on. They also respect each other's property lines. So, in farming, there are long histories of mutual help and respect for property.

Herdsmen, on the other hand, tend to mistrust their neighbors and to hide information from them. When the nomadic herdsman finds good grazing land, he does not share that knowledge with another herdsman. If one finds a hidden water hole, he does not disclose the location. So, the overall balance is much more toward *not* helping a neighbor. Similarly, property is less respected in nomadic cultures. And, of course, they developed different methods of warfare.

But, beneath all the details there are two different sets of assumptions regarding the world and human existence. The farmers developed what economists now call a *positive-sum* view of existence and the nomads developed more of what we call a *zero-sum* understanding of existence.

Briefly, a *zero-sum* assumption is that there is a fixed pool of any specific good and that in order for you to have more, someone else has to accept less. This is the essence of the common slogan, "there are only so many

---

choices humans make have enduring effects both within and upon them, which are encoded into their characters to one extent or another.

[9] There is also a strong possibility that these groups had been separate and isolated from each other well back into the ice age, which means that they could have developed separately many times longer than humans have developed in all the years since the ice age. However, this is all conjecture – we simply do not know.

pieces of pie." If you want an extra slice, someone else has to accept one less. A *positive-sum* assumption, on the other hand, assumes that the pool of assets can be expanded. In other words, if there are not enough slices of pie for your liking, you can make a new pie for yourself.

The important thing about zero-sum and positive-sum assumptions is that they form a mental pattern, an analysis program in our brains. This is one of the human software routines we discussed earlier. Positive- or zero-sum routines form in human minds and – if not analyzed and adjusted – color wide areas of thought. This affects all sorts of opinions and judgments. People take these basic views of the world as givens: things they don't need to waste time examining; things that are considered to be known. This built great differences in the thoughts of the farmers and the nomads.[10]

> Young nomads were instructed to *take*, from a world of limited resources.
>
> Young farmers were instructed to use the world intelligently and to *create* food.

These early farmers, for the first time we know of, discovered a post-parasitic way of living on earth. They did not feed off of what already existed, as do parasites. Instead, they became actors in cooperation with the earth, and made it produce food for them.

Of course, animal husbandry does ride the line between the parasitic and the creative, but it never fully crosses it. The farmers did cross it, firmly and permanently.

THE NORTHERN AND SOUTHERN NOMADS

The northern nomads lived in the flatlands above the Black and Caspian Seas, in what are now southwestern Russia, Ukraine, and western Kazakhstan. They tended to be taller and with longer rather than rounder heads. They were pastoral, war-like, patriarchal, and worshiped sky gods.

[10] Again, I am simplifying. There were certainly individuals in each group that differed from the descriptions I am attaching to them. Furthermore, such characteristics among groups of humans are constantly varying and competing. So, while I firmly believe what I write here is accurate, it is only a general statement and certainly varied greatly among individuals and between sub-groups.

The southern nomads lived in the flatlands of Arabia. They tended to be slight-boned, had long heads, were pastoral, war-like, patriarchic, and worshipped storm gods.

It is difficult for modern westerners to understand the structure and incentives of such societies. Most westerners expect cooperation in life. Most of the time, the store-keeper does not try to cheat us, we don't steal metal exposed on the sides of buildings, and so on. In short, we expect people to "play nice" because of the programming in their brains, not because they are forced to do so. We complain bitterly about the stupid criminals that do arise.

This assumption of cooperation did not exist in these groups of nomads. They were not the same as us in their assumptions regarding life upon earth. We westerners derive (more or less) from farmers who presumed cooperation and creativity. These nomads assumed dominance and scarcity.

The nomad existence was based upon a plunder model, placed on top of a clan model. At the base was the family clan. In these small groupings, there would have been a good deal of sharing and cooperative decision-making, but the final and large decisions would have been made by the senior male. For these clan groups to join together and form a larger group, a central dominator was always required.

What these people saw as "normal" was a dominator in charge, with a structure below him. Each clan, of course, would have a protected place within that structure, along with certain privileges and allowances.

The rigidity of these structures led to hatreds that could endure for centuries. When an outside group forcibly alters one of these societal hierarchies, the occupants live with tilted floors, so to speak, until the structure is righted.

The rigidity of this structure derives from the fact that it is a collection of clans, and the clans nearly always remain for centuries. Added to this, clans tend to constantly compare themselves with the other clans, and oppose any changes in status between them[11]. Because of these status-conscious and enduring bonds, the structure is not permitted to modify. Thus, the inconvenience and the humiliation of altered hierarchy endures.

[11] Again, this status consciousness is related to a zero-sum understanding of life. If what one wants is scarce, it must be grasped firmly, and re-taken if ever removed. A human with a positive-sum view of life might rather mourn the loss briefly, then go out to replace it.

Nikolay N. Kradin, in his paper, *Nomadism, Evolution and World-Systems: Pastoral Societies in Theories of Historical Development*, explains that the nomadic empire is organized on the military-hierarchical principle, and survives by exploiting the nearby territories. He goes on to say:

> The most interesting and novel feature of the steppe empires was their dual structure. From outside they appeared to be despotic aggressive state-like societies because they were formed to extract surplus product from outside the steppe. But from within, the nomadic empires remained based on the tribal relations without the establishment of taxation and exploitation.

So, this structure is based upon clan relations at the base, and upon plunder in the overall. This is more or less as one would imagine it to develop, given enough information.

James DeMeo argues[12], with much evidence, that physiological damage due to drought and starvation contributed to or caused a variety of cultural and character traits among the southern groups of nomads. DeMeo finds that the root cause was the spreading of deserts (and subsequent starvation, devaluing and mal-treatment of children) at approximately 4000 B.C.

THE CENTRAL FARMERS

The central farmers tended to be shorter, stocky, with round heads, short hair, no beards, and worshipped a fertility goddess. This group lived in the highland area of what is traditionally Armenia, extending into the Lake Van area of what is now eastern Turkey[13]. Settlements at several locations in the Alznik province of Armenia date to 10,000 B.C., before the ice age had fully ended[14].

The most likely structure of their "society" would have been a decentralized farming structure, similar to later farming groups that functioned beyond the edges of state control, such as in the early American colonies. (No state had ever existed at this early time.) The

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[12] In his book, *Saharasia*

[13] Interestingly, this is the same area that Genesis points to as the Garden of Eden, and, later, as the landing-place of Noah's Ark.

[14] Some of the more important finds were made in about 1980 by the archaeologist Hans Georg Gebel.

natural clan group certainly would have formed some sort of base for these people, but since farming scatters and moves people across landscapes, this clan structure would have been dispersed[15], reducing the strength and effects of the clan.

It seems that these farming groups kept an older forager tradition to gather in much larger groups for a few weeks every year. At these gatherings, they would conduct ceremonies and festivals, make marriage arrangements and trade goods. A standing monolith and building, dated to approximately 8,000 B.C. at Nevali Cori in western Armenia, was probably one of these ancient meeting places. It was located only three kilometers from the southern bank of the Euphrates river, a convenient meeting place.

These gatherings would have been very much like the religious camp meetings of strict sects such as Methodists in the 18th and 19th Centuries or of various Pentecostal groups in more recent times. Obviously the pretext for such modern gatherings differs from ancient tribal meetings, but many aspects, such as ceremonies and marriage arrangements would have been almost the same. Again, these people were that same as us, only with less information. We should expect their behavior to resemble that of modern people.

MALE AND FEMALE GODS

As mentioned earlier, these early humans had a very limited amount of knowledge of science and the forces that shaped the natural world in which they lived. But, they did have powerful minds and creative imaginations. So, they tried to imagine what made the world work, just as we would in the same situation. Over centuries, ideas such as these tend to shape themselves into forms that are easily repeated. This is no less a problem in our time than it was at the end of the ice age.

For example: Our common story of Adam and Eve's fall from paradise is supposedly based upon the Bible. But the ubiquitous form of this story – eating an apple – is nowhere to be found in the Bible; no apple is ever mentioned. Yet the story is repeated endlessly, merely because it is easy to draw and because "everyone else" seems to do it. Precisely the same thing happened to the myths of the ancients.

[15] As we will examine in the next chapter, these farmers had not yet invented crop rotation, and were required to abandon their fields every several years and move to the next fertile area.

The gods of the ancients tell us a great deal about the central assumptions they made about the world. The nomads, as mentioned above, saw the world as a place of scarcity and struggle against other men. They developed war gods and patriarchal structures.

"Patriarchal" is a term much abused in modern times, as if to imply that there is something evil in maleness itself. But the issue is not maleness per se, but dominance and submission. The problem arises when instincts for expansion are mixed with an ignorance of a creative principle. In such cases, the strongest one – almost always a male – "improves" himself by taking from others. So, "patriarchy" was the personification given to the central principle, being the easiest way to repeat it[16].

The farmers, on the other hand, developed female gods and cooperative cultures. Again, this is not because there is some inherently superior value in being female, but because of the creative principle – the opposite of scarcity. Female gods were developed because the female embodies creation and productivity: Her body literally brings forth new human beings.

For reasons that we will explain later, modern gods tend to be of the dominator type. For this reason, female gods are seen by some moderns as a dominator with a female face. This is not what female gods were to the earliest farmers. The female god was not a dominator, she was a *catalyst* - not striking from above, but *working with*. They were magic embodiments of the creative/productive principle.

Inanna may have been the first goddess (she was most certainly among the first) and the name itself indicates that it may have originated in the pre-Sumerian language of the Armenian farmers. She was, as mentioned above, the personification of the creative principle. Accordingly, her male consort was characterized as the force in the grain and as her priestly lover.

We will close this chapter with some passages from Inanna's myth-poetry. In them you will notice the glorification of creation and production in many forms: The production of the female body, the production of the grain in the fields and the production of the herds. You will note the erotic aspects as well, which are odd and even troubling

[16] And, so that the female half of humanity takes their fair share of blame, we should add that females tended to reward such behavior by seeking a strong male. Scarcity tends to create poor characteristics in all humans.

to many modern people, but were entirely sensible and laudable to the most-ancient farmers. After all, they were fundamental to the magical process of creation. Sex made them partners with the gods. It was glorious, not shameful.

Last night as I, the Queen of Heaven, was shining bright,
As I was shining bright and dancing,
Singing praises at the coming of the night.

He met me - He met me!
My lord Dumuzi met me.
He put his hand into my hand.
He pressed his neck close against mine.
My High Priest is ready for the holy loins.
My lord Dumuzi is ready for the holy loins.
The plants and herbs in his field are ripe.

O Dumuzi! Your fullness is my delight!

I bathed for the Shepherd Dumuzi,
I perfumed my sides with ointment,
I coated my mouth with sweet-smelling amber,
I painted my eyes with kohl.

He shaped my loins with his fair hands,
The Shepherd Dumuzi filled my lap with cream and milk,
He stroked my pubic hair,
He watered my womb.
He laid his hands on my holy vulva,
He smoothed my black boat with cream,
He quickened my narrow boat with milk,
He caressed me on the bed.

Now I will caress my high priest on the bed,
I will caress the faithful shepherd Dumuzi,
I will caress his loins,
I will decree a sweet fate for him.

As the farmer, let him make the fields fertile,
As the shepherd, let him make the sheepfolds multiply,
Under his reign let there be vegetation,
Under his reign let there be rich grain.

The King went with lifted head to the holy loins.
He went with lifted head to the loins of Inanna.

He went to the Queen with lifted head.
He opened wide his arms to the Holy Priestess of Heaven....

2

Civilization Is Created & Overrun

Man was born free, and everywhere he is in chains.
-- Jean-Jacques Rousseau

Throughout this book, we will generally assume that cultures are the natural order of humanity; the refuge and training-place of humanity. We will do this because the mass of humanity has indeed organized itself in this way and because it is far more convenient for our purpose of analysis. Nonetheless, it is important to be clear about the fact that culture is not simply a good or preferable thing – culture is also limitation.

Once a man or woman conceives of themselves as "an Armenian," as "a Jew," or any other flavor of cultural identity, they introduce a specific pattern into their minds and accept it as "Me." That is an inherently limiting thing. We humans are massively adaptable and creative beings; to limit ourselves to being "Armenian," Jewish," "Irish," or whatever, is a stupid thing to do – it grossly limits our thought processes and our creative output as beings.

Culture, per se, is not a good thing. It has value only to the extent that it is the least impractical thing among the other options at hand.

So, for the rest of this book, we will accept culture as a given, but it is important to understand that it is not something that is noble, pure and sacred. Culture is actually a transgression against a fully whole, healthy human being. Granted, there have never been many humans who we

could justly characterize as healthy and whole, but were they to emerge, culture would be a formidable barrier to them, and they would find crossing it a great struggle. They would justly condemn it as a false god.

FROM ARMENIA TO SUMER

As mentioned in the last chapter, the first group of truly productive human beings on earth, were, as far as we know, gardeners that emerged from the last ice age and appeared in the area of what is now Armenia. They tended to be short, stocky, with round heads, short hair, no beards, and embraced a fertility goddess.

Because they had no knowledge of crop rotation, they were forced to move from one area to the next every several years, after they had depleted the soil in their fields. This would have seemed normal and sensible to them, as it would have matched other aspects of nature, such as women being fertile for only a limited number of years. It is thus no surprise that they accepted soil losing its fertility as fact. As a result, crop rotation would not have been sought and indeed was not discovered for a long, long time. This, however, was not considered especially problematic, since there was no shortage of land. The earth was all but empty; if you wanted new land, you could simply take any piece you wanted.



The map above shows some of the earliest settlements of these people, as they slowly moved away from Armenia, seeking fertile new fields. Note that they followed the Tigris river into what was much later called Sumer (also, mistakenly, called Sumeria), an area often referred to as Mesopotamia and currently contained within the state of Iraq.

BECOMING STATIONARY

As these farmers moved slowly across the face of the earth, they happened upon places where they could become stationary and not have to move every few years. These were in the river valleys of the old world that flooded every year. (Properly termed *alluvials* or *flood plains*.) The group of farmers we are following found such a place in the Tigris-Euphrates valley. The valley flooded every year and a new layer of topsoil was deposited. Irrigation ditches could be built to extend this flood effect over a large additional area. This allowed the farmers to stay in one place, build permanent houses, and avoid the strains of moving every few years.

Carol Quigley, in his *The Evolution of Civilizations*, explains this as follows:

> At the risk of considerable oversimplification, we might say that these earliest agriculturalists appeared in the hilly terrain of western Asia, probably not far from Armenia, about nine thousand years ago. Because they knew nothing about replenishing the fertility of the soil, they practiced "shifting cultivation," moving to new fields when yields declined in their old fields. In consequence, they expanded steadily, reaching Denmark and Britain in the west and China in the east before 2000 B.C., that is to say, within five thousand years. In the course of this movement they found, in various alluvial valleys, sites adapted to permanent large-scale settlement because, in such valleys, the annual flood replenished the fertility of the soil by depositing a layer of fertile sediment; and, accordingly, the need for "shifting cultivation" ended and the possibility of permanent, eventually urban settlement was offered. This possibility was realized in four alluvial valleys of the Old World, in Mesopotamia during the sixth millennium B.C., in the valley of the Nile shortly afterward, in the valley of the Indus river early in the fourth millennium B.C., and in the Huang Ho Valley of China late in the third millennium B.C.

Life in these Pre-Sumerian settlements followed a routine based upon the rivers. During the flood season (which lasted for months) the farmlands were partly or fully flooded by the rivers. During this season, the farmers built, maintained, or extended irrigation canals to bring water to adjacent areas. Animals were moved away from the flood zones to prevent them from drowning. As the waters receded, seeds were sown and crops were cultivated. Finally came the dry season when crops were harvested and stored. Then, the cycle repeated.

It would be difficult to over-state the value to these early farmers of being able to remain stationary. Food was plentiful, goods could be accumulated, and large communities could be formed. This led to immense variety and specialization. Music appeared in variety and with many experimental new instruments. Written language developed, basic mathematics, and much, much more. It was the birth of man's intellectual life. Prior to this moment, men and women certainly had the same creative capacities, but their creations never left their small groups. Now, they inspired each other. Humans played off one another, helped one another, and corrected one another in very specific ways. For example, if you had the fortune to be born with unusual musical talent, the odds of finding a kindred soul among forty or fifty others would be fairly low. But finding someone of complimentary talents among a thousand was possible and perhaps even likely. And once you found each other, utterly new worlds of exploration opened to you.

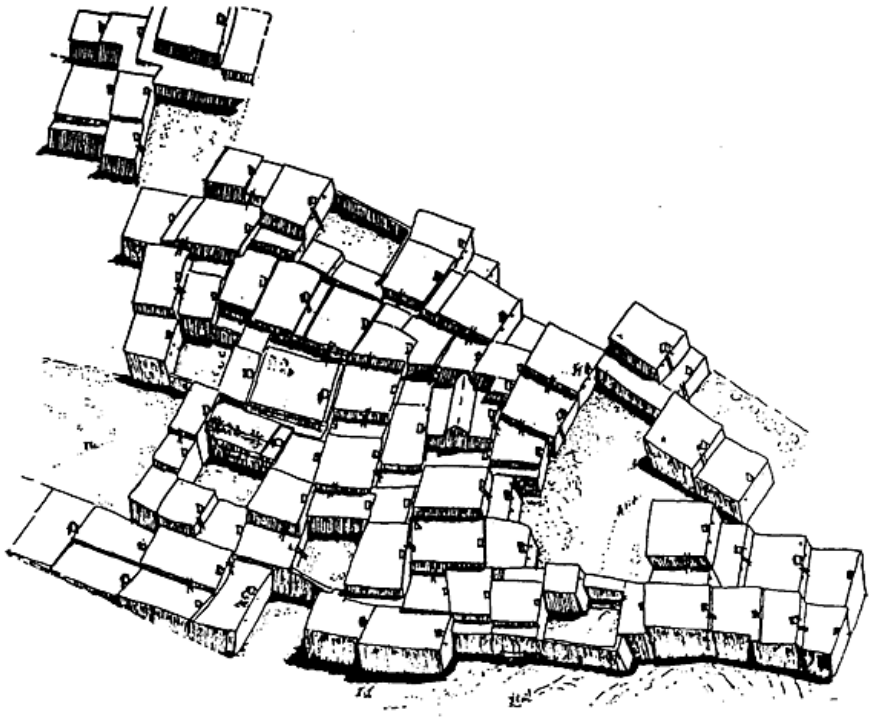
Farm communities created an undreamed level of prosperity and human growth. Humans had long been capable of such growth, but they lacked the interaction that made it possible. Now, ideas could be compared, experiments conducted, results written and distributed, and the knowledge shared among thousands. Mankind began to flower. It may have been the most exiting time our race has ever seen: Humanity awoke and the world opened wide unto them.

THE OTHER FARMERS

As our first farming culture spread out from Armenia, only some found their way to the Tigris-Euphrates flood plain. Most of the others began to spread in other directions, as Professor Quigley notes in the passage above. They literally brought the knowledge of farming from one end of the Eurasian land mass to the other.

There is not a great deal of solid information available on these groups, since they were small, moved regularly, and existed a long, long time ago. But a few early settlements have been unearthed. One of the earliest was

found in south-central Turkey. Thus far information is limited on the farming practices of this group, but considering the size of the village of Çatal Hüyük, they must have developed some level of agricultural technology to allow considerable numbers of residents. The village looked like this:



After James Mellaart, "Çatal Hüyük", Thames & Hudson Ltd., London, 1967

This village may have had a population of as many as 5,000 people and was built at about 6800 B.C. Notice that the houses are grouped together and that one had to enter each house through a hole in the roof. Such a style of building would almost certainly be for the purpose of protection, either from animals or from unfriendly groups of nomads in the area.

Note that this very early settlement still dates from well over a thousand years after the ice age had fully ended. While it is very, very early from our perspective, it was certainly not “early” from the perspective of these farming groups.

> *No student takes seriously the seventeenth-century notion that states arose out of a "social contract" among individuals or between the people and the ruler.*
> -- Will and Ariel Durant

The boundaries of human life are set and maintained by violence. No, it shouldn't be that way, but it is. Whether or not any of us like this fact, it is true. And until all men grow up and wake up, it will remain true to a greater or lesser extent. There are people who will, given the right incentives, challenge the borders of civilization. They must be kept in check by a credible threat of violence. Wishing it was not this way will not change the fact.

The balance of violence ultimately determines the boundaries of every human society, and – tragically – our Pre-Sumerian farmers were the first settled group to have this lesson thrust upon them.

Professor Quigley[17] describes it this way:

> The chief event was the invention of agriculture, metallurgy, and civilized living by the Highland Zone peoples and the subsequent linguistic and cultural submergence of these peoples by inflective-speaking longheaded pastoralists who pushed in waves from the Flatlands by the two post-glacial dry periods. One of the chief results of this process, a result seen most clearly in Europe, was to create a political and social structure in which patriarchal, warlike, horse-loving, sky-worshiping, honor-seeking Indo-Europeans were established as a ruling class over peaceful, earth-loving, fertility-dominated, female-oriented peaceful peoples. This pattern, first established in central Europe almost four thousand years ago, was not destroyed, in spite of Rome, Christianity, and later migrations, until the appearance of industrialized urban society in the last four generations.

Farming created large stores of food, typically as grain, which did not rot if carefully stored. Following shortly were other imperishable goods, such as clothing, furs, tools, and so on. By any ancient standard, these farmers were stunningly rich. And while our farmers were happy living

[17] Again, from *The Evolution of Civilizations*, published in 1960.

cooperative, productive lives, there were others who operated, not by a cooperation model, but by a plunder model. Our farmers were now immobile. Stationary targets are easy to hit and sedentary people are not well-suited for combat. They were easy victims.

The first plunderers were the nomadic hunters and herdsmen described previously. At some point they expanded into new areas and discovered that rich, stationary farmers were easy to rob. The consciences of these people were informed by sky gods who imposed power from above and by clan groupings that featured dominance, submission and structure. They were emotionally suited to plunder. Furthermore, these people had the necessary skills for rapid movement and killing; they hunted, captured and killed mammals regularly. They would also have resented the prosperity of the farmers and their wealth, as it made them look second-rate, something that would not be permissible in their hierarchical, "we must be the head, not the tail" view of the world. Outsiders being richer and better was not a contradiction that they could bear.

These nomads could easily remove the spoils of conquest, either to a safe place, or simply to the next settlement for the purposes of barter. And it is likely that their first actions against the farmers were simple looting missions. This, certainly, would have led farmers to build settlements designed for defense, like the one at Çatal Hüyük.

In some places, some of these nomads would have been so successful that they drove the farmers away, leaving them to either look for new victims or return to their previous lives. Before long they developed a third option: Steal only a limited amount, not enough to drive the farmers away. This way, you can work the same ground, as it were, for life. Thus, the first rulers were born. Like it or not, the probable scenario is that governance began as persistent theft, with hierarchical nomad groups sustaining plunder at a level that was low enough for the productive farmers to accept their rulership with a limited level of resistance.

On the farmer's side, giving a fifth of his crops to the thug every harvest was a lot less bad than facing death, or going back to being a traveling gardener or a forager. So, he grimaced and accepted it; as would most modern men. To illustrate this point, here are the words of modern man in a similar situation: An exceedingly remote Tibetian nomad, commenting upon his first ruler[18]:

[18] National Geographic, June 1989

> *The Panchen Llama owned areas and appointed officials to settle our disputes and collect taxes. He was our lord, although he never came here himself. Our taxes were heavy in those days, but we never went hungry.*

This series of events could easily have been predicted in advance. It was the incentives that the players faced that led to precisely this situation: Stationary, peaceful farmers colliding with nomadic herding and hunting societies could hardly turn out any other way.

AND GOD CHANGED

One way this "conquest of the productive by the plunderer" shows up in the archaeological record is in the mixing of the gods. We have said that the early farmers held to female gods based upon the productive principle. We have also said that the nomads held to male dominator gods. Sumer was eventually overrun by a nomadic group called the Akkadians. Dianne Wolkstein and Samuel Noah Kramer[19], studying the development of the goddess Inanna, report the following:

> In the cycle of Inanna, we encounter aspects of the earlier Sumerian Dumuzi (her male companion) as well as the more politicized Akkadian Dumuzi. The Sumerian Dumuzi… is characterized as the force in the grain and as the priestly lover and attendant of the Fertility Goddess, Inanna. The Akkadian Dumuzi, coming from the northern nomadic peoples who emphasized the arbitrary will and power of the gods is characterized as the shepherd, the astral heavenly bull, and the king who has "godlike" powers.

Whether imposed by force or accepted by intermingling over time, the dominator male gods of the nomadic plunderers were mixed with the productive female gods of the cooperative farmers. Again, this was entirely sensible, since extracting plunder openly is an expensive process. Violence is never cheap. So, the sensible ruler would certainly prefer to have his subjects give willingly, and because the gods were super-human, they were the obvious tool to use. Since the gods did not speak directly to men, their "true message" was a matter of interpretation and could be turned to the ruler's advantage, if done carefully.

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[19] In their book, *Inanna*

Although the first instances of rulership were mostly naked impositions of force, an ethic was later created that said that the gods, if obeyed, would assure great harvests and prosperity. Furthermore, clever priests were added to the equation. These first public intellectuals promoted a theology in which the king played a 'legitimate' role. Thus rebellion against the king became rebellion against the gods.

Under this new theocratic regime the female god – formerly the friendly catalyst of production – became an arbitrary withholder of prosperity[20].

Soon enough, the rulers began building temples and monuments under the rationale that these things would help them connect with now-arbitrary gods, who had been removed to somewhere above, not with them on earth. The gods had become high and glorious, and the people were low and dirty. Only very special men who were very specially prepared could move between the two worlds. By convincing people that special men, massive structures and dramatic statements were necessary to reach the Gods, a larger share of crops and labor could be collected more easily.

The first priesthood and state theologies were developed at these times. Related to this is the fact that many monuments of this era featured inscriptions regarding the importance of properly worshiping the gods. Such inscriptions had relatively little religious importance to the rulers, rather, they were designed to encourage tax compliance. They were apparently the world's first propaganda campaigns.

Details varied from place to place and time to time, but since all the incentives of the time led directly to this line of development, it was, again, nearly inevitable. The subjects had acclimated to being ruled and the rulers wanted more power and glory. The rest was obvious.

This more elaborate religious model mentioned above began in Mesopotamia in about 5400 B.C. and was also present in Egypt at a very early date.

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[20] This change would have greatly affected the psyches of the farmers (almost certainly damaging them), making this a fascinating field of study. How might humans think of themselves and experience themselves differently if they presumed that the divine principle was with them, warm rather than aloof, and creating along-side them? And if they were included in the physical act of creation, in which divine magic erupted as sexual ecstasy? The issue here would not be the truthfulness of these beliefs, or even their broad usefulness, but the emotional health they might engender. Scientific examination in this area could be of great value.

One sows, another reaps.
-- Ancient Proverb

Our first farmers from Armenia suffer a fate common to a shocking number of the true innovators and benefactors of mankind: They were overtaken by aggressive and abusive outsiders who claimed the innovators' discoveries as their own. Worse, the names of the innovators – who paid the dues, who expended heroic effort, whose genius it was that created human progress – were completely forgotten, and their usurpers were given their credit. Humanity's greatest benefactors have thus suffered the greatest injustice. In this case, as in so many others, a modern proverb is ever bit as true as the ancient one shown above: *No good deed goes unpunished*[21].

An annotated time line of human life in Sumer[22] shows this process:

Prior to 6000 B.C.

Gardeners travel down the Tigris River from Armenia into the land that will eventually be called Sumer. Stumbling upon the fact that they could create permanent settlements in the Tigris-Euphrates valley, they remain and create stationary agriculture. In effect, they create civilization. They become, as Samuel Kramer says, the "first farmers, cattle-raisers, fishermen, weavers, leather workers, woodworkers, smiths, potters and masons." Nonetheless, we have no written record of these people, few artifacts and only traces of their language. We don't even have a name for them.

Shortly after the Tigris-Euphrates valley was settled, Semitic nomads from what are now Arabia and Syria began to raid the agriculturalists. At some point thereafter, they invade and remain,

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[21] This is so common that it indicates structural causes. The innovator is hated and the exceptionally healthy man must be eliminated. Humanity seeking comfort in stasis is a potential explanation, unfavorable contrast being punished is a similar cause, and others are possible. In any event, this is a phenomenon worthy of close examination: The smart kid is picked on, the superior man is despised, Jesus must die.

[22] This outline is partly upon Samuel Noah Kramer's essay, *Sumerian History, Culture and Literature*, which appears in the book *Inanna*, mentioned previously. Kramer (1897-1990) was one of the world's leading Assyriologists and a world-renowned expert in Sumerian history and Sumerian language. An Institute of Assyriology and Ancient Near Eastern Studies is named for him at Bar Ilan University in Tel Aviv, Israel. Recent studies and findings were also used.

setting themselves up as a dominant political group. In other words, they make themselves the first stationary rulers, collect a portion of the harvest every year and claim a monopoly on the right to dispense justice to the agriculturalists, all by force of arms.

6000-5400 B.C.

The agricultural settlements continue under the coercive rule of the nomads. Technologies and arts continue to develop, albeit more slowly.

5400 B.C.

A new group of invaders, apparently originating in central Eurasia, arrive from the north. These are more effective than the southern nomads and overrun them. They develop more efficient schemes of rulership and control. It is likely that they leave much of the previous ruling elite in place as middle-managers.

Eridu, the earliest city in southern Mesopotamia, is founded. Monuments and temples begin to be built. A new myth is propagated, re-telling the story of the goddess Inanna, and stating that she had to travel to Eridu in order to receive the gift of civilization. This is fundamental to the new strategy of using the gods to create the moral legitimacy of the rulers and to decrease the difficulty of tax collections.

Groups of cities are built around temples, almost within sight of one another.

5400-3000 B.C.

City-state governments continually organize and control daily life. Creativity decays.

3000 B.C.

A powerful ruler appears and organizes all of the city-states of the Tigris-Euphrates valley into a single empire. A list of kings calls this man Etana, and describes him as, “the shepherd, who ascended to heaven and consolidated all the foreign countries.”

3000-2000 B.C.

A variety of kings and dynasties rule and fight for rulership of what is now properly (and finally) called the Sumerian civilization.

They exercise great care in organizing and regulating human life. Creativity and production finally fail and the civilization irreversibly degrades.

2000-1750 B.C.

The death throes of civilization in the Tigris-Euphrates valley. They are overrun by the Babylonian empire of Hammurabi. The name, Sumer, ceases to be associated with any human group.

THE PROGRESSIVE CHOKING OF CREATIVITY

As illustrated by this time line, the great benefactors of humanity – the unnamed first farmers – experience a stunning explosion of creativity and very shortly found themselves the effective prisoners of barbaric, ignorant men who harnessed and slowly ruined what they had created.

At first, the farmers simply gave up a portion of their harvest and tried their best to work around the stupid, barbaric rulers. It was only when a more clever set of rulers arrived that the more serious damage began. This, more serious damage, was two-fold:

1. Piece by piece, their actions were restricted and monitored. It is difficult enough to create useful things when a man is fully unopposed, but if, before he acts, he must also consider whether or not he will be punished, creativity is forced to overcome additional and large obstacles. The more controls, observations and punishments, the fewer useful innovations arise.

2. More importantly, their range of thought was restricted. The imposition of a dominating, arbitrary, punishing god upon men's thoughts is inherently intimidating, and intimidation powerfully opposes creative thought. When men fear that new thoughts will be punished, they allow few to pass through their minds, and admit to even fewer.

It is important to remember that the cities we are discussing here were small by modern standards. That meant that the ruler was never terribly far away and there was often no dark corner to hide in. The watcher was close and records were kept. Hiding was difficult.

As successive waves of rulership rolled over the Tigris-Euphrates valley, the structures of government and their associated theologies and punishments occupied more and more of men's minds and activities.

During the semi-creative city-state period (5400-3000 B.C.) temple complexes like the one shown below[23] were common.

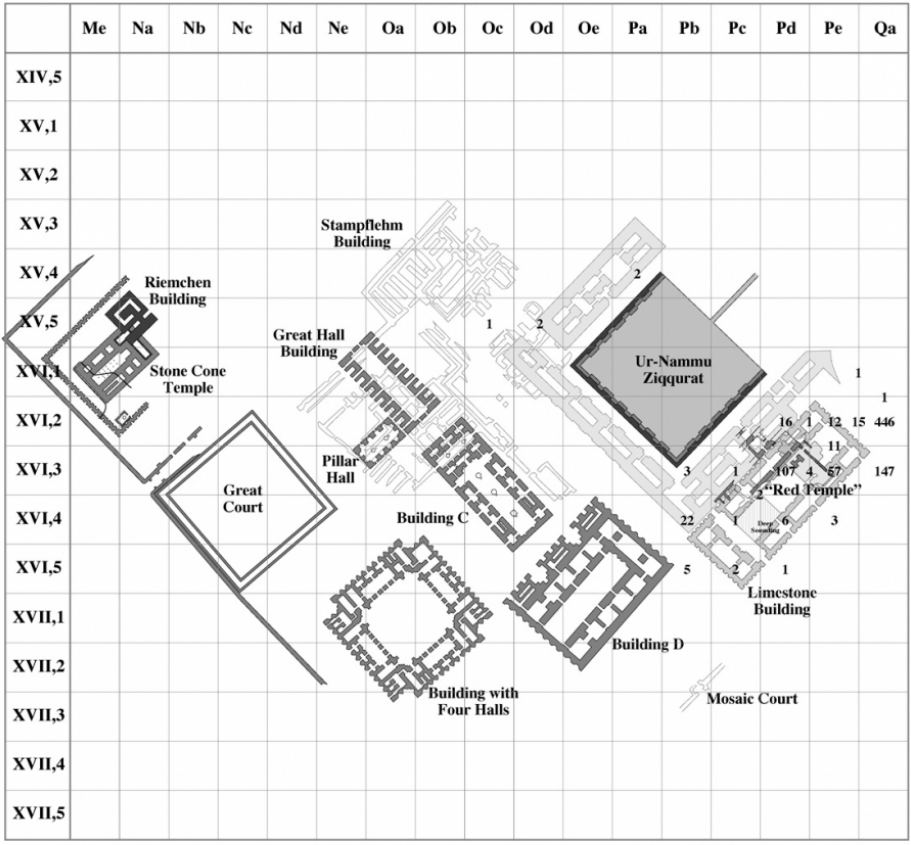


Image courtesy of R. K. Englund, UCLA

One of the primary features of these temple complexes was that they separated 'ordinary' men from their rulers and, especially, from the holy places. Restricted passages, courtyards, and great stairways had to be traversed in order to reach the important places. This had multiple effects:

- It instilled the idea that the rulers, priests and gods were of a different class than the average men. They were literally above and figuratively above.
- When a man was given access to the special places, he felt as though an honor was bestowed upon him. He had

[23] This is an excavation grid from the city of Uruk, which was constructed at about 3400 B.C.

attained a special status and enjoyed the feeling. He would now be considerably less likely to turn against the regime.

- The king, seeing that his subject was proud and moved to be admitted to his presence, was confirmed in his own eyes as being of a higher class of humans and worthy of rule. The kings of old often did consider themselves gods, and this effect of reflected glory contributed considerably to it.

- Occupying a position of power (able to call forth violence) and being associated with the gods, made the ruler a very powerful imposer of shame. That gave them a terribly powerful weapon to use in securing the acquiescence of their subjects.

Another function of the temple complex buildings and palace buildings were as halls of records. This love of control and order extended all through the years after 5400 B.C. For example, an archive has been unearthed at a city called Ebla, dating from 2350 B.C. The room was ringed with shelves and held approximately 2100 clay tablets. On the tablets were administrative records of:

- Textile accounts
- Metal accounts
- Tax deliveries
- Temple offerings
- Letters
- State reports
- Scribal exercises
- Villages (hundreds)
- Large animal herds (thousands of animals)
- A wool industry
- Large quantities of gold and silver
- Tribute paid to a superior city named Mari

This is but one example of Sumerian record-keeping. Thousands of additional tablets have been found, recording things such as:

- An appointment to a clerkship
- The establishment of a Food Office
- Legal documents in regard to slaves

- Legal document in regard to an office
- Agreements between parties
- Deed of sale of palm grove
- Deed of sale of a male slave
- Receipt of purchase money for a pair of slaves
- Documents in regard to loans of silver
- Promissory notes
- Acknowledgments of loans of grain
- Acknowledgment of loan of dates
- A bond
- Receipt for silver
- Receipts for grain
- Receipts for vegetables of various kinds
- Receipts for different kinds of beans
- Receipt for dates
- Receipts for figs
- Receipts for straw
- Accounts of the receipts for corn
- Account of the receipts for bronze
- Statement of silver, corn, oil, etc., received and at hand
- Statements of shiploads of grain delivered
- Statement of corn, wheat and vegetables delivered and at hand
- Statement of garments at hand
- Statement of chairs on hand
- Storehouse accounts: corn, wheat, grain, vegetables, beans, dates, bronze
- Accounts of the cost of the tilling of fields, as wages, feed of oxen,
- Renting of fields to different persons
- Account of fields, their measurements, condition
- Enumeration of belongings, as implements, weapons, victuals, silver
- Assignments of garments
- Expenditure of sesame oil
- Grain for the temple of En-lil
- Grain for temple offerings

- Flour and grain for temple offerings
- Temple offerings and porphyry stone for couches for the deities
- Lists of wages paid to officials, employees, artisans and laborers

A final and crucial area of importance was the general psychology of the people of Sumer. Enough records exist to reconstruct the general mind-set of the Sumerian period; that is, in the period of serious decline. Kramer says[24]:

> A Sumerian tended to take a tragic view of his fate and destiny. They were convinced that man was fashioned from clay and created for one purpose only: to serve the gods by supplying them with food, drink and shelter so that they might have leisure for their divine activities.

You can see here the result of the long centuries (millennia, in fact) of indoctrination by rulers and priests. Holding a tragic view of life means that very little action will be taken to change anything. By this point, these people had accepted that their role in life was little different than that of slaves or intelligent beasts of burden.

At about 2200 B.C., near the end of the Sumerian empire, a father writes this to his son:

> *Do not speak ill, speak only good. Do not say evil things, speak well of people. He who speaks ill and says evil---people will waylay him because of his debt to Shamash. Do not talk too freely, watch what you say. Do not express your innermost thoughts even when you are alone. What you say in haste you may regret later. Exert yourself to restrain your speech.*
>
> *Worship your god every day. Sacrifice and pious utterance are the proper accompaniment of incense. Have a freewill offering for your god, for this is proper toward a god. Prayer, supplication, and prostration offer him daily, then your prayer will be granted, and you will be in harmony with god.*

Note the caution, the uncertainty of mind, the fear of being impious. This is what control, regulation and fear breed. It created a mass of

[24] Again, from his essay *Sumerian History, Culture and Literature.*

people who were easy to rule but unable to adapt, arise or create. Thus Sumer, the place of humanity's greatest explosion of progress, descended into uselessness and was overrun in full.

By the time of the death of the Sumerian empire, rulers world-over were trying to conquer city after city and string them into empires. This lasted for more than five hundred years, during which time there were Egyptian, Babylonian, Hittite, Assyrian, Kassite and Elamite empires.

THE INVASIONS OF 1200 B.C.

The historical world that most of us know and understand actually begins in the aftermath of the Great Catastrophe of 1200 B.C. This event marks the "dawn of time" to the Hebrews, the Greeks, the Romans and to many others. They all seek to find their origins *after* this event, not before. As for the event itself: within forty or fifty years surrounding 1200 B.C., almost every significant city or palace in the eastern Mediterranean was destroyed, many never to be occupied again.

In effect, the decades surrounding 1200 B.C. erased the previous human civilization. The first civilizations of Sumer had ruined themselves and their replacements were not as hardy as the pre-Sumerian civilization had been. Egypt, which was able to (barely) survive the Great Catastrophe, was a shadow of its former self.

These civilizations had denuded themselves. In maximizing the technologies of rulership, they had irreversibly weakened the men and women upon whom all their actions ultimately depended. Kings, after all, do not till the soil and do not spin the wool themselves – their subjects do all those things. If the subjects were ever to simply stop performing their daily activities, the kings would be weakened immediately and would be unable to rule in a very short time. And, in these cases, having listless, unmotivated subjects ultimately ruined them. The "Sea Peoples" who attacked in 1200 B.C. were not listless, dull subjects – they were men on a mission – and they wiped out most of the old world in a moment.

MILITARY ADAPTION

The military adaptations that gave the invaders their advantage over the old empires were not works of genius. They were simple trial and error adaptations, along the lines of, "Gee, I wonder how it might work if we

tried this instead." But, regardless of the simplicity, the Sea Peoples[25] *did* think this way, while people of the old empires did not.

Late Bronze Age kingdoms (that is, at just this moment in time), both large and small, depended on armies that featured a chariot corp. A king's military might was measured in horses and chariots, and a kingdom with a thousand chariots was many times stronger than a kingdom with only a hundred chariots. What they didn't spend the effort to think about, however, was the possibility that a chariot force could become vulnerable to a new kind of infantry. The military model of the time was chariots being dispatched to scattered settlements in the king's area, both to collect taxes and to defeat competitors. (The competitors were always called "invaders.") And when the chariots were off collecting taxes, the cities were left unprotected.

We do have written records of precisely this from the period: One clay tablet was found – in a city named Ugarit, in what is now Syria – abandoned in an oven, apparently from the eve of the destruction of the city, just a few years after 1200 B.C. In the text, a man named Ydn writes to "the king, his master," that they are being attacked and requests the king to equip and send 150 ships. In an earlier tablet from the same place, the king of Ugarit writes to the king of Alashia, saying:

> *The enemy's ships came here; my cities were burned and they did evil things in my country. Does not my father know that all my troops and chariots are in the land of Lycia? … Thus, the country is abandoned to itself. May my father know it: the seven ships of the enemy that came here have inflicted much damage upon us.*

The ship-borne infantries that defeated great chariot armies during the Catastrophe used weapons and guerilla tactics that were characteristic of barbarian hill people but had never been tried en masse in the plains and against the centers of the Late Bronze Age kingdoms. It seems not to have occurred to people that infantrymen armed with javelins could defeat a force of chariots. But, once that lesson was learned, power shifted very rapidly from the existing kingdoms to collections of infantry

[25] Precisely who these people were is unknown and competing theories exist. In addition, the Sea Peoples may not have been the only groups involved with the sacking of the old world. Other groups may have simply observed the new military tactics and copied them, which allowed them to defeat the existing regimes.

warriors, many or most of whom seemed to arrive on boats, probably from the north end of the Mediterranean.

A chariot was essentially a mobile platform for an archer. Groups of charioteers would ride in circles around infantrymen – at a safe distance – and inflict damage until the infantry fled. Chariot versus chariot warfare was more hazardous, but neither side had any great advantage, so great conquests were uncommon. Chariots had been built in Mesopotamia since 3000 B.C. Horses seem to have been domesticated in the Volga region of what is now Russia at some time around 4500 B.C., and made their way to Mesopotamia some time before 3000 B.C.

The new military model of the Sea Peoples of 1200 B.C. consisted of three primary weapons:

1. Javelins. These were thin metal rods, less than an inch across and averaging about three feet long. When thrown by a trained man, they were deadly at about 30 meters and sometimes up to 50 meters. And, they were cheap and easy to make. These javelins were not generally thrown at the charioteers themselves, but at their horses. A horse, being a large target, was easy to hit. Then, once the horse was down, the charioteer was ill-suited to face the infantryman.
2. Light armor. This consisted of light body armor and round shields. The body armor was only enough to stop arrows at a distance. Several varieties from the period have been found, some better than others, but most featured metal plates and all were intended to protect the soldier from arrows. The round shield, though not very large (a few feet across) was well-balanced and could be moved quickly and accurately. Again, a good defense against arrows.
3. Long swords. Charioteers were generally equipped with shorter, thrusting swords and large shields. An infantryman with a long sword was very effective slashing the legs of a charioteer on foot. The infantryman could bring down the charioteer before the charioteer could get close enough to thrust his sword.

With these simple weapons, the “barbarians” assaulted, plundered and razed the richest palaces and cities of the previous order. The old empires showed no signs of adaptation in the face of the onslaught.

THE DEVASTATION

There are many records of the Catastrophe, and destruction by fire is almost always a major feature. Dozens of sites show a thick ash layer, meaning destruction by fire. In general, it seems that the smallest settlements were abandoned and that the larger settlements were looted and burned. Afterward, however, a large number of the major settlements were rebuilt. We may presume that the invaders made themselves rulers (which would be a sensible thing), but evidence sufficient to establish this or any other hypothesis seems to be lacking. Some of the more illustrative findings have been the following:

- One city in Southeastern Cyprus, Kokkinokremos, was abandoned suddenly, obviously as some threat approached. The bronze-smith hid copper ingots and tools in a pit in the courtyard, the silversmith hid two silver ingots and some scrap metal between two stones of a bench, and the goldsmith carefully buried all his jewelry and sheets of gold in a pit. Obviously, they hoped to return and recover their goods. They never did; the archaeologists found them. The smiths were almost certainly killed or enslaved.
- Another site on Cyprus was burned, but rebuilt and occupied for about a generation after the destruction, then abandoned permanently.
- After about 1180 B.C, Crete suddenly changes over to larger settlements in remote and protected places. In particular, the people fled to the mountains and rebuilt there. In other words, the organizational structure changed. This was certainly true in Crete, and we can fairly safely assume, in other places.

THE RESULTANT DARK AGE

> *Whenever God prepares evil for a man, He first damages his mind, with which he deliberates.*
> -- Anonymous, from ancient Greece

After this devastation followed a period of several hundred years called a "Dark Age." Historians call this period the *Greek Dark Age*, the *Dark Age of The Ancient Middle East* or the *Collapse of The Bronze Age*. All descriptions begin at about 1200 B.C. and all last for several hundred years. During this period, humans reverted to a simple farming existence with local thug-types of rulers and very, very few innovations. Actually, the

similarities of this period and the much later "Dark Ages" period of European history are striking:

- In both cases, a long-established, hierarchical, bureaucratic, old order failed.
- Life prior to the collapses featured peaks in the control of the state over the lives of men and, especially, peaks of involving the thoughts of men in and around their state/church system.
- The remaining social structure, having been previously legitimized by the state, was left with no inherent legitimacy or prestige. Things that were previously considered by all "right-thinking men" to be the god-ordained order of the world, were suddenly made valueless.
- The previous religions – again, tied directly to the state – were left without moral legitimacy and were generally abandoned.
- A period on the order of four hundred years was required for humans to readjust and to resume any type of broad forward movement.

The collapse of the Roman empire and the collapse of the empires of old Mesopotamia were of different characters, but the aftermath of the falls had many similarities. At the root of these prolonged dark periods was human psychology, and in particular, the ripping apart of their emotional stability when the state/church establishment – then occupying a very large portion of their mental landscape – evaporated.

This must be stated clearly: All states of all periods share a common foundation: A group of subjects who accept rulership. Without the minds of the subjects being malleable and willing to serve, no strong state has ever existed[26], or indeed could exist. All states – everywhere and at all times – work to keep their subjects willing and to induce their subjects to identify with the state. This applies to democratic regimes, socialist regimes, republics, monarchies, theocracies or any other ruling arrangements. It is simply impossible to rule without the minds of most of the people accepting you as legitimate in one way or another. Fear and

[26] A pre-state, such as the rule of invader nomads over a relatively few farmers mentioned earlier, can exist on a simple model of persistent, violent plunder. Organization beyond that point, however, requires middle managers and some level of willingness on the part of the populace.

terror *can* work, but not for long and not easily. If the people are unwilling, the state will fail soon enough.

Previous to the collapse of 1200 B.C., the minds of the subjects were at a peak of being filled with the state/church ideology and their thoughts were almost continually guided by, and kept within, the boundaries of the broader state culture. The advice of the Sumerian father to his son shown earlier was a striking example of this: the father didn't want the son to speak unapproved thoughts, even in private. Added to this was the fact that state regulation was at a peak; life was regulated and unapproved actions were recorded and punished. Thinking and acting beyond the acceptable limits set by the state were punished. The more that records were kept, the more likely guilt could be proven and the unruly mind punished. Over generations, this has a profound affect upon men.

In the cases of both Dark Ages, the "ruled" were mentally and emotionally undeveloped, regardless of their physical age. Rather than developing as individuals, these people had, to a variable but significant extent, ceded their decision-making responsibilities to their rulers. States, of course, always demand that individuals place their decision-making in subjection to the state's, but the amount of mental territory ceded to the state varies, and in this case had been quite high and greatly prolonged.

When the glorious state/church entity, their intellectual and emotional partner, failed, these people were lost, and remained so for generations. The people of Europe, for example, took almost every opportunity to pretend that they were still living in a Roman Empire for a thousand years after Rome was nearly desolate and the Empire broken. Why would they do that in, say, 950 A.D., for anything but an emotional need? They had still not learned how to replace the Empire's place in their emotional lives. They needed its prestige and honor – building their own was much harder than getting it from the state/church complex.

When a respected and established order is somehow removed, the people who lived under it wish for it back, and if they can, they will fight to restore it. This occurred in the wake of the Great Pestilence of 1348 A.D. (now referred to as the Black Plague). The circumstances between peasants and lords were irrevocably altered by the death of half the populace and the peasants had a stellar opportunity to improve their economic positions. But in actual fact, many of them did not want a new situation and fought its development. (The nobles fought as well, but this was not surprising, being a straightforward attempt to protect their advantages.) The peasants wanted the old ways back – not because it was

advantageous for them. The external reason for this was that they had rights and privileges guaranteed under the old system, and they did not want to give them up. The internal reason differed, however, and it was that they had lost a center of reference for their thoughts and felt lost without it.

Another way of understanding the cause of Dark Ages is with the concept of Higher Powers.[27] A Higher Power is a non-physical entity, to whom people attribute some special power or value. Gods and states are the two most common forms. People very commonly imagine how deities or states would expect them to think or behave rather than making the raw judgments themselves. Thus the Higher Powers are deeply involved in the daily thought patterns of many, many people. So, when those Higher Powers are removed, the individual experiences a shock of aloneness and feeling of loss. For long periods of time they pretend that the higher powers still exist or that they will soon return.

The development of a self-contained personal identity is a lengthy and arduous process. Most men are all too happy to take short-cuts. This suits rulers (of whatever flavor) perfectly. With a bit of pomp, impressive buildings, elaborate ceremonies and some nicely-spun national myths, they can give their subjects a fast, easy way to fill their developmental voids. When this trick fails, however, people are left grasping at nothing and recovery is very slow.

THE GREAT TRADE

During the years between 5400 and 3000 B.C., a great trade took shape; a trade between great numbers of humans and the hierarchical states that ruled them. This was a trade, not of money and goods or even of fear and safety. Instead, it was a psychological trade. And, being psychological (thus internal) meant that the trade was difficult to clearly identify.

It is highly unlikely that this trade was purposely developed. Rather, it arose unexpectedly as several factors came into play in the same place and time:

- The painful conflicts built into human character.
- Rulers trying to convince their subjects to pay taxes willingly.
- A populace with their actions increasingly constrained by regulations.

[27] This subject is covered in depth by myself and Sean Hastings in *God Wants You Dead*.

- A populace with their thoughts increasingly constrained by fear of punishment.

The first point above is of great importance. Humans are *internally conflicted* beings. This is inherent in human nature – we are all born to it and suffer accordingly.

We love family, we seek faithful mates; we know that children are happier and better when they are raised with two loving, committed parents. Yet, we have animal mating instincts that would drive us to other sexual partners.

Likewise, we see and value hard work, honest dealing and loyalty. Yet, we have impulses that would drive us to grab what is available in front of us, whether it be honest or not.

This set of inherent conflicts can certainly be trained and controlled to a very considerable extent (in fact, most of us do control ourselves quite well most of the time), but it takes considerable time and effort, and thus remains a universal problem. It has driven many developments in religion and philosophy… indeed, it is involved in almost all expressions of religion to a greater or lesser extent.

The crucial factor here is simply that most men and women *do* feel conflicted, insecure and confused, and that they lack the time, skill or desire to fix the problem. It is too hard. So, they find ways to work around it, most notably to seek belonging in a group, with the half-conscious thought that by being merely one of many, blame and shame will not attach to them.

The Great Trade was and is this:

> *The state and/or church presents themselves to men as a superior entity – higher than man. To be joined to them provides sanction from a higher source than that of their internal conflicts.*

In our times we often hear this expressed as: *People need to belong to something larger than themselves.* They need to sublimate their confusion and conflicts into a higher entity.

In effect, the man or woman's internal conflicts become less important than the entity to which they are joined. It is the great assurance from the great adult, and it is ever-so-easy to accept, since perhaps every other human you've ever known has done the same.

Note that blame for this trade does not lie with the state. Frankly speaking, the rulers weren't smart enough to have figured this out in advance. They merely watched as it developed and slowly learned how to take advantage of it. The majority of blame lies with the people who flocked to the deal. Again, it was so much easier than having to make peace with one's self.

This trade is the magic secret of politics and of rulership. People *wanted* the Divine Right of Kings. They *need* to think of their Leader as a superior being. Rulers and politicians merely play their roles as public theater.

You can also see from this why political science is so seldom scientific: The magic ingredient buried in it is anything but, and indeed, may not be explicitly named without calling millions of comfort-transactions into question.

ANALYZING THE CHARACTER OF THE SUBJECTS

We have now been analyzing the charters of the subjects at some length, but before we leave the subject, it is important to explain why such discussions have some validity. After all, making grand pronouncements about millions of greatly-varying individuals is beyond the scope of normal human ability and this tends to make such discussions seem almost arrogant. However, it is, in some very important ways, easier to analyze many than it is one, so long as we realize that any individual may vary from our conclusions. This is actually the same technique that is used in the analysis of gasses:

Trying to analyze the motions of each individual molecule of a gas is a practical impossibility. They push against each other randomly, impart momentum back and forth, and travel at constantly varying rates of speed. To measure each one, chart each one and determine from a study of $10x10^{24}$ individual molecules what will happen from compressing them would be a ridiculous waste of time and energy, presuming that we had the capacity even to do it. But we *can* tell – almost perfectly – what a volume of gas will do, if we take it as a whole. Compress it and it heats, decompress it and it cools. This we can determine with great precision. In the same way, we are often more accurate in analyzing the character of a mass of humans than we are when trying to analyze just one.

THE CHARACTER OF THE RULERS

One final but important area of exploration is the mind of the ruler. Rulers and subjects generally face very different sets of incentives, which greatly affect not only their actions, but their attitudes.

A first fact to reestablish is that the rulers of this era were generally from a different cultural background than that of their subjects. As mentioned earlier, the consciences of these people were informed by sky gods who imposed power from above and by clan groupings that featured dominance and structure. They were emotionally suited to plunder. Thus, to rule over others was far easier for them than it would have been for average farmers.

Perhaps the primary incentive for these rulers was simply to stay in power. One reason for this was simply that humans experience increased levels of pleasurable hormones[28] when in positions of power. It literally feels good. Another was that being deposed could mean death. Add to that the related perks of status and wealth, and not many rulers walked away from power. Plus, they wanted to pass this great advantage along to their children, and to see them prosper and rule after them.

The incentives above, however, are fairly common among rulers of every era. What set this era's rulers apart was the need for ferocity. Whether (early) to get farmers to capitulate, or (late) to keep sub-rulers in obedience when you were away, the newness of the rulership enterprise plus the extremely low population density made extending power difficult. Ruling one settlement could be done fairly well if the settlement was not large and if you remained there. But if you wished to rule another three or four nearby settlements as well, you needed to extend your power. And, since soldiers were expensive, other methods were required.

This difficulty was solved with ferocity and fear. The rulers of this era were especially willing to boast of the horrible pain and punishments they inflicted upon anyone who rose against them or refused them. They wanted people to hear about these things and to fear disobedience[29].

And, as mentioned in the previous section, the ruler had to play the role of being a better class of human, embodying the Higher Power.

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[28] Seratonin in particular.

[29] It is of some interest that the first ruler of men mentioned in the Bible is also the first man with an impressive legend: Nimrod, the mighty hunter.

Here are a few quotations from the period:

The Assyrian ruler, Ashurnasirpal II:

> *I stormed the mountain peaks and took them. In the midst of the mighty mountain I slaughtered them, and, with their blood, dyed the mountain red like wool… I carried off their spoil and their possessions. The heads of their warriors I cut off, and I formed them into a pillar over against their city. Their young men and their maidens I burned in the fire… I flayed all the chief men who had revolted and I covered the pillar with their skins; some I walled up within the pillar; some I impaled upon the pillar on stakes… Many within the border of my own land I flayed, and I spread their skins upon the walls, and I cut off the limbs of the royal officers who had rebelled.*

The Poem of Culgi:

> *I, the king, was a hero already in the womb; I, Culgi, was born to be a mighty man. I am a fierce-looking lion, begotten by a dragon. I am the king of the four regions; I am the herdsman and shepherd of the black-headed people. I am a respected one, the god of all the lands.*

King Lipit-Ectar:

> *I am a king treated with respect, good offspring from the womb. I am Lipit-Ectar, the son of Enlil. From the moment I lifted my head like a cedar sapling, I have been a man who possesses strength in athletic pursuits. As a young man I grew very muscular. I am a lion in all respects, having no equal.*
>
> *I am a gaping dragon, a source of great awe for the soldiers. I am like the Anzud bird, peering about in the heart of the mountains. I am a wild bull whom nobody dares oppose in its anger. I am a bison, sparkling with beautiful eyes, having a lapis-lazuli beard.... With my kind eyes and friendly mouth, I lift people's spirits. I have a most impressive figure, lavishly endowed with beauty. I have lips appropriate for all words. As I lift my arms, I have beautiful fingers. I am a very handsome young man, fine to admire.*
>
> *I am Lipit-Ectar, king of the Land. I am the good shepherd of the black-headed. I am the foremost in the foreign*

countries, and exalted in the Land. I am a human god, the lord of the numerous people. I am the strong heir of kingship. Holding my head high, I am established in my position.

3

Classical Civilization

Our love of what is beautiful does not lead to extravagance; our love of the things of the mind does not make us soft.
-- Pericles

Even though there was a long and dark period following the catastrophe of 1200 B.C., men did, eventually, re-gather themselves and begin to move forward again. But this was not a cold restart. Tremendous amounts of knowledge had been assembled and passed-on. Men knew what had been done and more or less how to do it. They still may have suffered from a delusion that a great hierarchical empire was necessary as a catalyst for human progress (as evidenced by the fact that they kept trying to rebuild them, and perhaps by the fact that hierarchy is still considered necessary and good), but they did understand many things, such as:

- Farming.
- The calendar and seasons.
- Trade.
- Seafaring.
- Rudimentary navigation.
- Basic mathematics.
- The use of currency.

- Accounting.
- Reading and writing.
- Metallurgy. (Brass, copper, iron.)
- Military technologies.
- Music.
- Art.

The Greek Dark Age was shockingly long. The previous, warlike, Mycenaean civilization vanished at some point between 1200 and 1150 B.C., along with writing and many other things. Stunningly, no visible progress occurs for almost four hundred years. As shown above, there was not an absolute lack of knowledge at this time, especially for the Greeks, whose lives were closely aligned with the sea. All through these dark years, there did remain a sea-faring culture that had not failed at 1200 B.C. – the Phoenicians. This Semitic merchant culture was thriving in the Mediterranean during this time and they definitely had outposts where they interacted with Greeks. The later Greeks (after the roughly four hundred years of silence) certainly borrowed heavily from the Phoenicians, who had long organized themselves into city-states and collaborated in leagues or alliances when threatened. They also developed the first alphabet.

The Phoenicians thrived between 1550 B.C. and 300 B.C., a period that is interestingly offset from land-based civilizations of the era, and is, also interestingly, in synch with the Biblical narrative of the Semitic Hebrew civilization.

In any case, the Greeks most certainly had retained knowledge available to them. Nonetheless, they were unable to use it for four hundred years. Again, this indicates an internal, psychological, reason for dark ages, and not external reasons.

Power devolved throughout this period, ending up in the hands of aristocracies. Slowly, equality grew among the different sects of people, leaving the fundamental unit of organization as the family. It seems to have been at this point that development re-started.

THE RISE OF THE INDEPENDENT MYTH-MAKER

When the Greeks did begin to recover themselves, one of the first things they did was to create stories. This was not mere entertainment, but

stories with moral lessons as central elements. And, very importantly, these stories were not sponsored by, censored by or approved by any state institution at all. They evolved almost entirely separate from imposed authority. Stories were accepted and writers rewarded solely upon merit. A good story-teller would prosper and a bad one would not.

Homer seems to be the first great Greek poet to arise. He was, as is still commonly known, the author of *The Iliad* and *The Odyssey*, and seems to have lived and written in the late 9th Century B.C., close to four hundred years after the great Catastrophe. Herodotus says that Homer lived four hundred years before his own time, which would place him at around 850 B.C.[30]

Sappho was another famed and early Greek poet, living approximately between 620 B.C.and 570 B.C. In history and poetry texts, she is sometimes associated with the city of Mytilene on the island of Lesbos. Sapho's poetry was well-known and greatly admired throughout antiquity. Most was lost, but her immense reputation has endured and is attested to by a few fragments of her works that have survived.

Many other poets flourished between the 5th and 7th Centuries B.C., creating all sorts of stories and songs, covering virtually all aspects of life and generally conveying some sort of message.

Recitations of poetry, especially Homer, were very popular at Greek festivals of the period. By the 5th Century, there were a great number of playwrights, such as Thespis, Aeschylus, Sophocles, Euripides and Aristophanes. Theater performances were extremely popular and were little-connected to the state. What we think of as entertainment began in Greece, and it was one of the primary ways in which the Greeks revived themselves and came out of their dark age.

It is very important to understand that the Greek myths were a radical departure from those of previous civilizations; they were written so that people could find meaning in them. The holy writings of the previous state/church systems were primarily rules of behavior. *Do this, and things will go well.* The Greeks had stories that were meant to address the reader's inner life. The theologies of the empires addressed men's actions; the Greeks had stories that addressed men's souls. And there was something else… in the Greek myths, men were not small, insignificant, and

[30] Some modern scholars question Homer's actually existence, much as they do Shakespeare's. His writings, however, are evidence of his existence, as are the beliefs of all the ancients (including Herodotus). Added to this, there is no direct evidence that speaks otherwise.

powerless before the gods. In the Greek myths, man challenged the gods, and sometimes won! They beat the gods through superior thinking. This was a radically new intellectual development.

THE SEPARATION OF KNOWLEDGE AND STATE

During the long period prior to 1200 B.C., there were very strong ties between knowledge and state/church systems. The intellectuals of the era – the priests – were the keepers of the most important technical information of the time, astronomical knowledge. They spent considerable time studying the positions of the sun, moon and stars during the various seasons and their association with precipitation, freezes and floods. The obvious reason for this was to keep track of the right times to plant their crops. They built a variety of naked-eye observatories, usually featuring a round, artificial horizon and a set of posts or pillars around the edge as measuring devices. Then, after a few years, they could predict with some assurance when the last freeze or flood might be expected. This system was eventually replaced by the calendar, but the important issue is that this knowledge was strongly controlled by the state/church system, with the knowledge often being mysticized. This was, obviously, useful to the cause of rulership.

Mechanical and other types of knowledge prior to this time generally concerned technologies, not science per se. In other words, it concerned the end uses of things, not the operating principles. The Greeks, however, were about to change that forever, and the first of them to do so seems to have been a man named Thales.

Before Thales (624 B.C.-546 B.C., but these dates are uncertain), Greeks explained the origin and nature of the world through myths of gods and heroes. Phenomena such as lightning or earthquakes were attributed to actions of the gods. Thales attempted to find reasoned explanations of the world, without presuming the supernatural. In other words, he and others like him began to inquire not just about *how* things worked, but *why* they worked.

According to Herodotus, Thales used his knowledge to predict a solar eclipse[31]. This would have been a monumental thing in the ancient days, equivalent to being able to read the mind of god. It was certainly a story that was much-repeated. Some of Thales' conclusions later proved to be

[31] This seems to have been the eclipse of May 28, 585 B.C. as determined by modern astronomic calculations.

highly inaccurate (such as the belief that the continents floated on the oceans and that earthquakes were caused by collisions), but his method of looking for reasons was a gigantic leap forward.

Thales was a moral teacher as well. A few of his still-valid and highly-influential principles were these:

> *That for which we blame others, let us not do ourselves.*
>
> *Be rich, yes, for success is sweet. However, do not be rich badly.*
>
> *A happy man is one who is healthy in body, resourceful in soul and of a readily teachable nature.*

It is with Pythagorus, however, that modern science begins to take shape. Pythagoras seems to have lived between 580 and 490 B.C., though, again, these dates are not certain. His pivotal discovery was that music was based on proportional intervals of the numbers one through four. He believed that this number system, and therefore the universe's system, was based on the sum of the numbers 1, 2, 3 and 4, which is 10. Pythagoreans swore by these numbers (which they called "the Tetrachtys of the Decad"), rather than by the gods.

According to legend[32], Pythagoras discovered that musical notes could be translated into mathematical equations one day as he passed blacksmiths at work and thought that the sounds emanating from their anvils (when struck) were beautiful and harmonious. He decided that whatever scientific law caused this must be mathematical and could be applied to music. He spent time observing the blacksmiths to learn how this had happened. He examined their tools and discovered that it was because the anvils were simple ratios of each other, one was half the size of the first, another was 2/3 the size, and so on.

Pythagorus thus discovered the numerical basis of musical harmony. He spent a great deal of time examining this subject and decided that all of the universe could be understood and predicted with numbers. It was one of the most important intellectual discoveries in history and almost all subsequent science has used this fundamental premise.

Pythagous went on to discover the trigonometric theorem named after him, the square root, that the earth was round, that all planets have an axis, and that all the planets travel around one central point. He also went

[32] And all we really have are legends, as none of his writings remain to our time.

on to form a complex cultic group around his teachings and became highly secretive. After this point Pythagorus, or at least his followers, seem to have become overly-enamored with their own doctrines and ran boldly into grand pronouncements for which they had no evidence. The Pythagoreans developed a series of mystical beliefs that later affected Plato.

LANGUAGE

One final issue of importance was the language that the Greeks spoke. Their Indo-European grammar, with its categories of gender, its sharp distinction of person and number, and its great emphasis on chronological tense, instilled in them (as it does in most every Indo-European speaker) a certain level of logical attitude toward life.

This is not a minor point, and the Indo-European languages differ in this way from others, such as the languages of the Far East which emphasize relative class levels. What people assume[33] in their speech has a powerful effect upon them.

HAVING THIS MIND IN THEM…

Because of the mountainous and irregular geography of Greece, stringing city-states together into an empire was a difficult thing to do. Certainly it was tried, but the obstacles were significant and a single organization was never able to dominate the civilization. Because of this they never developed a strong nationalistic priesthood that served the state. Their mythology became more a set of moralistic fables than a theology. Then, with an intellectual life fully separate from rulership or a priesthood, these men and women examined human grouping and military defense in the light of reason, more or less independent from mythology. Their thoroughly sensible and practical organizational methods of democratic city-states and temporary defense alliances were developed from this base.

Greek applications of democracy included such practical measures as random drawings for public duties and a mandate that an attempt was made at a private settlement before almost any case could be brought to court.

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[33] The important thing is that these things are learned in early childhood, when we have very little analytical ability. After that, they are assumed and rarely analyzed.

The basic unit of politics in Ancient Greece was the *polis*, or city-state. Each city was essentially independent. Some cities might be subordinate to others (a colony traditionally deferred to its mother city), some might have governments dependent upon others, but the supreme power of each city was located within that city. This meant that when Greece went to war, it took the form of an alliance going to war. It also allowed for wars within Greece, between different cities.

The Greeks exhibited a vigorous, healthy intellectual life. Those wealthy enough to enjoy leisure went to the *gumnasion*, which was a place to exercise both mind and body. They flocked to watch Greek tragedy, a subtle and sophisticated medium. And, as evinced by their public art, they had a keen eye for technical as well as artistic excellence.

At the same time, the early Greeks exhibited considerable control over base appetites and grasping desires. The freemen of the Assembly (their legislative body) could have voted themselves whatever they liked, such as generous pensions for life, but they did not.

The well-rounded natures of the early Greeks were highly admirable, and their general situation lasted for a few hundred years, until Athens found itself in a position to lord it over the other cities… and did.

ATHENS LEADS GREECE INTO THE WAY OF ALL EMPIRES

In the wake of the Persian Wars (491–479 B.C.), Greek city-states formed a voluntary alliance, "to exact vengeance by ravaging the Persian king's lands." And, as vengeance so often does, it led them all into trouble and to their eventual downfall, as the alliance was converted into an Athenian empire[34].

The alliance – called the Delian League because its treasury was on the island of Delos – was formed in 478 B.C. led by Athens. Policy decisions were made at meetings on Delos, where all members had one vote. Athens calculated the states' annual contributions, which were made in either warships or in cash. The League was especially popular among Greek states most open to Persian attack, located on the western coast of Asia Minor (modern Turkey) and the islands offshore.

[34] It is highly ironic, but this story line would make an excellent Greek Tragedy.

At first things went well and membership of the League reached nearly 200 states. But signs of dissatisfaction with Athens began to appear. The islands of Naxos and Thasos tried to secede, the latter in a dispute with Athens over mining and trading rights. Athens forced them back. Around 454 B.C., the League treasury was moved from Delos to Athens. At about the same time, Athens started planting settlements of Athenians on 'allied' territory. When cities began attempting secession later, Athenian 'overseers' and 'garrison commanders' took control.

Around 450 B.C. a final peace was made with Persia, but Athens saw to it that the League kept going. By this time, only three states contributed ships, and all the rest money. Athenian inscriptions relating to the League began to read: *The cities which the Athenians control.* Pericles (the renowned wise man of Athens) admitted that Athens had become, "like a tyranny."

What had started as a free union of states pursuing mutual interests slowly turned into an empire run by the Athenians pursuing their own interests. It would still be some time before Greece would reap the rewards of this moral devolution, but this was the turning point and no one went about to reverse it. Even Pericles acquiesced, saying that if it was dangerous to start it, "it would be worse to let it go."

In 405 B.C., the Spartan general Lysander virtually destroyed the Athenian fleet. Athens surrendered one year later, to end the Peloponnesian War. The war had left devastation in its wake. Many of the cities were unhappy with the Spartan dominance that followed, and this induced the Thebans to attack. They defeated Sparta at the Battle of Leuctra in 371 B.C., inaugurating a period of Theban dominance in Greece.

In 346 B.C., unable to prevail in its ten year war with Phocis, Thebes called upon Philip II of Macedon for aid, and he quickly conquered the exhausted cites of Greece. The basic unit of politics from that point on was the empire, and the golden age of Greece had fully ended. The conquests of Alexander did follow, but they were very short-lived and contrary to almost all that had once been considered Greek. Within 150 years, Greece became an unremarkable province of Rome, and nothing more.

REPRISE: THE WRONG GUYS GET THE CREDIT

In this case, again, it can be seen that the wrong people have been given the credit for human advancement. The Athenians, who fell heir to the creations of earlier Greeks, have generally been heralded as the great developers and examples, when it was, in actual fact, they who ruined the operation.

This is almost identical to the situation we explained in the previous chapter, where the people who have been given the credit for creating the first civilization, inventing the wheel, and so on, were not the ones who actually did it, but were rather the usurpers and destroyers of human progress. As we explained, the Sumerians were a much later group of people than the early creators, and they presided over the final decline and destruction of that civilization.

A few lines are in order to explain why this is[35]. The key reasons are the following:

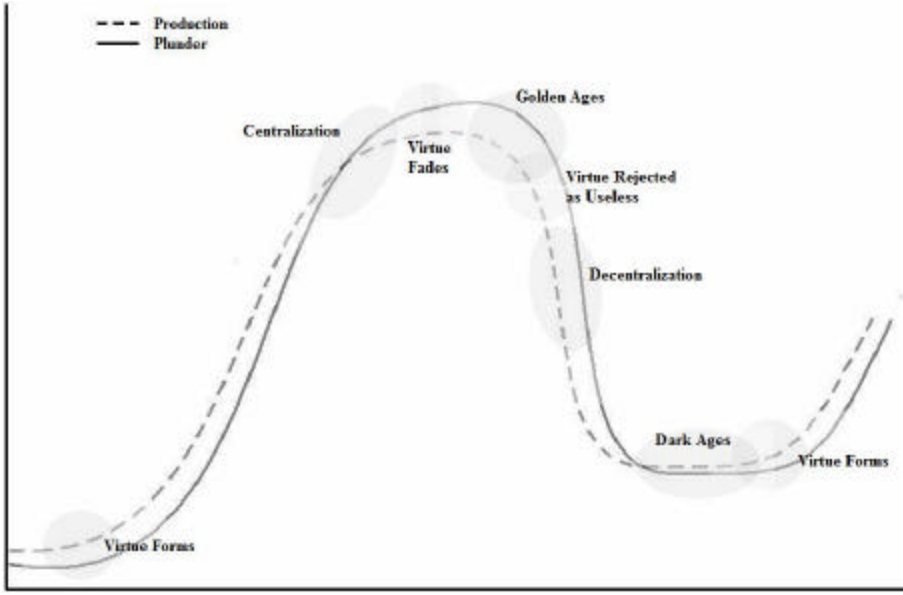
- The things that are easiest to repeat tend to be those that *are* most repeated. Instead of explaining the (complex) actual events, it is easier to say, "Sumeria and Athens." This is what is incessantly repeated to school-children and it is what tends to stick.
- In both of these cases, creation was fairly quickly overrun by ruling structures and absorbed. Not only are those who take-over diligent to claim credit, but the true creators almost never do. So, the only story passed-down is that of the usurper.
- The proliferation of goods does not take place at the moment of creation, but only after a significant period of time. New creations are almost always opposed at the beginning, are finally accepted, and only then begin to spread far and wide. (The idea, after all, survives the death of its creator.) As a practical matter, it took centuries for the discoveries of the Armenian farmers and the early Greeks to spread and to produce mass results. Commentators are frequently unaware of this fact and give credit to the people who were in charge when the goods proliferated.

[35] We are straying a bit from our subject matter here (and into popular culture), but I think it is warranted, since almost all of my readers will have had similar experiences to my own – wherein the Sumerians and the Athenians were given credit for the advances of mankind and our true benefactors were never mentioned.

- Museums and archaeologists have long been closely aligned with large institutions and have shared a 20th Century over-respect for things large; also, the 20th Century's over-regard for things centralized and hierarchical. In both of these cases, largeness and centralization came at the end of the development cycle.

But, for whatever reasons, credit has gone to the usurpers and the wasters of human progress. One sows, another reaps. Productivity is overrun by plunder.

The following graph shows this process in a highly generalized form.



This production/plunder cycle plays itself out in the following way[36]:

- Virtues form after cycles have bottomed out.
- Production follows virtue.
- Centralization feeds upon production.
- A Golden Age occurs when plunder is at a peak, and is characterized by monuments, public works and self-glorification.

[36] Note that this graph shows the same set of relationships as those between host and parasite and those of prey and predator.

- Virtues are overrun by the forces of centralization. This leads to a loss of production, but not immediately. The lag period may be a century or more.

- Centralization fails some years (possibly centuries) after production fails.

- After a long period of decentralization and psychological reset, virtues again form, beginning a new cycle.

COMETH ROME

Rome deviates from the cultural pattern we have been examining, in that their creativity was not home-grown and they did not simply overrun nearby creative peoples. Instead, they gathered to themselves the good ideas of distant peoples and made use of them, without trying to subjugate the creators. This may sound contrary, since Rome is known as a conquering state, but it should be stated, on Rome's behalf, that they didn't originally go about to conquer everything in sight, as Alexander had when he ruled Greece. There were simply competitors who would have gladly conquered Rome if they could. So, Rome conquered them first. Naked acquisition was an issue late, but not early.

Rome began, as best archaeologists can determine, in the 8th century B.C., comprised of people in two fortified settlements and another in the nearby woods. One settlement was on Palatine Hill (called *Rumi*) and the other on Quirinal Hill (called *Titientes*). The people in the woods were called the *Luceres.* These were three of numerous Italic-speaking communities that had formed in *Latium*, a plain on the Italian peninsula, by the 1st millennium B.C. The origins of these people is not known, but their Indo-European languages migrated from the east in the years between 1500 B.C. and 1000 B.C.[37]

The group that most affected the early Romans were the Etruscans, who lived north of Rome in Etruria (modern Tuscany and northern Lazio). Their influence is shown by the Roman list of kings (largely mythical), in which some names were Etruscan. The gladiatorial displays that we think of as Roman actually evolved out of Etruscan funeral customs. The

[37] Languages can be very effectively traced by specialists, and provide an excellent tool for tracking the movements of peoples. Since the people who became Romans came from the east in the time-frame of 1500-1000 B.C., it is quite likely that they fled the Catastrophe of 1200 B.C., then settled in Latium.

Romans learned to build temples from the Etruscans, and they may also have introduced the worship of a triad of gods, Juno, Minerva, and Jupiter, taken from the Etruscan gods, Uni, Menrva, and Tinia. Religion was a form of cult, hallowed by tradition, centered on rituals carried out in the right way at the right time. At its heart was sacrifice (which meant, literally, "making sacred"). With luck, the god you honored with valuable goods (your sacrifices) would then answer your prayers, the most common of which were to be safe, prosperous, fertile and healthy.

When Romans found new gods in new cultures, they assimilated them, if at all possible, into their pantheon. Minucius Felix, in the 3rd Century A.D. says, *All nations have their own gods, but Rome welcomes the lot.* Felix attributed Rome's success to this. Again, Rome would rather absorb than conquer.

The questions of where the Etruscans came from has intrigued archaeologists for some time. The Greek historian Herodotus says that the Etruscans emigrated from Lydia, a region in western Turkey. Recent genetic studies[38] point to the conclusion that Etruscan culture was imported to Italy from somewhere in the Near East. Etruscan settlements were frequently built on a very steep hill and surrounded by thick walls, arguing for organizing principles that were informed by the great Catastrophe of 1200 B.C., which, presumably, they fled.

After about 650 B.C., the Etruscans expanded into north-central Italy. Expanding also to the south, the Etruscans came into direct contact with the Greeks. After initial success in conflicts with Greek colonists in southern Italy, Etruria went into a decline. Taking advantage of this, Rome rebelled and gained independence from the Etruscans in approximately 500 B.C. It also abandoned its monarchy and replaced it with a republican system.

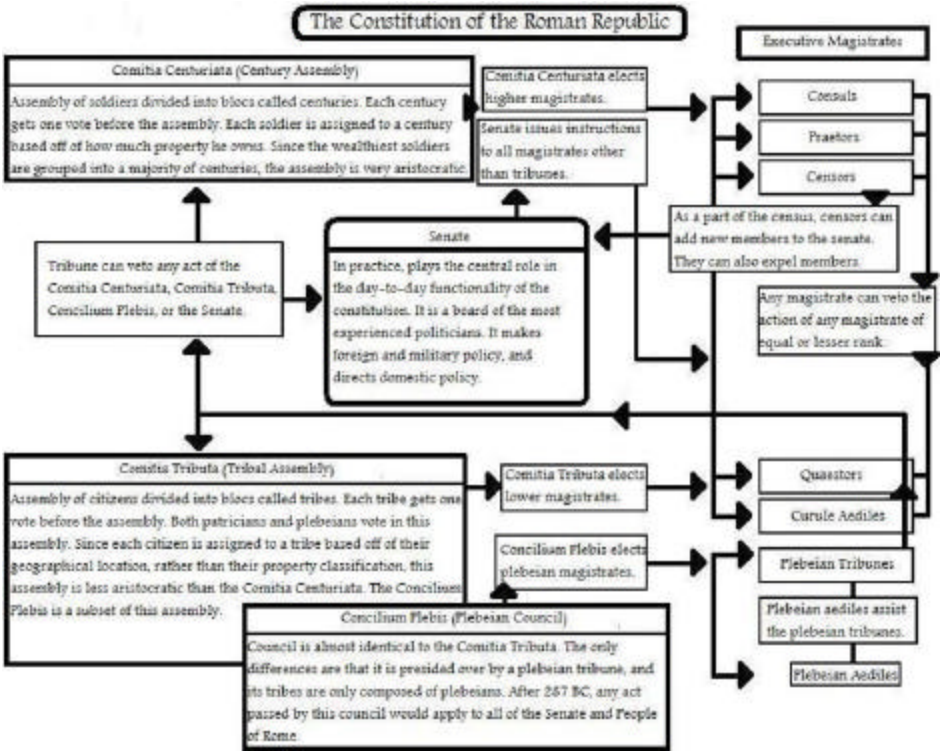
The republic was a scalable form of democracy had been tried in a few Greek cities previously. A democracy worked well for a single city where the participants (which included only a fraction of the entire populace) were all conscious of the effects of their actions and would expect to feel them. A republic, however, added a layer of representatives, moving the citizens one step further away from the actual use of power. This was the birth of the politician. Under city-state democracy, those who could vote did so directly; they decided and the decision was implemented. The republic, however, required a new layer of professional decision-makers.

[38] See the New York Times, April 3, 2007.

Those who could vote now elected a politician to do their bidding; they, themselves, were removed from the process.

A republican structure allowed a democratic style of government to expand beyond the level of a single city. In other words, democracy works well enough for a city-state, but beyond that point, another layer is required. This form is called a republic, and this was the form of governance that Rome chose.

The Roman Republic, though highly complex, was based on a Senate, composed of the nobles of the city, along with popular assemblies which ensured political participation for most of the freeborn men and elected magistrates annually. The structure of the operation is shown below.



Courtesy Wikimedia Commons

After 500 BC, Rome joined with other Latin cities to defend themselves from the nearby Sabines. Then, over the next hundred years (by 394 B.C.), Rome incrementally expanded over the entire area of Latium.

In 387 B.C., however, Rome was suddenly sacked and burned by a group from eastern Italy, called the Senones. The Senones had also successfully invaded Etruria. After this, Rome hastily rebuilt and went on the offensive, conquering the Etruscans and seizing territory from the Gauls in the north. By 290 BC, Rome controlled over half of the Italian peninsula and soon brought the Greek colonies in the south under its control as well.

At this time, the core ideals of Rome had been in place for some time, but there were as yet none of the impressive buildings and monuments that we usually associate with Rome. The great monuments were produced later, under the Empire, and only once they could be financed by the movements of the people's surplus to the Emperor's storehouses.

By the last Century B.C. (beginning 100 B.C.) serious internal problems threatened the existence of the Republic. The Social War (between Rome and its allies) and the Servile Wars (slave uprisings), were very expensive conflicts, all within Italy, and forced the Romans to change their policy with regards to their allies and subjects. By then Rome had become an extensive power, with great wealth taken from conquered peoples (as tribute, food or slaves). But, Rome's allies were unhappy. After all, they had fought side by side with the Romans, yet they were not citizens and shared little in the rewards. So, to keep peace, by the beginning of the first century A.D. practically all of the free inhabitants of Italy were made Roman citizens.

Between the massive expansion of Roman power and a massive increase in the numbers and types of people who could now vote, multiple new problems shook the old political system of the Republic. In January of 49 B.C., following numerous crises, Julius Caesar marched his legions against Rome. Within a few years he had defeated all his opponents, and then ruled Rome for four years. After his subsequent assassination in 44 B.C., the Senate tried to reestablish the Republic, but its champions, Marcus Junius Brutus and Gaius Cassius Longinus, were defeated by Caesar's lieutenant Mark Antony and Caesar's nephew, Octavian. After a long struggle, a final naval battle took place on September 2nd, 31 B.C.. Octavian (soon to be called Augustus) was victorious, and became the sole ruler of Rome and its empire. On that day, the Republic ended and the *Principate*, the first phase of the Roman Empire, began.

THE DEMOCRATIZATION OF PLUNDER

In the empires of the ancient world, plunder was reserved to the kings and to the emperors (the kings of kings). These rulers had the right to

plunder and would use violence to assure that they had no competitors. Each city was a separate unit, and its surplus production went directly up the hierarchy to a local ruler, with a portion of it continuing to a ruler above that one. This surplus allowed the rulers to live lush lives and to build the great monuments of the old world: Pyramids, hanging gardens, ziggurats, colossal statues, and the like. It was this hierarchical movement of surplus production that made monuments proliferate during this time.

The Greeks and early Romans, however, changed this arrangement and democratized the plunder. This model involved each property holder owning a number of slaves, whose work in the field he carefully supervised and very often assisted personally. The surplus production of this small group of slaves became the property of the property holder, which allowed capital to be used in productive endeavors, and very effectively so.

But the improved use of surplus capital was not the only attribute to this new arrangement. It also turned thousands of people into small-scale plunderers. This had a range of effects, which are difficult to properly weigh at our current distance of over two thousand years. However, some of the major effects seem to have been these:

- **A reduction in the respect for hierarchy and fear of the ruler.** The individual land-holder was not awed by the power of the ruler, who was much less powerful than the rulers of the ancient era, and may not have been much of a ruler at all. In fact, during the earlier parts of the classical age, the ruler was chosen from among the land-holders and would likely return to them. He was not separate from the others in class, only in temporary function.

- **Coarsening of the land-owners, stratification of humanity, fate and myth.** Holding slaves, even when treating them "well," causes humans to devalue and disregard those who they own. Unless, of course, the slaves are seen as victims of chance. So, to accommodate the "necessity" of slavery, the earlier Greeks and Romans developed the idea that slaves were slaves simply because of the acts of the gods, or by fate, or by cruel chance – not by the slave-holder's actions. In some cases, this was almost true. There were then – as there are now – many humans who would gladly trade their freedom for a position of entitlement. If they feel they will be guaranteed a basic sustenance, be treated with a modicum of compassion, and have some promise of protection from abuse, they accept. Freedom has always been far

more of an attractive slogan than a way of life that all people pursued.

- **Citizen armies.** When power is distributed, military defense cannot be assigned to a class of experts, simply because such a class does not exist. So, an army of citizens is required. Since the work-force could be relied upon to function fairly well in the land-owner's absence, this was not an insurmountable obstacle. And, it must be said that the Greeks and early Romans acquitted themselves quite well in military endeavors.

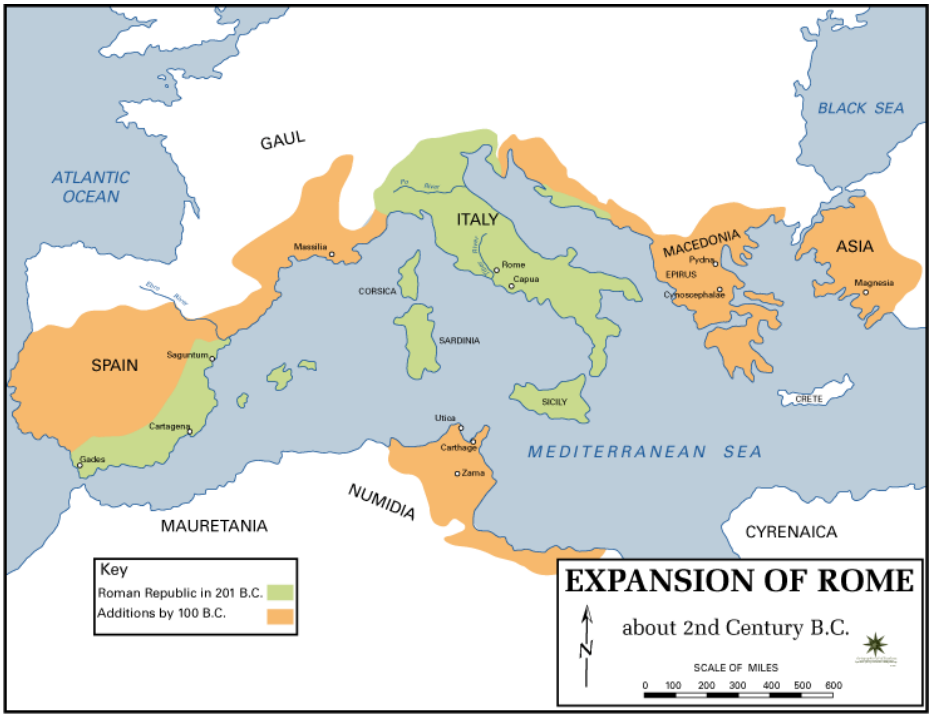
ANCIENT ECONOMICS

It is important to understand the ways in which the economics of the classical world differed from the economics we are familiar with.

First of all, the mechanism of economic growth was the social organization of slavery. This was not, during the centuries of the Republic, anything like 18th Century slave gangs on plantations: The slave owners worked closely with their slaves and were very often in the fields with them. But, since the slaves could not be holders of property, the surplus that they produced was taken over by the slave owner and became investment capital. This was then applied to further productive uses. And, since the owner understood the agricultural process, he was usually an excellent judge of where investment was best applied.

This system worked quite well during the Republic. The slaves were certainly short-changed in the bargain, but the slavery of those days was not equivalent to the brutal slavery that appeared at other places and times. Slaves were valued, commonly freed or adopted, and could engage in independent activities. Nonetheless, their surplus production belonged to their owner. A Roman (or Greek) of the time would justify this as the only conceivable social organization that could produce progress. The map below shows the expansion of Rome under the Republic.

Another great difference between the modern and classical world was the currency. Minted coin was the sole monetary instrument, and there was no machinery for creating credit. There were no banks in our sense, and only two sources of wealth: agricultural and mineral, with the former being more important. This had multiple consequences.



Courtesy Wikimedia Commons

One consequence was that funding military expeditions was difficult. This restrained unnecessary military campaigns. (Whereas today, with our fiat currency system, money can simply be created on demand.) For example, in 483 B.C. the Athenians had strained relations with the Persians, but had not done much about it. Then, the lead mines at Sounion suddenly revealed a fabulous seam of silver. Immediately, the leaders of Athens built a fleet and defeated the Persians at Salamis.

So, excess wealth could be gathered from the earth, erratically though dramatically, in the form of precious metals. Or, it could be produced regularly and predictably from the farming-slavery culture in the form of foodstuffs.

There was much concern in the ancient world over the storage and retention of gold and silver. One of the ancient laws of Rome (contained in their Twelve Tables of Roman Law) stated that: *Gold, no matter in what form it may be present, shall, by all means, be removed from the corpse at the time of the funeral.* They did not allow gold to be wasted. (They did make exceptions for the dead person's gold dentistry.)

At the same time, many problems we encounter, such currency exchange rates and volatile currency values, were complete non-issues. Gold was gold, no matter whose name was slapped on the coin, and all forms of gold or silver were of equal value per ounce. This greatly aided commerce and trade.

Another important factor to include was the attitude toward wealth. Members of the classical civilizations tended to be moderate in their attitudes toward money. They refused to regard either profit or power as goals of life, but rather tended to regard honor and the esteem of one's equals as goals that were at least as important as simple accumulation. The early Romans, being instructed by Greek mythology directed toward the inner man, were imbued with an appreciation for self-development. They valued this more highly than mere external things such as coins. In this way at least, it was a more elegant time.

At a personal level, credit was provided in the form of transactions between friends, neighbors and relations. There were no securities, interest or even written agreements, which implied distrust. Aristocrats, for example, felt an obligation to take on the debts of friends. Cicero, the great jurist, distinguishes two categories of givers: those who squander their money on public banquets, food doles, gladiatorial shows and wild beast fights (to gain political credit), and those who take over friends' debts, help in providing dowries for their daughters or assisting them in acquiring property. Each man was, in effect, his own bank.

THE ECONOMIC FALL OF ROME

This slave economy was a crucial factor in the fall of Rome. Rome's reserves increased steadily through foreign conquests. (They quadrupled between 200 B.C and 70 B.C., for example, then doubled again in the 60s B.C.) Under the Empire, the city of Rome was highly subsidized, with roughly 15 to 25 percent of its grain supply being paid by the central government. Julius Caesar found 320,000 beneficiaries in Rome – one in three. Claudius (41-54) had 200,000 heads of families getting free wheat. Commerce and industry played small roles; the economy was based upon conquest and upon agriculture, and other forms of commercial activity were looked down upon.

The nobility of Rome were excluded from commerce by law. This kept a great deal of capital and talent out of commerce and drove the nobles to build ever-larger farms, if they wanted to increase their personal surplus. (The elegant monetary ethic of earlier times was overrun during the Empire by a need to impress.) This, of course, required a continual

supply of new slaves. Obtaining more slaves, however, required more conquest. Rome was now dependent upon plunder to keep the system going. This was not sustainable, and all the Romans who wished to know, knew. The others kept their minds closed and pretended that all things would continue as they had been.

During the earlier years of the Empire (31 B.C. into the 3rd Century A.D.) Rome kept its citizens happy with plunder from the new provinces (especially slaves) and with very low taxation. But this can be done only so long as plunder from the provinces keeps coming in. After centuries of expansion, Rome eventually reached its limit and further expansion cost more than it gained. Then, the entire operation ceased its effectiveness.

One surprising fact is that Rome was able to retain elements of its moral core for quite some time. It occupied a great deal of 'mental territory' among its subjects. The standard mode of conquest in those days was to lay siege to an opponent city, surrounding it and burning or invading it. Almost inevitably, someone would open the gates of the opposing city, usually for a bribe. No one ever opened the gates of Rome, even while under terrific siege. The Roman symbol was the *fascio*, a bundle of sticks bound together into an unbreakable whole. This allegory had evidently taken deep root, and the people bought-in to the idea that they, like the sticks, could remain together and become supremely strong. During those years, no one ever left the bundle to open the gates.

But, as was inevitable, once Rome could no longer extend its frontiers the operation rotted where it stood. It did not rot instantly, however. Economic problems began first, as the treasury ran low on funds and the Emperors began to mix base metals into their silver coins. This, as always, created inflation and led to economic depression.

Government efforts to overcome economic depression led to a much larger government bureaucracy and tax burden. This fell primarily upon landlords, because commercial activity was shrinking and because the landlords were stationary. Merchants could avoid the tax-gatherer, landowners could not. The landowners were clever people, however, and did develop a method of avoiding taxes, by saying that their tenants had moved along in search of better wages[39]. To counter, the Senate passed laws that tied the tenant farmers (called *coloni*) to their tenancies and made

[39] Their taxes were calculated by the number of tenants, more or less.

them hereditary. Thus the coloni and their children were tied to the land, and the landlord could no longer avoid taxation.

Because of this relationship, the coloni came to look to the landlords for protection and to settle their disputes. As the government became weaker and more distant, the landlords became more powerful. Laws were passed to stop this process, but they were not enforced. As the Empire withdrew, the landlords became the last vestige of government. This, over time, led directly to *manorialism*, also known as medieval *serfdom*.

THE PATH TO CENTRALIZED POWER

As explained earlier, a great strength of the Roman Republic was that it was decentralized. Power and responsibilities were shared among many groups and no one of them could ruin the entire operation. The family was the core of the structure of Rome, which created this decentralized structure. This was successful for hundreds of years. This went far beyond the virtue of "having a stake in the game." They were bound by tradition, and the tradition was: *Work the land, fight for your country, go back to working the land. Expand your holdings. Make Rome wealthier. Your family will profit thereby.* This worked for three hundred years. If you owned property, you were a citizen, you had rights, and you served in the army when needed.

During these years, the army was comprised solely of Roman citizens. Then, as the Republic expanded, more soldiers were necessary and there simply weren't enough citizens. In 100 B.C., Marius opened membership to the masses (called the *capiti censi*, which literally meant, "the headcount"). So, non-citizens enrolled in the Army, and they did so for future benefits, which was a radically different motivation from the self-sovereignty and responsibility that moved the Roman citizen. These new recruits trusted their General to secure benefits for them, and that was the end of the matter. The exchange was not dishonest, but it did centralize power into the hands of high leaders and took it away from the citizens.

It must be added that this had a further degrading effect upon the idea of Rome itself. The citizens, like their fathers and grandfathers long before them, saw themselves as self-sovereigns, cooperating together in a sensible structure. But the masses – who were now users of force – generally had little understanding of the root of Rome, but had loyalty only to the General who secured their benefits. They took the payout, while the old citizens talked on about concepts that seemed old and silly to them.

Another issue was that the army had political power. Non-citizens with political power meant that they could enforce commands upon the citizens, at least when acting in concert with other political groups. In other words, people with no stake in the game could now dictate policy. They could vote themselves food and favors, which would be paid for by others, which, soon enough, they did. Again, this took surplus away from the citizen families and put it under the control of the central state. Surplus began flowing away from the farms, where it could be used productively, and into the hands of the political class, where it would be used to buy favors. This removed investment capital from the farms and caused grave economic problems. The farmer who wanted to make improvements had no excess to spend on them.

After the Second Punic War of 218-201 B.C., rich Romans began taking over large properties (called *Latifundium*) in the conquered provinces. This was crucial to them for attaining status. The wealth of a Senator was measured in his land. When the Censor examined the Senate and expunged those who were not wealthy enough – as happened from time to time – it was based on the amount of land owned by the Senator's family. So, obtaining large tracts of land became important in retaining one's rank in the aristocracy. And obtaining lands from conquest required friends in the central structure of the state. Those who wished for status had nothing to gain from the noble, scattered farmers. They had much to gain from the state. And so they championed the state, and especially their friends within the state. Again, power passed away from the distributed farms and to offices in the city of Rome.

The constitution of the Republic was built around a separation of powers and checks and balances, often taking the form of a struggle between the aristocracy and the average Roman. Over time, the laws that allowed the landed aristocracy to dominate the government were repealed, and the result was the emergence of a new aristocracy which depended on political power, rather than tradition or law, to maintain its dominance. Thus, check and balances vanished and power was transferred from distributed families into a centralized political state.

The collapse of the Roman Republic in the 1st Century B.C. was largely due to the naked power that people like Caesar and Pompey could wield by having private armies at their back. Cicero lamented in a letter to Brutus: *We are made a mockery by the whims of soldiers and arrogance of generals. Everyone demands as much political power as the army at his back can deliver. Reason, moderation, law, tradition, duty count for nothing.* The reason, of course,

was that moderation, law and tradition no longer had any bearing on the use of force. They may still have mattered to a majority of the citizens, but they didn't matter to the ruling classes. And by this time, the citizens had lost much of their power. They were talked to, far more than they were listened to.

Caesar was simply a realist who saw that only power really mattered. Tradition was for the workers in the fields, not for men of power. So, he consolidated military power, overcame the rest of Rome's armies, and made himself dictator[40]. Two centuries before, there would have been precious little power for Caesar to grab, but by the middle of the 1st Century B.C. the central state had a huge amount of power, making it an irresistible target for him.

Upon Caesar's assassination in 44 B.C., his adopted son Octavian became his heir. Thirteen bloody years later, Octavian emerged as the first emperor, Augustus. With the Romans sick of internecine strife, he brilliantly maneuvered all power into his own hands, created a single army accountable only to the state and, because he kept institutions such as the consuls and Senate, he persuaded the Roman people that the traditional constitutional order had been restored. Many of the farmers wanted to believe that the old ways still mattered. They were wrong.

A POST-MORTEM ANALYSIS

Rome, in its own way, follows a pattern that we have seen in both ancient Mesopotamia and in the Greeks: Virtue, creation and production at the beginning, which is usurped by semi-plunderers or outright plunderers, who end up getting credit for the entire enterprise. Note that very few people know anything of the Roman Republic, but they do know the Roman Empire with Julius Caesar, Nero fiddling while Rome burns, gladiators, stadiums and mass spectacles.

Following the first Dark Age, Rome organized itself and adopted the best virtues that they could find, from whatever source they found them. They took freely from both Etruscans and Greeks, and almost certainly from the Phoenicians as well. They made the virtues of these foreign peoples their own. This gave them useful views of reality and respect for science. They used these in their own ways, to be sure (for example, the

[40] The actual events were more complex than are stated here.

Romans majored in engineering rather than "pure sciences" such as physics), but they used them vigorously.

Rome, from the origin, had a very short, practical set of laws (the Twelve Tables), which aided not only in basic governance, but was a great aid to commerce, by making it relatively safe in every place to which the Empire had extended. Even though commerce was looked down upon by the agricultural Romans, the amount of trade was immense. As Professor Lionel Casson of New York University reports:

> *The Roman man in the street ate bread baked with wheat grown in North Africa or Egypt, and fish that had been caught and dried near Gibraltar. He cooked with North African oil in pots and pans of copper mined in Spain, ate off dishes fired in French kilns, drank wine from Spain or France... The Roman of wealth dressed in garments of wool from Miletus or linen from Egypt; his wife wore silks from China, adorned herself with diamonds and pearls from India, and made up with cosmetics from South Arabia... He lived in a house whose walls were covered with colored marble veneer quarried in Asia Minor; his furniture was of Indian ebony or teak inlaid with African ivory...*

This was the first global economy. Trade has always been surprising in its range (traders being the unsung heroes of world history), but never like this. And, along with traders came new ideas. For the first time, ideas passed from one end of the known world to the other in a relatively short period of time.

In a coastal town of northern England, there is a Roman funerary monument dedicated to a 30-year-old woman named Regina. It is dated to about 200 A.D., at the height of the Roman occupation of Britain. It tells us that she was originally a slave from a town near London, and was then freed by a man named Barates, from Palmyra in Syria, whom she then married. Barates, it should be noticed, was more than 4,000 miles from his home, and certainly conducting business of some sort. Note also that this trader was from a province and not the city of Rome or from Italy, where trade was ill-regarded.

Rome had wonderful effects for global business. Romans governed their provinces with a small bureaucracy co-operating with the local hierarchy to run the place as usual. Rome demanded its annual tax take and the right to station legions there if needed, but apart from that they imposed no monetary system, no education system, no rules and regulations, and,

aside from basics, no laws either. Under the Empire, you could more or less do as you wished, so long as you paid the required taxes (generally low by modern standards) and didn't make trouble. Rome's arrival opened up the massive economic network that was the Roman Empire. The map below shows the extent of the Empire at its greatest reach in the 2nd Century A.D. (You will also see from this map why the Mediterranean was sometimes referred to as a "Roman Lake.")



Courtesy Wikimedia Commons

But, again, early virtues gave way to later corruption. The Romans were proud of their original legal code, but law-making expanded endlessly, regardless of occasional attempts to cut it back By 533 A.D., when the eastern Emperor Justinian published a Digest of Roman law, he and his men had to condense this new work from 2,000 volumes. As one of Rome's own historians, Tacitus, says: *The more corrupt the state, the more it legislates.*

Likewise, Roman rulers began fairly well and ended very, very badly. The greatest example of Roman virtue was also one of the earliest: In 458 B.C., the very highly regarded Cincinnatus was happily plowing his field as Rome fell into military danger. The Senate sent messengers and called upon Cincinnatus to assume absolute power in Rome and to save the city from assault. Grudgingly, he agreed, and led a successful defense. And, as soon as the danger was past, Cincinnatus went back to the Senate,

resigned as Dictator, and returned to his field. This sort of relinquishing of power was rare in the ancient world, and Cincinnatus became Rome's shining example of virtue above power.

By the time of the Empire, this virtue was utterly gone. Rome's "Five Good Emperors" were most definitely the exceptions and it is not certain that they were all as exemplary as advertised.

A common example of imperial conduct is this: The unclaimed property of those who died with no will became a great source of state income, along with the property of anyone who had been condemned on a criminal charge. So, when the emperor Tiberias faced a shortfall, he drummed-up a charge against the richest man in Spain. Tiberias accused this man, Sextus Marius, of having committed incest with his daughter. Consequently, Marius was thrown off the Tarpeian rock in Rome, and Tiberius seized his extensive gold and copper mines.

From the start of the Empire in 27 B.C. until the end of the Western Empire in 476 A.D., there were 90 emperors. Of these nearly three in four were killed, usually by their own troops, or committed suicide. No one became or stayed emperor without blood on his hands. The terror of losing immunity upon becoming a private citizen played a part, as did the prospect of losing status and respect, however artificial respect for an emperor may have been.

One structural problem was that the Roman army was never fully removed from politics. Every emperor depended on the army's political power as well as its military power, and the army expected its kickback. At some point, the emperor's personal soldiers (the Praetorian Guard) realized that it was they who made the emperor, and not the emperor who made them. From that point on, the "idea of Rome" no longer played a significant role in the daily life of the emperor. Rome's virtues died alongside, and all that really mattered was naked power.

The details regarding the end of the Empire are illuminating:

The Roman Empire exerted authority over its provinces because it had an army ready to punish anyone who stepped out of line. This army was paid out of the taxes that the provincials raised. If you consider this for a moment, you can see that this is the same slave economy pattern, only writ very large. The Romans didn't treat the provinces especially poorly (much as they did not usually mistreat their slaves), but they did siphon-off their surplus production. And, like local slave production, it had limits. Once stretched beyond those limits, the economies failed.

The empire suffered serious financial setbacks in the 3rd Century A.D. (called the *Crisis of the 3rd Century*), after limits were reached and the structure could no longer sustain itself. Rome's hold over its distant provinces weakened. In 376 A.D., a group from the east, the Huns, attacked the peoples on the borders of the Roman Empire and chased them into the Empire proper. Rome did not have the ability to reach out any further and deal with the Huns, so the Huns continued and the western empire was flooded with terrified Germanic people. And, since these Germanic people did not share in the awe of Rome, they were not nearly as easy to rule as the provincials who were raised with it.

It must be remembered that by this time, all of the virtuous conduct and values that created the grand ideal of Rome were long absent. Many Romans, holding to this ideal as the core of their identities, were blind to the distinction. (It is a common human trait to fill-in gaps with things previously accepted as true.) The Germanics, however, *could* see that the Roman ideal had no connection to reality, and they knew that they were at or beyond the fringes of Rome's military effectiveness. They had no willingness to obey and they were no longer afraid. Thus, they could not be ruled.

Very shortly, "barbarian"[41] kingdoms formed all along the periphery of the empire, even into Italy itself. Realizing their tentative positions, the local Roman elites began colluding with these new kingdoms, against the Empire. As a consequence, tax revenue was creatively diverted and remained in the local kingdom. Without their resource supply, Rome was no longer able to raise armies and force the provinces back into obedience. Rome's borders weakened.

Roman central authority could now issue what orders it liked, but no one had any real need to obey, because they knew there would be no consequence. Rome had finally failed. In 476 A.D. the last Roman emperor, Romulus Augustulus, was quietly paid to go live in Campania by the "barbarian" Odoacer, and the Empire was gone. The provinces allowed an "emperor" to remain as the titular head of the Roman Empire, but these emperors had no power, took orders from the provincial rulers and could do little but watch as, once again, centralized power slowly devolved during a long, dark age.

[41] In the classical era, the term meant *foreigners* more than it implied bad conduct.

One thing that doomed the Romans and shaped the following Dark Ages, was their fetish for stability and permanence. To the Romans, change implied failure. Romans reinforced this perspective by using the past to act as a guide to the present. This left them psychologically unable to adapt and to choose another method of economy once their agricultural, slave and plunder economy reached its limits. All else was forbidden. They had staked their very identities to the *exemplum* of the past. Their basic concept of organization was inalterably rooted in the ideal of the initial Roman families of a past era: reliable, solid, held together by bonds of affection, the foundation of stable society. This, of course, was tied to piety, which bonded gods and men and nourished them.

This is also why the early Christians were persecuted – they cast off these bonds, which Romans took as either a deep insult to their way of life (thus insulting all Romans, past and present) or, as a direct threat, by making the gods unhappy, or, as undermining the spirit of Rome. In this way, the Romans were no different from modern people who expect doom if proper conduct in not maintained by every person (or at least the overwhelming majority) in a society. Saying "God will judge us for our culture's immorality" is little different from what the Romans did, save that very few moderns resort to violence[42].

[42] In fairness to the Romans, it must be said that the number of Christians who were actually killed in Roman persecutions is far lower than is popularly thought, possibly as low as 10-20 thousand over a roughly 300 year period. Also, there is no evidence that any Christians were ever fed to lions in the Coliseum. It is certainly possible that a few died there in gladiatorial fights, but even this is speculation.

4

Plato's Empire

To Plato is given the praise of having perfected philosophy.
-- Saint Augustine

Toward the middle of the classical era (about 380 B.C.) the Greek philosopher Plato developed a new mysticism of the state. This formulation was of little effect upon the classical civilizations (since their formative stages were behind them), but its effects upon future civilizations would be profound.

That religions of both the ancient world and the classical world are often categorized as *sympathetic magic.* The central exchange of sympathetic magic is that by performing a sacrifice that is somehow parallel to what you want, you influence the gods to act sympathetically, using their vastly superior power.

Sympathetic magic appealed to those who were desperate (as higher beings always do) and to those who hoped for easy production – to get more than they had earned. This second reason was based either upon simple laziness or upon a lack of confidence in one's own abilities. Both are very common human traits.

Among the Sumerians, for example, farmers would have some sort of fertility ritual, which they hoped would influence the gods to act along with them, and to keep the earth fertile. By the time of the Romans

(following the Greek discovery of science) this often became merely appeasing the gods, but the pattern did hold.

Plato began to teach in about 400 B.C., presumably as a student of Socrates. He had a strong affinity for governmental systems of control. Here are three of his thoughts on the subject:

> *Then first, we must set up a censorship over the fable-makers, and approve any good fable they make, and disapprove the bad; those which are approved we will persuade the mothers and nurses to tell the children, and to mold the souls of the children by the fables.*
>
> *The guardians must allow no innovations in gymnastics and music against the established order.*
>
> *Often the rulers have really to use falsehood and deceit for the benefit of the ruled; and we said all such things were useful as a kind of drugs.*

You can see from these that Plato would have little in common with the early founders of Greece, Rome, or the first primitive agriculturalists – all of these people were most definitely innovators. He would, however, share a great deal of common interest with the rulers of Sumer in its later stages. And, of course, he has been much admired by ruling types ever since. It is true that Plato, being a very bright and thoughtful man, did develop some useful and even noble thoughts, but this championing of the lordship of the few over the masses remained his highest priority.

Another of Plato's primary teachings was that earth is merely a shadow of a higher, better, unseen reality. According to Plato, men should not waste their time addressing earthly things, but they should seek to conform their lives, and the world in general, to a heavenly *pattern above*[43]. This, he promotes, will be the great catalyst that raises man to the heights of prosperity and enlightenment. He famously explains this in his book *The Republic*, which contains the following:

> *But the true earth is pure and situated in the pure heaven... and it is the heaven which is commonly spoken by us as the ether... for if any man could arrive at the extreme limit ... he would acknowledge that this other world was the place of the true heaven and the true light and the true earth.*

[43] Specialists call this the Theory of Forms.

This idea of a heavenly world is very normal to us, but it was not so normal in the dassical world. The Greeks, for example, described their gods as living high on an actual mountain named Olympus, not in a completely separate, higher realm. The idea of a separate world seems to have begun with the Hebrews, who placed their god outside of the visible universe. The ideas of the Hebrews were making their way through Greece by this time, so it is quite possible that Plato picked up this line of thought from them. But, regardless of source, it was Plato[44] that more or less originated our idea of Heaven[45].

Plato replaced the mythical gods of old with a mythic, ideal society. And this pattern of Plato's, as he spent a great deal of time explaining, was a city, a culture, the pure and perfect organization of human beings.

Plato replaced the mythical gods with a mythical society – a heavenly society. He created an ideal that said this: *If you faithfully imitate the pattern above, you'll get the same benefits you sought from the gods.*

Plato describes this ideal state:

> *Colors are brighter far and clearer than ours; there is a purple of wonderful luster, also the radiance of gold and the white which is whiter than any chalk or snow on the earth... and in this far region everything that grows - trees and flowers and fruits - are in a like degree fairer than any here. And there are hills, having stones ... more transparent, and fairer in color than our highly-valued emeralds and sardonyxes. The people have no disease, and live much longer than we do, and have sight, and hearing and smell ... in far greater perfection. They converse with the gods and see the sun, moon and stars as they truly are.*

People reading Plato's description – as would be expected – began to yearn for it. The clear implication was that by imitating the perfect pattern above, the conditions of the heavenly state above would begin to

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[44] Even in the Jewish scriptures, this idea was almost entirely absent. In those writings, the w ord "heaven" simply means the opening between the ground and the clouds, or as we might say, the atmosphere.

[45] Jesus never really teaches Plato's Heaven. Instead, he talks of judgment akin to the type predicted by the prophet Daniel and of individual mansions as rewards to the just, not cities. Talk of a heavenly city comes later, first, abstractly and briefly via Paul and then, explicitly, in the book of Revelation. But Jesus himself never really teaches this.

appear in your earthly state. You would magically receive benefits… more than you had actually earned by yourself.

But, this was not merely implied by Plato. He gets specific, writing:

> *The State, if once started well, moves with accumulating force like a wheel.*
>
> *Our State, if rightly ordered, is perfect.*
>
> *No State can be happy which is not designed by artists who imitate the heavenly pattern.*
>
> *What has been said about the State and the government is not a mere dream, and although difficult, not impossible.*

So, from Plato's time on, people took comfort in thinking that if their government was run properly, they would get more out than they had put in.

This line of thought remains with us, and we call it *idealism.*

Idealism functions on the instinctive hook of getting something for nothing. (Pay for a little bit, get the rest for free.) It implies someone taking care of you, so you don't have to be fully responsible. This is the political form of sympathetic magic, in which championing political ideas replaces sacrifice to the gods.

You can see how the formulations of the old gods and Plato's idealism are structurally the same:

> **Proper sacrifices gain sympathy from the gods and bring magic.**
>
> **Right political positions cause harmony with the ideal and bring magic.**

Here is a table, showing the relationships graphically:

	Action	**Mechanism**	**Result**
The Old Gods	Right sacrifices	The gods	Magic
Plato's Idealism	Right political positions	The heavenly ideal	Magic

No direct evidence was ever required for the old god formulation and none has been required of Plato.

Platonic societies ever since have featured the belief that, by grouping together and conforming to the ideal, people get more than they could on their own[46]. Accordingly, they labor long and hard to get others to join them in their political positions and symbolic acts. Their pursuit of symbolic acts is an effort to enhance the process by sacrificing to the ideal. Again, an appeal to sympathetic magic.

How different are we, really, from the ancients who made offerings to the gods of wind and rain?

PLATO'S OPPORTUNITY

Plato's books were widely distributed during the time of the Roman Empire. Nonetheless, as mentioned previously, their ideas were not implemented on a large scale, simply because there was an existing structure in place and no one was going to try and rip it down and attempt something utterly new. The rotting and inevitable doom of Rome, however, provided them with an opportunity.

The Crisis of the 3rd Century marked the end of Rome's strength, and the collapse of their method of expansion. They had reached their limit and could no longer bring in masses of new slaves and make huge land grants to prominent families. The Empire nearly collapsed and there was no way out of the dilemma; switching to a new ideology would be to admit failure and would ruin Rome's sense of legitimacy.

For the first time in centuries, Rome had to worry about invasions. They could no longer drive barbarians further and further away, and their economy was falling apart without new conquests. A return to their early days was no longer practical. Power had long since left the virtuous farmers and had been siphoned away to a massive political center which would never agree to dismantle itself. They had the power and they would not give it up. The distributed-power model of Rome's early days was hopelessly lost.

In 273 A.D., Emperor Aurelian finished encircling the capital itself with a massive wall which had a perimeter that measured close to 20 kilometers.

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[46] Which is manifestly silly, since a whole can never be more than the sum of its parts. But, again, mathematics and logic (that is, science) were never part of such formulations.

Rome formally remained the capital of the empire, but emperors spent less and less time there.

It was now clear that the empire was vulnerable to serial attack, and the last hundred years of the Roman Empire in the West were dominated by Rome's political structure moving in and out of relationships with various tribes of Germanic Goths and non-Germanic Huns who wanted to settle within the Empire. Immoral emperors had made a mockery of Rome's virtues and there was no legitimacy left – only raw power… and that had faltered. The original mechanism of production had been eliminated and the new mechanism had failed. Rome was doomed.

Diocletian (who ruled from 284 to 305) enacted political reforms that made the city of Rome almost irrelevant. (This would have been unthinkable in earlier times.) Rome was stripped of its traditional role as the administrative capital of the Empire. The emperors began to rule from Milan or Ravenna, or from cities in Gaul.

By the time of Constantine I (who ruled from 306 to 337) every honest observer knew what was happening. It was at this time that Constantine decided to try something radical and new. His precise reasons to undertake this endeavor seem lost to history, but while we lack specific evidence on *why* he acted, we have abundant facts as to *what* he did.

As is very widely known, Constantine made Christianity the religion of Rome and established a second capital at Constantinople. This was a major reworking of the Empire.

Precisely why Constantine chose Christianity as the new religion of Rome (there were many others available) has long been debated. When critically examined from the standpoint of an amoral ruler, however, the answer becomes much clearer. So, it is to this question that we now turn our attention.

WHY CHRISTIANITY?

Almost no one in the early 4th Century believed in the moral legitimacy of the Roman Empire. People might *fear* the Empire, but they did not respect it. The Empire attempted what we might call publicity campaigns, but they didn't convince many people, and they certainly did not convince the Germanics, the Gauls and the Huns.

Once military force had failed, legitimacy was left at the core of Rome's problems. Fear can keep taxpayers in compliance, or faith can keep them in compliance, but with neither, they ignore you and keep their money at

home. And with no money coming in, no government can survive. So, Constantine had to pursue legitimacy.

Rome could have restored their military power by dismantling their imperial structure, giving up the provinces and going back to the Republic as it was in 200 B.C., but this was certainly not something that the holders of central power were willing to consider. They would simply steal as much as they could and run away before they would go back to lives of personal virtue and productivity. So, this was out of the question. That left restoring legitimacy as their primary option, long-shot though it may have been. Whether anyone in Rome understood the question in these terms is both unknown and irrelevant; they dealt with this issue every day and tried to adapt and solve it continually.

Constantine came face to face this problem in his mid-30s, following a long career in many areas of the Roman government, so, he understood the problem quite well. The most pressing daily issue facing him was money. (Military expenditures at this time were 40% to 70% of the entire budget of the state.) He needed it to operate the empire from his central headquarters in Italy, and income simply was not coming in sufficiently. With it, he could pay-off tribes of barbarians, hire soldiers and bring ever-more free food and entertainments to Rome[47]. And, since Rome was now centralized, money spent in any other way, such as within farming communities or within families, was of no use to the Empire at all. Only cash coming to the imperial treasury mattered. Somehow, he had to get the surplus of the people.

There was, of course, the option of cutting back expenses, but that was a problem too. The people were kept in a manageable state by distracting them with expensive entertainments, and to eliminate these could be dangerous. Constantine wanted to scale-back the (very expensive) public games and festivals, and move toward austerity, but, again, Rome was now akin to a socialist state, and the populace was dependent upon distractions and hand-outs.

In this seemingly impossible situation, Constantine found a way out: Christianity. This strategy provided him both easy money and legitimacy. It would not be easy to get an entire empire to change religions in a moment, of course, but this strategy provided what the empire needed and nothing else did.

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[47] There is a great deal to be said about the Roman entertainment culture and its effects upon the populace, but I think we shall have to forgo most of it.

So, Constantine embarked on his plan[48]. He and his two co-emperors ordered the end of Christian persecution in 311 – *a year and a half before* the Battle of the Milvian Bridge, where he was supposed to have had a conversion to Christianity. In this *Edict of Toleration by Galerius*, Constantine's co-emperor (Galerius) more or less admits that the persecution of Christians under Diocletion had failed.

The story of Constantine's conversion, of course, is that God promised him victory by the sign of the cross before the battle of Milvian Bridge on October 28, 312, after which, he became the first Christian Emperor. The facts of his life, however, do not support this story.

As mentioned above, Constantine stopped Christian persecutions about eighteen months earlier. He also continued his personal devotions to Mars and especially to Apollo, also known as *Sol Invictus*. These are not acts that a Christian would take once, much less repeat them continually for decades. In addition, Constantine was as bloody as most other emperors. He broke a solemn oath and executed his brother-in-law, as well as other competitors. In 326, he ordered the execution of his oldest son, Crispus, who had not only been appointed Caesar[49] and had served as consul, but had recently distinguished himself in a military campaign. In the same year, Constantine ordered the death of Fausta, the mother of three of his sons. So, any claim of Constantine's personal devotion to Christ must be rejected.

SOLVING THE LEGITIMACY PROBLEM

Near the end of chapter two, we described a Great Trade between humans (all of whom are internally conflicted) and the higher powers who offer them shelter from their associated bad feelings, and we stated that the trade was this:

> *The state and/or church presents themselves to men as a superior entity – higher than man. To be joined to them provides sanction from a higher source than that of their internal conflicts.*

Rome was no longer able to provide this. The people had only to watch the emperors to understand that Roman virtues were a joke. The rulers were a group of corrupt men, and joining one's self to them could never

[48] As mentioned earlier, I am aware of no written record of Constantine's thinking – even a questionable one – aside from the "conversion story," which we come to now.

[49] The office of Caesar was akin to being the emperor designate – set to be the next emperor.

impart any sort of absolution or cover one's inadequacies. Rome was exposed, and there was no moral core.

Christianity, however, had an astonishingly solid moral core (one that weapons and bloodshed could not kill), which made it a perfect choice as a replacement. Unlike imperial Rome, Christianity *did* provide people a reason to sublimate their internal conflicts into something higher than themselves. Christianity provided full divine forgiveness – and not only forgiveness, but full remission – paid for by an innocent. And not just this, but it was proven to be right, in that the great God raised this man from the dead to confirm it. *That* is legitimacy, and it provided the best-ever salve for the internal conflicts faced by humanity.

Now, the emperor would regain his moral authority by joining himself with Christ. And, of course, he would need some special status within the Christ structure[50], which was shortly arranged.

The Emperor required specific legitimization. This was especially true because Diocletian and Constantine had removed the final connection between the state and its sovereign citizens. When Augustus had created the Empire three hundred years prior, he retained the form of the Republic, basing his legitimacy upon the sovereignty of the people. Having done away with all pretenses to this source of legitimacy, Constantine desperately needed something new. Further, one god of many would not do, since it would only legitimize him with a fraction of the populace. And, he had just learned that Christianity was not going to be defeated. So, the choice was clear: Christianity was in; all the others were out.

Specifics regarding the evolution of the emperor's personal legitimization are interesting, but beyond the scope of our coverage here, aside from pointing out that this was the beginning of the *Divine Right of Kings* in the Christian world.

SOLVING THE MONEY PROBLEM

It seems that Constantine and his followers gained a great deal of income in the transfer from pagan religion to a single version of Christianity. The state had long taken the estates of those who died *intestate* (without a will)

[50] It should be noted that the original "way" of Jesus and his students – long before the term "Christianity" existed – was a non-hierarchical group of individuals and had almost no resemblance to the Christianity of Constantine's time. This fact was very conveniently passed-over by Constantine and his writer Eusebius. Neither is it terribly important to the events under consideration here, but I think it significant enough to mention.

and of those who were convicted criminals. By changing religions, the Empire created whole new classes of criminals, many of whom were restricted in their abilities to create wills. And since the state controlled the legal system, very few people could avoid their asset seizures.

And not only were the assets of the newly-criminalized and the dead taken in this process, but the property and art of the pagan temples passed to the state as well. Either the pagan temples became churches – in which case the state owned them – or they were taken over in criminal proceedings, and again, the state owned them. Here is a partial list of edicts issued (and the year in which they were issued) by Constantine and his successors, as they pursued this agenda:

> 313 – Any property which has been taken from the Christians in persecution is to be restored. This includes gardens, buildings, or any other property, and is to be done in haste.
>
> 321 – Every person shall have the right to leave property to the catholic church in his will.
>
> 322 – Heretical groups are forbidden to assemble. Their buildings must be surrendered to the catholic church.
>
> 333 – Christians shall not be forced into participating in pagan practices; anyone who forces a Christian into such an act shall be publicly beaten, unless he holds an honorable rank, in which case he will be fined and the money given to the state treasury.
>
> 333 – Constantine orders that Arians now be referred to as Porphyrians, that all works of Arius or Arians be burned, and that anyone hiding a work of Arius suffer capital punishment.
>
> 346 – Pagan temples are to be closed; access to them is denied, and violators face capital punishment. The property of a violator will be given to the state treasury. Governors who fail to carry out this punishment will be punished.
>
> 347 – The Donatists were ordered to be reconciled with the catholic church in North Africa. Those who refused were to be exiled or killed.

352 – Persons who join Judaism from Christianity, if the accusation can be proven, shall have their property confiscated and given to the state treasury.

356 – Those guilty of idolatry or pagan sacrifices must suffer capital punishment.

377 – If a Manichaean should go underground and hold secret meetings, he is subjected to the law and must leave his goods to relatives or the government.

383 – Confirmed Christians who have turned to paganism may not issue a testament (that is, a will) to anyone.

389 – Manichaeans are to be expelled from Rome and banished from the empire. Their property is to be confiscated, and their wills are void.

392 – If heretical clergy are ordained, the property where the ordination occurred is to be seized by the government if the ordination occurred with the owner's permission. If it was done without his knowledge, he may be fined or beaten and deported, depending on his income. If it occurred in a public place, the procurator is to be fined.

396 – All heretical assembly places are to be confiscated, and heretics driven out of Constantinople. They are forbidden to enter the city for the purpose of gathering. If this occurs even in a private house, the penalty was a fine of 100 pounds of gold.

396 – Christians who became guilty of idolatry are not allowed to bequeath property in their wills to anyone other than parents, siblings, children, or grandchildren.

405 – Anyone who performs rebaptism will have his property confiscated unless, for the sake of his children, he returns to the catholic church. Places where rebaptisms were performed will be confiscated. Re-baptizers may not make contracts or leave wills.

429 Anyone who converts an orthodox Christian from the catholic church to another religion or heretical sect will have his property confiscated and be executed.

It is also noteworthy that Christians had no appetite for expensive public entertainments, and reducing or eliminating them was very attractive to the emperor.

THE CHURCH IS ESTABLISHED

Of course, Constantine hoped that the money problem would be partly solved by the Emperor gaining legitimacy as a Christian ruler. This did not occur immediately, however, since the changeover was difficult and very divisive; far more so than Constantine had planned.

It seems that Constantine was sincerely surprised by the divisions among Christians. It is certainly true that he worked long and hard to reconcile the various groups. He expended great effort to reconcile the Donatists and the catholics[51], an effort that ultimately failed and required death sentences upon the Donatists.

Once Constantine understood the fractured and divisive state of Christianity, he moved fast and powerfully to unite it. At the council of Nicea, in 325, he more or less forced the attendees to come up with a unified Christian creed. Several hundred bishops from all parts of the empire met in the imperial palace for a month to reach their agreement. Constantine then went forth to enforce the creed upon the entire empire.

Here are some of the imperial edicts that empowered and unified Christianity as a single doctrine and established it as a single organization which was part of the Empire:

> 313 – Imperial subsidies to be given to the catholic priests of North Africa. In addition, those who are seducing the catholic Christians of North Africa need to be corrected.
>
> 313 – All catholic clergy are from compulsory public service. (These compulsory public serves were taxes paid in the form of labor.)
>
> 318 – Constantine gives Christians the right to take their cases before an ecclesiastical court rather than a secular court. The ruling of those bishops will carry the same authority as a secular court.

[51] At this time, "catholic" was only a descriptive term, meaning *universal*. This dominant group of Christians (who were, again, radically different from the primitive Christians of three centuries earlier) were also called "orthodox" at the time, which is not to be confused with the Orthodox Churches of modern times. Again, this was more of a descriptive term than a formal name.

343 – Clergy and their servants shall not have to pay any taxes, or any new taxes in the future, nor shall they have to quarter strangers, and they shall be tax exempt if they start their own businesses.

349 – Clergy are exempted from all compulsory public services and municipal duties. Their sons should continue in the clergy unless obligated by service in the Senate.

355 – Bishops shall not have to appear before secular judges; accusations against them shall be brought before other bishops.

394 – Heretics are forbidden to teach their doctrines or appoint priests or other clergy. Judges and other officials must enforce this law.

395 – All pagan festival days are declared *non*-holidays. No one is permitted to perform a pagan sacrifice.

395 – Anyone who disagrees with the Catholic Christian Church even on a minor point of doctrine is considered a heretic.

396 – Local leaders and officials are not to be selected from the Alexandrian craft-guildsmen unless they are Christians.

398 – Eunomians and Montanists (non-conformist Christians) are to be expelled from the cities, and if they reside in the country and hold assemblies, they are to be deported and the owners of the land punished. Heretical books are to be destroyed. Those who refuse to surrender such books are to suffer capital punishment on the charge of sorcery.

408 – Laws in place against Donatists, Manichaeans, and other non-conformist groups remain effective. Prosecution against them must continue vigorously.

409 – Only orthodox Christians may be appointed as defender of the city, with the bishop and clergy joining the distinguished citizens in making the appointment.

412 – Anyone who hides a Pelagian (non-conformists, again) will suffer the same penalties as a Pelagian. St.

Augustine is authorized to publicize the penalties for Pelagians.

425 – No spectacles in honor of the emperor are to take precedence over worship of God.

It can be seen from this list that the Empire made great efforts to establish the church not only as a state religion, but as a *secular* power as well. ("Secular" means *pertaining to worldly things*. Secular power is governmental power.) This development was erratic but especially powerful under Theodosius II (emperor from 408 to 450), who seems to have finished the job with a great deal of violence.

This distribution of power to approved Christians only created further problems within Christianity by inducing Christians to fight for position. When proper doctrine is rewarded with money and power, these are the things that people fight over. Once such battles are underway, the only thing that can stop them is a central strongman that cannot be overcome. This was probably the driving force behind the papacy, which was utterly alien to Christianity before this time.

CONSTANTINE'S SECOND MOVE

Realizing that the Western Empire would not be saved, even with Christianity, Constantine moved the capital to a new city at the east end of the Mediterranean in 330. The city was built around a small, old town called Byzantium, and it was renamed *Constantinople;* it was also called *New Rome*. This city was positioned astride the trade routes between East and West.

In his new capital, Constantine stabilized the coinage and made changes to the structure of the army. This allowed the Empire to recover much of its military strength and to enjoy a period of stability and prosperity. The barbarians were primarily in the west, not in the east. That gave the new imperial center in the east some breathing room.

This modified version of the Empire welcomed trade. The state strictly regulated all trade, but allowed it to exist and to expand. The Empire, seeking to maintain control as all governments do, demanded a monopoly on the issuance of coins, controlled interest rates, and controlled the activities of guilds and corporations. There were price controls from time to time, especially on grain.

As in the west before the collapse, surplus was removed from the farms and from individuals and passed to New Rome, where it was spent as

payments to politicians and the military, for free food distributions, or for public works and monuments.

It is important to understand that the people in the east did not have the old Roman foundation of distributed power and virtuous living. They were children of the Empire, and did not know the virtues of the now-ancient Republic. But the old agricultural virtues were not critical for a trading empire. And, more importantly, the people of the east felt deeply honored that they had been chosen as the new center of the Empire. They would be the new, improved Empire. In response to this honor, they gladly amplified the glory of Rome. To praise Rome was now to praise themselves, and few men shrink from such opportunities.

As New Rome was established, part of the Roman aristocratic class left Italy and came to the new seat of power, followed by many of the artists and craftsmen. The eastern, "Greek" half of the empire, based in Constantinople, was never the power that the original Rome was, but it did survive, more or less, until 1453. During the latter portions of this time, it was known as the *Byzantine Empire.*

PLATO'S APOSTLE

Once Constantine had moved his capital to the east, the Western Empire was more or less left to its fate. Certainly there were titular emperors who wanted to restore the glory that had been Rome, but it was manifestly beyond saving. The barbarians grew stronger and stronger, and Rome weaker. Through most of these years, Rome was paying the barbarians hundreds of pounds of gold every year, in exchange for peace. The Western Empire had become a vassal state of the barbarians.

Into this mix comes the man we know as St. Augustine. Born in 354, he obtained an extensive education and by the time he was twenty nine, he was operating one of the best schools in Rome. By his thirtieth birthday (in 384), he was appointed the professor of rhetoric for the imperial court at Milan. This was the most important academic appointment in the Latin world (that is, in the western world, as opposed to the eastern, Greek world). This was also a very powerful political position.

Two years later, Augustine went back to his home in Northern Africa and became a monastic Christian. His conversion came about after studying Plato's work for years, plus the study of a famous ascetic saint who lived in the desert, completely cut off from civilization. Soon, Augustine was a renowned preacher and by about 396 he was a full bishop. Shortly thereafter, Augustine set out to remove the heresy of

Donatism[52] from his territory. At first he tried to convince the Donatists to join the approved church, but when that failed, he called for government force to repress them.

In 410, the city of Rome was taken by barbarians under the leadership of the Visigoth Alaric. As always, people sought someone to blame. Some said that their new Christian religion might be to blame for the disaster. The ruling class in particular complained that any religion that championed "turning the other cheek" and that held worldly empires in low esteem was dangerous.

In response to this, an imperial commissioner named Marcellinus, a friend of Augustine's, asked him to respond to the charges. Augustine quickly produced the first several chapters of his book, *The City of God,* which rather effectively quieted the complaints. (He continued the book over a number of years, until it was finally complete.)

It is important that Augustine was not merely a clergyman; by 419, he was personally acquainted with the emperors Honorius and Theodosius II, and was authorized by them to undertake the publicity of their edicts. It is also highly important that Augustine's teachings in *City of God* became the foundation of the Catholic Church's theology for approximately a thousand years, and are incredibly influential still. In short: *Augustine created the theology of the Roman Catholic Church.*

It is almost without question that Augustine is still considered the greatest theologian of the Church. But, to buttress the point, here are quotations from the current Pope, Benedict XVI:

> *[Augustine is] the greatest Father of the Latin Church.*
>
> *It could be said that all the roads of Latin Christian literature led to Hippo, the place in North Africa where he [Augustine] was Bishop from AD 395 until his death in 430.*

And, this was the case very early as well. At the Second Council of Constantinople in 553, only three Latin authorities[53] are quoted: Hilary, Ambrose, and Augustine.

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[52] The Donatists rejected any priesthood imposed upon them by the Emperor, especially priests that they considered unrighteous. Moreover, they considered the Emperor a usurper of Christianity.

[53] "Latin" authorities are those who wrote in the Latin language and came after the writers of the New Testament and the men of primitive Christianity, all of whom wrote in Greek.

Augustine's *City of God* presents human history as being a conflict between what Augustine calls the *City of Man* and the *City of God*, which strongly parallel's Plato's ideas on the *heavenly pattern* and the *ideal state.*

Augustine is not shy about his regard for Plato. In *City of God*, he gushes over him:

> *Among the disciples of Socrates, Plato was the one who shone with a glory which far excelled that of the others, and who, not unjustly, eclipsed them all. By birth, an Athenian of honorable parentage, he far surpassed his fellow-disciples in natural endowments, of which he was possessed in a wonderful degree. Yet, deeming himself and the Socratic discipline far from sufficient for bringing philosophy to perfection, he traveled as extensively as he was able, going to every place famed for the cultivation of any science of which he could make himself master.*

Augustine sees Christianity as the ideal and perfect philosophy, but it is very clear that he hold's Plato's ideals in exceptionally high regard, saying: *It is evident that none come nearer to us than the Platonists.*

Roman Christianity, from Augustine's time onward, was a Platonic Christianity. This is evident, not only from the doctrines, but from the art of the era, which was almost always unrealistic in its representations. This is the Platonic ideal in visual expression: The earthly form is but a shadow; it is only useful to the extent that it focuses the mind around the heavenly ideal. Thus, highly representational art would distract the mind from the high ideal to mere earthly beauty. Accordingly, realistic, representational art did not reappear until the 15th Century[54].

A NEW KIND OF EMPIRE

By the middle of the 5th Century (401-500 A.D.), the Church of Rome found itself in a unique position: Abandoned in the midst of a dying empire, with little and decreasing access to force, but in an excellent position of legitimacy. It is from this most unusual position that they began to build a most unusual form of empire.

The Church found itself with a monopoly on legitimacy. If they proclaimed something to be approved by Christ, a huge number of

[54] Gothic art, beginning a few centuries earlier, was a step in the direction of representational art.

people would presume that the person or thing was deserving of honor, respect and support. They would act accordingly. And, if the Church condemned something, it would be condemned by their now-millions of followers. It was almost the sole provider of legitimacy in what had been the original Roman Empire.

In this situation, it became critically important for them to maintain this legitimacy. They developed dazzling ceremonies, dramatic fables, and inserted their images into the minds of westerners at every possible point and in ever-improving ways. They sought to become the center of reference for every human mind in the Europe. Beyond all else, this imperative guided the rule of the Church. And it must be said that they succeeded astonishingly. The men and women of Europe referenced nearly all of their thoughts to the Church's opinion for a thousand years. Their odd empire was dramatically successful. They certainly proved that great masses of men can be very effectively controlled without weapons.

One of the most critical aspects of legitimacy, and one that is very little understood, is the ruler's need to be legitimate in his own eyes. (We will cover this in more detail in a later chapter.) Again here, the Church found comfort in Plato. One of Plato's more important teachings was that philosophers should rule over men, instead of soldiers and old-style kings. For example, he says:

> *Until philosophers are kings, or the kings and princes of this world have the spirit and power of philosophy, and political greatness and wisdom meet in one… cities will never have rest from their evils,-- nor the human race, as I believe,--and only then will this our State have a possibility of life and behold the light of day.*

And, the same sentiment in a more direct form:

> *Until philosophers bear rule, States and individuals will have no rest from evil.*

The Church at Rome went about to rule as philosopher-kings. Beginning with very little military power – and unlikely to have much for some time – they worked long and hard on techniques of persuasion, guidance and manipulation.

Students of the Middle Ages have often commented on the oppressive nature of the Catholic Church upon the minds of men. This was often true, but it was not generally the goal of Church leaders to be cruel, it was

to maintain power in conditions of limited force[55]. And the truth is that the greatest of all word-based motivations is the fear of shame.

For whatever reason, humans are grossly over-affected by shame and will cower before those who are able to impose it. It is very common that when people encounter the first possibility of shame, they instantly and almost unconsciously assess the likelihood of shame being brought upon them by each option in front of them. They move away from whatever might cause them shame, even before considering the merits of the individual options. In other words, we look ahead to see that shame will result from our options before we weigh the costs and benefits. Then, if shame will be possible, we reject the choice, no matter what its benefits may be. Shame is an unnaturally powerful tool of manipulation.

Accordingly, the Church became expert at applying shame and the fear of shame. It was necessary if they were to maintain the bizarrely difficult position of rulership without violence. This does not excuse their cruelty, but it goes a long way toward explaining it.

THE RE-CONQUEST

The Church was not, however, willing to forgo military power. They knew its importance and wished to get it back. To do this, they would have to turn legitimacy into military power.

During the 5th century, military power continually withdrew from Europe. Constantinople, in what is now Turkey, was being established and the eastern Empire was doing fairly well, but power slipped away in the west till there was almost none left. By the time of Pope Leo I (440-461), he was left as the senior imperial civilian official in Rome.

The famous story of Pope Leo (and one that the Church spared no opportunity to exploit) was when he went out of the city of Rome to meet Attila the Hun in 452. The dramatic story begins as Attila wreaks havoc throughout Italy and ultimately arrives at the gates of Rome. Then Leo, with two other civil functionaries, goes out to meet Attila and somehow convinces him to go away. Since this was highly contradictory to Attila's character, the Church proclaimed it a miracle and published the legend of Leo the Great far and wide.

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[55] Again, it is a most unusual circumstance to build an empire without possessing a significant military advantage. To force people to obey at the end of a sword is one thing; to manipulate them into obedience with mere words is quite another, and requires much greater skill.

According to numerous sources, the basic facts of the story are true: Attila did come to Rome, Leo did go to see him, and Attila did leave. From this point on, however, the stories begin to differ. Leo's contemporary, Priscus, opines that a large sum of gold may have been involved, or that logistical concerns may have been the true reason for Attila's withdrawal. The Hun army had dramatically stretched their supply lines and were overflowing with plunder; so, the Pope's plea for mercy may have served as an honorable reason for withdrawal. In any event, Leo was unable to prevent the Vandals from sacking Rome just three years later. But, this latter episode was forgotten. The Church championed their version of the first story because it was wonderful for their legitimacy. Miracles proved that they were associated with the great God and judge of all mankind. And the miracle of defeating the most fearsome violent army of the age was perfect for legitimizing the rule of philosophers above mere soldiers.

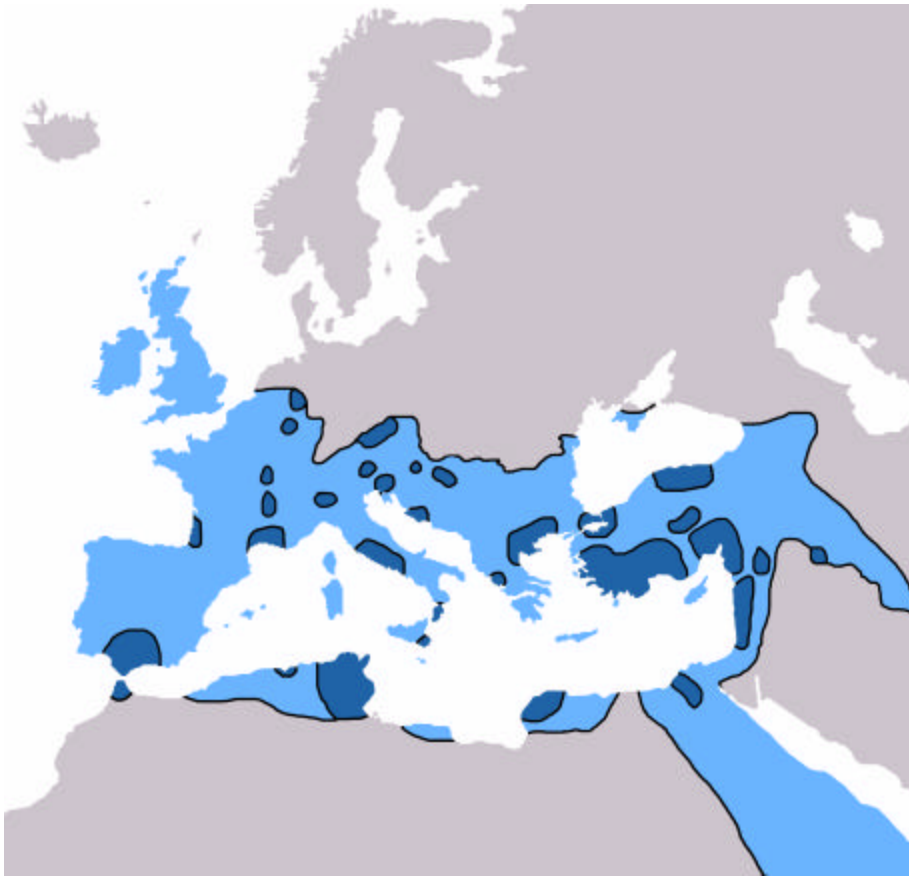
This event was also crucial in allowing Leo to promote the Papacy as the one true voice of Christianity. This theme, of the "universal jurisdiction of the Roman bishop," is found in many of his letters and even in the record of his orations, ninety-six of which still exist.

The Church at this time embarked on their first great campaign of expansion: Evangelism. By converting the pagan barbarians to Christianity, they didn't immediately gain military power, but they greatly expanded the range of their legitimacy. The map below shows the spread of Christianity during the early years of what we are calling a Platonic Empire. Note that most of the great military powers of the era – in what are now France and Germany – became Christian Kingdoms and subject to the legitimacy of the Church. That did not mean that the Church could issue direct orders to the kings – they usually could not – but that the kings now had to consider the effect of the Church's opinions upon their people. As always, these rulers were dependent upon the surpluses of their subjects to pay for their military might. The Pope and the Church now mattered a great deal to them.

The next steps in the re-conquest of the west happen to be some of the more entertaining passages in history. They involve forged documents and massive donations of land (and its governance) to the Church.

The first donation was a fairly mundane affair called the *Donation of Sutri.* This was simply **a**n agreement between Liutprand, King of the Lombards and Pope Gregory II in 728. At Sutri, the two reached an agreement by which the city and some hill towns were given to the Papacy, "as a gift to

the blessed Apostles Peter and Paul." The pact was only important in that it became a precedent[56] for the accumulation of Papal States.



Spread of Christianity to 325 AD Spread of Christianity to 600 AD

Courtesy Wikimedia Commons

The next episode, called the *Donation of Constantine*, is far more dramatic. In about 750, a letter was produced by the Church, supposedly written by Constantine I on his death bed. The *Donation* grants Pope Sylvester I and his successors, as inheritors of St. Peter, dominion over lands in Judea, Greece, Asia, Thrace, Africa, as well as the city of Rome, with Italy and the entire Western Roman Empire, while Constantine would retain imperial authority in the Eastern Roman Empire from his new imperial capital of Constantinople.

[56] Again, this shows an odd, instinctive human weakness – that if something has been done before, it must be "okay."

The text claims that the *Donation* was Constantine's gift to Sylvester for instructing him in the Christian faith, baptizing him and miraculously curing him of leprosy. It is unknown if any copy of this letter still exists and it is now universally considered a forgery, but it was accepted in its time. It was, again, a tool of legitimacy for the Church. They did not immediately try to collect all of the lands that Constantine "donated" to them, but they kept their legitimate right to those lands very much in the minds of the men and women of Europe.

The most dramatic story of "magic letters" occurs just a few years later in 754, when Pope Stephen II is reported to have received a letter from heaven, written in the hand of St. Peter, to the king of the franks, Pepin the Short.

Previously, Pope Stephen had traveled to Paris to anoint both Pepin and his sons as a new line of kings, thereby supplanting the old Merovingian royal line. Shortly thereafter, Pepin went to war with the Lombards who were taking Italy and heading toward Rome. After driving out the Lombards, Pepin apparently gave the Pope the lands which the Lombards had taken from the Byzantine Empire. Thus the Church was handed a sizable piece of the Italian peninsula – lands that would be called the *Papal States*, and which were the basis of the Papacy's secular power for a thousand years.

This purported letter – written in pure gold on the finest vellum – was widely considered legitimate during the Middle Ages. It is reported to have read as follows:

> Peter, elected Apostle by Jesus Christ, Son of the Living God. I, Peter, summoned to the apostolate by Christ, Son of the Living God, have received from the Divine Might the mission of enlightening the whole world.
>
> Wherefore, all those who, having heard my preaching, put it into practice, must believe absolutely that by God's order their sins are cleansed in this world and they shall enter stainless into everlasting life.
>
> Come ye to the aid of the Roman people, which has been entrusted to me by God. And I, on the day of Judgment, shall prepare for you a splendid dwelling place in the Kingdom of God.

Peter, Prince of the Apostles.

Again, whether or not there ever was such a letter, people widely believed that there was. It was not the letter itself that was important to the Church, but the legitimacy that came from people believing that the Pope was a holy enough man for Peter to drop down from heaven and give him such a note – and, again, that the magic virtue of a philosopher-king could overcome the military force of an army like that of the Lombards.

Pepin confirmed his Donation of land to the Church in 756, and in 774 his son Charlemagne confirmed the donation of his father.

In 800 Pope Leo III crowned Charlemagne as a Roman Emperor. This was a major step in establishing what later became known as the *Holy Roman Empire*, and from that date onward the popes claimed the right to crown its emperor. This gave them a legitimacy above the kings of the earth – just the right position for an institution of philosopher-kings, whose rule would continue without a major interruption for another five and a half centuries.

LIFE IN THE NEW EMPIRE

Daily life during the reign of the Church in Europe was stable. Life was not especially good – there were, for example, frequent famines, zero growth and ever-changing political alliances – but the Church was clearly regarded as the moral center of the universe, and they were almost always able to move the various secular rulers into paths that the Church chose, or at least into paths they could use with a back-up plan.

The Pope reigned as a king of kings, by maintaining a monopoly on legitimacy.

The Europeans of the Middle Ages were absolutely convinced that the order of their lives had been established by God and that to challenge that divine order would be a horrible offense. They saw a world made up of three types of people:

1. *Latores* - The kings and lesser nobles, who protected everyone else.
2. *Oratores* - The clergy, who interceded with God for everyone else.
3. *Laboratores* - The peasants, who fed everyone else.

There were always a few specialists on the fringes, such as itinerant traders and Jews, but they were not terribly many and always subject to

violence if they attracted too much attention. So, they seldom made much trouble.

Obviously, this was a horrible structure for production. Humans, after all, vary greatly in their talents, and any system that makes good use of human ability must allow people to operate where their personal talents are most effective. But, if breaking out of your hereditary 'place' is a sin, your talents are a non-issue. It was God's will that you were born into a certain class, so that is where you had to stay. And, once again, this rigid structure was first prescribed by Plato. He writes:

> *You are brothers, yet God has framed you differently. Some of you he has made like gold, who have the power of command, and also they have the greatest honour; others he has made of silver, to be auxillaries; others again who are to be husbandmen and craftsmen he has composed of brass and iron; and the species will generally be preserved in the children. … God proclaims as a first principle to the rulers, and above all else, that there is nothing which should so anxiously guard, or of which they are to be such good guardians, as of the purity of the race. … If the son of a golden or silver parent has an admixture of brass and iron, then nature orders a transposition of ranks, and the eye of the ruler must not be pitiful towards the child because he has to descend in the scale and become a husbandman or artisan … When a man of brass or iron guards the State, it will be destroyed.*

A very interesting comment follows, after someone asks whether instlling this idea in the populace is a practical possibility in the current situation. Plato goes on:

> *Not in the present generation… there is no way of accomplishing this; but their sons may be made to believe in the tale, and their sons' sons, and posterity after them.*

This is precisely what was done in medieval Europe. The people were made to believe something that did not come naturally to them – and it enslaved their minds for a thousand years. And, to an extent, this idea remains. This formulation of Plato and his empire has strongly contributed to the gut feeling of many mixed-race people that they are somehow inferior. The amount of human suffering caused by this giant lie has been astronomical.

GATHERING THE SURPLUS

We have previously described methods of expansion for previous civilizations, and showed that they all involved surplus production. This is a critical mechanism, and one that Professor Quigley defines as the defining characteristic of a civilization.

In the Mesopotamian civilization, surplus went directly upward from the people to a ruler. Then, as small centers of ruler-dominance were strung together into empires, portions went upward through middle layers of adminstrators and to the top levels of kings-of-kings, also called emperors. All through this era, surplus was used to build armies and monuments, and very little went to productive uses, such as the improvement of agriculture, metalurgy or the like.

In classical civilization, surplus-gathering was decentralized. Surplus passeed into the hands of a local farmer, who put it to work productively. In the early days of Greece and Rome, very little surplus left the places where it was used productively, and the civilizations thrived. Only later did both groups divert surplus to central political centers, where, again, it was used for armies and monuments. And, once again, the civilizations rotted.

During the time of this Platonic Empire, surplus was gathered by spiritual coercion far more than it was by direct force or even by political authority. Although production through this era was relatively low, there was surplus, and it was primarily gathered by the Church in the form of tithes, alms and other donations. (Some did go to kings, who used it for the usual armies and lavish living, though not much for monuments – that would have been condemned by the Church, so it was not done. The kings and princes did not want to risk the little legitimacy they retained.)

Probably the most effective method of surplus-gathering was bequests to the Church. A bequest to the Church assured that the deceased would have many Masses said for him, greatly reducing the unpleasant time he would otherwise have to spend in Purgatory. By the time of the Protestant reformation, the Catholic Church owned a shockingly large number of properties in Europe. This may have exceeded a third (and possibly approached half) of all the land that comprises modern France.

ONCE AGAIN, LEGITIMACY FAILS

In the film, *Ben Hur*, Pontius Pilate utters a great line, saying: *Do you know how to fight an idea? With another idea!* This is what happened to the Church

of Rome. In fact, it was a source of their own legitimacy that ruined them, a great irony.

During the reign of the Church (justly called the Dark Ages) knowledge was contained and controlled, but it could not be utterly done away with. For one thing, they needed to be the arbiters of Jesus, and that required the ability to quote him. With their legitimacy justified by being the successors to Jesus, Church functionaries had to be familiar with the story. They were very careful, however, that *only* the clergy had good access to Jesus' words. In fact, there are comments from the end of this period where the scriptures are called "the pearl of the clergy," which is taken from a saying of Jesus. Seeing this passage to completion, it was said that this pearl should not be "cast to the swine." The "swine," of course, being common people. This was a common attitude in the era.

But, Jesus' words had been written. They remained. The Empire tried to keep them wrapped-up, but they also needed literacy in order to operate their empire. And that meant that real human beings had to be able to read. And that was risky. The Church losing control of Jesus' words would make alternate interpretations possible. This would bring them back to the days before Constantine's council of Nicea and a unified doctrine. And if that happened, their legitimacy would be fractured and scattered in any number of directions. With no monopoly on legitimacy, their rule would end.

There are anecdotal stories all though the rule of the Church, telling of non-conformists in the Alps who retained both the scriptures and their own interpretations of them. Additional stories tell of these people doing things like smuggling passages of scripture into schools. But, there is little confirmation for these stories. It is certain that such people did exist by the 12th Century (1101-1200), commonly called Waldensians[57]. And, the Church, understanding the threat, used great effort to eliminate them by any means available, including massacre.

There were always clergymen differing with the Pope during the rule of the Church, but the massive authority of the papacy was quickly brought against them and none spread their variant ideas very far. Ironically, it was the writings of Plato's ancient adversary, Aristotle, that were pivotal in turning the tide.

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[57] There are stories tracing the line of the Waldensians back to Claude of Turin in the 9th Century, but though these stories do have their appeal, I have yet to find much evidence to support their authenticity.

While a few poor manuscripts of Aristotle had long existed in Latin, they didn't get much play. The Crusaders, however, returned from the east in the 11th and 12th Centuries with many more and better copies in Greek. Aristotle's ideas were not only new to most of the Europeans, but they had been highly respected in more ancient times, which gave them some legitimacy. This made them very attractive in a time when thinking was restricted to one path only.

By the early 13th Century, Aristotle was very popular in the schools of Paris. As a result, a Papal legate in Paris forbade teachers to lecture on Aristotle in 1225. Deeming this insufficient, Pope Gregory IX formed a commission to edit-out all objectionable passages of Aristotle's works in 1231. But there were, at this moment, another group of forgotten heroes in Paris – more of the true benefactors of our race, whose names are lost to history. These people were willing to face serious risks for what they believed, and they simply disobeyed the Pope, his emissaries and his orders. The seemingly omnipotent authority of the papacy was unable to stop them. As a result, by 1260 Aristotle was taught in virtually every Christian school. The Church did its best to merge Aristotle with their teachings, but it was a difficult mix. The Church had been built upon Plato, and Aristotle wrote some of his works in refutation of Plato.

It is fairly well known that most early Christian reformers were clergy. These were the people who had access to the New Testament, and reading Jesus' teachings led them to question the system they served. Ultimately, it made the bravest of them reject the Roman Catholic system, which had become horribly corrupt over time… as structures of central power always do.

The first great reformer was John Wycliffe, and he undertook the work of condemning the Church for extra-biblical teachings and corruption with exceptional ability. Then, Wycliffe created an even greater irritation to the Church by publishing the New Testament in English. This was a gigantic threat to the Church's precious legitimacy. Once anyone could read the record of Jesus for himself, he could form his own opinions and the Church's monopoly on legitimacy would be dead.

The Church tried to stop John Wycliffe, but he was far from Rome and the processes of the day were ill-designed for this sort of threat. By the time they came for Wycliffe, he was already dead[58]. Worse, there was a decentrlized group of followers called *Lollards* continuing his work. Over

[58] They did dig up his body, burn it, and throw his ashes in a nearby river.

time, they influenced many more reformers, such as Hus and Luther, who put a final end to Rome's monopoly on legitimacy.

The Church struggled long, dirty and hard to reverse the situation, but by the year 1500 it was clear that the changes were unstoppable. Guttenberg's printing press not only made Protestantism's victory certain, but it greatly sped-up the process. The official end of Plato's Empire came in 1638, when the Peace of Westphalia legally removed religious compulsion from rulership and gave Protestantism (in any number of forms) equal standing with the Church of Rome.

Certainly the Church of Rome continues, and certainly it continues to claim a special legitimacy, but its ability to maintain a monopoly on legitimacy is gone, and with it, its empire.

5

The Subversive Seed

That which is highly esteemed among men is abomination in the sight of God.
-- Jesus

Author's Note:

I had no intention of writing about Jesus in this book. This was not because of any disregard I have for the man – I just didn't see how he played much of a role in this story. But as the text took shape, he kept appearing. Before long, I understood that he was a major figure in my analysis. I couldn't keep him out and still write an honest book.

None of this has anything to do with Jesus actually being the son of God (or not). I am not dealing with beliefs here; I am concerned with the recorded teachings of Jesus and the effects they had upon the Western world. If the story of Jesus were nothing but a fable, it would make no difference at all in this analysis.

The Western civilization that follows Jesus is unique. It has gone through several rises and falls, yet it has never failed altogether. This is something that Professor Quigley noted fifty years ago and that puzzled him. Why is it that this one civilization keeps resurrecting itself? I never worked on the question very directly, but it did remain in the back of my mind. Then, piece by piece, an answer began to form, and its threads kept leading back to Jesus.

So be it.

THE INSERTION

Jesus' teachings enter history in a very interesting spot. The place is the Roman Empire, where communication and travel are approaching a peak that was not re-attained for nearly two thousand years[59]. Literacy is very high by pre-modern standards. In the province when Jesus arises, literacy is definitely high and the inhabitants have their minds unusually open to ideas[60]. The moment is just after the Roman Republic has been replaced by the Empire. The first emperor is in place, and all the seeds of Rome's demise have been sown.

Jesus seems to have been a fairly secretive man, and one who even his closest students never understood. Jesus, himself, wrote nothing that we are aware of. Yet within ten years of his death[61], his followers begin to spread far and wide, and to convince foreigners with their message. Within forty years of his death, the vast majority of his now-many followers were forcibly removed from both the city of Rome (49 A.D.) and from their center in Jerusalem (66 A.D.) They spread Jesus' teachings "below the radar" – in small towns, in the countryside, and in the mundane areas of cities. There were few restrictions on their travels and the Empire was a surprisingly open place to new religious ideas. Pagans did not seek to destroy other religions; rather, they allowed them. They did not think their gods had to be the only gods.

As is also well-known, Jesus was a Jew and lived among Jews. Their culture was, by this time, one of the few remnants of the Semitic civilization that invented a good deal of modern life. We turn to them now:

THE HEBREWS CREATE CAPITALISM

The Jews originated as a tribe of Semites in or around the region of Caanan, called *Habiru.* (Or, in modern language, *Hebrews.*) As mentioned earlier, their rise and fall closely follows another group of Semites called

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[59] Although we maintain in this book that centralized empires are a bad thing, it must be noted that their establishment does sometimes prevent fighting between smaller states. Since trade may be eliminated by such conflicts, there are can be certain benefits to a larger state.

[60] As usual for such situations, there were many ideas – both good and bad – flying around at the same time. But, such is the case when people become willing to think. Better this sort of confusion than the long, bleak periods when no one cares to think much at all.

[61] I am referring here to the spreading of Jesus' teachings throughout the Greek world, prior to the murder of James the son of Zebedee in about 44 A.D.

Phoenicians. The Phoenicians, crucially, kept knowledge alive during the Dark Ages of 1200-800 B.C.

The land-based Hebrew farmers were broken-off from the development pattern of the sea-based Phoenicians by their captivity in Babylon in the 6th Century B.C. After they were freed, in an unusual episode of world history, they returned to their land in Caanan and held ever-more stubbornly to their ancient beliefs.

As best can be determined, it was the ancient Habiru Caananites who invented what we call commercial capitalism, between 2000 B.C. and 1500 B.C. The name Habiru meant something along the lines of "landless and kin-shattered men." Specialists disagree on the precise meaning, but this rendering seems to be close to the original.

From this "landless and kin-shattered" description, we see that the originators of capitalism were disconnected from the impositions and expectations of their "culture." As mentioned at the beginning of chapter two, and as we will see in many other cases, what people term "culture" is very often a set of limitations placed upon a populace. These people, mentally separate from mass of humanity around them, were free to create a sensible new thing, and – even more importantly – were unopposed in their pursuit of it. When held strongly within a culture, many specific adaptations are forbidden to men, and are punished at every point where new ideas bump against cultural ideals. ("We don't do things that way.") That was not the case for the early Habiru, and they were the first non-farmers to create value as a way of life.

The genius of commercial capitalism[62] is that it puts human imagination and cleverness to work in overcoming scarcity. Under this system, the slavery of the classical era was no longer required; all men could be equally free. Like the early Armenian farmers, these people overcame scarcity with intelligence and creativity. The ancient Armenians did it via agriculture; the Habiru did it via commerce.

This separation that left the "kin-shattered" Habiru free to devise commerce remained as a defining characteristic of their descendents, the Jews. Separateness was most certainly the defining characteristic of the

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[62] The word *capitalism* seems to have originated with Karl Marx, and was intended as a somewhat derogatory term. It was meant to convey the idea of grasping and blind acquisition, in order to produce envy. A much better term would be *free trade*, but that has differing meanings. *Free markets* and *free human action* are also better terms, but require explanation and acclimation. So, I will continue to use *capitalism*, with this caveat.

early Biblical commands to the Jews and it most certainly carried over into the earliest forms of Christianity.

Roman Christianity obviously went the opposite way by forcing everyone to become a Christian, but the subversive, "we are separate" culture of the Jews and of Jesus remained in the words of the *New Testament* and still exists in many forms of Christianity.

An interesting clarification here is that the Hebrew and Christian "separateness" does not merely refer to specific us/them groupings, but to the act of grouping itself.

THE HEBREWS CREATE MONOTHEISM

Monotheism was a more potent formulation than is commonly understood. A strong argument can be made that it has succeeded because of inherent psychological advantages – primarily in that it harmonizes with human nature and legitimizes the more efficient modes of human reasoning.

Arguments can be made that the Hebrews were not the first monotheists. A few Egyptians and Persians seem to have come up with the idea independently, and proof one way or the other is thin. But it *is* fairly certain that the Hebrews created the first permanent monotheistic culture.

The argument for the utility of monotheism consists of four primary points:

1. Humans are, by their inescapable structure, individuals. We feel only the pain produced in our own bodies and we are only aware of thought produced in our own minds. (Unless we communicate, of course.) Our use of energy and creativity are individual enterprises. We may obviously cooperate, but we are fully individuals, not corporate entities[63].
2. What people hold to as the highest and best has a profound effect on their thinking. The images and ideals they hold as "high and great" in their minds are things that they continually refer to. This colors their thoughts and decisions on a moment-by-moment basis.

[63] This is utterly obvious, but does need to be pointed-out, since so many pop-philosophies champion imaginations such as "inherent unity."

3. Monotheism sets a distinct individual as the highest and greatest being that ever was or ever will be. Accordingly, the core statement of Judaism has always been: *Hear O Israel, the Lord is one.* Again, a distinct individual is set as perfection.

4. With this pattern in the minds of men, they are less afraid to think as individuals, which suits their nature. As a result, they tend to come up with marginally better ideas and to produce better results; not because monotheism correctly describes any deity, but because it encourages humans to think as individuals and to develop self-reference.

The image of a single, perfect god not only gives men the courage to think for themselves but it makes it easier for men to compare themselves to the highest and the ultimate. By imagining how the ultimate high and great being sees things, we can understand what it means to be high and the great… and begin to emulate it.

There could, of course, be many versions of monotheism. The Sikhs, for example, have a formulation that includes reincarnation. But, remaining on our subject, it is interesting that the Judeo-Christian version of monotheism has these additional characteristics of interest:

> **Supreme Goodness.** The Judeo-Christian god is seen as qualitatively perfect[64]. This gives believers something to strive toward. And since there is a huge theme of the believers being associated with God, they esteem themselves as at least largely able to gain these characteristics as well. This kinship of believer with God is especially strong in the New Testament, where the relationship is explicitly that of a father and his family.
>
> **The Ethical Becomes the Eternal.** Judeo-Christian monotheism magnifies ethical choices. Acting charitably toward your neighbor doesn't just matter here and now, it creates an eternal reward. Thus, ethical choices become hyper-important, and people, on average, tend to improve their conduct accordingly.

[64] Legitimate arguments are made that this was not the case in the long-distant past, but it has certainly been the case since the time of Jesus, so we will pass over such arguments.

Again, the issue here is not whether or not there is actually a god, but the effects that these ideas have upon the minds and conduct of human men and women.

WHO IS GOD?

In chapter two, we explained how gods became mixed in the ancient world as one group overran another and superimposed their god upon the previous god. Eliminating the old god was not practical for the goal of easy rulership, so it was retained, with the new god becoming a partner in the enterprise. The particular case covered was a female production-god being overrun by a male plunder-god. The gods of men have been mixed ever since.

So, who was god to be? Is he (or she) kind or vengeful? Does he champion creative synthesis or lordly control? Does he save or does he prefer to punish? Who is this being, really?

Jesus sets out a new version of God, and one that is further from the plunder-god and much closer to the production-god. It is true that elements of each come across in the recordings of Jesus' sayings, and it is likely that the versions we have are not identical to his actual teachings. Regardless, to a very significant extent, Jesus went about to un-mix the gods. Whether Jesus thought of it this way or not, a good deal of his message addresses this issue, and in ways that are seldom appreciated.

First of all, Jesus constantly separates his god from all previous gods, even the god of the Jews. At one point, he tells a group of religious Jews: *It is my Father that honors me; of whom you say, that he is your God: Yet you have not known him.* His followers would maintain that Jesus was trying to bring the Jews back to the true god – and Jesus may well have said this himself – but the point remains, he describes a god who is *different in nature* from the one they are currently worshipping.

To begin with, Jesus' God is not an arbitrary judge above; he is Jesus' father. And, more than that, a loving father. And this father loves "his own" in the world. In fact, Jesus goes so far as to say that his father loves his followers as much as he loves Jesus.

Jesus further brings divine ability back down among men, much like the production-goddess did. When people are healed, he tells them: ***Your***

faith has made you well. He tries (to little avail[65]) to convince them that divine power is present among normal humans, just not a special man like himself. *According to **your** faith, it is done unto you.* He comes back to this subject frequently, telling his students that they will be able to do everything he has done, and although the message was apparently lost by these men, the record of his attempts remains.

Associated with this are the ideas of hierarchy and separation, which are generally associated with rulers and with priesthoods, respectively:

Plunder cultures formulated gods that justified and aided their rulers: Hierarchical, demanding and punishing. Jesus differs[66]. He does mention a final judgment at the end of human civilization (with associated rewards or penalties), but to men within their earthly lives, his god much prefers to plead rather than to punish.

Religious leaders of all types have usually preferred to make God very high and man very low – creating a great separation. This, obviously, makes them far more important, as the special humans who are able to communicate across this great gulf. Jesus very directly addresses this, resolutely condemning the very idea of a special class of priests and eliminating a gulf between god and man by his very person – being both god and man at once.

This is a rich subject for believers and for theologians, but we will not spend great time on it here. The crucial issue is that Jesus made significant and persistent efforts to describe the true nature of god as much closer to the production goddess than to the plunder ruler.

- The goddess was benevolent and loving: Jesus' father fiercely loved men.
- The goddess was not above, but among men: Jesus insists that the power of god is among men.
- The purpose of the goddess was to effect production: Jesus incessantly demands that his followers should "bear fruit." That is, to be productive.

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[65] As in many other applications, it is easier to paint a man like Jesus as "the great one," and justify one's own lack of advancement, since "we are not special like him." Once again, self-improvement is a difficult business, and one that most men are happy to evade.

[66] In general, Jesus removes divine judgment to where the Hebrews had originally removed their God – outside of the created world.

- The goddess provided the magic spark of production to men: Jesus came, *to serve, not to be served.*

JURIS SUPERIORI, MORT

Jesus tried long and hard to stop men's minds from thinking about the enforcer above, who would punish them for stepping out of line. He wanted to replace this thought process with something better. He, clearly, set a new foundation for judging right and wrong.

Before Jesus, defining proper conduct was done by reference to law. In other words, men were told to measure themselves by an external standard. Jesus changed this, and told men to measure themselves by an internal standard.

Notice some of the things Jesus says:

- *Whatever you would have men do unto you, do ye even so to them.*
- *With whatever judgment you judge, you shall be judged.*
- *By your words you will be justified, and by your words you shall be condemned.*
- *He… has no root in himself.*
- *Forgive our debts as we forgive our debtors.*

These are only some more overt examples. Jesus clearly instructs men to judge themselves by reference to things internal rather than external. Indeed, he demands it of them.

This teaching of Jesus describes an entirely new moral system, based on a completely different operative mechanism than that of the Law of Moses or of any hierarchy that has ever existed. According to Jesus, you are to judge by self-reference, not by referral to a set of edict made or enforced by others.

This new formulation is highly subversive[67]. Indeed, it is fundamentally incompatible with every centralized application of governance.

THE CODE OF PRODUCTION

Within Jesus' teachings and those of his close friends, there is a code of production that has continually informed Western civilization. (We will be come to Western civilization in the next chapter.) Whether Western civilization currently retains any belief in Christ matters little; Jesus, the crowning prophet of the Hebrews, made the West what it is. And it is

[67] Which may explain why it has never been championed: Too risky.

this code of production that made the West cooperative and productive. Direct quotations from the *New Testament* are set in italics:

An Expectation of Reason

> *Why, of your own selves, do you not know what is right?*
>
> *Examine yourselves... prove your own selves.*

There are a few anti-reason passages in the New Testament, but the command to reason exists, and most emphatically from the mouth of Jesus himself. This gives any Christian full leave to use his or her mind.

> *Be ready always to give an answer to any man who asks you a reason.*

This makes the believer responsible for understanding. He or she must consider, understand, internalize the essential facts, and, be able to assemble and present them to others.

Compassion for the Outsider

> *If a man have an hundred sheep, and one of them be gone astray, does he not leave the ninety and nine, and go seek that which is gone astray?*
>
> *There shall be more joy in heaven over one sinner that repenteth, than over ninety-nine who need no repentance.*

Considering that hatred of "the outsider" has caused enormous death tolls under many belief systems, this love for the outsider is a critical feature indeed.

Violence is Discouraged

> *If a man strike you on one cheek, turn to him the other.*

This discouragement of violence (sometimes considered a prohibition) has kept human affairs far less ugly than they might have been otherwise. Where use of force is reduced, freedom and prosperity are increased. Whether any particular group of nominal Christians followed this admonition is not the issue; this primary message in the New Testament has borne good fruit.

Self-Reliance

How is it that you go to law, one against another?

In modern terms, we might express this as: "Why are you suing each other in court? If you can't solve your own problems, and are running to a government to do it for you, you're no examples of my teachings." This code expects people to solve their own inter-personal problems. In effect, it says, "If you can't handle self-reliance, you're not much of a believer."

Co-Dominance

Love your adversaries.

Let's say you are in the construction business; so are a dozen other people in your town; you compete against them every day. Can you still respect them and care about them as human beings? This is what Jesus demands of his followers – an essential and healthy thing. Without this, business becomes war. Actually, without this idea being mutually held, everything inter-personal becomes war, with one person or another always dominating, and the other forced to submit.

Where co-dominance is absent, anger festers, compassion fails, grudges are never released, and endless volumes of energy are wasted in posturing and scheming. (As opposed to using that energy to create value.)

Where co-dominance is present, cooperation rules and massive accomplishment can and does arise.

For people to live together in a peaceful way, either co-dominance with cooperation is necessary, or tyrannical central control is required.

Forgiveness and Repentance

Since the beginning, this set of stories has glorified men who had deep changes of heart. This not only allows bad men to start anew and improve, but it removes all guilt for their past actions. There are problems associated with this from a justice standpoint, but it did make human improvement popular. Again, this was hugely beneficial.

Separation of Church and State

> *Render to Caesar that which is Caesar's and to God that which is God's.*

This tends to keep the God-State alliance from getting too strong and keeps god and state in a permanent balancing act. Balancing means variation and modification of both. Neither states controlled by religion nor states that eliminate religion have ever allowed as much production as much as those doing this balancing act.

Self-Reference and Integrity

> *Whatever you would have men do unto you, do ye even so to them.*
>
> *With whatever judgment you judge, you shall be judged.*
>
> *By your words you will be justified, and by your words you shall be condemned.*

Consider how much better this is than the old, "Obey without thinking or else" model. This model encourages honesty above obedience and suggests that people can set their own moral code, provided that they are not hypocritical.

THE PERMANENT RESET

We have previously discussed the moments, at the end of Dark Ages, when people finally pulled themselves together and developed virtuous, cooperative arrangements that allowed them to move forward. We further said (and shall say again) that this early formulation is eventually lost, leading to the downfall of that civilization.

The historical importance of Jesus' teachings is that they created a *creed of the foundational moment*, incorporating, explaining and demanding a set of virtues that – if they are followed – produce a cooperative, productive society.

Because this code was written, it does not need to be entirely re-learned at the base of each societal cycle. In an enduring form, the foundation is effectively re-laid in one individual at a time, to one extent or another, every time these teachings are sufficiently explained. The teachings of Jesus are a permanent societal reset.

Of course, there are many possible objections to the statements above, based upon individual cases that differed[68]. And, of course, many of these cases were truly horrific. Nonetheless, this statement is generally true, and it provides the answer to Professor Quigley's question. So, why does this one society continue to resurrect itself? Because it contains a creed of the foundational moment, which remains accessible at all times. Most people will ignore this creed until absolutely necessary, but when they do need it, it is present.

It is also worth noting that Jesus' reset is also a Semitic reset. It particularly addresses the issues of commerce and trade. And – very importantly – it rejects the classical model of surplus through slavery and replaces it with human creativity. Instead of enforcing scarcity upon others, creativity conquers scarcity.

Furthermore, Jesus does not want men to merely hear and mimic his teachings, he wants them to live them and to make them their own. Jesus' goal is nothing less than for all men to become independent creators of original virtues. He teaches that virtues must be grown from within each individual, not merely accepted as hand-me-downs.

That, whether initially apparent or not, this is both highly productive and highly subversive at the same time.

[68] Most of these objections do not directly address Jesus' code, but the actions of people who merely pretended to follow it.

6

Western Civilization Forms

> *Western Civilization… might be summed-up in the belief that "Truth unfolds through time in a communal process."*
> -- Carol Quigley

The quote above expresses a great core of Western civilization, if not *the* core. There are many facets to the formula: *Truth is revealed by a communal (which means cooperative) process.* And while this statement may be new to most of us, its implications are not. Everyone in the West faces them every day; so much so that we never really consider their value.

This formulation has been assumed many times in this book already. By this, the sixth chapter, phrases like "We know that…" or "we have no information on…" have been used many times. Every time we use such words, we presume that truth is built, that all of us may contribute to this building of knowledge, and that we will certainly have more in the future than we have now. Truth is revealed by a cooperative process.

Obviously, this belief makes Western civilization[69] optimistic, but there is more than just that; it also makes authoritarian rule incompatible with our beliefs. If the final truth is yet to be revealed, who can say that he or she has full knowledge and should be given full powers? It also makes the West open to new ideas from whatever source. If something contributes to the accumulation of truth, who cares where it comes from? It is a fact we can use.

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[69] I do not consider the classical civilizations of Greece and Rome to be "Western civilization." Certainly we in the West have borrowed from them considerably, but they operated on a radically different model from ours. Their system was built upon slavery.

This idea that full knowledge comes in the future is even found in the root documents of Christianity, where Jesus talks about things that are "unknown to the son, but to the father only." Even the most strident evangelicals, if questioned properly, will make the distinction between having *some* perfect truth and having *all* perfect truth.

Another important aspect is revealed by saying, "We know." Who is *we*? It is any individual who contributes. That assumes a civilization based upon merit, individuality and equality[70]. Truth does not descend from a ruler or from any authority at all; we all can contribute truth and we all can and should take care to preserve truth. Again, dictatorships and blind faith are fully incompatible with the Western ideal: No one has full truth now, because it lies in the future. Thus, no one should be followed with blind faith.

Closely related to this ideal is the assumption that we are a community of interests. We don't all have the same dreams and desires; we don't all have to fit into the same mold. Even so, we all may contribute to the accumulation of truth, and so long as we do not intrude upon others, we are sure that we should be free to pursue our narrow personal interests unimpeded. This builds civilization on a decentralized model, which is exceptionally resilient and has many other advantages.

A STRANGE INCUBATION

When a massive civilization falls, as did Rome, whatever is to follow it has to reform, and only after the fallen civilization has fully unwound. But in the case of Western civilization, this unwinding and reformation took place beneath an odd, virtual empire.

Rome did devolve, but this devolution occurred underneath the rule of the Church. The process of devolution and reformation did occur, but it was continuously affected by the Platonic Empire that rode on top of it.

The breakdown of Roman society was dramatic: Roman law was forgotten, the currency more or less vanished and trade contracted. Regional and local rulers grabbed whatever territories they could control. Everything that was paid for out of the central treasuries was abandoned: Libraries, public baths, arenas, and educational institutions were forsaken

[70] Equality in the sense that all stand equally upon their merits and their actions; that there are no inherent classes. The radical egalitarian ideal that inequality is evidence of wrong-doing is NOT part of the Western tradition.

and their buildings either torn down for materials or used for other purposes (by whoever could grab them and defend them).

Things that were paid for and controlled on a local level, however, did well. Farming, for example, actually improved in many places. Crop yields rose as central interference failed and farmers were left alone to make their own, more sensible, decisions. As the massive load of Roman taxation ceased, more efforts could be put into farm improvements as well. For many farmers, the collapse of the Roman Empire was definitely not a catastrophe. Joseph Tainter[71] has published archeological findings, showing that average nutrition actually improved after the collapse in many parts of the former Roman Empire.

Trade was probably affected the most. Protection along trade routes had been handled by the central government. Once that was gone, it became unsafe to travel or carry goods over any distance, and there was a collapse in trade and in manufacturing goods for export. Protection could have been provided by local groups all-along (it was certainly in their interest to do so), but the Empire was not structured this way. Once protection provided by the center failed, the local powers did not step up to provide it: Such actions are almost never undertaken under conditions of collapse, when people grab at whatever they can take and think little of cooperation. So, trade and manufacturing fell along with centralization. A few manufacturing operations are known to have continued in the extreme southwest of England, but not many others.

THE CENTURIES OF STASIS

Between the 5th and 8th centuries, smaller ruling organizations filled the political void left by the centralized Roman government. Germanic tribes built decentralized kingdoms where the Empire had been[72]. Roman landholders in the countryside were generally removed (violently) and/or fled to the Eastern Empire. Some, however, made alliances with the new rulers. In areas like Spain and Italy, this merely required the acknowledgement of a new overlord, but in other areas a change of dress, language, and custom might be required.

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[71] An anthropologist particularly interested in the collapse of societies, and the author of *The Collapse of Complex Societies*.

[72] The Ostrogoths in Italy, the Visigoths in Hispania, the Franks and Burgundians in Gaul and western Germany, the Angles and the Saxons in Britain, and the Vandals in North Africa.

The one thing the Church[73] needed was stability. Its legitimacy was balanced upon the ideas that existed in twenty-five or thirty million[74] European minds. Minds, of course, are variable; they can change much faster than armies and weapons. So, constancy was paramount and the Church worked to keep the rule of the local priest strong, heresies to a minimum, and kingdoms controllable. In most cases, this meant to keep kingdoms small, weak, and in need of the Church's assistance. No one has even attempted[75] a history of the Church's manipulations during the Middle Ages. Finding solid information from this time would certainly be a problem, but it is the number of intrigues that would prove overwhelming: The Church watched, guided, manipulated and punished the hundreds of kings, princes and nobles incessantly.

One effect of Church manipulation was that it impeded the power of the rulers. This was probably best for the Church and it harmonized nicely with the general winding-down of power through the period. The few rulers of large areas could be brought into especially close (and therefore safe) relationships with the Church, as happened with Charlemagne and his *Carolingian* empire. It was during this period of Church-state rule that a brief moment of progress occurred during the Dark Ages.

The *Carolingian Renaissance* is generally thought of as a period of intellectual and cultural revival that began in the late 8th Century and continued through much of the 9th. During this period there was an increase of literature, writing, various arts, architecture, jurisprudence, and theological studies. However, these activities were sponsored by the state and were centralized in nature. The king, certainly, wished to receive the credit for the advances. Furthermore, this "renaissance" was not the birth of new cultural movements, but was an attempt to recreate the previous culture of the Roman Empire, and most of the changes were confined to the clergy. So, there were a few steps forward made at this time, but they were limited and temporary. Soon enough, the Carolingian Empire was invaded and broken-up. The underlying order of the time could not support an empire – it was a time of small and devolving units of power.

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[73] When I use the capitalized word, Church, I am referring to the Roman Catholic Church, which was ***the*** church for a millennium and more.

[74] The approximate population of Europe in the period between 400 and 1000 A.D.

[75] As far as I know.

The Vikings attacked the northern parts of the empire and went so far as to besiege Paris in 885–886. The Magyars attacked the eastern frontiers, especially Germany and Italy, and the Muslim Saracens were able to sack Rome in 846, as well as conquering Corsica, Sardinia, and Sicily. Like the Vikings, they operated via pirate raid, which seemed an especially good military strategy during this era. Before long, however, the Vikings converted to Christianity and stopped attacking. The Saracens, obviously, did not, and remained a threat.

So, as the Dark Ages rolled across Europe, the pattern was devolution beneath and stasis above. This continued for at least five hundred years. During this time, daily life became stable and not terribly good. By the end of this time, the vast majority of people lived in isolated villages set in the midst of open fields. These villages normally contained between twenty and a hundred houses, and were fairly evenly spaced. Around the clusters of houses were fields of wheat, oats, rye and barley.

A house was usually a two-room cottage of about twelve by twenty-four feet. It had one door and a window for each room. One room was usually used used for animals, but if a separate stable was built, one room would be for sleeping and the other for cooking and eating. The floor would be dirt and the roof could be thatch, shingle or turf. Everyone worked in the fields.

The average peasant would know no more than two hundred or perhaps three hundred humans in his lifetime. His entire vocabulary might be a few hundred words. Most importantly, he was persuaded that he was in the precise position in which the creator and ruler of the universe wished him to be. As a result, there was almost no desire to improve one's self. Medieval man had very, very few decisions to make; his life was scripted from cradle to grave.

Power was almost fully decentralized, with just a portion going up through many layers between the local *fief*[76] and the king. A man from one layer of land-ownership may never have met the man two or three layers removed. The central ruler had the right to call up soldiers from the lower levels (by passing requests down, layer by layer), but not a great deal more, and this only about forty days per year. Following is an example of how the hierarchy of land rights and ownership went, from

[76] A *fief* referred to small piece of local land. But, more properly, it meant the right to exploit this particular piece of land, and the obligation to provide some level of service to the lord above the fief-holder, in return for this right.

from the reign of king Edward I of England (1239-1307). This example is from a slightly later time, but it shows the multiple layers and rights to the land's produce.

Note that the peasants are considered part of the land. This was the pattern setup by Rome's laws in response to the Crisis of the 3rd Century, but by this time it was justified much differently. The Emperor's edict was backed by power. By this time, slavery had devolved into *serfdom*, whereby the peasants were tied to the land more by religious obligation than by power[77]. A serf was not specifically the property of the lord, he was "owned" by the land. His parents, grandparents, and so on were creatures of that sliver of geography and he inherited the same relationship. And, again, everyone of the era was assured that the serf's divinely-ordered place on earth was to produce food for everyone else.

So, here is a structure of ownership and rights from Edwardian England:

> *Roger of St. Germain holds land at Paxton in Huntingdonshire of Robert of Bedford,*
>
> *who holds of Richard of Ilchester,*
>
> *who holds of Alan of Chartres,*
>
> *who holds of William le Boteler,*
>
> *who holds of Gilbert Neville,*
>
> *who holds of Devorguil,*
>
> *who holds of the king of Scotland,*
>
> *who holds of the king of England.*

A village would have a pond, used for drinking water, wash water and water for powering the mill. In addition, animals would drink from this same pond. A large outdoor oven and a blacksmith's forge were shared in the village. In or near the village would be a small church and a residence for the priest. The one large residence in the village was the manor house. This was inhabited by the lord or the Lord's agent, who might be either very rich or of such modest means that he would also work the fields.

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[77] There were a number of types of serfs. As slavery continued to devolve, opportunities opened for those serfs who desired more freedom to get it. It was never as easy as it "should" have been, but freedom did increase.

Plowing was done with teams of oxen and iron plows, but few hand tools were available and roads for transporting grain were rare. Crops were planted in two-field or three-field rotations. There was little surplus and most people during this time lived at the edge of starvation.

The peasant was under constant surveillence by the *forester* or game-warden, to make sure that he did not hunt; hunting was the reserved priviledge of the nobility, both for reasons of food and for sport. This illustrates the continuing exclusivity of predatory skills. The rulers had lethal weapons, used them, and forbade all others to do so. The fundamental and ancient power equation remained – the rulers held both the ability and the legal right to violence; the peasants were forbidden to do so. As it was in ancient Mesopotamia, so it was in Medieval Europe.

THE EUROPEANS SEE TO IT THEMSELVES

> *Civilization can only revive when there shall come into being in a number of individuals a new tone of mind independent of the one prevalent among the crowd and in opposition to it, a tone of mind which will gradually win influence over the collective one, and in the end determine its character. It is only an ethical movement which can rescue us from the slough of barbarism, and the ethical comes into existence only in individuals.*
> -- Albert Schweitzer

The fundamental re-organizational element to the growth of Western civilization was *initiative*. People simply took it upon themselves to pursue the things they wanted. They did not wait for permission or beseech a ruler to do it for them; they simply went out and did it. This theme was showing itself widely by about 1000 A.D.

One of the first places it showed itself was in learning. Aside from Church facilities, which were highly restricted, there was no learning to speak of between the years of 500 and 1000. Then, a small number of men created the first universities of Europe, most of which remain to this day. Among these were:

1088 The University of Bologna
1160 The University of Paris
1167 The University of Oxford
1209 The University of Cambridge

1212 The University of Palencia

1218 The University of Salamanca

1220 The University of Montpellier

1222 The University of Padua

1229 The University of Toulouse

1235 The University of Orleans

All of these schools began as private enterprises – simple commercial arrangements between the teachers and their pupils. It was only after these schools were established that rulers began to acknowledge them and to certify them. A few minor reasons aside, the real reason for this was to maintain control. By "certifying" the university, they could effectively control what was taught, or else the certification would be pulled in the most embarrassing fashion possible. Popes and Emperors hurried to place their stamps of approval upon these schools, who had built their operations entirely with certifications prior.

The University of Bologna operated for seventy years before Frederick I, the Holy Roman Emperor legally declared it a place for research in 1258.

What became the University of Paris actually began with a few small schools in Paris that functioned quietly on the fringes of legitimacy. The man who turned them into open places of learning was Peter Abelard (1079-1142). Unhappy with the censorship of intellectuals by the Church, Abelard and others helped form what became a *universitas*, modeled on the mediaeval guild, as a self-regulating, permanent institution of higher education.

Abelard began his intellectual life by wandering throughout France, debating and learning as he went. By the time he was twenty, he was in Paris, studying at the cathedral of Notre-Dame, one of the three small schools mentioned above[78]. Soon enough, he ran into opposition from the principle teacher. So, in 1101, at twenty-two years of age, Abelard set up a school about forty kilometers from Paris, and then moved it to a closer town for some time before he was able to lay the foundation for a *universitas magistrorum et scholarium* (guild of masters and scholars) in Paris, which finally came together in a permanent form in 1160, eighteen years after Abelard's death.

[78] The others were the Palatine school and the school of the abbey of Saint Genevieve.

Note that is was not until 1231 that Pope Gregory IX formally recognized Abelard's creation – 130 years after he had opened his first school and 71 years after the universitas was fully in place.

A notable student of Abelard's was John of Salisbury (1120-1180), who somehow traveled from England to France in 1136, when only sixteen years old. He had a long and distinguished career in Paris, mostly after Abelard's death, eventually publishing a very important book called *Policraticus.* This book set the moral foundation of what later came to be called The Rule of Law. (As well as exposing the decadence and immorality of the royalty.)

The itinerant student Abelard had created a place of unapproved thinking in the midst of distributed kings and an overseeing virtual empire. In this situation, and partly by playing prince against Church, he found open room in which he could act and expand. And he found, within himself, the initiative to go out and do it. Soon enough, students with new ideas created a new ethical system that would bring kings in subjection to the law.

The fact that both Abelard and John were men of exceptional gifts certainly mattered, but this actually distracts from and confuses the point, since the human species always produces men of exceptional gifts. The truth about gifted men is this: At most times and in most places they find very little free space in which they are allowed to expand beyond the accepted and the mundane. Most of them die unknown and unhappy – frequently depressed, drunken, or both.

GOTHIC SCULPTURE

Another area in which Europeans began to show initiative was art, and sculpture in particular. This new direction began at the same time universities were forming, in about 1140 A.D.

The earliest Gothic art were religious sculptures, on the walls of Cathedrals and abbeys. But instead of continuing the existing, non-representative tradition, these sculptors changed the Virgin Mary changed from an iconic form to a more human and affectionate mother, cuddling her infant, swaying from her hip, and showing the manners of a courtly lady. These were the first steps into secular and representational art.

At this time cities were forming, trade began to increase, coins were circulating, and a class of tradesmen and shop-keepers was beginning to form; people could afford to commission artwork. In this situation,

artist's trade guilds were formed and some artists became so bold as even to sign their names to their work.

Gothic art told a narrative story through pictures, both Christian and secular. From 1225 on, Gothic art can be seen spreading throughout Europe. This art was radically different than what had had seemed permanent up till that time. This provided notice to the people of Europe that things were changing, and that better things were succeeding the previous things.

LITERATURE

In about the 8th Century[79], that is, during the recovery period following the dissolution of Rome, an epic poem called *Beowulf* appeared in Britain. It became so popular that it was considered a national epic, much like the Iliad had been in early Greece. It is of special interest to this discussion in that it explores many of the most important ideals for the reset of a civilization.

The story-line of Beowulf involves the slaying of monsters that were bent upon destroying the joy of mankind. But the more important part of Beowulf is not the direct story-line, but the lessons that it teaches.

For example, the story begins with a three-part setup:

1. Joy is the proper place of mankind**.** One passage reads: *How almighty God made this glorious world of wonders washed by the sea, how he set on high the sun and moon as undying lights for dwellers on earth and trimmed the distant tracts of the world with branches and leaves, bringing forth life in every kind of earthly creature.*
2. A man-eating giant hates this, and greedily, pitilessly kills, and the beer-hall[80] of joy is empty.
3. The people become estranged from God because of their pain – grasping at some way to end it. Another passage reads: *Hell had possession of their erring minds; they were ignorant of the Light of life, the Lord almighty, and of how to pray to heaven's King, the God of glory. Grim is the lot of heedless men who hurl their souls into the clutch of fire, who cut themselves off from grace forever!*

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[79] Some specialists date it as late as the 11th Century, and there is a great deal of contention on this issue.

[80] "Mead hall" is actually a better translation. Mead is an ancient type of alcoholic beverage – often similar to a wine - made from honey. It is still commonly drunk in some places. Mead halls were not only for drinking, but for meetings and for residence.

This setup grabbed the interest of men at this time, who had been through a roughly analogous process. They sat in the devastation, among people who were wounded to the point where they had become destructive. They needed a way back to decency, and the story of Beowulf gave it to them, at least as an inspirational image. Some of the images that appear in Beowulf are these:

- Honor. *To repay a debt of past kindness.*
- Humility. *He… was an abler warrior than I.*
- Composure and forbearance when insulted. Passing-over slights.
- Active faith in God. Not just words, but acting upon beliefs.
- Gratitude.
- Endurance.
- The conduct of a worthy successor.

So, at this time of reformation and recovery, Beowulf became exceedingly popular. Also popular at the time were Christian poems and hymns, most notably those of the monk Caedmon. Again, this was the literature of foundation and restoration. It would not likely have been popular several centuries earlier.

THE GUILDS

Medieval guilds were exclusive organizations, created to preserve the rights and privileges of their members. The guild was self-created power. (Again, the Europeans seeing to things themselves.) The guild was separate and distinct from the civic governments, although wealthy guildsmen soon-enough sought positions in city governments and blurred the lines.

Guilds were entirely city organizations. There was no place for a guild where specialization of labor didn't exist; they only arose where cities formed and specialists were required.

Merchant guilds were the first to appear, at around the year 1000. These were mutual protection societies for traveling merchants. In other words, these were traders who banded together and developed ways to protect themselves while traveling through Europe on business. They went so far

as to found their own towns, as we will examine later in this chapter. This was the rebirth of trade, this time on a decentralized model.

Craft guilds followed the merchant guilds, and normally included people engaged in the same occupation, such as bakers, cobblers, stone masons and carpenters. Again, these were self-created organizations for mutual aid. And, again, as the guildsmen became wealthy (or, more usually, their children), they sought municipal positions of power. And, once in power, the guild would soon use that power to forbid any non-members from practicing their trade. Local rulers were also eager to control the guilds, and laws were soon passed that forced all guild members to takes oaths of loyalty.

This process is one that is seen over and over:

1. A fresh start is made, independently, by unauthorized individuals.
2. The new venture gains popularity with other individuals.
3. Rulers seek to bring it under their control. Since the new venture has been accepted by many people, this is done in a subversive way, usually by offering official recognition.
4. The group grows into a formal organization, and second- or third-generation members seek position of authority within the organization. Thus focused on authority, they seek to join themselves with still greater authority – usually a state.
5. Once in a position of authority, the organization uses state power to magnify itself and to enrich its members by punishing and suppressing competition.
6. Eventually the organization goes too far and the situation changes. The organization fails, grasping and abusing all the power it can on the way down.

Soon enough, the purpose of the guilds became to maintain a monopoly of a particular craft – but some more so, some less. Manufacturing guilds, for example, tended to establish reputations for quality rather than restricting competitors. These people wanted to expand their sales and needed to convince people in distant places to buy their products. They wanted more people involved. *Victualling guilds*, on the other hand – the groups who sold foods – were big on restraining trade. People didn't need to be convinced to buy their products, since biology did that for them – their customers became hungry every day, no matter what. So,

with no need to convince people to buy, they went about to forcibly restrain trade and to raise their prices as high as they could.

There was usually a strong religious aspect to guild membership. This functioned as a way of enforcing the good behavior of the guild members; it may also have acted as a hedge against local officials and their power: *I am connected to the Church; don't mess with me.*

As the guilds failed after the Reformation, many turned to governments, asking them to enforce monopolies on manufacturing[81] or trade and to force members to pay back obligations. Where governments provided such force, the guilds hung on. In the absence of force, they did not.

THE SOVEREIGNTY OF LAW

> *It is established by authority of the divine law that the prince is subject to the law and to justice.*
> -- John of Salisbury

Since the state at this time had a minimum of direct legitimacy (the Church seizing as much as was possible) the previously-mentioned John of Salisbury published his book *Policraticus*, from which the quote above is taken. John was among the first to propose that the prince should be subject to law. The Church, conveniently, supported this idea, primarily because they always wanted to keep the princes under control, and, as mentioned previously, this was not easy to do, since they had a very limited force to use. And, since divinity was included in John's formulation, the Church signed-on and the idea stuck.

During the classical era, the citizen was considered the seat of sovereignty. As Western society evolved, however, sovereignty slowly accrued to "the law," instead of to the people or to the rulers. The ruler was legitimated by upholding law. The ruler was considered illegitimate if he failed to uphold law. Over time, the Rule of Law became the code of Western civilization.

But this did not spring into place in a moment, even after John's formulation was published in about 1159. It spread slowly and in

[81] Though seldom noted, it is important to remember that monopolies associated with the state function only with violence backing them: Anyone attempting to enter the same business as the approved monopoly will be forcibly punished, either by being jailed or by having their goods confiscated.

different forms in the various parts of the West, but especially as the common law of England.

Before we cover two of the more important developments in law, it is very important to understand that what people in modern times think of as "law" is actually a very recent development. Hundreds of years ago – when the Rule of Law began – "law" meant something very different.

Here is a passage from Bruno Leoni's *Freedom and The Law* that provides some historical perspective:

> The Roman jurist was a sort of scientist: the objects of his research were the solutions to cases that citizens submitted to him for study, just as industrialists might submit to a physicist or to an engineer a technical problem concerning their plants or their production. Hence, private Roman law was something to be described or discovered, not something to be enacted… Nobody enacted that law; nobody could change it by any exercise of his personal will.

The critical distinction to make is that "law" and "legislation" are not the same thing, or at least *were* not.

Properly, *law* was a process of determining whether actions were just or unjust. In practical terms, *laws* were the findings of judges. They were not edicts and commands; they were opinions, and were valuable because they explained justice and its reasonable application. A judge was called a *Justice* for good cause – he discovered, defined and explained justice to all men.

Legislation, in old times, were merely collections of laws (legal findings), put together into one group for convenience. It was only much later that legislation became a type of edict. (We will cover this further in a forthcoming chapter.)

So, in understanding the creation of the Rule of Law, we should not think of legislation; that came much later and greatly confuses the issue. "The rule of law" was certainly not "the rule of legislation."

THE GREAT COMMON LAW

As explained previously, the great eruption of civilization in Greece, after their Dark Age, was made possible by the difficult geography of the area, which made assembling an empire and a national priesthood very difficult. As we explained in chapter three, this allowed the development

of literature and science with no interference from above. Unapproved ideas were unhindered and the best of them could take root. It a more abstract way, the same thing happened in England toward the end of the Dark Ages of the 5th through 10th Centuries A.D.

During this time, kings, nobles and the Church all fought for control and advantage. There were endless fights over who was permitted to appoint bishops and over the legal status of clergy, among many smaller disputes. These two groups fighting meant that large areas of life were left alone as the combatants busied themselves with their battles.

In Europe proper, the Church had both power and communications, which meant that they could exercise a great deal of control, even while scrapping with small potentates. On the more distant island nation of England, however, their power was reduced. And, because of the physical separation from Europe, communication was slower. It was thus in this place that a new step forward could come, which had its foundations in the *common law* of England.

Common law refers to law and the corresponding legal system developed through decisions of courts and similar tribunals, rather than through legislative statutes or executive action. The common law is created and updated by judges, not by legislators.

Under the common law, a decision in any case refers to decisions in previous cases and affects the law to be applied in future cases. When there is no authoritative statement of "the law" - judges define the law by creating *precedent*. This body of precedent is called common law, and it binds future decisions to itself. In future cases, when parties disagree on the law, common law courts look to past decisions of relevant courts. If a similar dispute has been resolved in the past, the court is bound to follow the reasoning used in the prior decision. (This is known as the principle of *stare decisis*.) If, however, the court finds that the current dispute is fundamentally distinct from all previous cases, the court will write and publish its own decision, forming a new precedent. (This is often called a *matter of first impression*.) This new decision must then be followed by future courts under the principle of *stare decisis*.

On the occasions where a bad decision is made by a judge, other judges will reject the decision, usually publishing an explanation. If still other judges agree, the bad decision is eventually eliminated from the law books. Note that no legislation is required in these processes and no authority is required from a king or pope. This is because the common law was formed in the same way as the universities of the era – men who

needed it simply built it themselves, with no one either forbidding or authorizing. They built the system according to the necessities of active men, not the necessities of rulers. The common law, unlike Clerical Law or the old Roman law, was written primarily in the conversational language of the people, and was, therefore, accessible to them. This law was written for normal people, not for experts.

The common law began to form during the dark ages, once hierarchy had failed. It began to grow slowly, in scattered places and situations, until it became a method of law that was respected and demanded by average people. And as it grew, it formed a basic theory of rights, typically called the *theory of negative rights,* which embodied the ethics of productive Christians.

> The theory of negative rights says that the right way to look at the world is this: *Every man should be free to do whatever he wishes, so long as it is not forbidden by law.*
>
> The opposing theory of positive rights says that the right way to look at the world is this: *Men are permitted to do only those things which are permitted by law.*

You can see that the idea of positive rights contrasts with the basic core of Western civilization: That truth is revealed over time. If more truth is coming in the future, then no lawmaker knows enough to prescribe the correct limits of human activity.

On the other hand, the negative rights ideal harmonizes perfectly with the core ideal of the West: *We forbid certain acts, as we must, but we leave everything else open to adaptation, creation and the discovery of new truth.*

Being built around the idea of negative rights (even if not specified as such), the common law developed two primary statements, sometimes called *axioms.* They were:

1. Individuals should keep their agreements.
2. No man should aggress against any other man, or his property.

Aggression, in the usage above, would include all major types of force and fraud, but would not include legitimate self-defense.

A thousand years before the common law, Cicero wrote: *True law is right reason, consonant with reason.* This is what the common law grew into, as it evolved in conditions of competition and the freedom to improve. Litigants in the early period of the common law were not required to seek justice from the king; only in matters of land ownership did the king

have any monopoly on justice. Historically, this was an unusual situation, as even the very first rulers were careful to assert their right to be the sole judge over all humans under their control.

By the beginning of the 12th Century, common law was so well established among the populace that the kings of England had to acknowledge it. When Henry I proclaimed his *Charter of Liberties* in 1100, he says that things ought to be done "through force of law and custom," or "in a lawful manner," or that "were lawfully made." Henry is accepting, not just the common law, which was the law of custom not a law of edict, but he is also accepting the idea that law is binding even upon himself, the king. A Mesopotamian ruler of 6000 B.C. would never have made such a comment: He was the law; he was sovereignty personified.

The Clarendon Constitution of England, in 1164, called itself the "record and recognition of a certain portion of the customs and liberties and rights of his ancestors – namely, King Henry, his grandfather and of others – which ought to be observed and held in the kingdom." Thus the laws and customs developed by the citizens, rather than laws imposed by rulers, became the law of England. This was explicitly acknowledged by Article 39 of the Magna Carta (1215 version), which read, "No free man shall be taken, or imprisoned or dispossessed, or outlawed, or banished, nor will we go upon him, nor send upon him, except by the legal judgment of his peers or by the law of the land." Note that the ultimate arbiter was not the king, but "the law of the land," which was the common law.

Magna Carta did not, as is sometimes said, give rights to the people. Instead, it bound the king to the common law of the people and granted powers to the nobles. Again, this was not the usual foundation of rulership, and it very soon got the attention of other rulers, who did not like what they heard.

Once news of Magna Carta reached Pope Innocent III (two months later), he immediately issued a *bull* (a papal decree) against it, calling it "a shame for England," and saying: *We utterly reprobate and condemn any agreement of this kind, forbidding, under ban of our anathema, the aforesaid king to presume to observe it.* The Pontiff, schooled in matters of rulership and empire, understood that a crack in the façade of authority could de-legitimize all rulership, including, eventually, his own. And, Pope Innocent was right. Magna Carta eventually led to the American

Revolution and could lead to further de-legitimization of rulership in the future.

King John and those who followed him tried to repeal Magna Carta, but the barons of England stood their ground. Popes threatened eternal judgment; kings raged with threats, schemes, and awesome shows of authority. Masses of clergy and believers reviled them, but the nobles refused to give-in to intimidation and they remained standing; they outlasted the treats and liberty gained its modern foundation.

And, again, the names of the barons of Magna Carta are mostly forgotten, as is the name of the author of that crucial document, Stephan Langton.

THE SECRET COURTS OF GERMANY

At about this same time, a string of secret courts and secret societies sprung-up in the Westphalia region of what is now Germany. They were called the *League of the Holy Court*, or *Vehmgericht*, or the *Vehm*. Once again, something new was initiated by commoners, in response to their needs.

The beginnings of the Vehm are essentially unknown, which is not surprising for a secret group. They probably needed to remain secret for two reasons:

1. They were not legally armed, and might have difficulty defending themselves from powerful criminals.
2. They were forbidden by law from acting as agents of the law. This was the right of the king, not of commoners.

The Vehm had to protect itself from both kings and from criminals. Secrecy was necessary if justice was to be provided.

A story circulated that the Vehm was founded in the year 772 by Charlemagne, but this was almost certainly a fabrication made to provide justification and to give them the shield of authority. The Vehm seems to have originated a couple of centuries *after* Charlemagne.

Court sessions were held in secret, and the uninitiated were forbidden to attend, on pain of death. The court consisted of a chairman and a number of lay judges, and any free man of good character could become a lay judge. The new candidate was given secret identification symbols. All members of the Vehm were required to keep their knowledge secret, even from their closest family.

Lay judges gave formal warnings to known troublemakers, issued warrants, and took part in executions. After the execution of a death sentence, the corpse would be hung on a tree to advertise the fact and to deter others.

This idea of secret courts has been much attacked ever since, but historical research has vindicated the Vehm, who never used torture, although it was common at the time. Furthermore, their trials were only secret where and when they needed to be, and their meeting-places were always well known. A depiction of a Westphalian Free Court is shown below:



Courtesy Wikimedia Commons

In this case, again, the innovation of the responsible men of Westphalia was taken over by a ruler. In 1180, the archbishop of Cologne, Philipp von Heinsberg – also the duke of Westphalia – placed himself as the emperor's representative, at the head of the Vehm. After this time, the organization spread and was overseen by the state. Princes and nobles were initiated, and in 1429 even emperor Sigismund joined.

As kings and princes grew in power, the functions of the Westphalian Free Courts were brought under the control of state courts, and the

Vehm was confined to mere police duties. They were fully abolished by Jerome Bonaparte**,** the younger brother of Napoleon Bonaparte, in 1811.

THE HANSEATIC LEAGUE

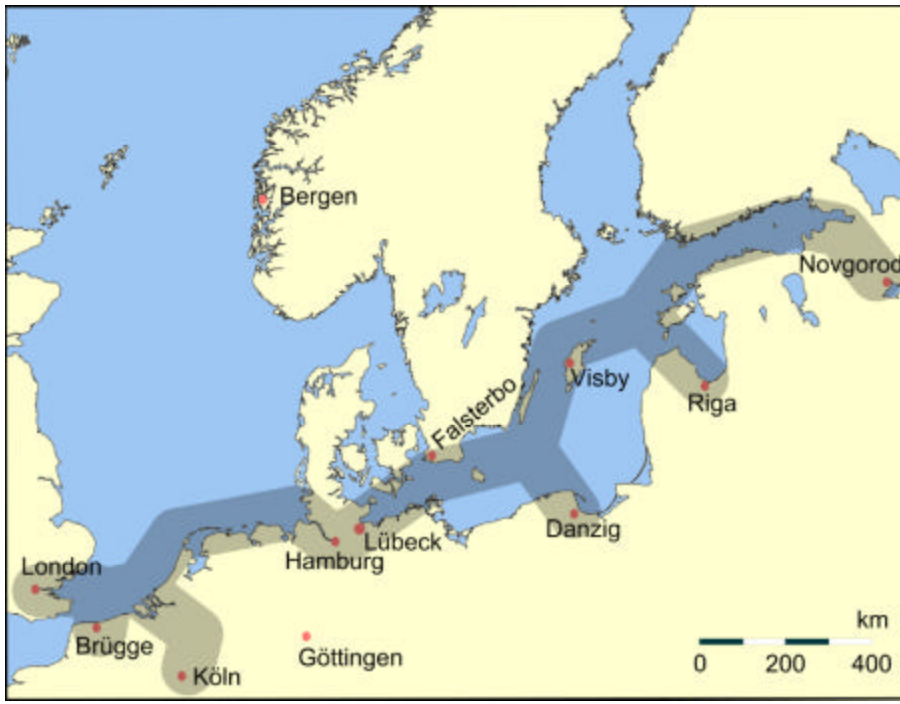
Earlier we mentioned that merchant guilds. These were mutual protection societies for traveling merchants, and that they began to rebuild trade on a decentralized model. One of the primary problems these traders faced was the plunder of local rulers. Princes and officials always seek revenue, and since traders were not defended by anyone with the authority to use violence, they were easy targets. In response, the merchant guilds boycotted the realms of rulers who did this, a practice known as *withernam* in medieval England. Since boycotts impoverished both the kingdoms that depended on commerce and the governments for whom tariffs were the principal source of revenue, this use of ostracism was effective and the rulers backed-off. This was an early instance of commerce winning a battle with the state.

Merchant guilds had long enforced contracts among members and between members and outsiders. Guilds policed their members' behavior, especially since reputation was a critical component of commerce at the time. The debts of bad merchants were generally paid by the guild. By the middle of the 13th Century (1201-1300), groups of merchants were becoming prosperous and joined together in a mutual-protection league, which went so far as to include ruling over their own trading cities, which the various princes were forced to allow for strictly commercial reasons, not by force of arms.

The *Hanseatic League* (also known as the *Hansa* or *Hanse*) was an alliance of trading cities and trading guilds that established and maintained trade along the coast of Northern Europe, from the Baltic to the North Sea and inland, between the 13th and the 17th Centuries. The Hanseatic cities had their own system of law and furnished their own protection and mutual aid. Here, again, we find independent Europeans seeing to things themselves, with no ruler approving their plans in advance. The main trading routes of the Hansa and their cities are shown below:

The early center of the league of Hansa was a German city named Lübeck, and from there, the merchants of Saxony and Westphalia spread to the east and the north. The name, *Hanse* is first known to appear in a document in 1267, but merchants had begun cooperating in the Hansa manner previously. An early goal of theirs was to trade with towns

overseas, especially in the less-developed are of the eastern Baltic, a source of timber, wax, amber, resins and furs. Even grains such as rye and wheat were brought on barges from inland producers to port markets.



Courtesy Wikimedia Commons

Hanse towns furnished their own protection officers, with each guild providing members for this work as required. When necessary, trading ships were used for carrying armed men, and Hanseatic cities came to each other's aid.

Hansa societies worked to reduce restrictions upon trade. For example, in 1157, the Hansa convinced Henry II of England to free them from all London tolls and allowed them to trade at fairs throughout England. Over the next decades, additional agreements were made with many princes and kings. Most of these agreements were called "the granting of special privileges," or similar terms, but they were often precisely the opposite. Rather than the Hansa being given government-enforced rights, they were freed from the government's tolls and restrictions. In other words, actual free trade was called a "special privilege."

The League never became a closely-managed formal organization; that is, it never created central power. Representatives of Hanseatic towns met occasionally in Lübeck (beginning in 1356), but many towns didn't bother to send representatives and, in any case, there was no central power to enforce rulings.

Over time, the League grew to include a flexible roster of 70 to 170 cities, who traded in timber, furs, resin (or tar), flax, honey, wheat, metal ores, fabrics and manufactured goods. The League also trained pilots and built lighthouses. Most Hansa cities either started as independent cities or gained semi-independence through the collective bargaining power of the League, which was simply the ability to refuse business with the lands of adversarial rulers – the power of ostracism.

Most foreign cities confined the Hansa traders to certain trading areas and to their own trading posts. They could seldom, if ever, interact with the local inhabitants, except when actually conducting business. And, of course, many people of all classes envied the League. In London, for example, local merchants continually petitioned for the revocation of League's exclusion from tolls. The situation was highly complex, of course, and we are passing over most of the details.

Over time, political events such as wars and changing alliances doomed the Hansa, as well as their own misguided attempts to enforce exclusivity upon their markets. The growth of larger states with greater power made the Hansa less effective, and the individual cities began to cooperate less. By the 16th Century, the League was a shadow of its former self and withered away over the next century or so.

The great port cities of northern Italy, Genoa and Venice, developed trade at about the same time as the Hansa, but their trade was always a central state function. Once the governments of these cities weakened or failed, trade was disrupted along with them. It is of interest that ever since the decline of centrally-controlled trade in Venice and Genoa, commerce in southern Europe has lagged. On the other hand, commerce in northern Europe, founded upon a decentralized, independent model, continued to thrive as rulers came and went, and even after the Hansa had come and gone.

THE LAW MERCHANT

The *Law Merchant*, or *Lex Mercatoria*, was a body of rules and principles laid down by the merchants and traders of Europe to regulate their dealings. It evolved among merchants who were doing business with no

state power backing them or overseeing them. In such a situation, they did what other productive Europeans of this period did; they created what they needed, by themselves.

The primary principle of this merchant law was the same as the common law – that is should grow out of commercial practice, adapt to the needs of the merchants and be comprehensible to the merchants who used it.

Lex Mercatoria was administered by merchant courts, which were located along trade routes and at trade centers. At these places, merchants could solve their disputes within hours and at minimal expense. Proceedings were informal, and were focused upon justice and productivity rather than upon rules and procedures. "Fair price," "good commerce," and "equity" were the primary concerns.

Judges were chosen for their honesty, their commercial background and their practical knowledge. Their reputation rested upon their expertise in merchant trade and their fair-mindedness. Before long, being a merchant judge became a profession of its own.

Much of international commercial law to this day has taken its fundamental principles from Lex Mercatoria. This includes choice of arbitration institutions and procedures, the necessity of reflecting customs, and good practice among the parties.

The Law Merchant declined as states grew in power and imposed their control over the merchant courts. Kings and princes became strong enough to control the activities of the merchants and they did so, by force or by threat of force. In short, they enforced a monopoly on the provision of justice and drove the merchant judges out, after centuries of functioning smoothly. The term "protection of state interests" tended to be the justification for this take-over and others like it. "Amoral force" would be a more honest term.

Given the similarities between the law merchant and the common law, it is little surprise that Law Merchant rulings were included in the common law. This was acknowledged by England's Chief justice Edward Coke, who commented in 1608 that, "the Law Merchant is part of this realm." Principles of the Law Merchant continue in equity and admiralty courts. They are also widely respected in international arbitration. In the United States, the traditions of the Law Merchant remain as the general principles and doctrines of commercial law.

The unconscious development of ideas is a fascinating subject, and one that is little studied[82]. Generally, ideas change very quickly; in fact, they change much, much faster than any other factor contributing to human conduct. But once they take sufficient root, they tend to be followed and repeated almost unconsciously.

By the late Middle Ages, Europeans held firmly to the root ideas of Western culture and had passed them down through generations. They valued them, did whatever was necessary to keep them, and they rooted. Again, when ideas are held for multiple generations by a comprehensive enough group of people, they stick, and are passed-down in ways that are seen and absorbed, even if not specifically taught.

In addition to the "western" ideas we have covered in this chapter, there were two others: The Christian code of cooperation and farming.

We discussed in the last chapter that the ideas of Jesus formed a creed of the foundational moment. In other words, it expressed the ethics of founders. The Europeans, despite a great many of them being illiterate, were exposed to the sayings of Jesus on a regular basis, and many of those ideas had taken root. Even if the local priest had a less than useful interpretation of Jesus' sayings, people would remember which parts Jesus had actually said and which parts were interpretations. Again, these people – even in the darkest and most ignorant passages of the Dark Ages – *were the same as us*. They were not defectives – *they were us.* So, when they had access to precious little information, they held the little they did have all the more carefully. They knew, surprisingly well, what Jesus had said.

Farming also, as we explained in chapter one, builds certain character traits into its long-term practitioners. As usual, it taught these people to cooperate and to respect property.

So, the mentality of the Europeans generally coalesced over centuries with a mix of Jesus' foundational ethics, the virtues of farming, the understanding that truth developed over time, and the boldness of self-initiative. Thus Western civilization was formed. And, being formed, it took on a life of its own. Like all civilizations, this "life" was not

[82] A few examples will be made of such occurrences in this book, but please bear in mind that I know of no scientific verifications of this phenomenon. Self- observant people notice this and know that it is true to some extent, but rigorous examinations of it are lacking.

permanent – it would either be refreshed or lost over time – but it was powerful and long-lasting.

The holding of these basic Western ideas by most of the populace had many second-level effects over time, and certainly far more than this book will attempt to address; but a few of them were the following:

> **A high-trust culture:** A *high-trust culture* is one is which people can be relied upon to do what is right. Others can trust them to do things like open stores on time and clean their own messes. Europe (especially northern Europe) created a high-trust culture because initiative was self-generated in them. When people are in the habit of seeing to it themselves – of being self-directed – they contain the root of responsibility wholly within themselves, and they do not refer to the approval, disapproval or disinterest of a third-party before acting. Instead, they simply refer to themselves and act. This produces reliable conduct, and conduct other self-referral persons can predict. But, far more importantly, self-referential conduct leaves men feeling good about themselves. Producing good acts from within themselves, not at the impetus of another; they produce honest self-esteem and satisfaction. A very important fact is seen here, as it is in other places: *Being ruled steals from men many of the best parts of their being.*
>
> **A voice in governance:** Democratic government became the norm in Europe because people demanded to have some type of input into the process. In other words, they expected to act as self-sovereigns, to one extent or another. They knew they could see to their own affairs and create what they needed. So, they demanded at least the minimal voice of being able to elect a representative with actual power[83].
>
> **Respect for property:** Knowing that they created wealth on their own initiative led them to respect property. A good deal of this was lost as Europe moved to specialized labor and lost view of the whole wealth-generating mechanism. Not understanding how the new process worked, they began to imagine that it was controlled by devious men[84]. But when Europeans actually

[83] We will explain in chapter ten why this ended up being a mistake, but it seems that no one understood that as they demanded a say over their own rule, which is, of course, reasonable.

[84] They were much helped along this path by socialist types.

understood the wealth-generating processes they were engaged in, they respected property.

Long-range thinking: When people consider the future results of their actions – instead of just the immediate results – they act far better and produce better results. Europe produced a great deal of this, because they understood farming and valued property. To survive on a farm, one must think ahead and save seed for the next year, to be prepared to plant and reap when the right time comes; also about the future state of one's property. This pattern leads men to think about the future results of their actions before taking them rashly.

Distributed enforcement of good conduct: Because this was a highly-cooperative culture, the people in it expected everyone else in it to cooperate reasonably. When members of the society acted uncooperatively by placing obstacles in the paths of others or by disrupting their activities, any number of nearby persons would express dissatisfaction. This assured good conduct far better than any king or police force ever could. A few bosses among thousands cannot interact with many of them. But when a man's family, neighbors, coworkers and even local shop-owners become enforcers of good conduct, he either learns to cooperate or he leaves.

THE KINGS RE-LEARN LEGITIMATION

There is a great deal of European history that we will pass-by here and merely say that after the devolution of the 5th through 10th Centuries, units of rulership slowly grew larger and fewer in number. In other words, there were fewer and more powerful kings. And, as briefly mentioned in chapter four, the Church lost most of its power in the Reformation of the 16th Century. This put the kings of Europe back into the legitimacy business.

As mentioned earlier, one source of legitimacy for rulers of this time was as the upholder of the law. They became a "good king" by talking about the sanctity of the law and by publicizing and successful punishment of notable crimes.

Another new source of legitimacy was simple geography. The king wasn't directly legitimized by this, but by championing "our land" (or "the motherland," or "our fatherland," or…), the inhabitants felt a connection with the ruler. Over time, this enthroning of geography took strong root.

Its original use may simply have been as a replacement for the previous self-identification of Europeans as "members of Christendom."

The role of royalty as the bestower of honor is one of the legitimacies that has held throughout almost all eras, and it certainly remained in the repertoire of these rulers. During these years it became a bit more potent for the highest levels of rulers (being even more powerful and thus impressive), but was not able to be used as often, the high rulers being fewer in number.

One other aspect of legitimacy explains many of the odd actions of kings. Max Weber, in his book *Essays In Sociology*, explains the ruler's personal need of legitimacy:

> The fortunate is seldom satisfied with the fact of being fortunate. Beyond this, he needs to know that he has a *right* to his good fortune. Good fortune thus wants to be *legitimate* fortune.

Rodney Barker, in his *Legitimating Identities*, makes a similar point:

> People issuing commands are legitimated by their being identified as special, marked by particular qualities, set apart from other people. When rulers legitimate themselves, they give an account of who they are, in writing, in images, in more or less ceremonial actions and practices. The action both creates the identity.

The rulers of this era, like the Church and like rulers of old, needed to play the role of the higher power. That is, they needed to be seen as a higher type of being, and to see themselves as a higher type of being.

Legitimization has always been necessary for two other critical reasons:

> **Giving the subjects an excuse to obey.** No man likes to call himself a coward. So, when the orders of a ruler reach a man, he must find an honorable reason for obedience. He knows that all orders from rulers are backed by force – by experts with superior weapons – but he must also find a reason to obey that is better than simple fear. A reason to call the king legitimate is required. These reasons range from the silly to the mostly-true, but they are always essential. The ruler must empower the subject to obey,

without offending the subject's sense of personal value and autonomy.

Enabling the ruler to issue commands. The ruler must be confident in what he is doing, if he is to produce the necessary theater. He must believe that he has a right to transcend the morality that law enforces upon the people – that one may not use force upon his neighbor. Rulers will go to great lengths to secure this feeling[85].

THE RENAISSANCE

The Renaissance, or *rebirth*, began primarily in northern Italy in the 15th Century. This was a very important moment in human history, but not from an organizational standpoint. The crucial thing about the Renaissance was that it freed the imaginations of men to venture into new territories and to imagine new things about themselves.

Art played a major role in the Renaissance. It first gave men a glimpse of past glories, to see that men had been better in the past. This was, by itself, a significant development, since every society tends to see themselves, in whatever way they can, as the best and/or most advanced ever to have lived. The people of the Renaissance, however, accepted that parts of their current state were sub-optimal. Then, in healthy fashion, they went about to correct the deficit.

The great artists, Carravagio, Donatello, Titian, Bellini, Michelangelo, Leonardo, and many others, became better than any who had come before. They were more aggressive and creative with technique, color, design, light, depth, and even with subject matter. This had a terribly important effect on the men who saw these great works. Yes, the impact of the art itself was good, but the crucial impact was confidence in themselves and in humanity in general.

At first they saw that the Romans had been better than they. Then they applied themselves vigorously and exceeded them – openly and honestly. Now they knew that they could improve, and quickly. Where the end of that growth might be, they couldn't tell, but they knew they could go up from where they were, and could quite possibly go very, very high.

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[85] The strange case of Rasputin and the Romanoff family comes to mind. But, it must be added that sociopathic rulers (of whom there have been many) are, by nature, free from such internal concerns.

7

The Quickening Of The 17th Century

Genius is present in every age, but the men carrying it within them remain benumbed unless extraordinary events occur to heat up and melt the mass so that it flows forth.
-- Denis Diderot

The 17th Century was the beginning of the modern age – when men (or at least a noticeable number of them) finally left their old order behind and stepped forward into something new. The previous order fractured and the Christian world began to re-form in two distinct parts. Gutenberg's new printing technology had burst upon Europe, and people were learning more about the distant world than they ever had before. Curiosity bloomed, hunger for knowledge erupted, and science as we know it began.

On top of this, virgin continents were available to any who dared go. These were free territories with no established order to restrict human action. Non-conformists could now flee to avoid punishment, and many were willing to brave dangers if it meant they could be different and yet unopposed. Men and women began to imagine lives in far-off lands, where they would be released from constraints and live as they pleased. As a result, innovators began to show their faces in public.

THE INTERNAL ENFORCER RETREATS

> *It is hard to fight an enemy who has outposts in your head.*
> -- Sally Kempton

We have previously mentioned the fact that men and women under authority refer their thoughts to the ruler, even if only as a safety mechanism. (One must think about what sorts of actions are punished before he or she acts.) Men hold images of the ruler in their minds, and they refer to that image when making decisions. The critical factor of the 17th Century was that this "internal enforcer" had lost some of his lofty image. (The crucial aspect of this – from the ruler's perspective – is that this image carries with it the impression of legitimacy.) This allowed the thoughts of men to differ from their usual script. The Protestants had wounded the Church's monopoly on legitimacy. Even in the areas of Europe that remained Catholic, the awe and majesty of the Church was diminished.

Under the rule of the Church, princes and kings had a generally restricted level of honor, and their kingdoms were far less permanent than states are today. It was common to begin life under one royal family and finish it under another. So, the glory and majesty of the king was not extremely high either. Escape from both internal and external constraint was now possible. Very few people would have described their thoughts in this manner; instead, they expressed it as a desire to "go to the new world," or merely to day-dream about it.

Rulers can survive being hated, but they cannot survive being ignored. In normal cases, the image of the ruler can be maintained in the minds of the people without much difficulty, causing almost everyone some level of mental pain if they stray from obedience – even if it is only a nagging feeling of guilt or impending doom. But at this moment, minds could be transported far beyond the reach of the governor and could then think with merely a fraction of his image in their minds.

EUROPE SPLITS IN TWO

The loss of the Roman Church's special legitimacy had serious political consequences. With their legitimacy, they also lost the obedience of princes and kings. This was due to the Reformers, but not *only* due to them. As people rejected the Church's demands on how people must live

(as peasants, tied to the land and with no choices about their lives), they began to discover commercial prosperity. So, the areas that remained faithful to the Pope tended to maintain a medieval culture and those that separated from the Pope began to build a more commercial culture.

As Europe split, it formed into northern and southern halves. The two halves had been developing differently for some time, as we mentioned briefly in the previous chapter when contrasting the merchants of the Hansa and of the Venetians. The northern Hansa were decentralized, self-ruling groups, the southern Venetians and Genoese were authorized by their central governments. This is precisely how Europe separated.

In the south, the Church maintained a high level of control and was able to hold to their lands throughout all the troubles of the Reformation (which, very roughly, occurred between 1517 and 1648). In the north, the Church found less of a stable base and had to work harder to maintain control. Once local rulers found a competing religion to support, many of them were glad to adopt it. In addition to the legitimate religious convictions some of them had, many more found a tremendous opportunity for tossing off the trouble-making Church and ruling alone. Protestantism provided them what they wanted, so they supported it.

The two sections of Europe hardened in their differing characteristics. (Each, of course, loudly championed their superiorities and denounced the failings of the other.) The north took on strong commercial characteristics, individual initiative and allowed some applications of decentralized power. The south remained hierarchical, traditional and centralized.

The compelling new thoughts spreading through Europe – not only wealth through commerce and new religious ideas, but the discovery of wild new continents – made literacy and learning prized things, and being "smart" made the young man a desirable mate. Instead of superior thinking being punished (as it normally is), this explosion of new ideas led to "smart" being rewarded. This created a dynamic intellectual culture, especially in the north, where it was less opposed.

The Church fought long, dirty and hard to remain overlord of Europe, including travesties like the St. Bartholomew's Day Massacre (which Pope Gregory XIII celebrated). But, as in pervious cases of this type, the armies of the old empire were slow to adapt their tactics and weapons, while the armies of the new idea were quick to do so. In the first war of the Reformation, the *Hussite* armies (named after Jan Hus, an early reformer) fought much larger armies to a stand-still, because they

adopted early gunpowder weapons and created new tactics suited to them. The armies taking the Church's side fought the old way and died in large numbers.

The areas that went Protestant were the places of the common law, Free Courts the Hanseatic League. The Church had lost the people of the north, who no longer wanted to be led by the hand; their kings acted accordingly.

Everyone in Europe, both north and south, had known that the Church was corrupt. This was old and universal knowledge. Everyone knew about the reformers as well, but only some dared take the care of their souls upon themselves.

The northern and southern areas of Europe (Protestant and Catholic, respectively) are roughly depicted in the map below. Political control over these two groups of Europeans shifted back and forth over time, and this map depicts something of an average condition for the Reformation period.

SCIENCE ARISES

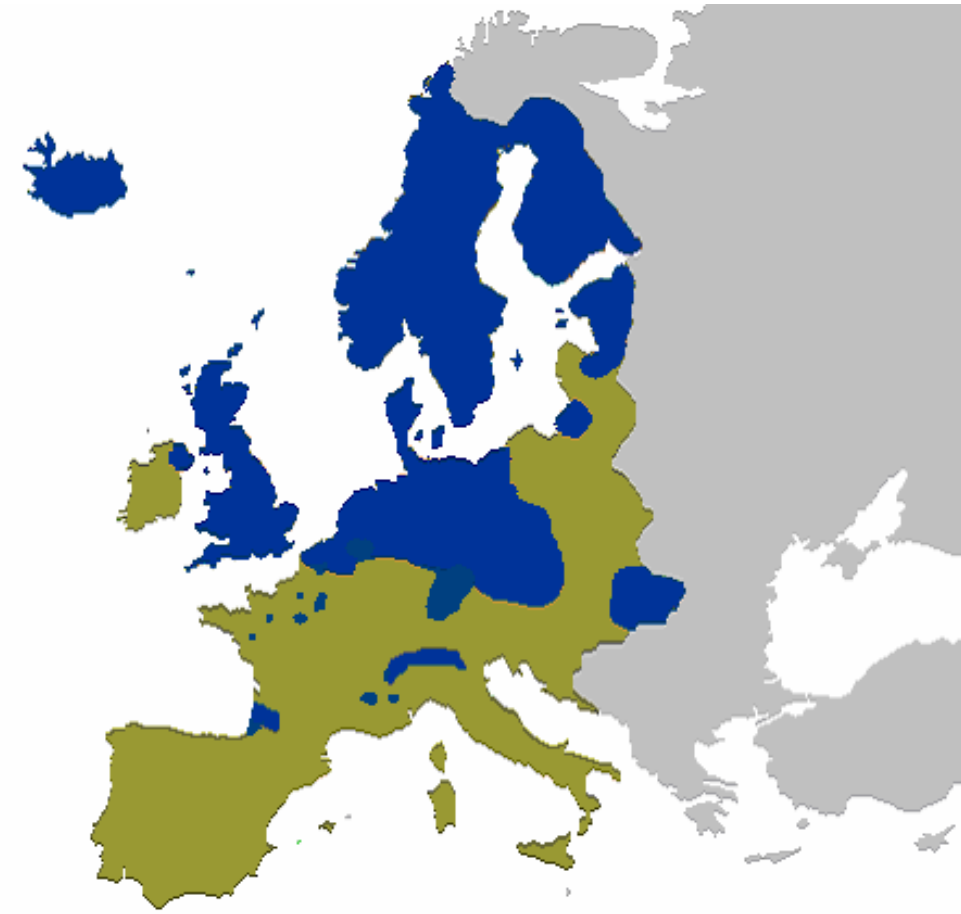
> *If a man will begin with certainties, he shall end in doubts; but if he will be content to begin with doubts he shall end in certainties.*
> -- Francis Bacon

The statement above describes the new, scientific way of analyzing the world. Prior to Bacon and a few likeminded men, the order of knowledge was that men got the "big picture" – the certain truth of the world – from the Church and from the Church's books, and then interpreted the rest of the world within that framework.

Bacon said that this should be reversed: We should assume nothing (as Bacon says, "begin with doubts") and start from this base, testing everything to make sure we are correct about it. Thus, science as we know it was born.

Science is not a set of institutions, is not a set of knowledge, is not a set of laws. Science is a *process* – a technique for verifying our ideas about the nature of the world.

Science uses a chain of logic that runs the opposite direction from religion's. It discovers specific small truths first, arranges them into larger theories, and comes to its most general truths last of all.



Courtesy Wikimedia Commons

The scientific method demands that observation and experimentation should be taken as the only ground upon which to build, and if new evidence is found which contradicts the existing structure, the whole structure ***must*** be shaken to the ground and rebuilt brick by brick. One of our great modern scientists, Richard Feynman, put it this way: *It doesn't matter how beautiful your theory is, it doesn't matter how smart you are. If it doesn't agree with experiment, it's wrong.*

Bacon was the leading developer of this new method, and his most important book was called the *Novum Organum,* which means *The New Instrument.* (Published in 1620). The title referred to Aristotle, who had written a book called *Organon*.

By shifting to this new method of dividing truth from falsity, men surged forward into new discoveries. Bacon himself considered the printing press, gunpowder and the compass to have been the most important inventions of the early 17th Century; an opinion that would be hard to argue with. They utterly revolutionized the Western world, allowing for knowledge and long-range travel, as well as for making war dependent upon knowledge more than brute, human strength. The brain overtook muscle, even in war.

Here are some of the discoveries of the 17th Century. Contrast these with the centuries of stasis Europe had previously experienced:

- William Gilbert creates a theory of magnetism and electricity.
- Tycho Brahe makes extensive and accurate naked eye observations of the planets. These became the basic data for Kepler's studies.
- Francis Bacon outlines a new system of logic, laying the foundation of the scientific method.
- Galileo Galilei improves the telescope, with which he makes important astronomical discoveries, including the four largest moons of Jupiter, the phases of Venus, and the rings of Saturn. He developed the laws for falling bodies based on experiments and mathematic analysis.
- Johannes Kepler publishes his three laws of planetary motion.
- William Harvey demonstrates that blood circulates, using dissections and other experimental techniques.
- Christiaan Huygens develops the first functional pendulum clock
- René Descartes publishes his *Discourse on the Method*, which further establishes the scientific method.
- Antony van Leeuwenhoek constructs powerful single lens microscopes, makes extensive observations, and discovers Bacteria. Modern biology begins.
- Isaac Newton develops calculus, opening new applications of mathematics to science. He went on to develop the inverse square law of gravity, explained the elliptical orbits of the planets, and advanced the law of universal gravitation. This, in addition to defining the basic laws of mechanics.

- Gottfried Leibnitz invents the binary system and invents calculus independently from Newton.
- Pierre Fauchard begins modern dentistry.
- Wilhelm Schickard builds the first calculating machines.
- Pierre Vernier (1580–1637) was inventor and eponym of the vernier scale used in measuring devices.
- Evangelista Torricelli invents the barometer.
- John Napier invents logarithms.
- Edmund Gunter creates logarithmic scales.
- William Oughtred invents the slide rule.
- Blaise Pascal designs mechanical calculators and clarifies the concepts of pressure and vacuum.
- Pierre de Fermat develops probability theory.
- Abraham Darby I develops a method of producing high-grade iron in a blast furnace.
- Thomas Newcomen invents a practical steam engine.
- Marin de Bourgeoys invents the first flintlock musket.
- Cornelius Drebbei builds the first submarine, made of wood and greased leather.
- Otto von Guericke becomes the first human to knowingly generate electricity using a machine.
- Stephen Gray demonstrates that electricity could be transmitted through metal filaments.
- Robert Boyle discovers the law of gasses. He also develops an atomic theory of matter.
- Henry Cockeram publishes the first English dictionary.
- Johann Carolus of Strasbourg publishes the first newspaper.
- William Shakespeare writes most of his plays and sonnets.
- Monk Dom Perignon discovers Champagne.
- Ice cream is invented. Tea and coffee become popular.

- The first public opera house opens in Venice.
- The first measurements are made of the speed of light.
- The Royal Society of London for the Improvement of Natural Knowledge is founded.

Note also that the overwhelming majority of these discoveries came in the north. This has nothing to do with the relative intellect of the two groups – naturally bright men are found everywhere – it had to do with their minds being less encumbered in the north, and being less opposed when treading new paths.

This flowering of science radically altered the development speed of mankind – not only that men found new information, but that they learned *how* to find new information. The phrase, "check it," became something that we keep in mind and use all the time. People used it previously, but not nearly as often or as well. We now know, with certainty, how to find and verify new facts. Before Bacon and his friends, this was much confused and partially understood. Because of that, human knowledge developed much more slowly.

As an example, Aristotle was certainly a bright, thoughtful man, but he did not understand the scientific method and made quite a few dramatic errors, such as believing and writing that heavier objects fell faster than lighter objects. This error persisted for almost 2000 years, even though it could easily have been verified by experiment at almost any time. No one is recorded to have performed a verification in all of that time.

The accumulation and storage of knowledge has greatly increased since the 17th Century. We know far more and we are making far more rapid progress than ever before in the history of the earth. Science sped up the process of development. Printing saved the knowledge, libraries made gigantic amounts of information accessible and useable.

THE GREAT CIVILIZER

> *As always, the honesty instituted by trade is far superior to any other conception of honest conduct.*
> -- John Maxcy Zane

The commercial culture that developed in the north of Europe tended to be an ethical culture. Certainly there have always been glaring exception to this statement, but it is also generally true, simply because commerce instills ethics. The vast bulk of commerce relies on fair dealing, trust,

reputation, and honest, responsible dealing. These things root good conduct in the participants, which they tend to spread throughout their families and communities. Shop-keepers generally make good neighbors.

To understand commerce properly, it is helpful to differentiate between "one-shot deals" and long-term commerce. The incentives are very different and thus they breed different types of conduct.

The standard *one-shot deal* is the car sale: The automobile salesman knows that he has one shot at any customer that walks through his door, and that he is overwhelmingly likely never to see him/her again. In such a case, it is in his immediate interest to get as much profit out of the sale as possible. If the customer is unhappy a month or two down the road, there will be no effective loss from it. It was a one-time deal, and it is over. You can see why deception in this kind of transaction has become proverbial

Long-term commerce is the kind engaged in by a local grocer. This businessman needs to do business with the same people many times per month. If he gives customers a bad deal, even once, he risks losing them. After all, there are other grocers. This type of business incentivizes honesty, kindness, and fair dealing. Over the long term, goodness pays[86].

One critical difference between the old medieval way and the new commercial way was the movement of surplus. Under commerce, surplus remained in the hands of people who were best-suited to use it productively, rather than being taken away to the control of the Church. Productive capital remained in the hands of the people. In fact, the great projects of this era were financed by collections of successful businessmen.

THE CRAZIES ESCAPE

The role of non-conformists, eccentrics and "Crazies" in human history has been greatly under-appreciated. If you look carefully for the roots of important new developments, you will very often find a "Crazy" as the forgotten, original innovator.

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[86] One exception to the civilizing influence of long-term commerce is the monopoly. Monopolies lack the feedback mechanism of normal commerce. That is, the customer cannot move to another supplier; it is either the monopolist or nothing. Monopolies are ineffective and infuriating for this one reason. And, it should be added, that no monopoly has ever endured for very long without governmental force protecting it. Without policemen punishing any prospective competitors, aggressive businessmen would soon undercut the monopoly's artificially high prices.

For example, the Flagellants of the Middle Ages (for whom the title, Crazies, is certainly fitting) made a critical breakthrough that led to the Reformation: Divine forgiveness, separate from the intercession of the clergy. Huge numbers of Flagellants believed this, including monks and priests. The Pope eventually fought back against it, but the idea of forgiveness via penance stuck and the clergy were not included in that process; their absolution monopoly was cracked[87].

It is the tightness of a culture that causes Crazies to be bent in their particular ways. These people, different by nature or by unique formation, don't want to be part of any homogenized mass. But because of the culture's demands upon them, they are effectively punished every time they behave differently or even express differing thoughts. This either crushes them or drives them to react further, giving them a particular "spin" in reaction.

So, the more restrictive the culture, the more radical are those who eject themselves from it. There are, of course many variances, since humans are adaptive, self-correcting beings, but the young man or woman who is able to break out of a restrictive culture almost always bears scars and almost always acts erratically in one or more ways. Breaking out is simply too difficult for it to be any other way.

This assures the main mass of a culture that anyone who wouldn't accept their rule must be a dangerous, deranged person. And, of course, it drives the unique man or woman yet further away[88]. There have been occasional radicals of this type who attained peace with themselves, but most were driven away and damaged in the process. The tighter the culture, the more tyrannical it is to the non-conformist.

In the 17th Century, however, such people could leave. Bear in mind that this was a much more complete "leaving" than is possible in our time. A fitting example of this is the modern tax protester. We could say to them, "If you don't like it here, go somewhere else," but this is actually no

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87 This was very much in the mind of Martin Luther, who was given to fasting and flagellation.

88 We have previously identified something like this as a good thing in the case of Western cultures enforcing cooperation. Since we sometimes lack ultra-precise words and human life is so complex, discussions can become conflicted. In the case of enforcing good behavior, the issue is parallel to the basis of law: Which actions are we willing to use force against? We certainly are willing to use violence against murder or a rape, but not against doing strange things in private. In similar manner, demanding that our relatives *act* cooperatively is a reasonable place to apply pressure. That they should *think* in the same way as 'authority' or even the same as everyone else is much too far. Conduct should be discouraged only as far as it affects others and opposed with force only when it directly impedes or harms others.

choice at all for the tax protester – the deal is the same everywhere. If an American tax protester goes to Canada, he finds a nearly identical situation. If he goes to Germany, it is the roughly same, and the same can be said, more or less, for all of the earth's two hundred states. If, however, there was an empty continent available, the same tax protester could simply leave and do his best to build a new life however he wished.

So, a great many such people came to the New World, bringing their wild new ideas and transformative energies with them. The New World of North America owes a much bigger debt to the Crazies of Europe than many 'respectable' types would like to acknowledge.

THE TWO NEW WORLDS

The New World of North and South America were, fittingly enough, settled by northern and southern Europeans respectively. Effectively, there were two new worlds, not one. And this is not related to the separation of the North and South American land masses – it is a result of the way they were settled and/or conquered.

The monarchs of southern Europe who were aligned with the Church had a very specific pattern of dealing with the new continents of the Americas. Settlers from the north of Europe had a completely differing pattern, and the effects of these patterns remain not only visible, but of massive effect, to this day.

THE SOUTH

The kings of Spain and Portugal were the leaders in sending explorers around the world, and – most importantly – to claim all lands for their kings: for "the Crown," as they used to say. They went so far as to claim all land that touched bodies of water they discovered. When Balboa found the Pacific Ocean, for example, he raised his hands, his sword in one and a standard with the image of the Virgin Mary in the other, walked knee-deep into the ocean, and claimed possession of the new sea and all adjoining lands in the name of the Spanish sovereigns.

As has been well-noted by many others, the Spanish and Portuguese Conquistadores treated the inhabitants of the new continents abominably, but it was the purpose of their missions and the structure of their arrangements that led directly to this. Spanish and Portuguese interest in the new world was entirely for the purpose of plunder. These

were systematic efforts of exploitation, later with a bit of missionary interest as well, which was the Church's version of conquest[89].

The pattern of plundering the new world began with the very first set of arrangements: The deal between Columbus and King Ferdinand of Spain. According to the contract, if Columbus discovered any new islands or mainland, he would be given the rank of Admiral of the Ocean Sea and appointed Viceroy and Governor of all the new lands. He had the right to nominate three persons, from whom the sovereigns would choose one, for any office in the new lands. He would also have the option of buying one-eighth interest in any commercial venture with the new lands and receive one-eighth of the profits.

In other words, Columbus was to get very, very rich by the outright plunder of the new world, and, after a few fights with the king, he did. Cortez, Pizarro, Balboa and all the others had deals of the same type: They became chief plunderers and were given high office, from which they could dole out favors to friends.

It is no exaggeration to say that this pattern took strong root in what we now call Latin America, that it remained, and that it has punished Latin America's inhabitants unto this day.

THE NORTH

The settlement of North America was undertaken by commercial ventures, after the models of commercial capitalism, decentralization and the Hanseatic League. The structure of these arrangements was entirely different than that of the southern Europeans and their hierarchical conquest model. These were private companies, owned by individuals, venturing to the new world for purposes of commerce. The high points of this process were the following:

- The London Company was an English joint stock company established by royal charter in 1606 with the purpose of establishing colonial settlements in North America. They financed and created the Jamestown colony, the first permanent English settlement in the new world, in 1607. (Along the way

[89] The Church was actually quite involved the whole time. In 1493, immediately following Columbus' return, Pope Alexander VI officially awarded the new world to Spain. (Notice the level of legitimacy attributed to the Pope, that he had the right to give away continents.) Portugal, however, was a powerful exploring nation and immediately entered negotiations with the Spaniards to divide the new world between them. Eventually the Spaniards agreed and Pope Julius II sanctioned the deal in 1506.

they accidentally found and colonized Bermuda.) Later in 1607, the Plymouth Company – identical in form to the London Company - established its Popham Colony in present day Maine. However, this colony was abandoned after a year and the Plymouth Company was dissolved in 1609. The Jamestown colony struggled for several years then found commercial success in growing tobacco.

- In 1609, under a contract with the Dutch East India Company of Amsterdam, Henry Hudson explored the waters off the east coast of North America. His report stimulated interest in the area as a trade resource, and Dutch merchant-traders began to fund expeditions. The Dutch began trading furs with the Native Americans who lived in the area. In 1614, they established a fur-trading fort at Nassau, in what is now Albany, New York. The Dutch traded peacefully with a large number of migratory Indian tribes and the area became known as New Netherlands. At the same time, they built a similar fort at a place called New Amsterdam, which is now known as New York City. Company policy required that all land be properly purchased from the existing peoples.

- In 1619, a group of religious outcasts called Pilgrims, who had been chased from England to Amsterdam some years prior, made commercial arrangements with the investors of the Company of Merchant Adventurers of London to establish a new colony in North America. In their own words, they had: *great hope, for the propagating and advancing the gospel of the kingdom of Christ in those remote parts of the world*. They arrived in 1620 and formed the Plymouth colony in what is now Plymouth Massachusetts.

- In 1629, another group of religious non-conformists and separatists established the Massachusetts Bay Colony with 400 settlers. They hoped to reform the Church of England by creating a new, pure church in the New World. Within two years, an additional 2,000 settlers arrived. The Puritans created a deeply religious, tight-knit and innovative culture that is still present in the United States. They hoped this new land would serve as a "redeemer nation," a "nation of saints" and a "City upon a Hill."

- Soon enough, in 1636, a preacher named Roger Williams, who advocated a complete break with the Church of England, was banished from Massachusetts Bay and founded the Rhode Island Colony, which became a haven for other religious refugees from the Puritan community. One year later, in 1637, a more-or-less Baptist leader name Anne Hutchinson purchased land on Aquidneck Island from the local Native Americans, establishing a settlement in what is now Portsmouth, Rhode Island. Still others followed, which all formed a loose alliance.

- In 1658 Franciscus van den Enden and Pieter Corneliszoon Plockhoy began work on a Utopian settlement in New Netherlands, in the area of the present state of Delaware. In 1663 Plockhoy and 41 settlers made their way to Delaware Bay and established their colony.

- William Penn was a wealthy convert to the despised Religious Society of Friends, also known as the Quakers. Quakers were frequently imprisoned and beaten at this time and the outspoken Penn was no exception. In the late 1670s and early 1680s, Penn settled a debt owed to his family by the Crown, receiving a huge area of land in the New World in return. This area, immediately settled by Quakers escaping persecution in Europe (which they called a "Holy Experiment"), included a good deal of several present US states, including Pennsylvania, named after Penn.

- In 1632, George Calvert, 1st Lord Baltimore, received a royal charter for what was to become the Province of Maryland, which became a Catholic colony. Calvert had apparently been stripped of his Secretary of State office in 1625, when he converted from the Church of England to Catholicism. This group of colonists purchased land from the local Indians and attempted to govern the area under feudalistic precepts. However, these efforts failed in the New World and after intermediate reforms, he was forced to abandon the Medieval model and to govern according to the laws of England[90].

[90] Note that this group – strongly influenced by the Catholic Church – at first tried to do things the Church's way. But there w as no inertia for such actions in a barren land, and these efforts, forced to stand or fall on their own merits - failed quickly. The northern, decentralized, individualistic model of England was adopted instead.

There is much more of interest to be said about each of these ventures and others, but, again, we risk straying from the primary subject of this book.

One point of interest is that the commercial ventures of northern Europe soon found ways to bring people to the New World at no initial cost. In other words, any reasonable poor person who wished could get to colonies in the new World. This was done by the process of *indentured servitude*. These were labor contracts, whereby the new colonist would agree to work for three years in return for his or her passage. A great many young men and women took the deal[91], possibly up to one half of all who came. The main section of one such agreement read as follows:

> *INDENTURE Witnesseth that James Best a Laborer doth Voluntarily put himself Servant to Captain Stephen Jones Master of the Snow Sally to serve the said Stephen Jones and his Assigns, for and during the full Space, Time and Term of three Years from the first Day of the said James's arrival in Philadelphia in AMERICA, during which Time or Term the said Master or his Assigns shall and will find and supply the said James with sufficient Meat, Drink, Apparel, Lodging and all other necessaries befitting such a Servant, and at the end and expiration of said Term, the said James to be made Free.*

Upon arrival in the colonies, advertisements were placed, to find employment for the indentured colonists. This was a complex set of business arrangements, and, minus the occasional problems that are associated with all complex human actions, the arrangements worked reasonably well: Poor men and women got a fresh and free start in life, and the businesses made money.

In general, the northern colonists sought peaceful relationships with the local Indians they encountered. Sometimes this was possible and sometimes it was not. Problems did certainly arise and there were travesties that can be blamed on both settlers and Indians. However, the actions of the northern settlers were of a wholly different character than

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[91] It is also of interest that a great number of women escaped the old world. We have already noted a Baptist leader and colony founder who was female. There were a great many women who came to the New World. They took indentured servant contracts, left their families behind, and jumped on boats for a new continent. There were strong traditions and histories of female freedom-seeking and bravery from this time.

those of the southern conquerors. In the north, cooperation was much preferred; in the south, only domination and submission were acceptable. Far, far more Indians died in the south.

TRIALS, ERRORS, RESULTS

In the south, a Conquistador culture was founded. In the north, however, no single culture was immediately possible. There were Englishmen, Dutchmen and a smattering of other Europeans; there were Utopians and the adherents of many religions, who sometimes fought each other. Beyond that, there were dozens of different business models, some competing and some complimenting each other. New ideas required no charter or permissions in the New World, and they flourished. Many were silly and some were brilliant, but it was difficult to tell which was which as they all sprung up together.

The key attribute of the northern colonies was that they were not controlled by authority. They developed from the ground, up, organically rather than hierarchically and by permissions. If someone had what they thought was a better idea, they could simply go out and try it. In effect, this was a free market in ideas. The ideas which were unsustainable, failed; the ideas that made life more productive, survived. This was an ugly, erratic process, and one that was always easy to criticize, but it also spawned the fast and effective evolution of ideas.

The old world had lost control of these people. They were facing nature and God on their own; they didn't need distant rulers and religious authorities any more. They were creating a new synthesis without any of them. No central pattern had to be held in pre-eminence above them. The best and brightest of them were allowed to use their talents, with the usual restrictions disregarded. They could be whatever they wished to be, and along the way they founded a new way of life.

8

The American Revolution

Our contest is not only whether we ourselves shall be free, but whether there shall be left to mankind an asylum on earth for civil and religious liberty.
-- Samuel Adams

The American Revolution is a historical event that inspires odd reactions from people. On one hand, it is grossly under-appreciated, even passed-off as meaningless; but on the other, it is also over-promoted for the sake of cheap self-esteem. Both of these common errors are the result of people interpreting the American Revolution in the light of their own psychological needs.

Any simple interpretation of the American Revolution is wrong. This was a unique and complex set of events that changed the world. It featured an exceptional group of men, produced by exceptional circumstances and exceptional ideas. And, ultimately, it was a remote and virgin territory that allowed it to come to fruition... just barely and with a lot of luck.

The Quickening of the 17th Century certainly provided the foundation for the American Revolution, but the Scottish Enlightenment was also critical to the American enterprise. This was an exceptional intellectual event, and we will now turn our attention to it.

THE ENLIGHTENMENT

There are several episodes in history called "Enlightenment," but it was the Scottish Enlightenment of the 18th Century that served as both inspiration and root for most of them.

There are several theories as to which events that led to the Scottish Enlightenment, but it is likely that many events deserve parts of the credit. Among these are the free trade that came along with the Union of 1707 and removal of church power and the adoption of the English Bill of Rights following the Glorious Revolution of 1688. But perhaps even more important than these was a general battle between the ideals of Humanism and Calvinism during these years. When there are competing ideals in a group of people, humans experience more free mental space. When one ideology rules among a group of people, adaptations and differences are punished in many ways, ranging from the subtle to the violent. When ideologies compete, however, no one of them has overwhelming authority, and new ideas find space to grow.

But, for whatever reasons, the Scottish Enlightenment – which occurred primarily in the city of Edinburgh - was a period of extraordinary progress. Within it, the following are seen:

- Robert Adam changes the course of architecture.
- James Anderson invents the modern plow.
- Joseph Black discovers latent heat, specific heat and carbon dioxide, as well as initiating the study of thermo-chemistry.
- Hugh Blair becomes a highly influential churchman and professor of rhetoric.
- James Burnett creates comparative linguistics and first describes the process of natural selection.
- Robert Burns writes poetry that is revered to this day.
- Alexander Campbell leaves Scotland to lead the Second Great Awakening in the United States.
- George Campbell modernizes the study and practice of rhetoric.
- John Clerk creates modern naval tactics. (His great-great nephew, James Clerk Maxwell, will go on to define the laws of electromagnetism.)
- William Cullen co-founds the Royal Medical Society and influences a full generation of physicians.
- Adam Ferguson creates the study of sociology.

- James Hutton founds the study of geology and James Hall contributes the first scientific studies.
- David Hume and friends create Empiricism.
- Francis Hutcheson organizes the study of metaphysics, logic, and ethics.
- John Leslie discovers capillary action and learns to artificially produce ice.
- Thomas Reid creates the study of Common Sense.
- John Sinclair becomes the first person to write on statistics.
- William Smellie edits the first edition of Encyclopedia Britannica.
- Adam Smith creates the economic theories that made commerce understandable and defensible.
- James Watt invents the functional steam engine.

This list, however, merely shows the more specific accomplishments of the group. These men crossed disciplinary lines continually. Lawyers studied and worked with artists, biographers with scientists, doctors with poets. These men allowed their interests to run wild, and they found fellows who were eager to do the same. Most of them made substantial contributions in fields other than the one they are remembered for most. Foreigners like Benjamin Franklin of the American colonies corresponded with these men at length.

In general, this group championed human reason and rejected of any type of authority which could not be justified by reason. They were optimistic and thought that human ability was sufficient to improve the world and their place in it. But, perhaps more importantly than all else, this was a group of intellectuals[92] who did not fight amongst themselves.

The truth is that most idea-sellers, at most times of history, fight each other for dominance. These men took the opposite course and helped one another. This may have been a primary reason why their ideas developed and survived intact. They did not waste their time and energies on temporary and destructive group dynamics. And it followed that these men tended to attract readers who were not in the game just so they

[92] I define "intellectuals" as people who make a living by (or are regularly engaged in) producing ideas.

could become important within a group. Rather than seeking glory and position, they sought knowledge itself[93]. Here, again, it was inner mechanics that created the important moments of human history, not externals.

NON-AUTHORITY AND ITS FRUIT

The men of the Scottish Enlightenment – partly due to the virtues they developed among themselves, partly due to the times, and definitely because of beneficial ideas that were passed-down to them – became free from both sides of the authority trap. That is, they were generally free from the oppression of authority and from the desire to become authority.

As mentioned previously, the ideological structure of the time was divided and oppositional: Calvinism versus humanism. There was no universal ideology that was in a position to harm them for thinking along new lines. In addition, the center of governmental authority had just been removed more than three hundred miles to London. (And it is important to understand that governments of this era had next to zero information on the daily activities of its citizens and were microscopic compared to our current ruling groups.) This greatly reduced the pains that authority would be able to impose upon them. And, as mentioned above, the culture of cooperation that developed at Edinburgh was quite contrary to any of them becoming an authority above another.

All of these things: Intimidation, becoming the leader, cult-followings, division into groups – these all divert effort from discovering the truth about the world and redirect it into struggles for the approval and control of other men. The men of the Scottish Enlightenment and those who followed their example showed, dramatically, that the energies wasted in authority struggles could be put to massively better uses.

Being ruled steals from men many of the best parts of their beings, and seeking to rule others corrupts men. The intellectual Scots of Edinburgh were able to provide their own escape from these wastes of authority. Others escaped external authority by simple separation. And, finding themselves in open territory, they tended to disregard the goal of ruling

[93] This brings to mind a comment made many years ago by an old minister. One of his people came to him to ask an important question. "Why," the younger man asked, "was Enoch taken alive into heaven, while people like Moses were not?" The old minister replied: "Moses loved the things *of* God… Enoch loved God."

(or even leading) others. Frontiersmen, as a rule, become notably non-authoritarian.

Living in the wild puts men in direct contact with nature and their natural place in it. They begin to face the man next to them directly, not through cultural expectations. Class boundaries diminish in importance. Processes that were once done in regimented, prescribed, restricted ways are thrown open to anyone who steps-up to do them, merely out of necessity. When it cannot be done the old way, nature is exposed and men confront reality directly, not through the filters and limitations of tradition. This is precisely what happened in the new world of the Americas, and the net effect of this approximated the inter-relation of the learned men of Edinburgh. The intimidations, privileges and protected positions of Europe fell by the wayside, and man dealt with man far more directly.

This unrestrained activity between men created different relationships and differences in human character. For example, at the end of the frontier era, in the American west, there existed a specific type of independent man: Self-contained but gregarious, generous and fair-minded. Frederick Turner, an American historian, wrote the following:

> *From the conditions of frontier life came intellectual traits of profound importance… coarseness and strength combined with acuteness and inquisitiveness; that practical, inventive turn of mind, quick to find expedients; that masterful grasp of material things, lacking in the artistic but powerful to great ends; that restless, nervous energy, that dominant individualism, working for good and for evil.*

MOST UNLIKELY LEADERS

The American Revolution featured a group of men who dared to live openly as free, independent men: Mature, self-responsible, informed, and bent on developing the higher and better aspects of human nature. They often fell short of this goal, but it remained an ideal that they held. When conflicts with the British came, they did not meet them as men pushed to the limit and striking out wildly. On the contrary, these were men doing the right thing, *because* it was the right thing. And, they did all of this after long study to properly determine what that right thing was.

The fact that a group of such men became leaders is most unusual in world history. In most cases, the leader is one who can impose directly power on others or one who convinces others that he can cause power to

be used in ways that they prefer. Or, sometimes, the one who offers some sort of easy path to good feelings. These men were not of any such type. Primarily they were respected and listened to because of their personal abilities and because their words made sense. Granted, it was never simple and there were many who listened because they thought they'd get easy benefits by doing so, but this was no normal group of "leaders."

Sam Adams was a failed and bankrupt businessman, John Hancock was a smuggler, Tom Paine failed at almost everything he had ever done and came to America almost as a vagrant, Jefferson and Madison were overly-studious farmers, Ethan Allen was a land-speculator, John Adams a not-very-successful lawyer, and Patrick Henry a twice-failed businessman. Franklin was a success in business, but was considered an ungodly man by a large number of people. Even Washington, an experienced military veteran, preferred farming and was a surveyor by profession[94].

World history is full of brave men standing up to tyranny, and they are to be lauded. These men, however, were different. This was a group of men who had studied, learned, and formed a vision of a better way to live. Then, they went about to create it. They fought the king because he refused to leave them alone. They were not trying to take over the system and run it their way as much as they were trying to create a new and different system. The Revolutionary Wars were, at least from the viewpoint of the colonials, about the old order trying to oppress a new development.

Of course, this group of men was not enormous and we are now focusing only on their virtues[95]. The majority of American colonials were too busy working to devote extensive periods to study. Nonetheless, even the working people were literate and well-read in many fields, including that of law[96]. The vast majority of them spent a good deal of time and intellectual energy in church and in discussing sermons.

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94 Washington was almost a modern replica of Cincinnatus.

95 Focusing on virtues – modern biases aside – is a fine thing to do. There are productive lessons to be gained from studying what other people did well. There is very seldom anything to be gained from learning about someone's drunkenness or laziness. The fact that many moderns cannot bear to hear good things about certain people is an issue we will examine in a later chapter. Until then, I will simply say that I do not hold that bias and I do not write in subjection to it.

96 Blackstone's *Commentaries on The Laws of England* was a best-seller in the colonies; for a long time out-selling everything but the Bible.

The result of all this was *not* a massive movement for independence from England. Almost all those who wanted independence wanted it grudgingly. Approximately one third of the American colonials wanted to remain loyal to England. Another third or so didn't want to take sides. But the final third styled themselves as self-sovereigns. This was a crucial and important step to take – not because of its impact upon the outer world, but because of the clarity of mind it gave the independent colonials.

We will not be examining the details of the struggle for American self-sovereignty, but there are some central facts that are of importance:

- The events took place in a virgin territory. These developments did not have to compete with an existing order.
- The events took place in a remote territory, where orders from the king were slow in coming. And, at first, the settlers were frequently ignored.
- The colonials grew out of the most productive, advanced, and enlightened culture the world had ever seen: The British Empire. The people of British America started from the leading edge, and went forward from there.
- There was a powerful moral culture. These people were in church regularly, they distributed sermons, and those who rejected traditional religion (like American founder and deist Ethan Allen), argued their cases for moral reasons.
- In the Scottish tradition, these people did not hold ideas as idols, but internalized them as tools. They examined them, adapted them and used them. They mixed them with other good ideas and expanded them.
- Americans had learned that the old human organizational myths were fairy tales. They were confronted with reality face-to-face, with no illusions of a king riding in to save them. They discovered that they could do it themselves, then began to question why, exactly, the king was necessary in the first place.

THE IDEA OF AMERICA

The United States has never been able to define itself by ethnic heritage, that is, by DNA. Americans come from every nation. The core of America is an idea: *self-sovereignty*. That the strength of this idea has ebbed

and flowed over time is a secondary issue, the United States was never pure and was always fiercely at war within itself over a variety of ideas. But the founders set this idea in the highest places, and wrote their core documents around it.

The real foundational document of the American Revolution was the *Declaration of Independence*. The *Constitution* contains the operating rules of the American corporation, but the *Declaration* defines the soul of the American experiment. And this declaration begins by making the individual – every individual – judge and decider. The phrase "We hold these truths to be self-evident" almost demands that an honest reader consider them and decide for himself or herself. There is no appeal to authority, no pedigree, no appeal to precedent, no appeal to anything except the mind of the reader.

And, the document goes further, defining the genesis of rights: From nature's God, to the people, and from thence delegated to a government: a government that the people have a *duty* to overthrow, if it becomes abusive.

The US Constitution, likewise, enshrines this idea. Its original ten amendments are explicit in stating what Congress may *not* do. People have always called these amendments "The Bill of Rights," but that is, and always was, an entirely misleading name: This is a list of actions that the sovereigns, that is, the people, forbid Congress from doing. The language is repetitive and blunt: *Congress shall make no law.*

The overriding idea of America is that the people possess all rights, and choose to delegate a few of them to their government, for specific actions. As corrupted and overblown as the US government may now be, this idea of self-sovereignty lives on in the central documents. (Whether people pay any attention to such things, is, obviously, another matter.)

WHEN AMERICA WAS YOUNG, IT HAD NO MYTH

National leaders nearly always promote some sort of myth – one or more "uniquenesses" that give the nation a noble identity. (And the people, seeking fast and cheap approval from their fellows, are usually eager to join in the self-congratulation.) But in its earlier years, the United States had no such myth, and this was very healthy. If a government officer wanted to get people to do something, he would have to appeal to reason. With no myth, there are many fewer emotional strings to pull, and people who decide based upon reason are much harder to manipulate than those who operate upon emotion.

That the idea of America was good (and that life based upon the idea was good) could only be proved by American success. (And succeed they did, to the shock of the old world.) Americans success cannot be credited to any sort of genetic superiority (the converse could easily be argued), nor can it be credited to natural resources. (Brazil, another new world nation, has always had more resources.) Americans succeeded because the structure of their society allowed them to operate according to a better set of rules.

America proper is not a nation of dirt or of DNA, it is a nation of mind. Fidelity to better ideas was America's advantage, and little else. This lesson has now been taught to any who wish to acknowledge it.

THE DOWNHILL RUN

> *Government is not reason, it is not eloquence -- it is force.*
> *Like fire it is a dangerous servant and a fearful master;*
> *never for a moment should it be left to irresponsible action.*
> -- George Washington

Once the American Revolution turned into the United States of America, power was consolidated. This is a perennial issue and one that is well-illustrated by the American experiment, which was conducted on the blank canvas of an empty continent.

As Washington states above, all governments maintain a monopoly of force in a geographic territory – this is the definition of a state. This makes any political process not cooperative, but combative. Once a political process is finalized, only two choices remain: To obey or to break the law. Individuals, acting outside of government, secure the cooperation of others via persuasion. Governments demand and punish.

The above is not an indictment; it is merely a clarification. If we are to understand human societies, we cannot avoid honest definitions. Governments operate on a completely different model than do non-criminal individuals.

Once the American experiment moved from convincing people to forcing people, its nature was radically changed. One of the first overt changes was the creation of political parties. Parties are, after all, the pooling of political power.

The administration of George Washington (that is, the first eight years of the United States government) and the first few sessions of the US Congress were nonpartisan. Legislators came to their meetings and

decided their vote upon the merits of the bills presented to them. Certainly they might face the disapproval of their constituents if they voted for a hated project, but they dealt with the issues almost directly. Once parties became involved, however, a new layer came into play. The legislator now had to consider whether the party would approve or disapprove of his vote. (Every one of his votes.) His attention was drawn away from the actual merits of the bill and away from his constituents.

The appeal of parties to voters was that they could pool their power to vote candidates into office and thus gain a much greater grip on the government. This, if we are to be honest, meant that they could force others to do the things that they wanted. (Again, government is force, and not persuasion.)

In short, the adoption of political parties pushed the cooperative principle further away and made force a larger component of American life. Ironically, Washington specifically warned his countrymen about this in his Farewell Address. A portion of that address reads as follows:

> *They serve to organize faction, to give it an artificial and extraordinary force; to put, in the place of the delegated will of the nation, the will of a party… they are likely, in the course of time and things, to become potent engines, by which cunning, ambitious, and unprincipled men will be enabled to subvert the power of the people, and to usurp for themselves the reins of government.*

When parties control legislators, debate is almost meaningless – everyone comes to the session knowing in advance which vote their party demands of them. Even reading the legislation is a waste of time – the party has decided and the individual legislator can choose either to obey or to break faith with the party. This adds a layer of complexity to the intended operation of the US government, a layer of separation between the people and their representatives, and a layer of confusion blocking the view from one side of the process to the other.

To contrast the change that occurred by the time political parties became part of American life, here are the thoughts of Samuel Adams during the revolution itself:

> *The natural liberty of man is to be free from any superior power on Earth, and not to be under the will or legislative authority of man, but only to have the law of nature for his rule.*

To reconcile the intentions of Adams with American political rule following Washington is impossible.

But, regardless of the general down-hill slide that began with the consolidation of state power, America served as an agent of change world-wide. As Thomas Jefferson said:

> *All eyes are opened, or opening, to the rights of man. The general spread of the light of science has already laid open to every view the palpable truth: that the mass of mankind has not been born with saddles on their backs.*

PASSING-ALONG THE IDEA, POORLY

The American ideal of self-sovereignty never fully took root[97], but at the beginning it did have enough force to create a carefully-planned republic and to deeply influence a new branch of Western culture. With great difficulty it (along with the religious ideals that had originally informed it) brought about the end of slavery in the United States in the following century. But in the process of eliminating slavery, the republic changed dramatically.

The south, while certainly morally conflicted due to the enslavement of human beings, was more uniquely "American" than the north in other ways. The authors of *Constitution* and the *Declaration* envisioned a state well-suited to the agricultural era. When the industrial revolution began to roll over the north, unexpected commercial and urban forces began to change the republic. The agricultural south reacted against this, and at the same time, some in the north began to abuse their new power. This, combined with the revolution's unfinished business of slavery, created the Civil War.

The end of slavery was, obviously, an important and necessary step, but something of the original idea of America died along with it. Lincoln refused to allow the South to leave the union. Bear in mind that there is absolutely nothing in the Constitution that would forbid such a thing. All of the states joined the union voluntarily, and none forsook their rights to ever leave. Even if they had, this would hardly be binding upon their grand-children. Furthermore, the *Declaration* specifically gives the people the right to overthrow an abusive government. How much more, then, the right simply to leave it?

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[97] From the beginning there have been all sorts of financial scandals, back-room deals and public mud-slinging – regarding facts both true and imagined.

Lincoln's justification for forcing the south to remain in the union was not logical, but mystical. The famous phrase, "that government of the people, by the people, for the people, shall not perish from the earth," presumes a falsity. Was it really only a union of thirty-four states that could keep government "of the people" alive? The union started with only thirteen, after all.

We will not go through a long examination of the war and the "saving" of the union – they are not important to this discussion. But what is important is that the Civil War defined a new America: One that was industrial and one where sovereignty was transferred from the people and from the states, to the central government. The states were now clearly subservient to the central government, and if *they* couldn't assert their independence, how much less an individual citizen?

So, along with the old and flawed south, something of the original idea of America died during the Civil War. And with the rise of industry, the old power centers presumed by the founders were changing. Unfortunately, there was not time for the best men to watch the changes, make sense of them, and modify the republic for the new reality. Indeed, it was only by the long study of history (and reference to previous analysts) that the founders were able to reach to the essentials and design a reasonable structure for the late agricultural era. The industrial revolution simply came too quickly and there was no group of towering geniuses to understand it and to convince others to change appropriately.

To make matters more difficult, many of those who did hold to the old ideas spent their remaining strength in less than ideal ways. Quickly following the Civil War, millions of immigrants began to arrive in the United States. Political energies during this era of immigration were generally wasted in battles over side-issues and details, rather than on passing-on the core ideals that really mattered. The people busied themselves with fights over the control of centralized force rather than on the morality that affects daily life and the ideals of the American Founders. They fought immigration and drunkenness, leaving self-sovereignty behind. They had learned to use force rather than persuasion to secure what they saw as good conduct. They acted politically, not economically; by coercion rather than by cooperation.

The great tide of immigrants during the late 19th and early 20th Centuries were primarily oppressed peoples from eastern and southern Europe. (Immigrants from northern Europe tended to arrive earlier.) They came, not really for the *idea* of America, but for the *results* of America. Then, as

now, their arrival in large numbers caused discomfort and sometimes anger.

Assimilation was generally expected of the immigrant. But this expectation, while somewhat helpful for passing-on the idea of America, was often turned into a bludgeon and used as a tool of insult. Yes, there were good Americans who wished to pass along the great idea of self-sovereignty, but the unkind Americans were at least as loud and the fine points of these arguments were often lost on the immigrants, who, after all, spoke little English.

So, the core ideas of America were poorly passed-on. These new people generally worked very hard and loved America, but many ideas from the old world and their experiences as underdogs and outsiders weighed upon them. On top of this, they were often exposed to discrimination and hatred, making the idea of America considerably less attractive.

Because of the above, late 19th and early 20th Century immigrants (and their children) became excellent fodder for new-style politicians who were now offering the public precisely what they wanted – promises of nurture, acknowledgement as victims, and so on. This, added to the fact that the idea was in a weakened condition by the time they arrived, assured that the immigrants didn't understand what America originally meant. They were generally decent people and good neighbors, but, aside from the most well-read, they didn't understand American foundations very well.

9

The Industrial Surprise

Three hundred years ago, give or take a half-century, an explosion was heard that sent concussive shock waves racing across the earth, demolishing ancient societies and creating a wholly new civilization. This explosion was, of course, the industrial revolution.
-- Alvin Toffler (1979)

The Industrial Revolution was, beyond anything else, a great surprise. It seems that almost no one saw it coming, including its greatest champions. The mixture of scientific discovery and unrestrained human action produced a new method of organization that was overwhelming in its ability to produce valuable products on a never-imagined scale. The new factories made more people more enduringly rich that anything that had ever come before it – by a very, very big margin.

The other ingredient that brought the Industrial Revolution to life was cooperative, inter-disciplinary discussions and projects by groups such as the *Lunar Society of Birmingham*, which was responsible for the development of Watt's steam engine and many other important innovations. This group, like the group in Edinburgh, met regularly, argued, invented, invested, tested, corresponded with others and worked on an endless series of ideas. These were individuals operating with very few restraints, having the Rights of Englishmen, living with minimal government intrusion into their lives, and with very low levels of taxation, which allowed them to accumulate monetary capital. They had the freedom and the ability to finance their own innovations, and they did so.

As all new developments do, the Industrial Revolution relied upon earlier developments, such as clocks and the organization of the printing business[98]. But these were limited contributions.

By the 17th Century, scientific developments were being made rapidly and clever men throughout Britain and northern Europe were tinkering on ways to use them productively. All sorts of new ideas were coming out of workshops and hovels. Most of them are lost to history, but they led to ever-better innovations and to better and cheaper production.

These new machines and new processes, however, were opposed by entrenched interests: people who had learned to rely upon central force to maintain their advantage and to generally order their worlds aright. So, once again, progress was not welcomed, but hated. The first effective manufacturing machines, weaving looms, were often hidden in homes and production was carried out in secret. (This was common in mid-17th Century London.)

Force was applied to stop these new developments. Here are some events of this type from the early Industrial era:

> 1586 – A new type of machine loom is forbidden by the city fathers of Danzig and its inventor is secretly murdered[99].
>
> 1616 – Official English documents refer to "alien weavers," (weaving machines were accepted in Leyden, from where these men may have come) who were: *bold of late, to devise engines for working of tape, laces, ribbon and such, wherein one man does more among them than seven English men can do, so as their cheap sale of these commodities beggareth all our English artificers of that trade.*

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98 Clocks had been developed in the 13th and 14th Centuries by monks, who wanted to organize and regiment work and prayer schedules. Printing press operations were a precursor to factory organization.

99 This story is related in *The London Weavers' Company, 1600-1970,* by Alfred Plummer, page 162. (Other items on this list are also drawn from this text.) Plummer obtained the information from J. Beckman's *A History of Inventions, Discoveries and Origins* (4th Edition, 1846) II, pages 528-9, which quotes a work by Lancellotti, published in Venice in 1636.

1623 – The Privy Council of England orders the destruction of a machine for making needles.

1625 – The Weavers Company of London beseeches the city fathers: *Order that none may use the said engine, except those who are Weavers by trade, for they which now use them are… Merchants and other tradesmen, but not Weavers by trade.*

1638 – King Charles I prohibits the use of "engine, or great looms," and adds, "whereby much deceit is practiced."

1649 – British Navigation Acts, are passed to prevent economic innovation in the colonies and to force all their produce to pass through English hands. This made the colonials subject to all English regulations and criminalized any innovations that were not accepted in England.

1666-1730 – France publishes their Crafts Codes: 2,200 pages of regulations, prescribing every detail of the established craft techniques, and forbidding any innovations to them.

1667 – The Weavers Court of Assistants in London sends a group of Yeomen to conduct a search, and to find out how many looms were in use in their jurisdiction, so that, "a course of action may be decided upon."

1675 – A guild of London area weavers petitions the Lord Mayor to outlaw new "engine looms." In addition, they riot for three days and destroy numbers of such machines.

1686 – England outlaws Indian Calico fabric.

1698 – England outlaws cloth buttons.

Here, again, the names of the early innovators are forgotten. They created methods that would enrich mankind beyond all that had been previously imagined; in reward, they were declared criminals, spied upon, persecuted and sometimes killed. Production was in danger of being overcome by plunder once again.

STEAM POWER

Steam powered devices had existed as parlor tricks as far back as the early Greeks. But the practical steam engines of Newcomen (in 1712) and especially of Watt (in the 1770s) made steam the greatest power source in the history of the world. It allowed fantastic power to be produced and distributed easily and efficiently. Systems of belts, drive shafts, gears and pulleys could distribute this power quite effectively through a medium-sized building, and that from a single engine. With multiple engines, large factories became a practical possibility. This made large manufacturing operations practical.

The steam engine made the Industrial Revolution unstoppable. Power was available upon demand for virtually unlimited periods of time. All sorts of beneficial activities could be arranged around such a power source, and, quite quickly, they were. Once this was seen, the sheer numbers of people who wanted it to exist overcame the users of central power, who wished to maintain a developmental stasis.

Very shortly, it was seen that whoever embraced the steam engine and the possibilities it created might become very rich. And, since wealth can be turned into power, the users of power, not wanting to be overrun by "new money," began to re-arrange their stances and to get in on the new game.

SPECIALIZATION & ECONOMIES OF SCALE

The unique structure of the Industrial Revolution was the factory. Here, for the first time, huge numbers of men and women worked in a coordinated fashion. (At its height, factory production was responsible for most employment in the Western world.)

Factories became dominant for the simple reason that they were effective. By hand, a single piece of furniture, to pick an example, could be built by a single mechanic in perhaps forty hours of time. But if a factory was set up to produce that same item, it could be produced with perhaps ten hours of labor, a four-fold increase in efficiency. (And other examples are much more impressive.)

The first cause of this great gain was merely specialization. A man who works on every aspect of making furniture will become relatively proficient in most of them over time. But if the man works only on cutting wood from the forest, he will become excellent at that specialty, and quickly. By specializing in specific tasks, not only does efficiency

improve rapidly, but special tools and processes for that specialty can be developed. In a short period of time, productivity rises dramatically.

But setting-up a factory full of specialty work-stations was neither cheap nor easy. It required a few highly skilled engineers and a number of highly-skilled machine builders and installers, not to mention the necessary materials and tools. This could be very expensive.

To continue our furniture example, let's say that the factory setup cost was 100,000 silver coins. At a labor rate of 10 farthings per hour, costs of one-half labor and a mark-up of 67%, the factory would have to manufacture and sell at least one thousand pieces before it recouped the 100,000 coin setup costs. You can see from this that factories had to produce huge volumes of identical items if they hoped to gain an economic advantage. But, since the cost to the buyer of such furniture was far below the cost of hand-made furniture and the quality better, they began to sell huge volumes.

MASSIFICATION

As a result of this *economy of scale*, factories became places of mass production. And, as the central engine of commerce went, so went the culture. What Alvin Toffler calls "massification" became the central paradigm of organization: Bigger was better. Bigness was virtue, smallness an embarrassment. The cult of size affected almost every commercial entity. The assumption was that size had inherent advantages. So, almost everything tended to become big, including news organizations, government, entertainment companies, and so on.

In the early chapters of his book, *The Third Wave*, Alvin Toffler dissects Industrial civilization (he terms it "Second Wave civilization,"), explaining why the mass production model, with its unbeatable productivity, was adopted in nearly identical fashion world-wide. Toffler explains that, as the core of industrialism, was a set of six interrelated principles that, in the end, affected every aspect of human life in the industrial era. They were:

1. Standardization
2. Specialization
3. Synchronization
4. Concentration
5. Maximization

6. Centralization

One of the primary ways in which the new model of centralized economic action trained humans to operate within it was government schooling. Toffler explains:

> Built on the factory model, mass education taught basic reading, writing, and arithmetic, a bit of history and other subjects. This was the "overt curriculum." But beneath it lay an invisible or "covert curriculum" that was far more basic. It consisted—and still does in most industrial nations—of three courses: one in punctuality, one in obedience, and one in rote, repetitive work. Factory labor demanded workers who showed up on time, especially assembly-line hands. It demanded workers who would take orders from a management hierarchy without questioning.

With a population trained in conformity, large-scale manufacturing became a practical possibility. People were willing to trust in it (and yield themselves to it) because manufacturing brought an immense increase in material prosperity. Factory production was much, much higher than the earlier non-technical methods. For example, working the old way, a seamstress may have turned out a single dress on a good day. Now, with the aid of a few steam-powered machines, a handful of partly-skilled workers could produce hundreds of dresses in a day. An equal amount of labor delivered ten times the result, or more.

THE NEW URBAN CULTURE

First in England, then in the United States and many other places, a new, urban culture began to rise. Farm boys and girls, in immense numbers, began leaving the countryside for well-paying jobs in the city. The old order, based upon sedentary farm life, cracked open and split apart. The leading edge of progress moved to the cities, causing governance to begin changing accordingly. A middle class composed of merchants, traders, supervisors and engineers formed, and kept growing as the most skilled workers (who were better-paid than the average worker) began living the first versions of modern city life.

Over the next century, industrialization spread throughout the Western world. (And in very few other places.) Wave after wave of farm children came to the cities for good jobs, and most stayed. All of our modern

institutions began to form, in service of the new order: Banks, courts, meeting halls, merchants' associations, central markets, warehouses, barge terminals and, soon, railway terminals. Mutual-assistance organizations formed, churches sprang up to service the new arrivals, restaurants, barber shops, taverns, grocery stores, dry good stores, and many others. The world took its modern form.

Government also was forced to renovate. Industrialism displaced the royal families of Europe. Their power at the time was gigantic and their methods of influence were many, but they failed to prevent themselves from being pushed from power. The new system was built over and around them, and, once in pace, it removed the ground from beneath their feet[100]. Rulership (especially in England and America) evolved into representative government, with the people of each area choosing and sending a few people to regional capitals, to pursue their interests. Now, the great masses of people were a force for the ruler to reckon with. And with newspapers and mail now common, the ruler's actions were at least partially public and open to scrutiny.

In response to this, the various classes of rulers had to pay close attention to the wishes of their employers – that is, to the people that elected them. To further complicate matters, these citizen/subjects were no longer peasant farmers, but factory workers, managers, shop-keepers, and the new professionals. As a result, the rulers paid a lot less attention to the farmers. Power shifted to the cities and to their masses.

Members of governments were forced into the popularity business. Getting huge numbers of people to vote for them determined their employment And, since there is a certain addiction to power, many of them wanted very badly to retain their offices. As a result, politicians began to work very hard at gaining popularity. They struggled to determine what the masses wanted, what they were afraid of, what made them like someone and what made them dislike someone.

In some ways, turning governance into popularity contests was beneficial, since it made the politician dependent upon the populace. In measure, at least, the politician listened to the voters, and did what they wanted him or her to do. But, on the other hand, politics became a manipulation contest. There were few rules on what could be done to get a citizen to

[100] The families didn't vanish, of course. They still have massive influence, financial and otherwise, but even the few that remain "in power" are little more than figure-heads.

vote for you. Outright bribes were soon enough outlawed, but promises of money from the public treasury always played well.

No longer was the local community of farmers the central unit of power. Now it became groups of people: The factory workers, the bosses, the investors, specific immigrant groups, and so on. Politicians played one group against the other with virtuosity. As time went on, the groups played-to by industrial era politicians has continually shifted, but income discrepancies and envy have always played major roles.

RESULTING PROBLEMS

> *Woe to him who teaches men faster than they can learn.*
> -- Will Durant

The Industrial Revolution had negative consequences as well as good. The technology and economics were fine by themselves, but a lot of people were not ready to leave the archaic world and join the modern world. They felt dragged into it, and were simply not ready to deal with the emotional dislocation that it caused. They were not ready to adapt; they were not ready to change; but, the open offer of making a lot more money and living in a much grander style drew them into it anyway. Modernity was thrust upon them.

Modernity is defined by the process of science – that of testing ideas one at a time and building them into larger ideas. The pre-modern mind focused much more around beginning with large ideas and fitting smaller ideas into that model. It was a model built for mental stasis and comfort within rigid boundaries.

Specific things that gave shape to the modern world were these:

- Reduced security in - and benefit from - the clan, tribe, or local group.
- Rapid change.
- Multiplied choices.
- Multiplied information.
- Private property, secure title, lot lines, surveying.
- Business competition, with the attendant possibility of failure.
- Greater accumulation of wealth.

All of the above caused great turmoil and often wild, reactionary responses.

Wealth, for example: Its very existence threatens those who do not have it and fills them with shame. The modern thirst for equality is, to a very considerable extent, an attempt to escape the shame of comparison with people more wealthy than themselves. In the Middle Ages one was held within one's class, and no one could be blamed for lack of achievement. Industrial society ripped that comfortable situation apart. Many Europeans were partially enslaved prior to the Industrial Revolution, but within that restrictive structure they found sanctuary from blame. Unrestricted wealth accumulation took that away and spawned reactionary movements such as Marxism, which held wealth accumulation itself to be criminal.

The demotion of place had similar effects: Once your "special" place is no longer special, and people are leaving it for other places (such as the cities), centuries-long self-esteem supports are removed. People who found belonging and/or superiority in their special place are left grasping for some reason to feel good about themselves[101].

There have been far more variations on this theme than we will have time to catalog, but they all orbit around the issues of externally-based self-esteem, permanent uncertainty, and methods of escaping feelings of shame: Identification with great "personalities," living vicariously through others, wishing for successful people to fall, wishing for primitives or their attributes to ascend, hating progress, hating variant opinions, and so on. These all certainly existed before the industrial revolution, but they gained far greater prominence when a new way of living was thrust upon the world.

The first dislocation occurred when the farm boy left his farm and would no longer undertake his traditional family obligations. This left the older generation unprepared and vulnerable. The young generation focused on themselves and told their parents, "I never signed up for life-long duty to the farm. I have my own life, and I will live it as I see fit.[102]"

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[101] Which, of course, illustrates why basing one's self esteem on anything but an honest estimation of one's self is a fraud and leaves one permanently vulnerable to anyone who can remove the fraudulent base, or to anyone who says they can strengthen it against the winds of change. This is how tyrannies are formed.

[102] Better jobs in the city was not the only factor affecting these people, although it was the strongest. At about the same time, mechanized farming became possible. As the McCormick Reaper and other farm machines proliferated, the demand for farm labor receded. There were, of

The children who went to the cities also suffered shock. They usually found their hoped-for job quickly enough, but found themselves in a completely new situation. In the city, life was ruled by clocks. They rose and lay down according to the sun on the farm. The factory required workers to arrive and be ready to work at very precise times. There was no going to work when you were ready; you had to be in your place and ready to perform at eight o'clock. If not, you were fired and replaced with another newly-arrived farm boy.

There was also the matter of acculturating to city life. A large percentage of these people felt lost, as if they no longer knew where they belonged in the world. They had no certain place, and that void gnawed at them. Before the Industrial Revolution, they at least knew that they belonged somewhere: They had a place, a local church, and a significant number of neighbors. Love them or hate them, they felt at home there. Now that was behind them and they felt isolated in the midst of chaos, and vulnerable. Their identity was in question for the first time. They left the farm where they knew who they were and had a place in a hundred-generation chain. Now they were in a city where no one would know or care if they did or didn't show up the next day.

THE ROAD TO AUSCHWITZ

The road to World War Two, the central man-made disaster in world history[103], began with the dislocation culture of the Industrial Revolution. The story is important in its own right, but more so because it illustrates the kind of problems that can arise from mass changes. That the creation of better production would lead to something like a Holocaust is not initially obvious.

As the Industrial Revolution proceeded into southern Europe and to points east, it created groups of people that were less able to be dragged into a new world than Englishmen, Dutchmen and Americans had been.

In most of the south, there was no representative government. That left these people even more isolated than their northern counterparts. In the

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course, farmers that used the Reaper as a tool to allow them to farm many more acres, but expansion was not always possible, and the number of farm workers declined steadily.

[103]This statement, obviously, is subject to debate. The 20th Century's socialists killed almost unbelievable numbers: Stalin over 20 million and Mao over 50 million, not to mention what happened in Cambodia and in many other places. But, these were not single events per se, and were not as flamboyant and concentrated as the killings of WW2. Certainly they were less memorable (for better or worse).

northern places, one could, and often did, attend a political meeting simply because there was nothing else to do in the evening, and because they were assured that the local politician would welcome them with open arms. Not so in southern and eastern Europe, where there were no representative politicians.

So, if there was no group to find representation in, and if the state was not particularly welcoming, as alternative would have to be found. Soon enough, the concept of the *People* came along. So, 19th Century Europe became a breeding ground for what came to be called the "Pan" movements. (*Pan* meaning universal.) There were pan-Slavic movements, pan-German movements, pan-Polish movements, and many others. The dislocated factory workers found their identity as part of a "people," not directly or permanently associated with a single nation. Men organized themselves by ethnic self-image, which was better addressed by the Pan groups than it was by the state, which may or may not accept him as a member, and which barely listened to him in the first place.

At about this time, the root of human rights was changing as well. In the Middle Ages, one would speak of his or her "rights as a Christian." But with the rise of national sovereignty, formalized with the Peace of Westphalia in 1638, the root of human rights was passing, slowly and erratically, to the nation-state. This also led to the popularity and strength of the Pan groups. Particularly hard-hit by this change were minorities in the various states. For example, who would protect a Frenchman living in Germany? He was not a German, and therefore not a citizen of the German state, and not entitled to its protection. Our modern processes for such situations were not in place at this time. Minority populations were not accepted for membership in the state, resulting in large numbers of "stateless people." These were people with no authority to protect them. The most notable of these were the Jews.

Regarding the Pan movements, it is important to remember that, up to World War One, even the strongest rulers accepted their legitimacy. One of Czar Alexander III's primary reasons for entering World War One was to "protect our fellow Slavs." These Slavs were *not* citizens of the Czar's Russia. The First World War can be understood as a clash between Pan movements at least as well as it can be understood as a clash between states.

After World War One, the winners attempted to redraw Europe's borders according to the "peoples" of Eastern Europe, and to give them all a nation or to make them legally-protected minorities. Hitler called

this artificial and became the great implementer of the Pan ideals. He demanded control of the Sudetenland because the German minority there was not protected and should naturally belong to his Germany and not to the Czechs. After that, it was Austria, which he considered a natural part of "The German Nation." Thus the system of States broke down, creating World War Two.

The fate of the Jews was also wrapped up in this tumult. The people of the Pan movements saw themselves as superior to the state. When they saw the Jews associated with state power, they became ever so much more the enemy[104].

Schoenerer, the leader of the German Pan movement, seems to have discovered the effectiveness of anti-Semitism by accident. But, whether by accident or not, the Jews became a perfect tool. Hitler condemned the Treaty of Versailles, its humiliation of the German nation, and the current order of states. Then he placed the bulk of the blame upon the Jews - a stateless people whom no one was willing to protect. He had nothing to lose and everything to gain. (Anti-Semitism already had deep roots in Eastern Europe.)

Following World War Two, Bolshevism and revulsion at Nazi atrocities killed the Pan movements in a moment. The world would be organized in states for the foreseeable future.

DUNBAR'S NUMBER

Dunbar's Number[105] is the number of identities that humans can manage and work with. These are relationships in which an individual knows who each person is, and how each person relates to every other person. At numbers larger than this, rules, laws, and enforcement are required to maintain a cohesive group.

Beyond about 150 people, most humans have a hard time dealing with individual identities: considering how a new policy will affect Jimmy and Suzy and Herman and Sarah and George and Bob, etc. At that point,

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[104] The truth is that only a fraction of the Jews were associated with power, usually as money-lenders. The popular images of the time left out the majority Shtetle Jews (poor Jews in small towns), and focused on the few "abusers of the People."

[105] Developed by British anthropologist Robert Dunbar. He based it upon brain size and function. He and others have found evidence for it in human history. Some place the number higher than Dunbar's 150, but none more than twice as high.

they move into abstractions[106], and individuals are replaced by groups and symbols. (At this point, trouble begins.) Human minds have limits, and keeping complex 'images' of more than 200 people in their head at once is too much for most people. They resort to symbols and binary decision mechanisms: Yes/No, Allowed/Forbidden, Blue/Red, and so on.

This abstraction is the great corrupter of large systems, and the root of their de-humanizing aspects. Rules and laws always devalue the individual, and *cannot do otherwise*. This is because of information theory, not character flaw. When you stop seeing humans *as humans*, they are inherently devalued, and their individual personalities are excluded.

Because Dunbar's Number describes real human limitations, this de-humanizing effect will remain part of large organizations until human brain-power increases dramatically, which may be a long time.

Because of this fact, systems based upon rules are oppositional to human-to-human cooperation, and, to human liberty. The great advantage to the common law of England was that it was not based upon rules[107]. Rather, it was based upon principles, which would be interpreted and applied by legal professionals. The core of the issue here is information processing. Principles are designed to be applied intelligently to real human actions. Rules are rigid and binary: not at all suited to a complex humanity.

Rules eliminate reason and interpretation. They forbid complex thought and demand blind obedience instead. Thus, what we might call a terabit processor (the human brain) is forbidden to decide, and merely becomes a tool of obedience. The rule – a simple, two-bit, binary decision – is enthroned: Thus the best information processors are ignored, in favor of two-bit processing. Again, this is simple information theory[108].

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[106] An *abstraction*, as I use the term, is the substitution of a symbol for one or more real things. Rather than considering the thing itself, someone using abstraction would consider the category to which the thing belongs. For example, if I were planning a new schedule in my factory: Rather than thinking about its impact upon each of my company's 500 employees, I would simply consider the impact upon an imaginary "worker." This "worker" would be an abstract image, not a real thing by itself.

[107] As a result, people living where the common law was held tended to be more adaptive and creative than placed where Civil Law was in force. This was not because they were inherently better, but because they were allowed to think and operate more freely.

[108] The great fear of abandoning rules is that "something could go wrong." This is held as a deep bias by most people, as is evidenced by the fact that things go wrong every day under the primacy of rules, and that they do not fear this, nor do they question it. And, of course, something always *will* go wrong. Human complexity assures that – under any system.

Because industrial production required large numbers of people working in one place and at one time, the effects of Dunbar's Number were a primary (and negative) feature of Industrial society. The problem could have been worked-around (and has been, to some extent, in recent years) but it simply was not properly understood at the time, and the people working to create industrial production were too distracted to do much about the problem. And, of course, the people who felt the sting of this de-humanization tended to blame it on the malice of their employers, or on the "moneyed class," or on "capitalism" in general. All were distractions from the core of the issue and all created hatreds.

NEW OPPORTUNITIES

Although we have spent a number of pages explaining the problems that arose with the Industrial revolution, it is important to return to its benefits, which greatly outweighed these costs[109].

All humans have talents, inclinations and abilities that are far, far more complex and varied than the assumptions of the societies that contain them. For the vast majority of human history, such abilities found little outlet. The early Armenian gardeners of 6000 B.C. experienced a moment in which their abilities were free to flourish, but it was restrained by force soon enough. Since then opportunities have found an occasional open space, but generally within the limits of agricultural communities. Trade did exist, but it was often limited[110]. Beside, trading is but one occupation.

In complex industrial societies, for the first time, humans had both freedom and access to multiple avenues for the expression of their abilities. Choices opened up, seemingly without limit: Engineers of many varieties, specialty manufacturers, repairmen, parts suppliers, transportation specialists, instructors, inspectors, insurance providers, nurses, custom builders, after-hours entertainers, and the list goes on almost without limit.

Of course, there were continual attempts to limit this explosion of growth with professional regulation laws, but these were generally circumvented over time. For the first time ever, humans encountered

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[109] The more horrifying aspects of which cannot be blamed on the Industrial revolution any further than we blame the peaceful poet who unintentionally inspires a killer.

[110] Rulers of most types throughout the agricultural era resented and insulted both traders and trade. It functioned as a "wild card" for them: Necessary to some extent, but bringing in strange new ideas and upsetting their systems of control.

more choices than they could possibly consider seriously. This did cause some discomfort (and still does), but it is so much better than the old alternative that comparisons are silly.

This was also highly productive, since it allowed people to find their unique strengths and to use them, rather than being stuck in work for which they were not suited. Granted, finding out what one is best at is usually a lengthy and difficult process, but at least it became a serious possibility.

It should be added that this new ability to choose among unlimited vocations remained more difficult in class-bound societies, such as was frequently the case in England. Every time someone was not permitted in some economic activity, productivity was reduced. This form of exclusion was occasionally tried in America (as the professional regulation we mentioned above), but classes per se were never enforced – one of the greatest advantages of the new world.

THE MARKET INTRUDES UPON THE STATE

Under the new model of Industrial civilization, power was steadily removed from the ruling families and taxing groups and given to commercial groups and individuals. That is, to the markets in general[111]. By any objective standard, the market is a more ethical organization than any ruler. Markets force no one to do anything against his or her will, do not possess arbitrary power and are very seldom seen ordering violence[112].

States, always cultivating their legitimacy and having the raw power to impose upon any individual it wishes, maintained an advantage in public image. Nonetheless, everyone knew that generating wealth was something that the market did, and that the state did not. So, for the first time, the market began to remove power from rulers and keep it for itself.

Under the rule of a market that bore the impress of Christianity, commercial competition became a game of cooperation: Competition was not between individuals as much as it was between strategies. The best strategies displaced others, and could be adopted by any player in

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[111] By "market" or "markets," I refer to the entire system of voluntary trade.

[112] I am excluding any consideration of criminal activity, which arises in roughly equal amounts under all systems: state, market, religious or any other. Condemning any system because it fails to provide perfection is silly; no system has ever been able to provide such a thing.

the game. Thus competition became a discovery mechanism, and the best methods of improving human life were those which were best-rewarded. Certainly this game-play was always sloppy, punctuated by cheating, and uneven, but overall it provided more and better strides forward than had ever been before – by a large margin.

Furthermore, the market provided unlimited opportunities for its participants. Where the market was freest, any player had the opportunity to make a fortune for himself or herself, and the method of doing this required that they provide people with what they wanted better than anyone else did. This was a virtuous cycle[113] such as had never been before. Indeed, the best thinkers of the Industrial era championed free markets, not because they were effective, but because they were the most ethical structures for human cooperation and progress that had ever been built.

[113] The great unethical actions of the free-market era – Colonialism and Mercantilism – were the doings of governments and of companies that influenced governments to exercise power on their behalf. Therefore, they cannot be honestly attributed to markets.

10

The Decline Of Western Civilization

There was a golden world which developed between 1815 and 1914. Over that century and with the interruptions of a few short wars, notably the US Civil War and the French/German War of 1871, a general peace had been the main feature…

An immense optimism covered the world, economically underpinned by the Classical Gold Standard. Gold coinage, though often of different weights in different countries, WAS money. The entire western world was a form of payments union in the sense that Gold was money.

Governments were small; tiny compared to today. What taxes existed were almost imperceptible. The US had no income tax. Privacy, property and contracts were sacrosanct.
-- Bill Buckler, *The Privateer*

The 19th Century was a time of immense progress. In the first half of the century, a huge number of canals and roads were built, opening up trade and travel. In the United States, this allowed for the settling of an open frontier.

In mid-century, railroads spread across continents, making travel much faster, easier and cheaper. Never in the history of mankind had the transport of goods at these speeds and distances been possible, much less affordable. Steel went into mass production, making super-strong

building materials available at little cost. Electricity was put to practical use in the telegraph.

By late in the century, electricity was used for the telephone and then for electrical light and power. In addition, radio began to develop, along with sound recording.

Scientific advances were far too many to mention: Chemistry, physics, biology, medicine, botany, zoology, mechanics, material sciences and dozens more leapt forward. Engineering positively went wild with new possibilities. For the first time in history, intercontinental travel for leisure and education was possible for people of average means. Humanity surpassed, clearly and even flamboyantly, all heights that had been previously achieved. The race was in new territory. The great forward movements of the 17th and 18th Centuries came to full fruit.

And then…

As we have seen from so many examples in the past, civilizations do not last forever and once they forsake the virtues that created them, they enter a long, slow period of decline. This is precisely what has happened to Western civilization, and all of our lives have taken place in the midst of this process. Yes, it is still possible for Western civilization to turn itself around, but absent heroic measures, it will reach its end – if not soon, certainly in the times our great-grandchildren. The factors that enabled Western civilization to renew itself in previous instances are not very strong at the moment and replacements are not apparent. The situation may not be hopeless, but it is dire.

For the rest of this chapter, we will track the descent of Western civilization, focusing on the primary issues and passing over a great deal of minutia. One of the interesting things about the last few hundred years of history is that it has been wonderfully documented. But, this book is not intended to be a compendium and we shall pass over a great deal.

REVERSING COURSE

> *Ages of experience testify that the only way society can be improved is by the individualist method ... that is, the method of each 'one' doing his very best to improve 'one'.*
> -- Albert Jay Nock

The first great step backward was the attempt on the part of many people to turn the coercive force of the state into a tool of righteousness. Having forgotten Washington's admonition that *government is not reason, it*

is force… a dangerous servant and a fearful master, they grew weary of convincing people to be righteous and began forcing them, completely changing the nature of their moral offerings and substituting exterior change for internal change.

In other words: If you work to convince a man to change his behavior – voluntarily – he may not follow your ideas, but if he does, it is because of authentic, internal changes in that man.

If you get a man to change his behavior by force, he follows your ideas for the wrong reasons. He is *not* changed internally. He learns nothing except that raw power can be used. Some will be insulted in the process and will begin to seek power, in order to force their way upon all others.

This reversed the flow of Western civilization, which had been built upon internal virtues, by which Europeans, "saw to it themselves." Under this new model, internalities were bypassed and externalities were enthroned. Persuasion was abandoned for the use of power upon others.

The process unfolded in three primary initial steps:

RIGHTEOUSNESS JOINS WITH FORCE, PART ONE

Slavery in the Western hemisphere was instituted by Spain immediately upon Columbus' arrival in what is now Latin America, and the first African slaves arrived less than ten years later, coming to Hispaniola in 1501[114]. Over time, slavery spread up to the English colonies, but it was not well-liked in many of the colonies, and by 1807 the importation of African slaves was banned in both the US and in British colonies.

Regardless of the cessation of new slave arrivals, however, the existing slaves remained, and this was an open wound for both Britain and the United States. Both countries were populated with religious Christians, many of whom had moral difficulties with the concept of slavery. A large number of non-religious people who had absorbed the teachings of the Enlightenment were also ardent opponents of slavery.

Soon, strong abolition movements gained numbers and force. In England, one of the lead abolitionists was William Wilberforce, a wealthy Englishman who left the Church of England and became a fervent, non-conformist, evangelical Christian. He waged a decades-long campaign to abolish the slave trade. In the United States, William Lloyd Garrison was

[114] There had been African slave trade for centuries prior, bringing African slaves primarily to the Muslim world.

the most notable abolitionist. To illustrate the religious aspect of abolitionism, here is an image of one of the most popular medallions of the time:



Courtesy Wikimedia Commons

Abolitionism is crucial to our subject here because it was the beginning of what we might deem *righteous activism.* Religious or people who considered themselves to be fighting "the good fight" began to use government as a tool for reaching their goals. And reach them, they did. Slavery was outlawed in the British Empire in 1833 and in the United States in 1863.

In Britain the effects of this union of righteousness and force carried-on, but not as powerfully as in the United States, which probably was due in part by the drama of the Civil War and the sudden emancipation of the American slaves by Lincoln in 1863.

The success of abolitionism set a pattern for future righteous activism. In fact, William Lloyd Garrison moved into the temperance[115] movement

[115] For those who do not know, *temperance* is an old word for self-control. It signifies the opposite of excess. The temperance movement sought to restrain or eliminate the drinking of alcoholic beverages.

once slavery had been eliminated in the United States. In England, the temperance movement began at almost the precise moment that slavery was outlawed. The strategy was shown to be successful: Righteous people push the government to enforce righteousness. This became a dominant civic ideology in the United States within a surprisingly short period of time.

RIGHTEOUSNESS JOINS WITH FORCE: PART TWO

By the mid-19th Century, many of the ills of America were widely blamed on the consumption of alcohol. Drinking, however, had been a sometimes-troublesome activity from time immemorial; so, why a gigantic temperance movement should form just at this moment is a good question. One partial answer is that a great number of people were moving from farms to cities, where no one would keep them from over-drinking. With no family members or close commercial associates nearby to scold them, some people went to extremes. This, however, would not apply to married men, one of the chief targets of the temperance movements.

The other answer to why temperance movements became big at this moment was that the "righteousness plus government" strategy was winning great victories. It had just worked at outlawing slavery, and energetically righteous people – of whom there were very many in the United States, especially among northeastern descendents of Puritan and Pilgrim types – had made the massive force of government bring their desires to fulfillment.

So, massively-increasing numbers of people – typically religious – sought to pass laws and to enforce righteous living upon the nations of England and the United States. Temperance laws were passed in Maine by 1851, in eleven additional states within several years, and with English activists attempting laws several times, beginning in 1854.

Interestingly, one cause that is often given for less progress in England than in the US was that the movement was split. There was a significant part of the movement that opposed hard-liners and preferred moral persuasion to the force of law. The US-based groups did not split this way and remained committed to the forcible prohibition of alcohol consumption. And not only that, but many temperance activists used vigilante violence to stop people from drinking. For many people, righteousness plus force had become the new model.

The temperance movement, of course, led to the 18th Amendment to the US constitution and the outlaw of alcohol sales in 1920. (Commonly called *Prohibition.*) In England, laws were eventually passed, such as the *Defence of the Realm Act* in 1914 that restricted pub hours of operation and taxed beer. Some breweries were nationalized two years later, but with World War One raging, further temperance laws were pushed to the side.

Prohibition in America ended the temperance movement. To reverse a famous business quote (from Tom Peters): they over-promised and under-delivered. The temperance movement had promised that Prohibition would be the solution to the nation's poverty, crime, violence, and other ills. On the eve of Prohibition the invitation to a church celebration in New York said this: *Let the church bells ring and let there be great rejoicing, for an enemy has been overthrown and victory crowns the forces of righteousness.*

Famed baseball-player-turned-evangelist Billy Sunday said:

> *The slums will soon be only a memory. We will turn our prisons into factories and our jails into storehouses and corncribs.*[116]

The Women's Christian Temperance Union (WCTU) went so far as saying that after Prohibition passed, it would go onward and bring "the blessing of enforced abstinence" to the rest of the world. People committed to righteousness were now fully invested in using state force to create blessings upon earth.

Prohibition, of course, failed to solve crime and created a whole series of new and immensely profitable criminal enterprises. Once the results were clearly seen, the experiment was discredited and Prohibition was repealed. The strategy of *righteousness plus force*, however, did not end with it.

PART THREE: PROGRESSIVISM

> *The role of the public official, and in particular of the public school teacher… is to collect little plastic lumps of human dough from private households and shape them on the social kneadingboard.*
> -- Edward A. Ross, *Social Control,* 1914

[116] And, in fact, a number of towns did actually sell their jails, only to buy them back or build new ones shortly thereafter.

The quote above is from Theodore Roosevelt's favorite sociologist, during what is called the Progressive Era (roughly 1890 through 1920, but with many elements continuing through the current time). You can see from this short passage that Mr. Ross was fully committed to using compulsory schooling to shape children (the lumps of human dough) into the types of adults that he thought they should be. The Progressive Era is known for many things, but nearly all of them revolve around the "righteousness plus force" model. Under this model, people would not be persuaded, one by one, to do the right thing; they would be forced and molded en masse. And this was not only seen as righteous, but it was seen as efficient as well.

Murray Rothbard, in his paper, *The Progressive Era and the Family*[117], traces the roots of the Progressive era back to the pietist revival movement of the 1830s. Pietism broadly taught that the creeds of churches or sects did not matter, nor did obedience to rituals. What pietism maintained *did* matter, however, was being "born again," and establishing a direct relationship between the individual and God.

Pietists in the south tended to be self-contained, holding that the experience of individual regeneration, of being born again, was enough to ensure salvation. Pietists in the north, however, tended to add that it was necessary to ensure the salvation of everyone else in society, at least as much as was humanly possible. A common goal was "to transform the world into the image of Christ." This is not surprising, considering that religious traditions in the northern United States were begun by people who required their co-religionists to hold to their doctrines very closely – or else be removed.

In any event, pietists in the north soon took it upon themselves to stamp out temptations and occasions for sin. Accordingly, many of these people were drawn into abolitionist and temperance movements.

The other large religious groups in the United States at this time were "liturgical" Christians, such as Lutherans and Roman Catholics, who were arriving in large numbers. Both of these groups relied more upon their churches than upon individual experiences.

It was the shock of immigration that brought the Progressive Era to full force. In particular, the ideals of Progressivism were applied to Catholic immigrant children in public schools. Teachers frequently lectured on the dangers of "Popery," (Roman Catholicism), the wickedness of alcohol

[117] Available on the mises.org web pages.

consumption and so on. By 1901, for example, every US state required classroom instruction in temperance. This was not a Catholic doctrine. Roman Catholics often felt that drinking to excess was a sin, but that drinking in moderation was clearly acceptable.

In this case, and especially since most Catholic children went to state schools, many Catholics worked to rid the schools of Protestant requirements and ceremonies, and of anti-Catholic textbooks. Many battles ensued, including massive anti-immigrant efforts. And, again, the final version of righteousness would be decided by state force, which all parties sought.

Progressivism was the next step in the evolution of righteousness plus force, and it expanded into many areas. Beside mandatory state schooling of all children, Progressives wished to regulate most aspects of economic and moral life, and even family life. They fervently pursued regulation upon businesses, wilderness use laws, and labor laws. In all these cases, the underlying general motivations were to save America and the world via state force.

By about 1920, Progressivism began to change. New laws restricted immigration for the first time, and with the stock market making people rich, the previous desire to "reign in" corporations began to wane. But, far more importantly, Prohibition was failing dramatically, which discredited Progressivism's Christian base. Religious Progressives said that Prohibition would solve all ills, and it clearly did not. That line of Progressivism failed. In its place came several new ideals:

- Populism: That "the people" were the proper ones to direct power, and not politicians, business owners and "interests." In short, the righteous people versus the devious elites.

- Social sciences: As former pietists replaced religion with intellectualism (their zeal remaining), they began using science as a tool to direct righteousness plus force in the right directions.

- Collectivism: Social Gospel ideals, with their elevation of equality, had been circulating for some time, but the Bolshevik revolution in Russia gave great hope to many Progressives. Here was a vibrant new government, committed to scientifically and forcefully creating a righteous world. And, since Progressive Christianity had embarrassed itself, Bolshevik atheism was hard to argue against.

The end result of this, leading into modern times, was that the Progressive's feeling of active righteousness – and especially of a religious-style of zealotry – has been passed-down consistently, but Christianity per se was removed, or at least powerfully demoted[118]. *The rights of the working man, people power*, *social justice*, and similar ideas were enthroned in religion's place[119]. The various feminist, environmental, housing and other movements extending into our time share this base. The civil rights movements of the 1960s featured a temporary return to religion as an influence, but that has not lasted.

However, it is important to add that the religious aspect has returned as "social conservatism." Here, again, we see religious people seeking to *enforce* proper living, rather than *convincing* individuals to "live right." Regardless of political party, the motive force is the same.

The formula of "righteousness plus force" endures through all of these. For every "good" end to be reached, the prescribed course of action was for a government to enforce it.

AND LAW CHANGED

Back in chapter six, we explained how John of Salisbury and others developed an ideology that put the ruler in subjection to the law. We quoted a key line from John's work: *It is established … that the prince is subject to the law and to justice.*

The key point had been that the ruler was beneath the law. Another fact – absolutely crucial for understanding this issue – is that legislation was not "law" at that time.

Legislation is a modern invention. It barely existed under the rule of kings and princes. But with legislative bodies, such as a Parliament or Congress, legislation arose. These edicts of groups slowly displaced the findings of judges as "law;" not because they were morally or practically superior, but because they were more directly backed by force, and because legislatures were better legitimized than judges. Legislators were elected by the people; judges were merely appointed.

Again, as we said in the sixth chapter, the seat and legitimization of sovereignty in Western society had been "the law." A king was a worthy

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[118] The Scopes Monkey Trial seems to have cemented the removal of religion from the Progressive cause.

[119] And, far more than almost anyone would like to admit, many strains of Progressivism after 1920 were financed, either directly or indirectly, by the Soviet Union.

ruler if he upheld the law, and unworthy if he did not. The law was above the ruler.

When law became legislation, however, the old "rule of law" formula was ruined. Now, groups of rulers were not *subject* to the law – they *created* the law. Worse, they could change the law however they saw fit. They were no longer beneath the law – they were above it. This was a re-conquest. From roughly 1200-1800, rulers in the west were subservient to the law. From roughly 1800 onward, groups of rulers made the law and were superior to it. "The law" became something wholly different than what it had been, and sovereignty was transferred.

During the 19th Century, this change caused fairly little trouble, for two primary reasons: First was that the common law remained and continued to be held in high esteem in both the United States and in Britain. Even though new, different laws could be passed, the common law remained as a reference. Secondly, legislation was a slow and difficult process. Law-makers arrived at the state house on horseback and had to return home for long periods. Legislatures would frequently meet for only weeks at a time, and only a few times per year.

Modern transportation and large government operations changed that, however. Since the beginning of the 20th Century, legislators have spent extended periods in their various capitals and have begun measuring their effectiveness by the numbers of laws they have passed. So, by the middle of the 20th Century, the process was mostly complete and rulers were no longer effectively subject to the law.

Six hundred years of kings in subjection to the law were over[120]. The rulers had taken back their power and retained their legitimacy. So long as people believed in the democratic process, the law-makers were sovereign without challenge.

SIZE AND SPECIALIZATION RUIN UNDERSTANDING

Industrial production, as it spread across the West in the 19th and 20th Centuries, required workers to be organized into huge factory operations and in specialized work. This was immensely productive, but it took a terrible toll on people's understanding of the world.

When working for a factory, the young man or woman never saw much of the entire operation, only their little part of it. Unless they were quite

[120] Certainly legislatures are held to certain laws, but actually not many. Beside, they can rewrite those as they see fit in almost any case.

well-informed, they saw only a "system," which they didn't understand. The "system" was not creative so far as they could see; instead, it was a huge organization that demanded blind obedience and issued a paycheck in return. In most cases, an individual never met or even saw the ultimate boss – he was probably several states away, seated in a tall office building.

All of this created immense distances between the goals of the worker and the goals of the business in general. The worker seldom understood why production mattered, aside from making distant people rich and for hanging on to his job. This made the worker ignorant.

Workers lost sight of economics. A shoe-maker (*cobbler* in the old days) understood the economic value of his profession: He purchased leather and other supplies from traders, he worked with customers to deliver the best shoe he could for their money. He understood making compromises on products because the customer could afford no better and that something was better than nothing. The factory worker understood none of this, unless he or she went out of their way to find understanding.

But worse than economic ignorance was the fact that the workers became ignorant of the world in general. They obtained a job through the help of a friend or relative, learned only that specialty, showed-up to work every day, purchased a house, sent their children to the local school, imbibed mindless entertainment… and precious little else. They did not know how the world worked, how humanity had arrived at its present state, or what the principles of civilization might be.

If they had some understanding of the whole, rather that one isolated fraction, they would have been able to see the gaps in their knowledge and could have filled them. But size ruined their view, and they became knowledgeable only in a small sliver of the whole and ignorant of the rest. This, of course, made them easy to manipulate. They had no way to tell if the manipulator was describing the world correctly or not.

Perhaps the worst part of this was the death of moral understanding caused by factory organizations. As we explained in chapter nine, the human inability to hold more than about 150 identities required that de-personalized controls were involved. Rules were defined and enforced, with no explanation attached. "The office says we have to do it this way," was an ever-so-common phrase in industrial production. People were told *what* to do, but they were not told *why* to do it. In fact, explanation was specifically avoided, since it wasted time on long arguments. It was inefficient. Inside the factory, the higher levels dictated and the lower levels obeyed – understanding and reasons were discouraged, if not

forbidden. The end result of this was that understanding was not often sought. Things were "good" or "bad" because someone in a high position said so. Reasons were non-essential.

This was a massive change. As mentioned previously, commentaries on the common law were popular reading prior to the industrial revolution. People judged themselves competent to decide and to understand what was right or wrong, and to debate the reasons. After a few generations of factory-style living, this pattern was broken. The phrase, "You're not qualified to think" may have been used in humor, but it was used often.

The effect of state schooling on this change cannot be over-estimated. Schools were specifically designed to eliminate questioning and to instill blind obedience to authority. This is death to critical reasoning. Given the current (2009) near-deification of "education," it seems sensible to devote half a page toward establishing the point a bit further. Here are a few statements from key players within the state school system:

> *Ninety-nine [students] out of a hundred are automata, careful to walk in prescribed paths, careful to follow the prescribed custom. This is not an accident but the result of substantial education, which, scientifically defined, is the subsumption of the individual.*
> -- William Torrey Harris, US Commissioner of Education, 1906

> *In our dreams, people yield themselves with perfect docility to our molding hands. The present education conventions of intellectual and character education fade from their minds and unhampered by tradition we work our own good will upon a grateful and responsive folk.*
> -- The General Education Board, 1906

> *Educating the individual is but a means to the true end of education, which is to create a viable social order to which individuals contribute and by which they are sustained. 'Family choice' is, therefore, basically selfish and anti-social in that it focuses on the 'wants' of a single family rather than the 'needs' of society.*
> -- Association of California School Administrators

> *Parents give up their rights when they drop the children off at public school.*
> -- Judge Melinda Harmon, 1996, ruling against parents who sued a Texas School District for strip-searching their child.

The crucial aspect of compulsory education is that it forces children - at their most vulnerable and impressionable stages – to sit in a room, exposed to intentionally-designed conditioning, for the majority of their conscious time. School literally dominates their minds and their development for their entire youth. And it is a process designed to produce automatons, as was honestly expressed by the Commissioner of Education in 1906[121].

In brief, children in schools are taught to obey rather than to question, to repeat rather than to think[122]. Unless of exceptionally strong character, they fail to develop skills for judging; they seek the opinion of authority rather than performing independent analysis. This is the foundation for much of the present time's moral relativism. Since so many people no longer had skills for judging right and wrong, it was easy and natural for the idea to arise that "there really is no right or wrong." Similar ideas have always existed, but they very seldom found fertile ground. In this situation, they did.

LOGIC FAILS

An important area of decline has been in critical reasoning skills. This has been broadly noted and a few organizations have even been trying to address it, but the ability of the average modern person to reason carefully is considerably worse now than it was a hundred years ago. A review of schoolbooks and newspapers from the mid-19th Century usually illustrates the point quite well. The study of logic (non-contradiction) is completely absent from almost all state educational courses and shows up in college only as an elective. Basic ironies and self-contradictions are never noticed by most people.

When logic is gone, people tend to form opinions based upon emotion and their identification with famous persons and groups. This is extremely dangerous. The worst actions of history have been performed

[121] At some point in the future, people will look back at this with horror. Right now, the majority avoids such thoughts, since almost all are guilty of feeding their children into the system or at least of praising it. But at some point (which may still be a considerable distance in the future), the self-enforcing cult of denial will break.

[122] Certainly there are a number of excellent, dedicated teachers within the state schooling system. Unfortunately, the system works against them, as they will generally admit. These teachers most certainly do some good, but not only are there many others who do not produce as well, but the system wears all of them down over time. Over and beyond this, the ambient curriculum is far more continuous than the occasionally excellent teacher. This curriculum remains constant from kindergarten through high school (and beyond), punishing independent thought and rewarding mindless obedience.

by groups of people who chose not to think and to ignore reality. This affects the West in myriad ways – making every complex interaction between human minds more difficult, more problematic, and more frustrating.

Of special danger is that a lack of logic removes restrictions upon political leaders, especially "charismatic" ones. As mentioned above, logic's absence leaves emotion and attachment to operate unsupervised. This is how dictators come into power and this is how a populace does things that their grandchildren remain embarrassed about into the following century.

SURPLUS PRODUCTION

In all successful civilizations, the production and use of surplus has been crucial. We have seen that as surplus remains in the hands of the people who created it, civilizations arise and grow in a more or less distributed fashion. We have also seen that when surplus is redirected to a central point, the civilization begins on a downward path. This pattern held in Mesopotamia, Greece, Rome and in many others.

In like manner, the crucial step in the decline of Western civilization was the forcible re-routing of surplus away from the producers and to centralized governments. Before World War One, surplus production in the West generally remained in the hands of those who produced it. From a modern perspective, we would say it this way: *In the 19th Century, it was normal for people to accumulate money.* After 1914 this changed very quickly and surplus was immediately gathered and transferred to central governments all through the West. The primary instrument of this transfer, of course, was the income tax. There have been other direct taxes, but none comparable in scope.

Before the income tax, young men would go out to "make their fortune."[123] They would go to where money was being made, work hard, cooperate with similar young men, learn everything they could from the older men, save, invest, learn how to succeed, then return home as a prosperous adult[124]. This was certainly not a universal activity, but it was

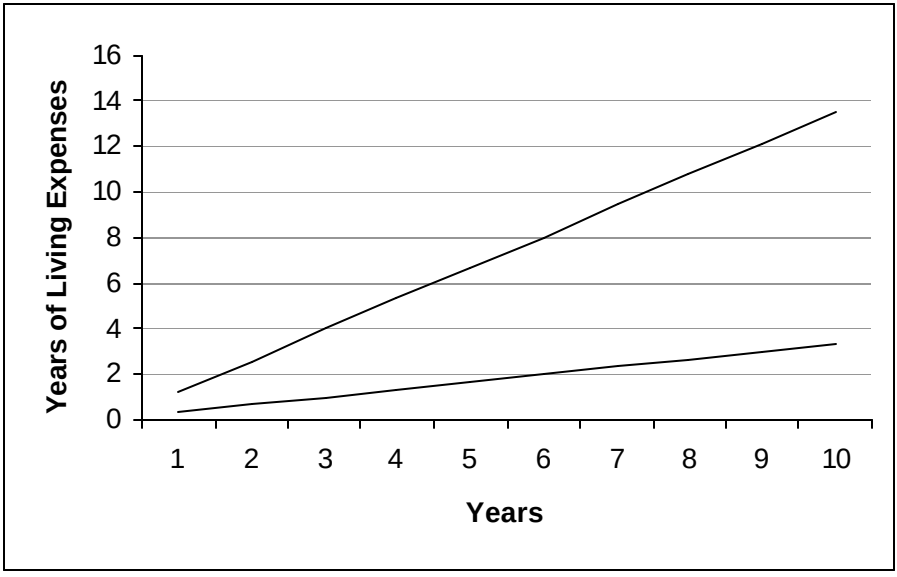
[123] Fortune never really meant multiple billions; it meant enough money in the bank to provide capital and safety for the rest of your life.

[124] This was actually a very healthy mating strategy, and was completely undermined by the rerouting of surplus from the producer to the capital city. As the strategy failed in the 1920s and 30s, people busied themselves finding ways to criticize it, since they could no longer live up to it and didn't wish to be compared to people who had. They needed reasons to condemn it, and, as

quite common, and very often expected of the young man by his own family and by young women.

In the modern world, everyone's fortune is taxed away as it is being formed, and very few of us are able to accumulate money. Prior to World War One, it was the opposite: Surplus mostly remained in the hands of those who produced it, and it was not transferred to a central government.

The graph below shows how this affected people. It contrasts the amount of money a hard-working young man could save in 1890 with the savings of an identical young man in 2008. Notice the left-hand (vertical) scale: Years of living expenses retained. The horizontal scale shows merely the number of years[125].



The top line is the young man of 1890, the bottom line is the young man of 2008.

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usual, clever people found ways to do so, frequently becoming popular for their efforts. Recently-lost virtues must be popularly condemned.

[125] The numbers were generated as follows: $725. per year is the income in 1890, based upon previous discussions with men who lived through the time. The 1890 figure of $325. for living expenses is taken from a New York Times article, dated 29 September, 1907. Assets were presumed to appreciate at 10% per year. For 2008 the annual income is $45,000 and monthly expenses were $2,000. This young man pays 30% income taxes and investment return is calculated at a reduced rate of 8.5% because of taxes upon interest. The young man of 1890 is investing $400./year against living expenses of $325. His 2008 descendent is investing $7500./year against living expenses of $24,000.

But at the end of five years, the young man of 1890 has about seven years of living expenses saved, while his great-grandson of 2008 has less than two. After eight years, great-grandpa has eleven years of living expenses in the bank and his descendant has less than three years worth. This illustrates an important point regarding surplus: The income tax moved almost all surplus to central governments, and left precious little in the hands of producers. In fact, the withholding tax removed the surplus of every working man before he ever held it in his hands.

Consider the effects: The young man of 1890 had money in the bank. First of all, he knew that hard work paid-off and he knew that he was capable of it. Secondly, he had security. Thirdly, he had money to invest in projects that he thought would be successful or that he thought were important. Contrast that with the factory worker who lives paycheck-to-paycheck, doesn't know how to do anything saleable except his one highly-specialized job that is only of value to a single employer. These are radically different positions in which to live. The first is healthy, the second is much less so.

The man of 1890 had a solid base, from which to act in the Western tradition and "take things upon himself." The factory worker of the industrial era had a fragile and broken base – one misstep and he was fully vulnerable. As a result, he took orders and not risks.

One notable area where this is seen: In the era when men kept their surplus, great museums were founded by and financed by highly successful men. Museums of modern times are generally financed by giant corporate (most often financial) and government institutions.

This forcible removal of surplus was a crucial step, and one that is difficult to over-state: *It destroyed the expansion mechanism of Western civilization.*

By the mid-20th Century, Western civilization no longer functioned in its traditional form. Many aspects of the culture continued, but its core economic principle had been replaced with an opposing principle.

It may seem overly dramatic to say that direct taxation (such as the income tax) destroyed Western civilization, but the statement is not particularly far from the truth. Through the 19th Century, surplus capital was gathered from productive enterprises and remained in the hands of those who had produced it. These people were far more likely than anyone else to know how to use this capital effectively. And, in fact, the

great expansions of the 19th Century attest to the fact[126]. Once annual income was taxed, however, the surplus was removed to capital cities and spent erratically by politicians, and only after it was filtered through a rapidly growing bureaucracy.

From the time permanent income taxes were instituted (1914 in the US), a new surplus mechanism operated. This mechanism soon brought very nearly all surplus into central governments, and spent it from there. The mechanism of Western civilization was abandoned and changed. Without returning to it or replacing it with something better, Western civilization *will* end.

THE MAGIC MONEY MECHANISM

Prior to the First World War, money in the West was gold, silver or other metals that were inherently valuable. The various paper currencies that circulated were actually just receipts for these metals. The few un-backed currencies that were tried generally became famous for their worthlessness, such as the Continental Currency in the U.S. ("Not worth a Continental.") After 1914, however, the West changed-over to national currencies controlled by central banks.

The mechanics of the changeover, the reasons for it, and complexities of how money is created under the new system are the subject of many other texts and are not central to this discussion, so we will pass over the subject, interesting and important though it may be. What is critical here are two facts:

1. The currency was partly (and later fully) disconnected from actual value. The prestige of the state replaced the value of gold and silver.

2. The currency was not only controlled, but created at will, by politicians and by bankers very closely associated with them.

From 1914 onward, currency could be manipulated, and it was. Schools of economics[127] arose to examine how currency could be used in the new

[126] There are volumes to be added here regarding the common slanders against the 19th Century and its economics, but I must leave them aside. One notable falsity should be mentioned and rebutted, however: It is often said that state financing is required for the largest ventures and that Laissez-Faire fails in this regard. The construction of the Great Northern Railway, by James J. Hill displays the falsity of this claim, in that it was a trans-continental railway constructed entirely with private funding.

[127] Most notably that of John Maynard Keynes.

system where it was simply created by a central bank. This did have limits however, since it was partially tied to gold. In 1971, however, the tie to gold was fully broken for the US dollar, and most currencies of the world became nothing but fiat currencies: They have value only because people think that they have value and because it is legally required to use them[128].

From 1971 onward, currency was available to legislatures upon demand. There was the problem of inflation to face on occasion[129], and the problem of massive national debts (still not faced as of this writing), but the ability to create currency became the great supercharger of the late 20th Century; the great tool of politicians that enabled them to promise and spend money on a scale previously unimagined.

CAPITALISM WITHOUT CAPITAL

> *This is a staggering thought. We are completely dependent upon the commercial banks. Someone has to borrow every dollar we have in circulation, cash or credit. If the banks create amply synthetic money, we are prosperous. If not, we starve. We are, absolutely, without a permanent money system. When one gets a complete grasp of the picture, the tragic absurdity of our hopeless position is almost incredible, but there it is.*
> -- Robert H. Hemphill, Credit Manager, the Federal Reserve Bank of Atlanta.

This is a strange idea for those who have not studied it, but the quote above is true, and all modern money is debt. Properly, your dollar bills are debt tokens. That has made no obvious difference in the lives of Westerners of the 20th and early 21st Centuries (after all, trading these debt tokens to the baker will still get you a loaf of bread), but it matters in many subtle ways and will matter in overt ways at some point in the future.

With surplus removed from individuals, all investment capital is forced through institutions. Money was not saved and invested, it was obtained through banks. In this way, finance was centralized, and removed from the hands of individuals.

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[128] By Legal Tender laws.

[129] Aside from the problems of rising prices following large creations of currency, inflation is a stealth tax, removing roughly 95% of the value of savings over a life-span.

Your local bank may not be a direct organ of your government, but it is chartered by a central government, overseen by a government, audited and managed by government employees and subject not only to every new law, but to having their right to operate revoked at any time. Central governments, by the mid 20th Century, controlled very nearly all investment capital.

The effects of this were many, but large among them is the fact that it gave the state a monopoly on one of the primary means of production, having taken it from the laboring man. In the 19th Century it was very common for a farmer or a mechanic to amass capital and to make loans to people he knew and trusted. Since these people lived in close proximity to each other, they knew who could use the capital well and who could not. This set of interactions was never perfect (as human dealings never are), but it was healthy in many important ways, including economic efficiency and personal virtue. The removal of the surplus capital into central institutions beggared the farmer and the mechanic. In the 20th Century, their children would shuffle into banks and beg for loans. It was the centralization of surplus that did this to the working man, and not one in a thousand understands it.

LOSS OF CONFIDENCE

One of the more widespread characteristics of Western life at this moment is that so many people in the West have no confidence in their culture. The schools and the mass media seek and promote discussion of Western Civilization's flaws and are especially eager to imply crimes to it. Primitive civilizations are portrayed as better, more "authentic," and far more noble.

Explaining the reasons for this is certainly beyond the scope of this text, but they are important and we will itemize a few:

- The reactionary hatred of the modern and preference for the primitive caused by the Industrial Revolution. (As mentioned in chapter 9.) A primary transmission path for such ideas has been Rouseau's "myth of the noble savage," also championed and passed-down by Margaret Meade and like-minded social scientists.

- The championing of equality as the primary virtue[130]. If equality is *the* virtue, and if the West is richer and lives better than the rest of the world, then the West must have done something bad. They are not equal and the obvious conclusion – if equality is righteousness - must be that the West is guilty of stealing from the rest of the world.

- Fear of envy. Fear of envy ("the evil eye") is an ancient superstition, and has had strength through hundreds of generations. In some primitive cultures, mothers publicly cry out about the ugliness of their newborn child, to keep envious spirits away. These mothers, like all mothers, have quite opposite feelings, but they do this out of fear: If they have something great and beautiful, some invisible force is going to get them. These impulses still exist, and still have effects, although dressed in modern clothing, so to speak.

But, for whichever reasons, the West lost its courage at approximately World War One. Sensitive commentators at the time (such as Virginia Wolfe) made note of it.

One interesting effect of lost courage regards the names of places. During the 19th Century, places were most commonly named after great men. Since the mid-20th Century, they are normally named after trees, birds, or local geographic features such as hills, lakes, and so on. The West is embarrassed of its great men, and would rather avoid their mention and honor animals instead.

THE NEW TEMPLE OF RIGHTEOUSNESS

> *Increasingly, politics is not about "who gets what, when, how" but about values, each of them considered to be absolute. Politics is about "the right to life"...It is about the environment. It is about gaining equality for groups alleged to be oppressed...None of these issues is economic. All are fundamentally moral.*
> -- Peter Drucker

We began this chapter by discussing the joining of righteousness and force. The end result of this has been the evolution of politics as the

[130] Properly called *egalitarianism*, this concerns not equal standing in law but equality in results and living standards.

great forge of morality. As Peter Drucker says above, people see politics as the process that forges final judgments as to what is or is not moral. Political processes have become the temples of righteousness.

Numerous factors had led into this:

- The most active people have taken their moral fights exclusively into the realm of politics and state force.
- Religion – the traditional place of moral teaching and debate - has generally receded in popularity and esteem.
- The central government became the law-giver.
- The central government became the seat of financial power.
- Central power has been legitimized under democracy. Under Monarchy, there was less of a cloak for state actions; an individual human (king or prince) acted and bore responsibility for decisions that did not turn out well. Under representative democracy, decisions are made by hundreds of people, each elected by the people. And, in most cases, bad decisions are blamed on opposing parties, with no blame falling upon the state itself.

In short, the state has become the organization that decides upon morality and punishes or rewards it accordingly. It is no stretch to say that the state has taken over many of the attributes of a deity to its citizens. In Rome, the ruler became a god; in the 20th Century the state attained the attributes of deity, but not the name. The differences are less in substance and more in form. Fiscal power has left the individual and accrued to the state; moral judgments have been given up by most individuals and have been taken-over by the state. We may not say "Hail Caesar," but both our power and our virtue has been handed to a centralized state as much as that of the Romans. Our attempts at centralization will work no better than theirs did.

SUMMARY

Several main points have been made in this chapter regarding the decline of Western Civilization and its inevitable dissolution if it continues on this course. In order to make the case clearly, we will recap the central issues and elaborate a bit here:

- Surplus production, by the middle of the 20th Century, was sent directly to the national capital, for redistribution. This removed it

from the hands of the producers and mostly away from local governments. The honorable working man had his strength and honor taken from him.

- A mechanism for creating currency at zero cost was established, replacing the actual value of metals with the honor of the state. Money is created with debt and this new type of currency has been instituted throughout the West. The new debt currency was manipulated by politicians and bankers aligned with them and stretched far beyond limits.
- Finance became centralized and run through a very few financial centers which were almost completely under the control and oversight of central governments.
- So long as standards of living rose, centralized control was accepted by most people, who had lost their ability and courage to judge.
- Never, in the history of the world, has such financial surplus been wasted in a more complete manner. The governments of the West have spent all the surplus they removed from their people and are massively in debt beside.
- The seat of legitimacy – law – has been conquered by central governments. Law was previously independent of rulers and above them. With the advent of legislation it was taken over by the governments, who now create law, rather than being subservient to it. The state replaced the law as the seat of sovereignty.
- With the advent of democracy, legislation was legitimized. Further, blame for failed policies was divided and muted, since there were always opposing parties to blame and because the policy-makers were elected by the people. Blame was diffused. Esteem for the state reached what were probably the highest levels in history.
- Much of the populace has lost its initiative, which was the original kernel of Western Civilization. People have been scientifically conditioned to obey rather than to question, to repeat rather than to think. Furthermore, the time that they might spend on learning and in building virtues is mostly spent upon

empty entertainments. The old way of individual courage, virtue and initiative is routinely punished.

- The most morally active people in the West have adopted a strategy of enforcing their righteousness upon others via the coercive power of the state. Political process thus became the center of morality. Morality was merged with state.
- The state greatly increased its share of involvement in daily life. Government regulations concern nearly every product bought or sold and nearly every area of daily life. It became difficult to exclude government from any area of one's life[131].
- The inescapable modernism of the Industrial Revolution led to many reactionary movements, some of which remain.
- The West has given up the philosophy of their founding. Christianity has been largely abandoned and the crucial portions of the Christian philosophy that informed Western Civilization have not been replaced with equally useful concepts.

This situation cannot last. It will not last. Every other time this pattern has been seen, it has led to collapse and to four centuries of dark ages.

Either the West changes or the West eventually fails. We will examine patterns of failure in Chapter Twelve, but regardless of the specific dates and details, the West will either recover itself, probably with grave difficulty and with blood, or it will be overrun.

THE FOUNDERS ARE NOW CRIMINALS

> *It used to be the boast of free men that, so long as they kept within the bounds of the known law, there was no need to ask anybody's permission or to obey anybody's orders. It is doubtful whether any of us can make this claim today.*
> -- Friedrich Hayek

Hayek, one of the greatest thinkers of the 20th Century, wrote this decades ago, and was entirely correct even then. "Taking it upon yourself" is now illegal. Consider:

[131] Surveillance, which we have yet to cover, is making this much worse.

- Peter Abelard would last on a modern university campus for as long as it took security to show up and remove him. Teaching students with no up-to-date certification? No tenure? No authorization? They would, quite literally, eject him from the campus. If he persisted, criminal charges would be filed.

- The honest and virtuous judges of the Vehm would be given enormous prison sentences. All forms of surveillance would be used against them and the public would be continually told that they were ruling through terror. Before long, there would be a tremendous outcry for them to be hunted, arrested and imprisoned.

- The Hansa would be indicted for smuggling, running criminal enterprises, tax evasion and money laundering. Plea bargains would be arranged to obtain incriminating facts. Every bit of their property would be confiscated. The states that imprisoned them would use the Hansa's boats to patrol the coasts for any "immoral smugglers" that remained.

- The judges of the Law Merchant courts would be arrested for practicing law without a license, operating courts outside of the national legal systems and for breaking many specific regulations. It is doubtful that they could last a month operating openly.

- Watt would never have found financiers who deeply believed in him and would endure the ten years and many failures that were required. No modern financial institution would allow the loans to remain outstanding. Watt would not have developed the steam engine.

- Thomas Jefferson and John Hancock would have been arrested on July 5th.

It is clear that the values of the founders are no longer permissible in the West. The Romans, in an analogous time, complained that their people had lost their hardness, their courage and their virtues.

The decline of the West is in full force, and will remain so until founders are no longer criminals. Such men are present in every age. In some times, they are grudgingly left alone to operate. In other times, such as ours, they are intimidated, chased away, or locked-up.

11

A Chance For Renewal

Freedom arises from within the individual: either you are determined to be free, in which case you have grasped the essential tool of your liberty, or not. Nobody else can free you; you must free yourself, if you mean to be free.
- Jim Davidson

The people of the West have a chance to prevent the fall of their civilization, but it will require individual action. This was the original core of the West and it must be returned to if the West is to change course. Complaining about politicians and bureaucrats will not be sufficient. Either the people of the West will get up and build something better or their civilization will fall.

This statement that the West will fail is not hyperbole, it is a simple conclusion to a simple pattern. When a civilization's method of expansion is changed, when centralization and complexity are imposed upon a populace, when the virtues and courage that started their civilization fade away, that civilization fails. The process is not fast, but it is consistent. It has happened many times before and it will happen this time as well, if the people of the West let it. The process is underway; it can be stopped, but stopping it will require sacrifice[132].

[132] The word, "sacrifice" has been much abused, and is often problematic. I use it here because it is the best way to make my point. I am not talking about people contributing to some collective; I am talking about them suffering for their virtues, at the hand of one collective or another.

This will not occur top-down, for the simple reason that the West was not formed that way[133]. There is no leader that will save the people of the West from their decline. That is an illusion, and often a cowardly one. Appeals to central power will not diminish central power. Either millions of individuals take it upon themselves to act or the decline will continue.

At one time, people in the West learned to believe strongly in true and necessary ideas and to act alone. They gained these lessons from the examples of Abraham, Moses, Jesus and other traditional heroes. The crucial question by which history judges the current members of Western civilization may be this: *How many people are still capable of independent action?*

All that said, there has been progress made toward renewal, to which we now turn our attention.

DECENTRALIZING TECHNOLOGIES

> *A new civilization is emerging in our lives, and blind men everywhere are trying to suppress it.*
> -- Alvin Toffler, *The Third Wave*

The transistor and the integrated circuit have changed the world and continue to change the world, primarily in that they enable modern information technologies. Because information can now be assembled and distributed in massive amounts and in unlimited ways, centralization has ceased to be necessary in many applications. This does not mean that decentralization has gained in all areas of life – it is, after all, forbidden by law in many applications – but where decentralization has not yet been forbidden, it has gained.

Primarily, decentralization has occurred in commercial settings, where economies of scale are slipping and standardization and specialization are no longer as essential for manufacturing. More information means that less people and things need to be present at the same places and times.

The greatest decentralizing technology, rather obviously, has been the Internet, which allowed hundreds of millions of people to communicate person-to-person, with no gatekeeper or central switch required. The Internet was decentralized by design, and has grown spontaneously. It was not planned by central governments; it was built by scattered

[133] It is also true that leaders are empowered by the system as it is and will consistently favor more centralization and oppose renewal, but the crucial issue is that a decentralized design requires each of the distributed nodes to contribute.

enthusiasts who jointly contributed what they could and turned it from a small, decommissioned government system into a radical, new, world-wide communication system without precedent.

In many ways, the Internet became *the* technology of free thought, free communication, and progress. The governments of the world are desperately trying to reign it back in, but the Internet has survived and may continue to survive.

The sharing of knowledge between scattered people has been of tremendous importance, but there are many other ways in which its effects have been important, some of which are these:

Reducing the life-span of bad information: Because information on the Internet is open to all, manias play from end-to-end much more quickly; people who can poke holes in wild theories are able to jump-in and do so. Even news from "respectable sources" is torn apart by individuals. Bad information often lasts only days or hours on the Internet. At many other times in history it lasted for years and sometimes for centuries. Now, ideas are tested much more rapidly, and truth better secured.

Replacing a few gatekeepers with peer-review: While the Internet allows an unlimited number of small silly voices, it also tends to suppress large, silly voices. When there were limited information sources (before the Internet), once a silly voice got past the gatekeepers, it could go big, but this does not happen on the Internet, where communication is decentralized – going multiple ways, not from a center to all others – and where every person can comment on everyone else's ideas. Big media had gatekeepers. New media has peer-review.

The correction and improvement of ideas: It is important that ideas are tried, contrasted, extended, defended, absolved and convicted. This is how the best ideas are discovered, in exactly the same way as the best commercial products are discovered via competition. The anonymity provided by the Internet is especially important in this regard, as it allows people to put ideas

forward without suffering public shame[134]. The fear of ridicule may keep some silly things out of the public square, but it also means that bad ideas will probably remain in people's minds, freezing them in an unimproved state.

Providing recordings of events: Now that many events are recorded and distributed, wild interpretations and exaggerated reporting are torn-apart by video review. Considering the immense harm that has been inflicted upon people due to stretched truths and mythologies based upon them, this is an important thing.

The disarming of collective identities: A "collective identity" is a single identity applied to a large number of individuals. The use of collective identities ("It's the fault of the Gypsies!") has led to the worst crimes in history. By using the Internet, people can actually get to know the outsiders that their older relatives merely assumed were bad: "No, Grandpa, I talk to a Gypsy all the time. I'm sure some of them are bad, but not all of them! My friend is a good person."

"I'm not the only crazy one": Many people who held true but unpopular ideas have felt entirely isolated, not really believing that anyone else held similar ideas. The Internet has allowed many of these people to find each other, rather than leaving them forever wondering whether they were the only crazy ones. They can compare their ideas with those of others, sharpen them, and, hopefully, begin to use them.

Critical thinking returns: As people compare ideas more and more (rather than repeating as they have been told) reason and critical analysis become more important,

[134] Anonymity allows people to expose ideas to the world with no path back to them for recrimination. This makes correction and growth far less risky, which is superbly important. Bad ideas are attacked quite well anyway, and the improvements allowed in hundreds of millions of minds are far more valuable than the few associated costs.

and learning to think straight is something that more people do.

FROM ONE VOICE TO MANY

> *We don't tell people what to think – we tell them what to think about.*
> *-- Michael Gartner, President of NBC News*

Through the 1970s, a large majority of news stories in the United States found their origin within only two zip codes of New York City. The owners and operators of ABC, NBC, CBS, the New York Times and other minor players all shared the same small physical space and the same small world-view, with almost no variation. The American people asked few questions– they respected largeness and centralization.

In the early 1980s, however, cable television began to provide alternative sources. The draw of having twenty or thirty stations rather than only three or four was obvious and cable TV became financially successful. Soon there were hundreds of stations and the original national networks were facing difficulties. People had many choices for information and were walking away from the networks.

By the end of the 1980s, talk radio was springing up. Political discussion on these shows was far more in-depth than anything on the networks, whom they usually opposed quite directly. Talk radio was more interesting as well.

What we might call "Talk Radio Conservatism" is in many ways similar to classical liberalism, and while it is prone to flying off in odd directions from time to time, it includes a huge number of people who are thinking about current events and even about philosophies. Those who hold the remnants of America's founding ideology are often devotees of talk radio. It is from such people that movements forward sometimes occur. Most of these people believe in self-responsibility, putting them more in the camp of those who built Western Civilization than in the camp of those who are disassembling it.

Cable television, with its multiplied sources of information, has been adopted nearly world-wide. Talk radio, however, remains primarily an American phenomenon. But, the general effect is important almost everywhere. And, on the heels of this came the Internet, adding innumerable more voices to the mix. The days of a single set of voices informing everyone have ended. The quality and distribution of these new voices has been erratic, but the simple fact of their existence matters

a great deal. By itself, this is not nearly enough to stem the downward move of Western Civilization (these are groups of people being talked-to, and not people acting), but it certainly helps.

Another American phenomenon that is spreading to other places is home schooling. By teaching their children at home, parents not only remove their children from enforced conditioning, but they educate them better than state schools do[135]. According to the U.S. Department of Education, 1.5 million American children were home schooled in 2007, up 74% over four years, although it is certain that the actual number is higher than this official figure[136]. Even so, the 1.5 million figure signifies that almost 3% of American children are home schooled. Reliable figures on children home schooled world-wide are hard to obtain, but it appears that the number of children home schooled in other countries equals the number of those in the U.S.

In addition to home schooling, state schools are being generally abandoned by those who are able to do so[137]. The educational establishment is in no danger of cracking, simply because its funding is involuntary, and continues whether people like it or not. Nonetheless, those people who can are very often avoiding it. Almost no one believes that state schools are the best choice for their children.

With each family that chooses home schooling, each parent that carefully involves himself or herself in their child's education, each parent who chooses to instill his or her personal ethics into their child rather than leaving it to the schools, uniform conditioning fades. With each drop in network TV ratings, with each percentage increase of people who get their news from Internet sites, centralization and conformity decline. These are hopeful developments.

THE FLYNN EFFECT

The Flynn effect is the rise of average IQ scores over generations. This effect has observed in most parts of the world over the past few

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[135] Numerous studies have been undertaken, nearly all of which show home educated children out-performing children educated in state schools by a wide margin.

[136] A significant number of home school families avoid all reporting to governments. The Home School Legal Defense Association places the number at 2.1 million.

[137] "Those able to do so" are those who are able to pay double for their children's education. The state taxes them to pay for the government's educational system, whether they use it or not. Paying for a private school is to pay a second time: the first time involuntarily, the second willingly.

generations, although it does vary. James Flynn, a professor of Political Studies at the University of Otago in New Zealand was the first to recognize this and to write about it.

IQ tests are re-normalized periodically, so that the average score always remains 100. Revisions to these tests have surprisingly shown an average rate of rise of around three IQ points per decade. Numerous reasons and explanations have been proposed for this, especially among academics who seem troubled by it. One early explanation was that IQs were rising, since "schools are so much better now." This has turned out to be false, since scores related to school content (vocabulary, arithmetic, general information) show small gains and even occasional declines. The largest Flynn effects appear instead in general mental processing abilities.

It is likely that the Flynn effect can be attributed to improved nutrition allowing brains to develop better than in the past. But, this too is uncertain, and arguments are also made for adaptations to the modern world's more mentally demanding environment.

The importance of the Flynn effect is that faster thinking allows people to see through false arguments and manipulations more easily. This matters, for example, when a speaker moves quickly through unsupported statements, not giving the listener enough time to consider any deeper than the surface layer of the argument – a common method of manipulation. Intelligence is useful in many ways, but crucial in only a few. In most areas of life, the slower thinker can accomplish the same results as the faster thinker, albeit over a few extra seconds. When time limits are imposed, however – as in the fast-speaking example – speed matters. The fast thinker may be able to see through unsupported statements, while the slower thinker may not. The inability to analyze at speed, combined with some basic intimidation, leads people to simply accept lies as truth. The general line of thinking is this: *The statements made some sense on the surface and other people nodded their heads in agreement, therefore I should accept them.*

To some unknown but probably significant extent, the Flynn effect makes manipulation harder. The Flynn effect can be overcome by restricting information and by imposing extra intimidation, but it remains a positive development.

NEW PHILOSOPHIES

> *There are only two means by which men can deal with one another: Guns or logic. Force or persuasion.*
> -- Ayn Rand

By the mid 20th Century, a number of new philosophies began to develop. Because of the great diversities among them, they are hard to categorize, except perhaps to call them "pro-liberty." The earliest of these were people who wished to hold on to classical liberalism, a philosophy that was replaced with Progressivism, quite its opposite. Classical liberalism was the predominant philosophy of the 19th Century, focused around laissez-faire capitalism and human liberty, and taken from the ideas of men such as John Stewart Mill, Adam Smith and John Locke. It was similar in many ways to modern Libertarianism.

A major point in the development of counter-philosophies to the centralization and uniformity of the 20th Century was in 1943, when three women combined to give the modern liberty movement a set of foundations. In that year, Rose Wilder Lane published *The Discovery Of Freedom*, Isabel Patterson published *The God Of The Machine*, and Ayn Rand published *The Foutainhead.* All three are still in print, now sixty six years later; one or all of which have influenced nearly every pro-liberty thinker since that time.

Following 1943, works promoting liberty and opposing what is now called *Statism* continued. Economists like Frederich Hayek, Ludwig von Mises, Murray Rothbard and Milton Freidman produced a huge body of work, and many others contributed greatly in fields ranging from law to psychology. Many of the best science fiction works portrayed the future as embodying a pro-liberty philosophy of one sort or another.

At various times, movements have come out of this general freedom philosophy, often to fracture and fade. But the philosophy remains, and it routinely attracts many of the best human minds. What will develop from this, if anything, is uncertain, but there is now a great body of information on the subject for anyone who seeks it.

NEW NATIONS, CYPHERPUNKS AND ANARCHOCAPITALISM

A great number of people, reading the literature mentioned above, have sought new territory in which to live their own way, leaving the state behind. If these people were living in the 17th Century, they would be boarding boats to the New World. Stuck in the 20th Century, however,

with no open territory to go to, they dreamt of beginning new nations. In fact, some of the more entertaining stories from the 20th Century involved people who tried to buy, rent or steal territories from existing states and to start new nations. None have ultimately succeeded[138], which is actually a grand indictment of the modern system of states: people who are desperate to separate themselves and try a new thing are forbidden from doing so. Escape is not permitted.

The failure of a long line of new nation projects did not, however, stop new pro-liberty people from wanting a place to run away to. And, at the end of the 20th Century, they got something of a chance, as the Internet opened a new territory of sorts to them. Very quickly, groups known as *Cypherpunks* began building enclaves on the Internet that were protected by encryption, much as city walls might have protected them from threats several hundred years earlier. In the course of time, the set of ideas that began with the Cypherpunks became a more organized set of ideas called *Cryptoanarchy.*

Cryptoanarchy is, at its base, an effort for people to separate their lives from all outside interference, or at least for as much of their lives as can be conducted over the Internet or other communication systems. Cryptoanarchists want to communicate, buy and sell with no person, state or group watching and/or interfering. All of this can be accomplished reasonably well with cryptography. Quite a few individuals and companies have been using these technologies for years, although the name, Cryptoanarchy, is seldom attached.

One important and unusual thing about Cryptoanarchy is that – unlike many other new ideas – it does not seek to change the state or to gain any involvement in politics; it attempts simply to leave them behind. These ideas and technologies are not reform movements, they are secession movements. They seek to build over and around the existing systems of the world, and not to take them over and order them aright. This is a fundamental difference, and one that puts them squarely in line with the founders of Western Civilization.

The final philosophy to come from this line of development is called *Anarchocapitalism*[139], which is the general theory that all coercion – even the coercion of the state – is immoral, and that all men should be left alone unless they engage in force, fraud or similar forms of aggression

[138] Though a new type of effort, called *Seasteading,* does show promise. www.seasteading.org

[139] Also called Free Market Anarchy.

against other humans or their property. There are many variations of this philosophy, but all generally hold to a core moral concept of non-aggression.

Of great interest regarding Anarchocapitalism is that it calls for a fully decentralized arrangement for human society. This is an essential attribute in times of failing centralization. When Rome fell, the things that had been done centrally collapsed, such as trade, and it was a long time before they were restored. With ideas like those of the Anarchocapitalsists in place, however, even if centralization does fail, there will be people who are prepared to take up the necessary functions that fail with it. People bearing such ideas might be able to shorten a dark age considerably, or at least to create pockets of sanity in the midst of it.

It is worth taking a moment to explain the word "anarchy" in the names above. This is a word that is routinely misunderstood and mischaracterized, primarily because of violent anarchist groups that gained attention during the Progressive Era. "Anarchy" simply means "without a ruler." It does not mean "without rules," and it certainly does not imply bomb-throwing. There are socialist anarchist groups who endorse violence, but they are, in many ways, the opposite of anarcho-capitalists. But, again, we are in danger of straying from our subject matter and will leave this line of discourse.

The important thing about all of these philosophies is that they are clearly throw-backs to the beginning of Western Civilization, when people simply took responsibility upon themselves and built things they thought they needed. People who want to start new nations and who want to build crypto-tools are clearly seeking to take responsibility upon themselves and to create a better world. People who spend years of their lives developing better philosophies for humanity are precisely the same types of people as Thomas Jefferson, John Adams and James Monroe, the overly-studious men who laid the moral foundations of the American Revolution.

THE FIGHT FOR HONEST MONEY

> *The study of money, above all other fields in economics, is one in which complexity is used to disguise truth or to evade truth, not to reveal it.*
> -- John Kenneth Galbraith

Those few people who have studied money, currency and central banking are generally horrified by what they find… if, indeed, they are lucky

enough or tenacious enough to find solid information on the subject. Once, however, they come to grips with what they have found, they tend to oppose fiat currencies and central banking vehemently. Many of these people have taken it upon themselves to either return to honest money, or to create honest money themselves[140]. This, again, puts them back with founders of Western Civilization, and not with the operators of states and fiat currencies.

Ever since paper currencies have existed, some people have been complaining about them and demanding a return to gold or silver as money. These movements rise and fall from time to time, but always seem to continue. They showed surprising reach during the 2008 Presidential candidacy of Ron Paul, when thousands of young people turned out to hear Rep. Paul lecture on the Federal Reserve and sound money.

Another group of honest money people are those who are creating digital gold currencies[141]. Provided that they are operated honestly, digital currencies have all the benefits of the old gold standard and none of the drawbacks. It is simply better money than fiat currency, and those who understand money hope for it to succeed. This popularity extends even to unexpected places. For example, one strong backer of digital gold is Benn Steil, the Chief Economist at the Council of Foreign Relations, who has written favorably on the subject on several occasions.

Digital currencies are currently under attack by the United States and other state governments, but the idea refuses to die and new operators are moving to foreign jurisdictions rather than quitting or fighting the US government. This is very strongly in the Western tradition. These people are not only going about to build something new themselves, but are enduring attacks from the biggest power in the world and continue to build.

THE BLUEPRINT FOR RENEWAL

So, with all of these streams leading toward renewal, will renewal occur? And if so, how? While we will cover this in some depth in the next

[140] I am stating my personal conclusion here, that fiat currencies are dishonest. I will leave it to the thoughtful reader to examine the facts himself or herself, and to decide whether they agree with me or not.

[141] For explanations and details on digital currencies, refer to Wikipedia and www.dgcmagazine.com

chapter, there is an important point to make first: *There is no "blueprint for renewal."* And there will not be one.

There is no plan, no prescription, no steps to follow. A central plan is precisely what will *not* work. Renewal will occur – if it occurs – because millions of individuals decide that they are going to take actions that they "don't have to," to do things that are not expected of them, to create unapproved but superior ways of living for themselves and their families, and perhaps to defend themselves. In whichever directions they *act* – not talk, not plan, not debate, but *act* – those will be the directions that renewal tends to take, and no others.

Again, this point hearkens back to Jesus, who says:

> *Whosoever heareth these sayings of mine, and doeth them, I will liken him unto a wise man, which built his house upon a rock: And the rain descended, and the floods came, and the winds blew, and beat upon that house; and it fell not: for it was founded upon a rock.*
>
> *And every one that heareth these sayings of mine, and doeth them not, shall be likened unto a foolish man, which built his house upon the sand: And the rain descended, and the floods came, and the winds blew, and beat upon that house; and it fell: and great was the fall of it.*

Talk is cheap; often less than worthless. Only action will save the West.

12

The Two Futures

Multitudes, multitudes in the valley of decision: for the day of the LORD is near in the valley of decision.
-- Joel 3:14

Two futures stand in front of the West. The world we stand in is halting between these two futures, and this straddle may continue for some time (or not). Ultimately, the West is almost certain to go either one way or the other; information technology is making the divide sharp and the process much faster than it would be otherwise. If people of the West specifically choose to change their recent paths, the better of the two futures may still be obtained. If they do not wish to make a choice, one is made for them: continuing the decline.

Timidity, stasis, and quiet acceptance of life as it is will bring the West into a steep decline and into a new dark age that will doom generations of their offspring to yet another long regrouping. In all likelihood, it will take our descendents between three and four hundred years to drag themselves out of the pit their great-great-grandparents dug for them. It happened in Sumer, Greece, and Rome and it can happen to us. We are them; they were us.

Self-reliance, courage, belief in principles, innovation, initiative, and doing the right thing regardless of cost will secure another growth cycle for Western civilization. And, if this growth is sufficient, mankind's

continuing cycles of expansion and contraction, pained creation and mindless wasting, may end.

So, the moment of truth is at hand, in this, the West's valley of decision. The choice - or the evasion of choosing - sits directly in front of us all.

SEEING BEYOND THE DAILY EXPLOSIONS

> *Trying to determine what is going on in the world by reading newspapers is like trying to tell the time by watching the second hand of a clock.*
> -- Ben Hecht

The overwhelming majority of information people receive about the world involves daily reports of the strange and the shocking. Most of these reports will be gone within hours, to be followed by the next cycle of the most surprising and rare events that can be presented on video. Developing a clear view of the world based upon these bits of information is nearly impossible.

Our interests here are not daily outrages, or even wars, but the structures of rulership and changes within civilizations. Wars and borders come and go, but the necessities of rulership are more or less the same in all modern states.

For example: Passport treaties are signed by every nation, communist or capitalist alike, Christian and Muslim alike, and all for the same reason: Once travel was available to the masses, some method of controlling them was required, or else they could evade the state. So, passports were mandated and every ruler agreed to force every person entering their area of dominion to present travel documents authorized by the other ruler – or else to forbid entry. It was a restriction created solely by the necessities of rulership.

Paper currencies are adopted by all, taxation and control systems are similar or identical, use of the media is the same, and elections are conducted in the same ways. They all endorse the same rules of war. They all run courts of law and prisons. Nearly all run some type of legislature. Groups of rulers fight for more and better territories, but the structures controlling life within those territories are strikingly similar.

So, subjects like "the balance of power" and "area of hegemony" are unimportant to this analysis. Who gets to enforce the law over any single slice of geography is not our subject: We are interested in the structure of

an overall civilization, not the minutia of border changes and which leader's portrait hangs in a million government offices.

THE TWO STRUCTURES

Every chapter of this book has, in one way or another, highlighted a critical choice in the structure of civilizations: Centralized or distributed.

It is neither a simplification nor an overstatement to say that *centralization is a framework suited to plunder and control*. Centralization, by its very nature, requires that goods must be taken away from the people that produce them and transferred to a central point. This is *always* done by force or by a credible threat of force.

Likewise it is no stretch to say that *decentralization is a framework suited to production, cooperation and liberty*. The most productive structures in the history of the world are free markets. There is no legitimate argument to this statement; the only objections to it are tightly focused around the times and places when markets were not operated freely. A truly free market involves no involuntary transactions; whoever takes part, does so in liberty and cooperatively. All else are thieves and liars; these are attackers of the market, not players within it.

Note that the plunder or cooperation mentioned above are not results of good or bad *intentions*, they are the result of the *structures*. This is a crucial point. When things go wrong, humans nearly always want to find a person to blame them on. In this case, and in many others, that is simply wrong.

> The people operating a centralized structure may actually mean well, but their system will always produce plunder – that is the nature of a centralized system.
>
> The people operating a decentralized structure may be unkind and even cruel, but their system will always produce cooperation – that is the nature of a decentralized system.

Certainly all systems are operated by real humans, and this means that things can and will go wrong under either type, but that only makes both processes sloppy, it does not change their natures.

It is a great and common human stupidity to find some fault with a thing and to reject it based upon a single flaw – even when the thing they are comparing it with has many flaws. For example, when new systems of

education are proposed, the operators of the old systems inevitably isolate their arguments on something that could go wrong with the new way. (Usually with a lot of emotion attached.) When doing this, they imply that this bad thing negates every virtue of the new system. Something could go wrong… it is dangerous… it must be rejected… it is evil. But at the same time, horrible things are happening in their existing system, every day, and in huge numbers.

The effort to find a flaw, to create ridicule and shame, and to reject the new thing… this is nothing but an effort to bypass reason and to overpower it with fear. It is a trick to turn a thinking man into an unthinking animal, bypassing reason almost completely. (And, usually, moving on to the next subject before people can re-engage their analysis.)

Decentralized structures, like centralized structures, will always contain a few bad people doing bad things; that is simply the nature of humanity. Real-life operations will never be pristine and pure. But, rather than highlighting the weakness of decentralized systems, this actually highlights their greatest virtue: *Decentralized structures are inherently self-correcting*[142].

When something goes wrong within a decentralized structure, the first member that is injured may directly respond and communicate the problem to other members. The ability to react is present in every part of the structure. That means that the first response is immediate and tends to be proportional to the offense. Again, none of this is perfect, but taking advantage of this mechanism is not easy, usually requiring considerable complexity.

When something goes wrong within a structure that is centralized, the first member injured is probably forbidden from responding directly. The ability to react is present in only one specialized organ of the structure, and only after orders are received from the executive portions. That means that the first response is almost never immediate and tends to be wasteful, since centralized structures consider overwhelming force a virtue – which means they use it often. This mechanism can be taken advantage of with simple strategies, such as using speed or by corrupting small but crucial elements of the system. Both of these strategies are likely to generate gains above their costs.

Finally, centralization requires size. The surplus production of thousands or millions cannot be gathered to a center without a large number of

[142] The works of Frederich Hayek cover this in great detail.

specialized employees. And it cannot be justified without large groups of people upholding the honor of the centralized institutions. Because of this, the problems we saw with Dunbar's number related to factory work come into play. Rules are required to keep the system organized, and rules – by their very nature – forbid human judgment.

This is why governments (or other large systems) cannot treat people sensibly or compassionately, even when they try. The man or woman dealing with the individual citizen is forbidden from considering the citizen's personal circumstances by a long list of rules. And every time something goes wrong and embarrasses that institution, more rules are added to prevent it from happening again... which further restricts the possibility of human sympathy from a government worker. It is a system that chokes itself to death over time.

THE RE-CONQUEST

Western Civilization is currently declining, and this process is clearly a re-conquest of plunder over production.

When the Church entered the Middle Ages, after the failure of Rome's central authority, all it had was legitimacy. It did not have temporal power. In other words, it could not do what previous empires had done, and simply overpower what stood in front of them and take full power over it. The Church had to *convince* the scattered princes of Europe to cede power to them.

This is the same position the rulers of the West found themselves late in the 19th Century. Up to that point, control had continually slipped away from them: Unapproved learning had taken root, and they had to work to bring it back under control. Art was lost and never returned as a central tool. Commerce and international trade found their footing, built their own systems, and even dealt with powerful states like England as equals. More importantly, law – at that time created and expanded in a distributed way – had been placed above the ruler. These were dramatic losses for the state. The rulers worked to get their power back, but new developments kept moving the goal further away: New continents opened up and allowed people to live and grow beyond their reach. New machines made unregulated production possible; people went ahead and prospered without even seeking permission. Then came the steam engine and created overwhelmingly powerful commercial activities. The state was over-matched and couldn't catch up. *The state had lost control of production.*

Certainly all was not lost to the rulers, they still had strengths, the primary of which were these:

> **The Great Trade.** As we have mentioned twice previously, humans are inherently conflicted beings, and seek to sublimate those conflicts into something larger than themselves. This became newly important at the end of the 19th Century, since the legitimacy of the Church was failing badly. People sought something big to find identification with – something that told them they were special for being joined to it. Markets, the structures of production, had no interest in providing this to people and lacked status for doing so. Only something large, impressive, and centralized would do. The state was almost alone as a suitable actor for the role of "larger than man."
>
> **Military power.** This couldn't be directly used against their own subjects, for fear of losing legitimacy, but it was a great source of national pride. "Leader" personality types plus permanent armies is a recipe for war, which almost always focuses the minds of the people around foreign threats. And when people fear threats, they run to the state for protection. The saying is true: *War is the health of the state.*
>
> **Ceremonial legitimacy.** This is directly related to the Great Trade mentioned above, but applied differently. It can still be a highly emotional thing for people to receive awards from "important people" dressed in impressive garments. Think of college graduation ceremonies, where the proud parent sees his or her child receive a degree from an important official. The emotional impact is significant and long-lasting. Markets and rogue inventors don't provide this; institutions do.
>
> **A central position in the attention and imaginations of men.** A ruler is different than the rest of us. That has always generated an immense amount of interest, particularly among people whose own lives were uneventful. The larger the ruler is in the minds of his subjects, the more power he has.

It was from this base that the state was able to resume its conquest. Soon enough, a few breaks went their way (some of which we mentioned in Chapter Ten), primarily the following:

Legislatures. Legislative bodies became popular, giving people a feeling that they held a share of state power in their hands. Unbeknownst to them, and probably completely unplanned by the rulers, this changed the nature of law and put it back beneath the state. The state would now be a large organization – depriving the king of almost all of his power (even where he did remain). The state regained sovereign and was fully in control of the formerly-sovereign law.

Economies of scale. The economies of scale of the Industrial Revolution made for fewer and larger companies. The state had no hope of controlling commerce when it consisted of thousands or millions of home-operated looms and family businesses – they were far too many. But small numbers of large firms could be controlled. Not only that, but they were very large and very rich, and had a great deal to lose. Close down a two-man shop and they will move somewhere else and start over. General Motors, on the other hand, cannot. So, the state had power over large economic actors[143] and in this way exerted great control over commerce in general.

Taking over money. As we have explained in some detail, money was historically silver and gold. This was certainly true in the 19th Century. But in the early 20th Century, people were willing to accept state control of money[144]. The power of controlling a nation's currency is a far greater and subtle than is commonly understood. U.S. President James Garfield said *Whoever controls the volume of money in any country is absolute master of all industry and commerce.*

Truth comes from experts. This was another effect of the Industrial Revolution and the splintering of knowledge. People began to stray from the core of Western Civilization that *Truth is revealed by a cooperative process.* At this time, the shift was made to truth coming from experts. This made the individual feel vulnerable and powerless – they couldn't learn the truth through

[143] Fascism was the pinnacle of state control over large companies.

[144] Primarily due to fear of violent socialists rousing the masses into a revolution, due to an economic crash. In the US, the creation of the Federal Reserve was in reaction to the Crash of 1907 followed by the death of J.P. Morgan, the man who "saved" the US economy in 1907.

their own powers[145]; it had to be provided to them by experts. This transferred great power to the state, who put itself into the business of certifying and decertifying experts.

Mass conditioning. Through state schooling, as we have mentioned several times. This has greatly affected the minds of the populace.

All of these avenues were paths of re-conquest for the state. In all of them, the state regained power and control. By the middle of the 20th Century, the state had been restored to tremendous power[146]. The greatest tool for conquest, however, is coming into the state's hands as the 21st Century begins: Surveillance Technology.

"THEY'RE LISTENING"

> *I know why you did it; you were afraid. Who wouldn't be? War, terror and disease. There were a myriad of problems that conspired to corrupt your reason and rob you of your common sense. Fear got the best of you.*
> *-- V For Vendetta*

Odd though it may seem, the first surveillance state was the first empire in ancient Sumer. As we explained in Chapter Two, the base organizational units of Sumer were small cities, each with a temple and government buildings, and there were so many of these units that they were nearly within sight of each other. The rulers and their employees spent tremendous amounts of time cataloging almost every sort of financial transaction. Sales of land, wheat, seed, gold, silver, oil, beer, and almost everything else were recorded and stored in state record-houses. The cities being small meant that everything was seen.

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[145] It is one thing to take input from specialists on complex subjects; it is quite another to simply adopt the conclusions of experts. In this second case, the individual's powers of analysis and judgment are bypassed. Again, this is an obedience reaction, not analytical. Teacher tells, the child repeats.

[146] It is my opinion that the massive numbers of state-induced deaths at this time are directly related to massive state power. Well over 100 million people died in one form of state action or another during the 20th Century, far outpacing Inquisitions, Crusades or even the Black Plague (in raw numbers). A long examination would be required to substantiate this point, but I think it important enough to mention: Huge states = Huge wars. Huge states plus self-assured ideologies = massive citizen deaths.

During all the intervening years, staying away from the state was possible, to a greater or lesser extent. The rulers did try to see and record everything, especially if it involved collecting taxes. One of the last Roman Emperors, Valentinian III, instituted a $1/24^{th}$ sales tax in 444, and required all sales to be conducted in the presence of a tax collector. These measures, however, were of limited effectiveness. Taxing land has always worked exceptionally well, since it couldn't be moved and was easy to seize, but mobile wealth has continually remained a problem… until now.

In a very real way, the disaster of September 11th, 2001 was to Western states what The Donation of Constantine was to the Church – a path to power[147]. In the aftermath of that day, people all through the West were terrified, and ran (as usual) to the state to protect them. The state, of course, was eager to oblige. In effect, a new role for the state was found: *The Great Protector*. Massive new agencies were placed over and around existing agencies and massive systems of control were instituted. Chief among these was surveillance: Interception and storage of telephone calls, emails, money transfers, Internet use, cell phone trails, thousands of traffic cameras, and much more.

Crucial to all of this, however, is some way of sorting through all of the data that is gathered. At the time of this writing (early 2009), the ability to make use of all this data is still lagging, but catching up quickly. One of the great advantages of computer technology is that its capacities increase rapidly and continuously. It is only a matter of time until managing all this data is easy and cheap. More than likely, the time will not be long. Between five and ten years should be sufficient. Already, complex programs are in use to flag suspicious behavior. This goes far deeper than large cash transactions; purchasing habits are now being monitored, including things such as alcohol consumption. And if this is being done now, what comes with the next upgrade of computer technology?

Those observers who complain about the failure of character in the West are right, of course, much as the Romans who complained about the death of their virtues. What many of them fail to understand, however, is

[147] This is not to say that states had anything to do with the event itself (I don't believe that they did), only that 911 gave them leave to spy on everything in their realm… just as technology was making it possible.

that a surveillance state makes the process much, much worse[148]. If it continues, there may be no reverse of the decline.

Surveillance is a subject worthy of its own book, and we will not take much space on it here, but it is crucial, not only for its direct effects, but for its indirect effects: It returns men to serfdom. The state has everything you do in their files: All the emails you sent when you were depressed, every porn site you've ever surfed, every phone call you've ever made, every dollar you've ever spent. This is not overly-dramatized hyperbole. States cannot do this now, but they have the records and are well on their way toward the ability to use them. There is little to stop them. People are in fear and they want to believe that the state will protect them. They are willing to give them whatever they ask.

At the end of this process, demoralized human beings content themselves to live as sheep… and prefer it. Things most certainly *can* get worse, and if this process continues, they will.

Sumer was not conquered because their opponents had any natural advantage, but because they had closed themselves in and rotted. The empires of 1200 B.C. fell because they failed to adapt military strategies – something that was clearly within their power to do. The armies of Church-aligned princes failed to defeat much smaller armies of Protestants, simply because they did not adapt.

In all of these cases, and in many others, it was a failure to adapt that made a civilization vulnerable. In simplistic terms, the people and their systems were tuned to obedience instead of action, to stasis and not to innovation, and to finding meaning in their place rather than in production. They became neuters, and whoever was not a neuter – even if he were vulgar, ignorant and stupid – could conquer them.

Once again, the Christian creed of the foundational moment runs contrary to events during a decline: Jesus demanded production of his followers: They were to bear fruit. Whether we call this spiritual fruit or physical fruit matters little; the man Jesus wants is one who takes things upon himself and produces[149]. The obedience model chokes this process. And if it chokes it well enough, any outside force that does not feature such mentally-constrained people will easily overrun it.

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[148] Protection is certainly a legitimate concern, but it does not have to be arranged according to the centralized model that is currently being used. In fact, the centralized model is deeply flawed. But this, again, is a subject that we will have to bypass.

[149] The parable of Matthew 25:14-30 is especially clear on this point.

In the end, *Easy to rule = Easy to conquer*. Always and forever it heralds the death of a civilization.

THE FUTURE

This brings us more or less up to date in our coverage of the state's re-conquest of production. We will now look ahead. Bear in mind that no one knows enough to say which trend will be more or less powerful than another or when and where each will have more effect. What follows are simple conclusions, based upon the concept that large powerful things in motion will tend to remain in motion.

We don't know how these things might deviate from their present course, but we do know in which directions they are moving, and we do know something of their overall mass and speed.

The Fruits Of Complexity

Earlier we briefly mentioned Joseph Tainter's excellent book, *The Collapse Of Complex Societies*. In it, Tainter describes how the need of the state to be looked to as source and savior leads to the ultimate collapse of that society. He describes a process that runs like this:

1. You intervene to make society work for a goal that society doesn't want to provide for itself. (Defense, for example.)

2. This always produces side-effects that cause new problems.

3. Then you intervene to mitigate these side-effects from your first intervention.

4. Then you intervene to mitigate the side-effects of your second intervention.

5. Then you intervene to mitigate the side-effects of your third intervention, and so on…

Tainter describes how this process ruined the Romans, the Maya and others. In our time, it is playing out in these directions:

1. Citizens have their rights voided in the name of being protected.

2. The government becomes unable to do the things they are supposed to do.

3. The cost of government rises.

4. The cost of doing businesses goes sky-high, but not in a way that is apparent.

5. Information is stopped from going where it should on time.

6. Ever-increasing laws mean that almost everyone is a law-breaker. The citizen stays out of jail only due to prosecutorial discretion.

One bureaucracy is placed upon another, rules multiply, reform committees proliferate, overseers are added. Any progress is temporary: As soon as the burst of new energy has spent itself, it is dissipated in the structure, which continues unabated. In the end, this process chokes the society to death. It has to: *The model is force, not cooperation.*

Finally, complexity is expensive. This is what happened in Rome. By the end of their empire, people were desperate to avoid the state because of the costs of complexity. Historian R.M. Adams put it this way: *By the 5th Century, men were ready to abandon civilization itself to escape the fearful load of taxes.*

Small Business At Risk

Commerce is always choked by multiplying regulations, for the simple reason that regulation forbids adaptation. Small business is based upon rapid adaptation. So, a crush of new legislation and regulation prevent small business from adapting and drives many of them out of the market. Or, more likely, it prevents them from ever opening. This is why black markets always flourish in oppressed economies: Small operators cannot keep the rules and are forced to go around them.

Restraining these small operators are the fear of punishment if caught, plus a general emotional framework that identifies anything outside of approved channels as evil. In such conditions, a potential small operator will probably not want to be seen as a criminal by his friends and family, and will remain as an employee of a large, respectable corporation.

As a nation turns into a regulatory state, only the very largest and best-connected entities are able to get their concerns dealt with. Small firms are immensely vulnerable in such conditions, and they tend to merge with larger entities for survival's sake. This results in fewer but larger firms, each with as many ties to the state as they can obtain. It approximates the old fascist model, minus the dictator.

Centralized things only address the largest issues; all others fall off the sides. Again, this is a result of the system's structure, whether or not any ill-intent is present.

The State Overtakes Society

Large central structures remove information, initiative, adaptation, and virtuous traditions from individual men and women, and force them into a fixed structure. The crucial thing is this: *When regulation is within the individual, complex and beneficial interactions thrive. When regulation is outside the individual, personal virtues fail.*

> When civilization is *within* people, they tend to develop themselves positively.
>
> When civilization is *imposed* upon people, they degenerate.

This damage is structural: They cannot rely upon themselves and their patterns of thinking change: Rather than referring to their own information and their own analysis, they defer to the judgment of the greater power. They lose themselves in the process. The result of this is denuded individuals and non-adaptive structures.

Do not assume that this cannot happen in the West. Look at what happened to equally human individuals in North Korea. Video from the funeral of Kim Il Sung in 1994 show this in horrifying images. Millions of human beings, denuded just as mentioned above, were brought to such a state of dependence that some literally cried themselves to death following the death of their "great leader." At Kim's funeral, a radio announcer went so far as to implore the dead ruler to raise himself back to life:

> *All the people have finally come forward to bid farewell to the soul of our Great Leader. Children, adults, young and old, all are crying out for our father, the Great Leader, and we all yearn for you to just open your eyes, at least once. Great Leader, who has been able to fulfill all the people's desires and dreams, our great father, can you not grant us this final wish?*

These Koreans are not a sub-species of human beings; they are the same as us, and if we allow ourselves to travel the same road, what happened to them can happen to us. This is not a comforting thought, but it is true nonetheless.

The Intel State

The post-911 Protector State model of the West has an important feature that has been little understood, and that is the promotion of intelligence agencies to special status. As we begin, it is worth noting that the old name for intelligence services was the more honest one: Secret services.

Intelligence operatives have never been benign beings. Their daily work involves getting people to do things they'd rather not. That's what an "asset" usually is. Intelligence is *nothing* like James Bond. The work itself tends to damage and/or corrupt the people involved. Stealing information, hiding it, lying about it, misleading people, blackmailing innocent people, and worse… people who do these things daily are not made better by the process.

The people who work in these operations are the wrong people to entrust with power for other reasons as well. Intelligence agents have their views of the world formed by traumatic experiences. They hold their opinions about what bad people do based upon reference to past traumas. That leads them to bad conclusions.

And, of course, the results provided by these agencies have been far less than stellar. The FBI took an astonishingly long time to catch Aldrige Ames and Robert Hansen. The FBI, CIA and NSA combined failed to prevent 911, even though they had enough information to do so. Similar verdicts could be applied to a host of other events. These results are not good. Defenders of the agencies say that they have prevented many attacks, but we have no way of knowing and no real reason to trust them.

It is also worth noting that Intel agencies have a long an uninterrupted history of fighting each other. This is likely to get worse, not better. They will manipulate events (no matter the lost lives) to position themselves above their competitor. The competitor, of course, will manipulate back. This makes for a lot of human damage.

Nonetheless, people want to believe in James Bond and Jack Bauer, and we do have the beginnings of an Intel state, resting on a foundation of mass fears. That means that it is strongly in their interest to create more fear. And, once people have some level of inertia in that direction, the cycle perpetuates itself: A new disaster is not evidence that the Intel state has failed, it is evidence that we need to give it even more power and money.

The Intel/Protector state has been working to regain control of the Internet[150] and other decentralized communications recently, as well as in shutting down uncontrolled money flows. Once it regains command and control of the Internet, communications and cash transfers, it is uncertain as to which directions the agencies will take. They could manipulate their way into serious power, but even this is unlikely to change much but the names on the doors. After a fit of silly policies, the new bosses will have to revert to the policies of their predecessors. They may behave a bit differently, but not substantially so.

Once again: The shape of the structure dictates the form of its necessities and its results. If you want real change, you have to change the structure.

The Crime Of The Century

> *The current project to identify the humanity of the world will make identity theft the crime of the century. It's really extraordinarily simple: The more everything rests on identity, the more value identity will have. And the more value it has, the more it will be worth to steal.*
> --Ian Grigg

State surveillance creates massive treasuries of data, and generally in easy-to-steal locations. These collections of valuable data are vulnerable in many ways, which means that organized criminal enterprises will be able to steal quite a lot of them. With data becoming more valuable, these criminals will become very rich. Already in 2007, data theft was more profitable than illegal drugs[151].

These processes are complex and involve all sorts of side-enterprises and deals with politicians (at all levels).

The more that individuals and small firms suffer losses from this, the more the state will be called upon to tighten things up even more, which makes identities that much more valuable. And so the cycle goes. The cycle ends in the state taking complete control over the world's finances (in something akin to the Bible's "mark of the beast") or with people ejecting the state from the Identity business.

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[150] The primary step has been regulating ISPs and demanding all their data, thus creating points of control. Mandatory state ID to obtain communication services and other methods are also being used, as well as massive data gathering, as we briefly mentioned earlier.

[151] Per the SANS report.

In this case, as in others, fear is the state's best friend[152].

Hollow States

The term "failed state" is popular at the moment, but "hollow state" is probably better. A hollow state is one that exists in all outward ways, but that is "hollowed-out" and used by a criminal organization for cover.

Criminal organizations need safe havens, and hollow states provide them. These organizations make massive amounts of money from data theft operations, product piracy, traffic in illegal drugs and in any number of additional operations. They can afford to create and support corrupt states, and do so.

The hollow state is a perfect protection from other states. The system of Sovereign States is held with religious fervor by the operators of nation states. They will not easily breach sovereignty. Criminal organizations take advantage of this fact – a strategy that is working very well for them and will probably continue to work well.

Western nations might want to stop criminal organizations that are stealing their data, but they are not going to bomb any other sovereign nation that has committed no aggression against it. The non-state criminal group may have paid a dozen officials to obtain virtual control over territory and free operating rights, but they are not formal leaders. Essentially, they rent the state's infrastructure.

There are many variations on this theme, such as destabilizing a small state, so that it is easy to deal with. Renting France, for example, would not be possible. But renting a war-torn African nation could be done affordably. The ideal hollow state is one with a clear international standing, but with massive internal problems.

In times past, the common strategy was to take over a state. The new strategy is to find one that is hollowed-out, or to hollow it out yourself, and then move in. So long as a titular government remains in place, there is no requirement to provide social services. The state can be held responsible for any failure in this regard. The only true responsibility these groups retain is to their membership.

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[152] This is NOT to imply that the state causes fearful events. This is a simple statement and implies nothing beyond itself. Conspiracy theories are generally wastes of time, as they take the reverse view of science: They start with a grand conclusion and seek to fit pieces of facts into it. It is certainly possible for a state to create terror for its own sake, such as in false-flag operations and the use of Agent Provocateurs. But, such conclusions should be based upon actual fact, such as might be presentable in a court of law, and not on emotionally-pleasing guesses.

This is now the sensible strategy for all sorts of non-state groups, especially for attacking the West. No one will attack the United States very directly, for example. The U.S. has nuclear bombs – that is not a fight that can be won. Nukes, however, cannot be used against non-state groups, so this is the proper method of attack. The West refuses to adapt because they cannot give up the idea of national sovereignty.

"Smart" Centralization Programs

At some point, it is highly likely that a leader in the West will begin tearing down his or her bureaucracies and replacing them with technology. Because of the massive political forces involved (especially the gigantic and very rich government employee unions) this will probably require one or more crises, but it is the sensible move and will probably be done at some point.

For example, it would be far, far cheaper for all Western states to eliminate their welfare structures and simply issue minimal credits to everyone. (We will discuss this further below, in the Reverse Economy section.)

Research programs, also, could be nationalized and better-managed. They could go so far as to hire people for 4-year terms. If they solve their problem, they get a bonus. If not, they never get hired again. The one area where this is most likely to happen is in medical research, because states have promised free medicine to their people and because it is so very expensive.

This technique might work for the first several years, but even with exceptional success, the process would again stagnate. The steps might run like this:

1. Researchers cure Alzheimer's Disease.
2. The public cheers and the programs are greatly expanded.
3. The players figure out how to manipulate the programs.
4. Complex rules are made, and special fees are required to bend those rules.
5. Complexity grinds everything to a halt.

None of this should be interpreted as implying that such reforms would be actual improvements. Centralization in these areas is just as bad as it is in others. But the initial impacts of these changes could be positive, and politicians seldom consider more than the initial impact.

Removing Troublemakers

States have never been benevolent organizations and they are not likely to become benevolent at any point in the future. That means that they will, in one way or another, move to get rid of people who make trouble for them[153]. Western States will be careful not to appear to be traditional police states like the socialists and fascists, being concerned with maintaining their legitimacy.

Nonetheless, all the elements of the police state are already present in the West; the only issue is who they are directed toward. This may seem like an overly dramatic statement, so an example is in order:

A SWAT Team charges out of their black van in the middle of the night and breaks down someone's door; they charge in with shields and automatic rifles. They drag out their bound target and drive away. If this person was a drug dealer, people are calm and satisfied. But what if a Jew or a homosexual were dragged out instead? The only difference lies in who gets dragged out – the mechanics are identical, and they are already in place.

One important aspect to watch as we move forward is sovereign immunity applied to policemen, freeing them from all consequences for their actions while working. If they are separated from all legal consequences, only their bosses control them; the law does not[154].

It is crucial to understand that the people of Nazi Germany thought they were living in conditions of law and order. The Jews being dragged away were, in their minds, "bad." Before states can remove troublemakers, they will have to convince their masses that these people are threats. It may seem that this could not happen in the modern West, but it happened among the cultured people of Germany only two generations ago. These people were not a different species than the rest of us. What happened there can happen elsewhere. It is right to say "I won't allow that to happen," but it is wrong to say "it cannot happen."

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153 This is not referring to one party arresting their opposing party members. This refers to states removing people that oppose or insult the state itself. Parties fighting parties is no real threat to the state.

154 I must add that the policemen themselves are corrupted in this process. There is honor in doing the work of a peace officer, but that tradition is being destroyed, demanding obedience to rules and officials above service to citizens. The better police officers will quit as this process continues, but they will be easy to replace with less honorable men.

In general, states will be careful to avoid large actions that make them look bad, but there will be exceptions. These will probably be conducted via the "two steps forward, one step back" method.

A classic method of removing troublemakers is to leak damaging stories to prominent news organizations, then to create a criminal case against them. (Reporters make their careers with leaked information, so they are all too eager to run with information from highly-placed but unnamed sources.) With public opinion against the trouble-making person or group, everyone expects them to be indicted and almost no one cares when they are. Furthermore, no one wants to step forward and say, "the state framed them," because they all 'know' that only crazy people say such things. (More on this below also.)

For example, a strongly centralized government in the United States will eventually need to rid itself of Talk Radio. At this moment, such an action would probably lead to some level of violent revolt. But if talk radio listeners are put on the defensive first, the goal could be reached successfully. A process of this type would look like this:

1. Wait for a large, public and very well photographed episode of right-wing violence. Something like the Oklahoma City Federal Building bombing, but one that can be clearly and quickly blamed on someone with "Talk Radio" reasons for the violence.

2. Reinstate the Fairness Doctrine to eliminate talk radio. In this case, rebellion will be minimal, provided that the timing is right.

Another version might be required to create a new law that would hurt small business owners. (The majority of whom are, in the U.S., white, male, or both.)

1. Institute the plan.

2. As anger rises, diffuse it by removing Affirmative Action[155].

3. Insert the voice, "Well, at least we got this."

It is important to understand that step #3 is a very common state action. President George W. Bush, for example, was caught with prominent journalists on his payroll. Intelligence agencies and law enforcement

[155] A U.S. program that excludes whites, and especially white males, from obtaining government contracts.

agencies have been doing the same since mass communication existed. Stories are planted continually.

Diversions

The Roman Empire kept its people happy with free food and massive entertainments – the proverbial "bread and circuses." The nations of the West are doing the same and will need to do more of the same. But the balance may have to shift toward more circuses and less bread, simply because they cannot afford endless handouts, especially now that those handouts include doctors, medicine and retirement income. There is simply a limit as to what the state can afford, as will be discussed momentarily.

It will be increasingly in the state's interest to have entertainments that uphold its legitimacy, or at least to distract people from acting against state interests. Aside from influencing entertainment, the logical methods for the state to take would be along these lines:

- Elections are staggered so that at least one major vote is held every month, to keep people involved. Votes are cast online and may be changed until the last moment.
- Referenda are held on all matters of moral judgment. The majority rules.
- Trials are broadcast and the public votes to decide guilt or innocence. Juries are eliminated.

Laws regarding proper treatment of animals, loud music at night and a hundred other things can be shifted from the legislatures to the voting kiosks. News broadcasts would end with: *Have you voted this week? There are important cases to be decided and your vote counts! Full coverage here immediately after the polls close.*

A related area is the dissipation of instincts and energies that could be used against the state. This usually involves living vicariously through entertainment or sporting events. Normal, aggressive human impulses are drained this way. Video games may eventually play a role in this, but they are currently moving in the opposite direction, into massively cooperative games. Not much is certain here, except that it is strongly in the state's interest to make this happen, especially in hard times.

One final and obvious way of dissipating rebellious energies is by the use of drugs. Already, massive amounts of mood-altering drugs are

administered to children in schools. It will be easy for desperate states in the future to build on this model, and add to existing adult drug-use models. At some point in the future, if the current line of decline continues, drugs will be used. It is too obvious, too effective, and people are already used to the idea. It just has to be presented carefully.

Harmless Ideologies

States since Rome (and probably earlier) have encouraged ideologies that they found harmless to their interests and tried to remove ideas that were harmful to their interests. As always, large organizations tend to act amorally toward their own expansion.

As the West declines, states will have to discourage the West's traditional Christianity – it is simply not in their interest. This has nothing to do with the truth of falsity of Christianity's central tenets; it is due to the fact that Christianity is a bad ideology for rulership and a bad religion for a ruler.

Christianity is by nature subversive, even though many Christians fail to understand that fact. Much of Judaism is also subversive, even though it tries desperately not to be. (Cryptoanarchy and Anarchocapitalism are subversive ideologies with no religious aspect attached.)

Saving an endangered species, on the other hand, is anything *but* subversive. They worst activists do is push the state to act. They need a powerful state; in fact, they would be best served by a dictator who was on their side.

Political activism is nothing but righteousness plus force. Politicians and institutions alike encourage and praise these activities. The more energy spent in these ways, the more it is kept away from dangerous activities. Activism is harmless to the state.

Sometimes, people proclaiming irrationality of such movements see conspiracies in their opponents, since governments and institutions take coordinated actions. While there may well be some conspiracies, they are most certainly not required. All the incentives are in place for states and large organizations to seek identical goals and even to recognize them at the same approximate times.

Things that function on centralized power (like foundations, corporations, banks and states) will nearly always promote the same sorts of things. People who oppose environmental and similar movements are almost always people and groups who live by the productive model of small commerce.

The Frame

One of the most crucial things for modern states to do – if they continue on the path of centralization and decline – will be to build a comprehensive mental framework through which its subjects view the world. The states that embraced "scientific socialism" tried long and hard to construct such frameworks and had some success doing so, but modern technology plus scientific manipulation techniques will make such systems far more effective, and at less expense.

For simplicity's sake, we will simply call this unified mental and emotional framework, "the frame." The key elements of constructing and maintaining the frame are the ability to inject clear messages into all significant public information sources, re-direction and manipulation of base human instincts, techniques of manipulation such as neuro-linguistics, public shaming, and simple fear. Advanced systems would include massive data gathering and on-the-fly interpretation, combined with advanced manipulation techniques. (This cannot be done yet, but it will be possible within a decade or two.) At some point, escape from the frame becomes nearly impossible. Imagine North Korea times five.

Within a frame, there are specific limits – a "box" if you will – within which everyone knows their thinking is safe and acceptable. If you leave that box you become first "strange," then "a lunatic," then "an extremist," and finally "dangerous."

A crucial element of the frame is that a man is seen to exist only as part of a community. (This is popular already.) Next, this community-man is led to identify himself with one or more "framers," who are the experts seen on television[156]. To challenge the frame is to declare yourself less-human.

In effect, the public framers create a firm tribe/not tribe line. This is not done with fiery claims, but with endless, mundane repetition. Again, this is nothing new. Consider the following statement:

> *The intelligence of the masses is small. Their forgetfulness is great.*
> *They must be told the same thing a thousand times.*
> -- Adolph Hitler

[156] These experts will not need to be unified; in fact, it is far better for them to have certain conflicting opinions. They would always, however, support the state and remain well inside the borders of the Frame.

Repetition works, displacing all other messages. Consider the example of *The DaVinci Code*: Regardless of the fact that this was clearly a work of fiction and that the claims made in it were proven to be wrong, people in gigantic numbers actually believed them. A thing does not have to be true to be part of the frame. It can be demonstrably false; it just has to be repeated at many times and places.

Another element of the frame that already exists is this: Many people perceive that the only things that really matter are the "big, important things" on television. What's on TV is the bigger reality – the uber-world. So, they give far more credence to what we see on TV than they do to their neighbor who is saying the same things. TV has automatic authority, with the implied message, "if you were important, you'd be on TV." This is a primary reason why people are willing to utterly degrade themselves to get on certain TV shows. At least for that moment they reach the larger reality.

Another necessary element of this is the belief that thinking is for experts. Obviously this is silly; even an average intellect is very powerful, and thinking is for all humans, save the very few who are seriously damaged. But, people – often from simple laziness – want others to do their thinking for them, like they want others to bake their bread for them. They want to get the end-product without working for it. Thinking, however, is utterly necessary to us, and has deep effects upon us. In the end, a non-thinking man becomes a neutered human.

A generalized view of a fully framed world follows. Many elements of this are already in place, at least in an early form:

1. The Frame exists inside of everyone.
2. Professionals engage in endless manipulations of the mind of the populace. They give them what they want… after they tell them what they want.
3. All public intellectuals are sycophants.
4. The populace has full faith in the rulers, who are never judged by their actions or by their results – only by their stated intent.
5. Entertainment continually reinforces the nobility and power of the rulers.
6. Education is mandatory, systematic conditioning.
7. Learning has been replaced with non-stop entertainment.

8. Sentences for crimes are astronomical, forcing you to confess or face life in prison.
9. All money is tracked and controlled. Nothing escapes the state, everything is accounted for, nothing is beyond their punishment.
10. Everything is recorded.
11. All of your life is open to them – they can get you no matter where you hide.
12. We are all law-breakers. We remain free at the mercy of the state.
13. Police can break and enter at any time.
14. Warrants are no longer real protections.
15. Anyone who tells you about a law enforcement action against you will go to jail.
16. The system is locked-down and protected because anyone attempting independent thought threatens the self-esteem of everyone else. Think differently and you insult them all. Act differently and you will be attacked by all.
17. Zero initiative, zero hunger for something better. They are neuters.
18. Harmless activities abound.

Denial

Most people don't want to believe a decline is possible. This refusal to stare into the face of reality is what permits it. If the elements of the decline listed here do happen, a huge number of people will go far out of their way to find plausible explanations for them; anything except facing the fact that bad things are afoot. This will drive them even to cheer it on. The alternative would demand too much of them – better to blank it out.

And this denial does *not* have to break at any point. It will be stable enough for a generation through control and force; after that it becomes self-enforcing. The only thing that will bring it down eventually will be the degrading of mental abilities combined with natural disasters.

The Great Default

The ability to create currency upon demand gave states in the 20th Century a way to promise life-long security to their citizens, and to deliver on them… at least for a generation or two. This process,

however, cannot continue forever. As of 2009, the point where the national debt of most Western states could be paid has been passed. The two obvious options - increased taxes and printing more currency - are no longer possible. The military, the embedded entitlements, and interest due are now more than tax receipts, so paying the debt down with current taxes is mathematically impossible. Even if the state were to create more debt-currency, the amount of interest that would be due upon it would be beyond payment. People are avoiding this thought with vigor.

Default will occur, in one way or another. How much of a shock to the world this may be is unknowable, but it could be very large.

The Reverse Economy

The money problems of the 21st Century have a strange but obvious solution, which is what we might call a reverse economy. What follows here is early speculation, but some system of this type will probably be instituted, merely because of necessity.

In a reverse economy:

- There is no currency, only the right to goods and services. These may or may not be denominated in currency names ("50 dollars for an electrical tester"), but the purchaser never has any currency, only a right to a certain amount of stuff.
- All credits are distributed by the state. A typical notice might say, *You have credit toward four meals worth of groceries.* With that, you could go to a store and choose ground beef, vegetables, fruit, bread, or similar items, but not gasoline.
- By doing approved work, you could obtain additional credit, which could be used for a wide variety of products or services, but the limits to these would be set by the state.
- The rates of "pay" for the work mentioned above would be set by the state and changed as required to control production – paying more or less for things that they presume are needed or that are in surplus.
- A basic level of sustenance for all. Government simply credits everyone for basic groceries and a cheap apartment. The welfare bureaus are eliminated, reducing the state's burden. (This will be *very* popular.)

- If you don't collect the goods credited to you within a specified time, those credits disappear.
- Super-strong biometric identity-verification systems will be required. Realistically, all humans will have to be fitted with some type of non-removable ID device.
- Powerful computer programs will mimic market interactions in virtual space, then distribute credit accordingly. In other words: A virtual free market will exist as an advanced computer model[157]. This will be the *only* free market that will exist. The results from this model will decide how credits are distributed in the real world.
- Such a system requires that there be no possible escape. If there were, the system would fail. This is the lesson that the Soviets learned in Berlin, and which required the Berlin Wall. This applies both to individuals and to "rogue nations." Violence will be used to keep everyone in the system.

Every element of this can be justified in one or more ways. For example, limiting the choices for your personal credits can be advertised as preventing non-farmers from obtaining fertilizer for bomb-making.

At some point, this will be the way states have to go. It will probably be the only path left to them. One question is how many Christians will take violent action. The system described above bears a great resemblance to the ominous predictions of Revelation 13:17 – *That no man might buy or sell, save he that had the mark, or the name of the beast, or the number of his name.* But, as long as the ID devices cannot be described as "marks," many Christians will not oppose it.

Such a system, however, would require a perfect virtual market model. It would require perfect knowledge of the present as well as knowledge of the future, including temperature, social influences, and more. The predictions would have to reach years into the future for many goods. Were the program to fail, mass starvation and associated horrors would be the result. And it is worth noting that starvation can be far, far worse than most people understand it to be.

[157] Preliminary work has already begun on this type of model. See www.eurace.org

The Great Entropy

The Great Entropy is what happens if the advocates of "global governance" get their wish, and it is the worst possible outcome.

Earlier we said that "easy to rule equals easy to conquer." But what if all the world's states cooperate together, and all decline together? How does that end? Or does it?

The horrifying thing about this scenario is that the normal breakdown leading to a dark age is avoided. This means that humanity, as a species, descends past their usual reset point. The examples we have of people being held within conditions of permanent decline are war zones, housing projects and the worst prisons… which are not comforting thoughts. Humanity *can* decline horribly, and such conditions do not have an inherent end-point. If states can hold together, humanity can be degraded far beyond the normal dark ages reset. What this means for the species is hard to gauge.

In conditions of global governance plus decline, the whole operation withers together, lifestyles degrade continually, theologies of suffering return, and mass starvation returns, even if news of it is suppressed. States covertly promote drug use and activities that cause early deaths, to reduce medical needs. They probably need to align with religion at some point, that so much death can be addressed.

By remaining interlocked, states will be able to stave-off collapse from outside forces, but will require:

- More distraction.
- Lower standards of living.
- More surveillance, control and regulation.
- Substitutes for escape. Drugs, movies, etc.
- More legitimization. Worship of great men, terrorist events (real or staged), wars, invaders.
- Ideologies of suffering.

Wars may be avoided by the use of inanimate threats, such as Global Warming. If the people are told they are in danger long enough and convincingly enough, actual wars may not be necessary. This would make things easier for the states, since publicity is much, much cheaper than actual war.

In real life, such a system probably cannot be held together in a pure form. People seeking power will always seek more of it, which would cause the system to crack. Nonetheless, such systems can certainly form and hold partially. This would probably include a number of hollow states and large, "soft totalitarian" states. It is possible (but probably unlikely) that a few "less ruled" states will be tolerated. These would have to be well-separated from the biggest states and able to survive without international trade.

At some point even this type of system would fail. The likely scenario would be a natural disaster or plague. Inter-ruler battles, possibly including nuclear weapons, are also possible. There seems to be no inherent time-limit to this process; it could preserve conditions of deep suffering and depravity for centuries or even millennia. But, aside from prison camps (where, in the extreme, people simply lay down and die), we have no good examples to base guesses upon.

THE DECLINING MIND

This line of projection seems like a dark fantasy, but much of it is already happening and all of it has happened before in one place or another. Dark, yes; fantasy, no.

Again: denial is a very strong thing. To face these things openly will be horrifying and demanding; most people will prefer to escape it at almost any cost, including that of closing their minds to it. So, the first characteristic of the mind of a human sitting in the midst of such a decline is simple denial: "It's okay, I still have my ____," "things will turn back around," "it's not so bad," and so on.

Associated with this is another characteristic: Failure to internalize experiences. By this, we mean that people don't take experiences within themselves; they keep them outside. People read books – not to internalize their lessons, but to pass a test or to impress someone. The self never changes and is never affected. Everything is kept external. A Catholic of this type attending a service at the Vatican simply sees "the Pope show," and is not affected internally. She will tell certainly her friends about it, but she will talk about what she *saw*, not what it did for her. Life is an external thing and one's self can always be avoided by plugging in to some form of entertainment.

With no internal references in operation (because of denial, lack of internalization, drugs and other factors), the only things that end up mattering are local references. If such people maintain their relative

position versus the people they see every day, they will accept conditions of decline passively. People will care that they keep their balcony garden more than they care about their privacy and their liberty. So long as they have the little, external, daily things (excuses to say all things remain as they always have been), they will ride the tide downward; they may complain, but they will never act to change things.

Again, this *has* happened in the past and it most definitely *can* happen again. Actually, it is happening in smaller ways continually; the chief issues are the percentage of people who operate this way and how many are willing to do more than complain.

THE DE-CONQUEST

Having taken a look at the process of decline, we will turn around and examine the reverse: A De-Conquest.

As we mentioned in Chapter Eleven, state control over communications and information have rapidly slipped since the invention of the micro-chip. The voice of the state is not what it used to be, and people are comparing ideas far more freely than ever before.

In addition, new concepts of looking at the world in a decentralized way have not only formed, but have been soundly established. In fact, the more intelligent and well-read a person may become, the more likely he or she is to hold to some form of pro-liberty philosophy.

Some essential elements of a less-ruled or un-ruled world are these:

- Free human action (negative rights for all[158]).
- Unregulated trade.
- Individual defense, distributed defense.
- The frustration of talent becomes a cardinal offence.
- Unobstructed transportation.
- Massive, decentralized communications. The Internet by itself will suffice, so long as connections are easy and affordable.
- Ad hoc grouping and temporary hierarchies.
- The market takes over territory from the state, step by step.

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[158] See the Common Law section of Chapter Six, where this is explained.

- Self-regulation, to please the market, replaces legislated regulation.
- Excessive advertising reaches its limit and fails. People finally become insulted by it.
- Temporary Autonomous Zones.
- Distributed justice and enforcement on the common law model.
- Breakup of states into multiple jurisdictions.
- Creativity overtakes Scarcity.

The process of going from the current world of massive, controlling states to a freer world will involve many small steps and can take multiple directions. It is impossible to define them all now, but some of the more obvious ones are the following:

Federations Of Mini-States

The basic model for this is Switzerland, although the new federations will deviate from a pure Swiss model.

In all likelihood, the right to vote within these mini-states would go only to residents who had earned it. That would probably be done in the following ways:

- Property ownership above a minimal level
- Successful military training and continued readiness
- Passing a difficult test on the operation and philosophy of governance

Such states would have military units that are small and adaptive. The key will be adaptive intelligence at the point of enemy contact. In other words, the brains are at the tip of the spear. Orders are *what*, not *how*. They will also major on defense rather than on offense.

Falling Economies Of Scale

Technology will continue to shrink economies of scale. Microfabrication, also called rapid prototyping, may be a key technology for many types of manufacturing. Think of Micro-fab machines as 3-D printers. Instead of a printer taking output from your computer and producing an image on a two-dimensional piece of paper, this machine produces a three-dimensional object. Micro-fabrication is digital-to-physical

manufacturing, without product-specific tools or skills. It is a small factory on a desktop, or in a garage.

This technology is still in its early development, but it already exists, with prices falling and capabilities rising. Many current units are no larger than a band saw.

Micro-fabrication wipes out the need for large-scale operations. This is a radical change, and one that will spill-over into many other areas. Largeness will be dethroned. Fabrication will eventually be possible with a wide variety of materials. You won't have to get shipments of special stuff from the big city – you'll mix-up a batch from wood, hay and stubble.

Once economies of scale fall, a great deal of state power will fall with them.

Anonymous, Digital Cash

The easy answer for the problem of international data theft is anonymous, digital cash. With no identity to tie anything to, the data and identity theft businesses would die almost instantly. However, anonymous financial instruments also mean that taxation cannot be enforced.

If and when anonymous, digital cash comes into widespread use, the expansion method of Western Civilization will be restored. This would almost certainly be the most crucial element of a de-conquest. People will be able finance projects without bankers. Money games will only be played by confirmed crooks. Stock markets will chase yield, not price.

Systems of anonymous, digital cash already exist. They are, however, unapproved and "weird," which keeps most people from using them.

It is worth adding that commerce is the only form of organization that can provide equal treatment for all as well as accepting and accommodating the inherent inequality of humans. Commerce plus anonymity equals the impossibility of totalitarianism; even of discrimination.

A New Safety Model

The old safety model was central control and central power. This model was not instituted because it provided the best safety, but because it was the model of the empire.

The new model is distributed power. Applications of this model could be many, such as:

- Every responsible adult plays some role.
- More responsible and better-paid policemen.
- An explicit preference for Peace Officers rather than Law Enforcers.
- Cell phones used as distributed justice tools.
- A Swiss model of territorial defense.
- An understanding that Control = Danger.

The use of cell phones requires a bit of explanation. With each person involved in the process, evidence is gathered by anyone in the area. Non-specialists are almost always much closer to the scene of any crime anyway. ("Where's a cop when you need one?") Instead of 911, we can have a simple snap-shot and text message upload to 555. Bear in mind that there are no problematic surveillance issues with such a system: These photos and reports are not centralized and are for a specific purpose only.

This system would also be a powerful impediment to bad policemen. With thousands of camera cell phones surrounding him, the bad cop getting away with his crime becomes a more and more remote possibility.

The obvious result of such a system is that more crooks get caught, more streets stay safe, cops become respected and respectable, and the cost of safety plummets. But more importantly, everyone feels like they have a stake in the game and they begin to tend to their own world, rather than leaving it to central control systems.

A fascinating passage is found in Alexis de Tocqueville's *Democracy in America*, written in 1835. In it, you can see the conditions that naturally develop in less-ruled and un-ruled places:

> *In America, the means available to the authorities to uncover crime and to arrest criminals are small in number… However, I doubt whether crime evades punishment less often in any other country…Everyone feels involved in providing evidence of the offense and in apprehending the offender… I saw inhabitants of a county where a major crime had been perpetrated spontaneously form committees with the aim of arresting the guilty man and handing him over to the courts.*

> *In Europe, the criminal is a luckless fellow, fighting to save his life from the authorities; the population, to a degree, watches as he struggles. In America, he is an enemy of the human race and has everyone entirely against him.*

Once systems such as these are in place, justice can re-form along distributed lines, with competitive agencies providing services that are a cross between insurance, law, police work and bounty hunting. Once again, a long document would be required to describe such services sufficiently, so we will abstain here.

Resilient Communities

As states break down and a mix of free and unfree locations exist (and probably struggle), it will make sense to form strong, autonomous communities. These will be towns or areas where the residents form strong bonds to assist and defend each other.

Such resilient communities form naturally in un-ruled frontier areas, but since there has been no frontier for generations, this is now a novel idea.

Several people are already working on resilient communities and aside from the usual difficulties of human life, such communities will be formed with little trouble. (Except from outsiders, of course.)

It is also almost certain that such resilient communities will form links[159] with one another and assist one another. They may also compete for the most talented people.

Private Charity Returns

Once people again hold their own surplus in their own hands, private charity will almost certainly return with vigor[160]. Self-reliance and charity have always gone together… at least while people controlled their own surplus production. When people do keep their surplus, actual care for one's fellows tends to return, along with self-regard from it.

This, again, is actually more important for reasons of human character than it is for its more obvious, direct results.

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[159] I use the word "links" rather than "bonds" carefully here. Links are voluntary, while the idea of a bond implies permanence and rigidity. I think links, sustained by natural commonalities and interests, will be the better model.

[160] Private charities do certainly exist under the rule of states, but at an understandably low level. The average man's extra money is removed before he ever sees it, leaving him with only scraps to give to the needy.

Under the state model, charity is forced upon people. Money is taken away in taxes and justified in the name of helping the poor, with the further implication that without the government doing this, the uncaring and greedy people would never do so. This is insulting, false and teaches horrible lessons.

It is important to carefully consider that *obligation is the enemy of compassion.* When we are forced to give charity, we get no internal benefit from the exercise. In fact, we usually get just the opposite. But when we give willingly – to people we think are suffering unjustly – we honor our own sense of goodness. We feel good about ourselves, we feel compassion for others, we are proud to be making the world a better place. That the state stole this from productive men is one of the greatest indictments that can be made against it.

In Virtus, Libertas

In virtus, libertas is Latin for, *In righteousness, freedom,* and this is a great truth of life. Without virtues such as courage, integrity, honesty and compassion, liberty can never be retained. Liberty is only for evolved men, containing civilization within themselves and able both to produce and to defend. Only these are suited to post-institutional life. Others must be excluded to one level or another, in one way or another. Accomplishing this will give outward form to the new society of humans.

People who seek to put their responsibilities off on others, who seek to avoid work, who wish to intimidate others, are suited only to the lives of slaves or masters. Such people are not compatible with actual liberty. Certainly children[161], who have yet to develop these characteristics, can find places in a truly free society, but when they are grown, they will either have these basic qualities or they will tend to tear down their free society. There is no other choice, only more or less willingness to face the fact.

This has always been true in every chapter of human history. In virtus, libertas. All else are dreams of something for nothing. All other paths lead eventually to ruin.

[161] The same, of course, applies to mentally damaged people and other victims of cruel chance. Most fortunately for us all, they are few in number.

The Demise Of Plato's Magic And The Great Trade

As states unwind, both Plato's magic idealism and the Great Trade sublimating human conflicts will unwind with them. This will require adjustment.

Individuals will have to get over the idea of getting more than they've earned, then roll up their sleeves and create for themselves. They will also have to accept the fact that they are conflicted beings and get serious about making peace with themselves.

In time it will be seen that these emotional tricks were never really necessary. Plato's deal, in particular, will be considered something akin to the story of Eden written in Greek letters, wherein Plato offers men a shortcut to the power of the gods, men accept the deal, and suffer for ages.

Privatization

The continual privatization of state services would be the smoothest path to de-conquest. (No route will be especially smooth, since the people who seek high office are not types who will relinquish power easily.) That said, it is uncertain whether privatization remains a serious possibility. Before 9-11 it was. Now, with massive controlling states, the chances of a smooth passage have diminished.

Nonetheless, if and where privatization can be arranged, it makes for a smooth, manageable transition. All of the "scary" issues, such as firemen, roads and policemen are easy to solve, once people stop panicking over them. Private military firms already exist. Even the most ridiculous, complex systems are streamlined and made efficient, once people make or lose money on them.

New Spiritualities

New theologies will certainly develop during the process of de-conquest. To a far greater extent than most people – even theologians – have realized, millennia of state rule have deeply affected theology.

Abraham was no statist, nor was Moses. Jesus certainly was not. Regardless, the religions based upon them (and others) have taken on the deep assumption that states are ordained of God.

As states fail, the statist assumptions of theology will change, and the beliefs that emerge from this change will be far closer to the true intents of their non-statist founders.

Defending Virtue And Merit

The smartest child in school suffers for his abilities. The superior man suffers for his virtues. Envy reigns and even children learn to degrade themselves in order to escape its sting.

This situation will not survive a process of de-conquest. The smart child will not be placed in a situation where he (or she) is forced to deny the best parts of himself in order to escape constant fear. The innovator, who was previously an insult to the prestige of the state and a magnet for envy, will be freely rewarded for his work by an unregulated market.

No one knows how much benefit was lost under the rule of inescapable envy.

Those Who Act Create The Future Their Way

No single individual, under the rule of states, can honestly think he or she will direct the course of the world. States direct the course of mankind; massive groups of young men dying on battlefields determine whether changes are successful or not.

In an un-ruled world, however, any individual who cares enough, expends enough effort, and who learns from his mistakes can – himself – chart a new course for the world.

Consider: There remain some people in the West who are willing to sacrifice for their beliefs. Among them are people of these types[162]:

- Home schoolers.
- Some private school parents.
- The digital gold industry.
- Human rights advocates.
- The Russian opposition.
- Anti-surveillance and civil rights protesters.
- Some journalists.
- People who emigrate for economic improvement.

[162] At one time, openly gay people had to sacrifice to live their own way, but that is seldom required any more. A couple of generations ago, civil rights activists sacrificed, but most of those involved have now passed. Some soldiers also fit into this category and would find an honored place in an un-ruled world, but we will not include that discussion here.

- Parts of the encryption industry.
- Tax protesters.
- Most missionaries
- Messianic Jews.
- Ex-Muslims.
- Some religious groups.
- Some Whistle-Blowers.

Through all of our lifetimes, most of these people have fought not only to move forward, but to avoid problems with states or state-aligned institutions. How much further might they have progressed if they didn't have to fight two adversaries at once?

In an un-ruled world, or even in a less-ruled world, these individuals *can* change history. In those conditions, the first man or woman to take up an important new job sets the course for all who follow. They *do* change the world.

AND THEN…

No one knows how far and in which directions humanity is able to progress. What will we discover once we have private space travel? What can nano-technology do for us? What happens when genetic engineering allows us to control our own evolution? What faces us if we learn to conquer aging?

No one knows the answer to these questions, and only one of the two choices now facing the West gives us any hope of finding out.

BACK TO THE BEGINNING

> *The evil of the world is made possible by nothing but the sanction you give it.*
> -- Ayn Rand

Think back to the beginning of this book and to the first group of stationary farmers in the Tigris-Euphrates valley. What would they have been like if they had not been overrun by nomads and herded into mini-states, like sheep into pens? Where might humanity be now?

Do you think the organization of humanity into groups of *rulers* and *ruled* has been helpful toward progress? Would our pre-Sumerian farmers have chosen it willingly?

Was living as *the ruled* beneficial to the first society of farmers? They began as free and prosperous people. Their religion may seem strange to us, but we can certainly understand their love of production and their joy in discovering music and art and metallurgy and fabric and a hundred other important things that had never been before. After existing under state rule for a long time, this same group of people sunk to a tragic view of their lives: *Created for one purpose only: to serve.*

Now, consider this: The process that did this to the first society has never completely stopped; only a few temporary escapes have been made. This is a dangerous thought, but it is very definitely true.

The Denial section above was important. We said that the denial of a decline does not have to break. And, in actuality, *it has not*… for some eight thousand years.

Humanity is not a race that should be herded, reaped and used like sheep, yet that is precisely what has happened to us since 6000 B.C. Nonetheless, most of us remain in a denial that says, "it's not so bad; it will be okay." We exist in this state without even realizing it; it seems completely normal to us, and probably has since the third or fourth generations.

We give our sanction to rulership because anything else would be far too strange. It would call too much into question. All the world knows that people are supposed to be treated like sheep and that rulers are the order of the universe. Rulership is that which is, and was, and ever shall be.

There is no sensible reason why humans should be grouped and ordered around as they are, and it is nothing but their mass acquiescence that allows it to continue.



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